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Roland Barthes//Nayland Blake//Zach Blas//Gregg
Bordowitz//Leigh Bowery//AA Bronson//Kaucyila
Brooke//A.K. Burns//Giuseppe Campuzano//Jean
Cocteau//Ryan Conrad//Tee Corinne//Vaginal Davis//
Barbara DeGenevieve//Dyke Action Machine!//
Elmgreen & Dragset//Rotimi Fani-Kayode//fierce
pussy//Simon Fujiwara//Richard Fung//Malik Gaines//
Jean Genet//Gilbert & George//Felix Gonzalez-Torres//
Gran Fury//Sunil Gupta//Gordon Hall//Harmony
Hammond//K8 Hardy//Sharon Hayes//Hudson//Holly
Hughes//Roberto Jacoby//Derek Jarman//Isaac
Julien//Mahmoud Khaled//Zoe Leonard//Lesbian
Avengers//Ma Liuming//María Llopis//Catherine
Lord//Renate Lorenz//Charles Ludlam//Nithin
Manayath//Allyson Mitchell//Carlos Motta//Carrie
Moyer//Zanele Muholi//Ulrike Müller//Richard Bruce
Nugent//Ocaña//Hélio Oiticica//Henrik Olesen//
Catherine Opie//Hanh Thi Pham//Paul B. Preciado//
Queer Technologies//Karol Radziszewski//Ridykeulous
(Nicole Eisenman & A.L. Steiner)//Marlon T. Riggs//
Emily Roysdon//Prem Sahib//Assotto Saint//Braden
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Tillmans//Toxic Titties//Wu Tsang//Danh Vo//David
Wojnarowicz//Yan Xing//Las Yeguas del Apocalipsis//
Akram Zaatari//Sergio Zevallos

Whitechapel Gallery
London
The MIT Press
Cambridge, Massachusetts

Edited by David J. Getsy

QUEER

Documents of Contemporary Art

Co-published by Whitechapel Gallery
and The MIT Press

First published 2016
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ISBN 978-0-85488-242-7 (Whitechapel Gallery)
ISBN 978-0-262-52867-2 (The MIT Press)

A catalogue record for this book is available from the British Library

Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data

Names: Getsy, David, editor.
Title: Queer / edited by David J. Getsy.
Other titles: Queer (M.I.T. Press)
Description: Cambridge, MA : The MIT Press, 2016. |
Series: Whitechapel : documents of contemporary art |
Includes bibliographical references and index.
Identifiers: LCCN 2015036952 |
ISBN 9780262528672 (pbk. : alk. paper)
Subjects: LCSH: Homosexuality and the arts. | Artists' writings.
Classification: LCC NX180.H6 Q44 2016 |
DDC 700/.453--dc23 LC record available at http://lccn.loc.gov/2015036952

10 9 8 7 6 5 4 3 2 1

Series Editor: Iwona Blazwick
Commissioning Editor: Ian Farr
Project Editor: Francesca Vinter
Design by SMITH
Allon Kaye, Claudia Paladini
Printed and bound in China

Cover, Ulrike Müller, *Print (Franza)* (2014). Courtesy of the artist and Callicoon Fine Arts, New York.

Whitechapel Gallery Ventures Limited
77–82 Whitechapel High Street
London E1 7QX
whitechapelgallery.org
To order (UK and Europe) call +44 (0)207 522 7888 or email MailOrder@whitechapelgallery.org
Distributed to the book trade (UK and Europe only) by Central Books
www.centralbooks.com

The MIT Press
Cambridge, MA 02142
MIT Press books may be purchased at special quantity discounts for business or sales promotional use. For information, please email special_sales@mitpress.mit.edu



Whitechapel Gallery



Documents of Contemporary Art

In recent decades artists have progressively expanded the boundaries of art as they have sought to engage with an increasingly pluralistic environment. Teaching, curating and understanding of art and visual culture are likewise no longer grounded in traditional aesthetics but centred on significant ideas, topics and themes ranging from the everyday to the uncanny, the psychoanalytical to the political.

The Documents of Contemporary Art series emerges from this context. Each volume focuses on a specific subject or body of writing that has been of key influence in contemporary art internationally. Edited and introduced by a scholar, artist, critic or curator, each of these source books provides access to a plurality of voices and perspectives defining a significant theme or tendency.

For over a century the Whitechapel Gallery has offered a public platform for art and ideas. In the same spirit, each guest editor represents a distinct yet diverse approach – rather than one institutional position or school of thought – and has conceived each volume to address not only a professional audience but all interested readers.

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The essential elements of our movement will be FEARLESSNESS, AUDACITY and REVOLUTION

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David J. Getsy
Introduction//Queer Intolerability and its Attachments

Outlaw sensibilities, self-made kinships, chosen lineages, utopic futurity, exilic commitment, and rage at institutions that police the borders of the normal – these are among the attitudes that make up 'queer' in its contemporary usage. The activist stance of 'queer' was developed as a mode of resistance to the oppression and erasure of sexual minorities. Importantly, however, it was concurrently posited as a rejection of assimilationism proposed by many in gay and lesbian communities who aspired to be just 'normal'. Since its formulation in the crucible of the AIDS crisis in the 1980s, 'queer' has an ongoing political and cultural currency that continues to prove catalytic to artists and thinkers. It signals a defiance to the mainstream and an embrace of difference, uniqueness and self-determination. Still contentious today in LGBTI politics and culture, the defining trait of 'queer' is its rejection of attempts to enforce (or value) normalcy. Within artistic practice, queer tactics and attitudes have energized artists who create work that flouts 'common' sense, that makes the private public and political, and that brashly embraces disruption as a tactic.

While the appropriation of the term 'queer' coalesced in the 1980s, many had long understood the urgency of such anti-assimilationism before it became a slogan. It is an attitude of defiance that has arisen again and again in response to the operations of power that police difference and that exile the otherwise. My own awareness of this stance emerged before I knew it had a name (or a coalition). The first stirrings of my identification with it were tied up with an infatuation I had as a teenager with a book by Jean Cocteau. In the days before internet book stores, there was more of a reliance on chance encounters. I would travel to the small city near the town where I grew up and spend hours in one of its few used book stores. My favourite was the Paperback Shack in Binghamton, New York, with its tiny warren of floor-to-ceiling shelves packed with pulp fiction, random textbooks and discarded literature. One day, I found a copy of City Lights' reprint of the infamous *White Book*, written anonymously by Cocteau. I'll have to admit it was his sinewy and lingering line drawings that led me to bury it in the pile of books I bought that day, but reading it was transformative. Bound up with conflicted emotions and erotics, the book nevertheless offered a sense of possibility amidst the neglect, silence and prejudice that marked mainstream media's accounts of queer lives in the 1980s.

In particular, it was the final words that stuck with me and, indeed, became something of a guiding principle as I turned to queer activism and scholarship in

the following years. The main character concludes his tale with the lines 'But I will not agree to be tolerated. This damages my love of love and of liberty.' This, to me, remains the core of queer defiance. Difference should be difficult. It should not simply be grudgingly admitted and sidelined, nor should the aim be for it to disappear in some fantasy of an expanded and more inclusive 'normal'. To be intolerable is to demand that the normal, the natural and the common be challenged. To do this is not to demand inclusion, but rather to refuse to accept any operations of exclusion and erasure that make up the normal and posit compulsory sameness. Of course, I included Cocteau's words in this book. How could I not?[1] But, more importantly, these lines articulate a key theme running throughout this book and characteristic of the many different artists included in it. The aim is not to be admitted to the normal but to question its categorical centrality and the clandestine ways in which it is relentlessly enforced. All the artists included in this book have been, in different degrees and at different moments, deemed intolerable for the beliefs they demanded be witnessed.

Perhaps the best way to understand the stance that self-nominates as queer is to see that it is, fundamentally, *adjectival*. It does not stand alone. Rather, it attaches itself to nouns, wilfully perverting that to which it is appended. It is a tactical modification – this name 'queer' – that invokes relations of power and propriety in its inversion of them. That is, its utterance brings with it two operations. First, it appropriates and affects the thing that it now describes (a queer *what*?). Second, this attachment of 'queer' to a noun necessarily cites the standards and assumptions against which it is posed (the presumed 'normal' that it abandons).

To deploy 'queer' as a slur is to activate an apparatus of aspersion. The thing nominated as 'queer' is now looked at awry and with invasive suspicion. As well, the presumption that there is an already agreed upon 'normal' becomes reinvested as a silent authority through this calling out of its deviation. This speech act is performative in the strict sense. It inexorably alters the person or thing by proposing the mere possibility of its difference and divergence.[2] This was its historical power as an allegation throughout the twentieth century, and it was used to imply abnormality, outsiderness and difference. To nominate something as suspicious, as unlike or as inauthentic is to produce an effect – regardless of the facts. That thing or person is, henceforth, actually suspicious, unlike and inauthentic in the eyes of witnesses to that slur.[3] Evidence is sought by others to confirm their newly stirred doubts. From this point on, that person, thing, text or image is, indeed, now inspected in detail for the degrees to which it achieves or fails to achieve the normal. The driving fear is that difference remains invisible and uncontrolled. This is the reason that, historically, the defences activated by the targets of this allegation so often turn aggressive or compulsive in their

I will not
agree to be
tolerated.
This damages
my love of
love and
of liberty

Jean Cocteau, *The White Book*, 1927

repudiations. These are responses to the real and powerful semantic violence enacted upon those branded as (or merely rumoured to be) 'queer.'

Beginning in the 1980s (in particular, in English-speaking countries such as the United States and the United Kingdom), the negative speech act was appropriated by those it had been used to defame. It became the basis of a broad-scale cultural and political movement and was embraced as a badge of honour. The idea of aspiring to be normal (and hence invisible) was rejected, and 'queer' became a self-declaration and a political stance. Such an insolent and collective embrace of queer and anti-assimilationist activist tactics allowed for an address to power's workings, highlighting the policing of normalcy through self-exiling oneself from it. It is no surprise that this strategy emerged at the moment when 'silence equalled death'. Governments' inaction over the AIDS crisis and the wilful suppression of it in the media as something private, not public, demanded a reaction that was relentless and loud in its declaration of presence and its refusal to have difference erased.

These activists understood that to declare oneself 'queer' is no less of a speech act. It is a recognition that the fear of the un-normal is also a source of power. Such a defiant self-nomination disarms those who seek to use it to shame and silence. The adjectival mechanism of queer is turned outward to focus not on the covertness of difference but, more politically and polemically, to call out and to target the camouflaged workings of power and normativity. Similarly, for those who embrace this stance, the experience of seeing an object, a text or an act as queer produces not suspicion but affection. Once the performative force of queer is taken on with pride and insubordination, the veneer of enforced normalcy cracks. Sites of resistance, resilience, dissent and immoderation appear everywhere as possibilities for rebellion, for connection and for solidarity. Queer artists are exemplary of this. They see the experience of difference and dissent as replete with capacity, and they make visible the otherwise as a means of valuing it. The 'otherwise' is my term for those endless positions of apartness from which queer stances are posited. It is a term that positively signals alterity as a site from which to re-view the presumed normal. The 'otherwise', that is, is what queer attitudes and activism seek to defend, proclaim and propagate. Queer artists' work is tied up not just with the important work of political defiance and critique, but also with visualizing and inhabiting otherwise.

While 'queer' draws its politics and affective force from the history of non-normative, gay, lesbian and bisexual communities, it is not equivalent to these categories nor is it an identity. Rather, it offers a strategic undercutting of the stability of identity and of the dispensation of power that shadows the assignment of categories and taxonomies. Indeed, it was developed as a primarily public stance and a political attitude from which cultural authority could be disputed.

As a recognizable queer politics coalesced, aesthetics were central. Because of the adjectival apparatus and performativity of 'queer', it is fundamentally about *appearance*, in many senses.[4] That is, how does something look *and* what are the conditions under which it *appears* in the cultural field? Consequently, when activists began to fight the governmental policies of disinformation and wilful neglect during the first years of the AIDS crisis, visual strategies were central. The 'politics of visibility' demanded representation and accountability, and they opposed the enforcement of normalcy through radically performed presence. Agitprop, street performance and guerilla art were developed as counter-tactics to invisibility and silence. It's also important to remember that, before the 1980s, such defiant declarations of difference also characterized earlier movements, but the AIDS crisis demanded, globally, a response that was *visible* and collective in higher degrees. In that same decade, the 'in-your-face' tactics and the focused rage were further expanded as a means to argue more broadly and unapologetically for sexual self-determination, for alternate kinships, and for difference to be a site from which to speak to power and with power. On the heels of these activist developments, academics began taking the anti-assimilationist stance of 'queer' and its refusal of the stability of categories as prompts to theorize cultural authority differently. In this manner, a widespread scholarly movement emerged in the late 1980s and 1990s that, as well, fed into artistic practice.

Artists who identify their practices as queer today call forth utopian and dystopian alternatives to the ordinary, adopt outlaw stances, embrace criminality and opacity, and forge unprecedented kinships, relationships, loves and communities. Much of the energy of these practices derives from the experience of oppression and prejudice against those whose sexualities or genders do not fit. In response, strategies for surviving and flourishing have emerged as the primary character of queer cultural production in the twenty-first century, and this unapologetic demand for self-definition is a reason that queer artistic practices have re-emerged so forcefully in the past few years.

This book collects a range of artists' deployment of the adjectival disruption of 'queer'. It catalogues how the concept can be used as a site of political and institutional critique, as a framework to develop new families and histories, as a spur to action, and as a basis from which to declare inassimilable difference. I made the decision early on that this volume needed to break in one respect with the conventions of the 'Documents of Contemporary Art' series and focus almost exclusively on artists' own voices. With a few small exceptions in the first section, this is a collection of those who speak from the perspective of being makers. I have left to one side the many theoretical texts from the discipline of queer studies. Were this an anthology on queer scholarship or criticism, many other

writers would find a place here. The theorists and historians have been avoided in order to give more space to artists' own formulations of 'queer'. (However, a selection of important texts from both these categories can be found in the bibliography.) Similarly, the many art writers who themselves have queer practices have not been included in order to make more room for the over seventy-five artists whose voices are collected in this book. While there are many queer artists who have been written about by others eloquently and engagingly, I have chosen not to make the book a collection of third-person accounts of queer art, preferring instead first-person accounts of artistic practice and motivating ideas. I looked for texts that offered ways into artists' thinking about queer practices. I wanted to showcase how artists engaged in dialogue with others about negotiating difference and collectivity. Ultimately, my hope was to assemble voices that could prove useful, inspirational or catalytic to others who, themselves, are working to articulate queer positions. That is, rather than a book of queer theory for artists, this is a book of artists' queer tactics and infectious concepts.

This book series is unillustrated, so the words had to operate for themselves. For this reason, a number of engaging and inspiring artists without their own writing practices were not included. Similarly, artists who draw on queer experience as a resource but do not foreground it as central to their art's message or mission were also not included in this book that takes confrontational anti-assimilationism as an organizing principle. Nevertheless, the literature on artists' negotiation of queer politics and theory is rich, and it became clear to me how varied and useful it could be instead to present a wide range of queer artists from across the globe who, each in their own way, declared that they were present, inassimilable, intolerable and committed. This is a book about artists speaking rather than being spoken for, and I hope readers will take this into account when considering its range.

A central aim of mine was to provide an expanded account of the global manifestations of queer artistic practice throughout the historical trajectory offered in this book. It is my hope that it will introduce new artists to readers already familiar with the art history of these decades, and some texts are here translated into English for the first time. In these endeavours, I have been aided by many historians and critics from around the world who offered advice and suggestions, and I am grateful for the generosity of the many who helped this collection come into focus.

With regard to the geographic range represented in this book, it is important to remember that the activist anti-assimilationist stance that emerged in the US and Britain had neither the same currency nor the same horizon of possibilities in other parts of the world. So, we see very different ways of enacting and propagating queerness in Latin America and Asia during the 1980s and 90s, for

instance. It would be an error to see such practices as less activist or engaged than their American contemporaries with whom the idea of queer art has often been singularly associated. In these other political, religious and national contexts, the articulation of queerness and the declaration of difference operated in complex and varied ways that only sometimes resembled those of English-speaking nations. Artists' engagements with sexuality and alternate modes of kinship in Latin America, Asia, Eastern Europe and Africa could not be disentangled from issues that, in the US, were less present: political revolution, dictatorial regimes, the interdependence of national identity and religion, postcolonial attitudes toward the English-speaking world, and class consciousness. For this reason, the ways that some artists have spoken about queer stances may, at first, seem oblique compared to the 'in your face' stereotype of American art of the 1980s and 1990s. It is important to remember, however, the context of those utterances and the bravery it took to make them.

Another challenge faced in putting this book together was the ways in which gender nonconformity has operated for many as the sign for queer. The historical reasons for this are too complex to discuss here, but a consistent and widespread way of representing and self-representing otherwise sexualities has been to hybridize or transgress ascribed genders. At base, one explanation for this is that all non-heterosexual sexual identities trouble gender. It is this fact that many assimilationist modes of gay and lesbian politics would have us ignore in their seeking to be 'just' normal. Indeed, as Susan Stryker has eloquently written in her text included in this volume, the adoption of transgender by LGB rights movements has had the insidious effect of implying that all gender trouble can be located in the addition of the 'T'. Not only does this desexualize all transfolk, but it also fuels the fantasy that the content of the 'L', the 'G' and the 'B' merely involve the reshuffling of intimacies among conventional, binary genders.[5] Such efforts by assimilationist movements seek to manage the much more complex history of the interrelations between what we now call transgender and queer. Throughout the twentieth century (and before), the complex history of gender non-conformity and transformational genders and bodies has been appropriated as gay and lesbian history – even as gender rebellion has been caricatured and transfolk erased in that history. It was for these reasons that a distinct transgender politics emerged in both activism and scholarship as a response to such misappropriations of trans experience.[6] To be blunt: trans does not equal queer, and it is problematic to subsume the concerns of one into the other. That said, there are many who find it generative to identify with both positions.

In collecting the texts for this book, I could neither simply include trans artists and texts (thus replaying the queer appropriation of trans) nor could I wholesale exclude artists for whom it was gender, rather than sexuality, that was

the primary category of analysis. So, readers will note the presence of some artists who might be understood to represent queerness through cross-gender identification (such as Ma Liuming) as well as those who draw on transgender politics and experience as resources for opposing normativity with regard to both sexuality and gender. It was important to the global ambitions of this book to not exclude such positions. The presence of this range of texts in this book is both historically appropriate to the multiple and interwoven histories of trans and queer in different locations and, I hope, contentious in the ways that they disrupt any misconception of a unitary narrative of queer.

Undoubtedly, there is a different story to be told about trans politics and experience in contemporary art, and I believe this book should be followed by a volume on 'trans'. For this collection, however, I hope that the presence of voices that engage both with trans and queer positions will remind readers of the complexities of these histories, the importance of distinguishing between the politics of gender and of sexuality, and – most of all – the ways in which the force of critique is enhanced when their politics are understood to be both distinct and mutually reinforcing.[7]

With the intention of staging such debates and confluences among the global, the political and the gendered, I put this book together as my ideal textbook for a studio seminar for artists. The texts included are meant to offer a diverse and contentious set of attitudes and politics in order to spark new ideas. By definition, there can be no singular 'queer art', nor is there only one way to work queerly. I have sought to encode this proliferative potential in the selection of texts that make the particularity of the artist's perspective central. In making the selections for this book, I had four main aspirations. First, to foreground artists' voices. Second, to gesture to the longer history (and current vitality) of anti-assimilationist and other queer tactics before and after the production of queer as an activist and academic category in the 1980s and 1990s. Third, to explore the variety of more recent twenty-first century practices that embrace queer stances, and, fourth, to extend the global conversation about queer practices. As a consequence of these priorities, there are some 'usual suspects' that do not appear in these pages, and some readers will no doubt generate lists of important artists who have not been included. At the same time, I believe I have put together a selection in which there are many new voices in the conversation from different parts of the globe, showing a wider network of artists that have not yet had significant presences in existing accounts.

The first section, 'Recognizing Backward', seeks to complicate the assumption that queer tactics simply began in the 1980s. While the usage of the term 'queer' and its anti-assimilationist stance became consolidated out of the activism of that decade, they drew on many years of earlier practices that inform them. For

this reason, I have included a very small number of early and mid twentieth-century texts to indicate this longer history, focusing on often-cited figures such as Jean Genet, Natalie Clifford Barney, Charles Ludlam or Jack Smith. The activism of the 1980s and onward has continued to look back to such individual voices in their formulation of a queer praxis, and I have included these earlier texts to signal the longer history of defiance that extends beyond the chronological range of this book. This section also addresses these earlier histories by incorporating some of the very few writings by non-artists such as Nithin Manayath and Roland Barthes, the latter concisely articulating the paradoxes of toleration that were increasingly apparent even before the anti-assimilationist activism of the 1980s. His observations continue to be relevant today, and could well be applied to current debates about homonormativity (as in Section IV). Beyond these forebears and sources, this section also includes texts by artists who have actively constructed their own lineages as a means to propel their own work, critique and activism. In addition to examples of artists who engage specifically with these forebears (Bordowitz on Ludlam, Julien on Hughes, Oiticica on Smith), I have also included artists who remake earlier traditions as their own (Fani-Kayode on Yoruba art, Sillman on Abstract Expressionism) and artists who directly engage with their own histories and art histories. Cumulatively, this section speaks to the longer running practice in queer culture (stretching back centuries) in which the past has been scoured for evidence of existence and models for futurity.

The next section, 'Public Rage', focuses on the emotionally-charged tactics of insubordination in which the presumed boundaries between the public and the private are refused. Not only is anger embraced as a source of strength, but also its public display is adopted because of its disruptive force. Neutrality and objectivity become targets of affectual critique as a means of revealing how the suppression of emotion has been used as a strategy for denying that differences matter. This section foregrounds the responses to the AIDS crisis in the 1980s and 1990s but also expands out to other tactics of focused anger that constitute queer practice's truculent public address.

'Queer Worlding, Defiant Flourishing' brings together a heterogeneous collection of voices of those who seek to establish new ways of living and loving. These texts embrace utopic futurity, current anti-assimilationist practices, alternate families, rogue kinships and the production of communities based on particularity rather than sameness. Emphasizing art since 2000, this section also seeks to understand the production of queer spaces and queer events. It charts how the activist ethics and epistemological tactics of 'queer' manifest in current artistic practice. Importantly, this section also demonstrates how queer artistic stances have a wide range of resources and aims. Queer art is sometimes very much about sex and desire, and this is reflected in clusters of texts about the

embrace of unauthorized desires (as with the group of writings on parents by Hughes, Olesen, Shah, and Fujiwara) or that examine the production of pornography (DeGenevieve, Community Action Center). Other texts are about self-made kinships and new familial units (Toxic Titties, Llopís, Gilbert & George, Elmgreen & Dragset, Mitchell) or the revolutionary importance of love (Roysdon, Hayes). Living queerly is a political act, and this section examines the different ways in which doing so has been imagined and realized.

'Against Homonormativity' brings together texts that speak against assimilationist and homogenizing views of LGBTI communities. Importantly, queer stances are often oppositional within such communities, and their tactics are directed against the subordination of difference and variability in mainstream (or, rather, *tolerable*) accounts of LGBTI politics and life. The same reliance on the power of normativity – that was once an object of critique – often re-emerges in mainstream gay rights movements (especially for those unmarked by other intersectional positions of struggle). That is, a singular LGBTI politics often proves ignorant to other modes of difference such as race, region, language, class and genders. Included are texts that speak directly to these issues, including some by authors that may be more familiar to some readers as theorists (notably, the filmmaker and scholar Susan Stryker or Paul B. Preciado, whose narrative of making a video is included in this book). Also included are texts by artists who have long set themselves against homogenizing narratives (Athey, Opie and Davis), and younger artists attacking the suppression or appropriation of differences by homonormativity (Tsang, Acosta and Radziszewski). All in all, this final section makes the case for resisting a singular understanding of queer and demands that its critical stance be renewed and re-engaged for future practices.

Definitionally, there is no one set of politics, way of speaking or mode of practice that characterizes all of these texts, and the selection has intentionally posed internal debates and contentious divergences. Due to context, history and sometimes proclivity of the authors, there is language and terminology within these covers that some may find objectionable or counterproductive. In keeping with the historical debates, I have not excluded texts that contain elements that I personally find problematic (such as the sexism that occurs in such texts as Jack Smith's or the transphobia that sometimes bubbles beneath the surface of others). I have only included such conflicted texts when I think the overall contribution to the volume outweighed such sentiments and when I thought that the historical context of the text bore out (sadly) that such prejudicial views were common in the discourse of that time. At the same time, I have balanced the attitudes of some of these earlier texts with later interventions that take to task such issues as misogyny, transphobia and racism so that the book, as a

whole, represents those historical debates and their progression while at the same time speaking clearly to the critique of prejudice.

In offering this volume, I realize that I have risked domesticating queer practices in my efforts to relay them. At every step, I was faced with the difficulty of doing justice to the radical and glorious particularities of individual queer practices while nevertheless trying to make sense of them as a whole. Art's engagements with politics and with worlding are this book's themes, and I hope it leaves the reader with no happily settled sense of what 'queer' is. Rather, I hope it spurs questions, imperatives, urges and aims that hover around the capacity to make strange, to bracket normalcy, and to demand the ability to reject, to self-determine and to simply depart from.

1 I was further emboldened to do this once I saw that its importance has also been registered in other compilations of queer themes in art, as with Christopher Reed's *Art and Homosexuality* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011) 139.

2 For further writing on the performativity of queer, see E. Patrick Johnson, '"Quare" Studies, or (Almost) Everything I Know About Queer Studies I Learned from my Grandmother', in E. Patrick Johnson and Mae G. Henderson, eds, *Black Queer Studies: A Critical Anthology* (Durham, North Carolina: Duke University Press, 2005) 124–57; Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick, *Tendencies* (Durham, North Carolina: Duke University Press, 1993); and *Touching Feeling: Affect, Pedagogy, Performativity* (Durham, North Carolina: Duke University Press, 2003).

3 For a methodological primer on the ways in which threats (founded or unfounded) produce affects and effects, see Brian Massumi, 'The Future Birth of the Affective Fact: The Political Ontology of Threat', in *The Affect Theory Reader*, ed. Melissa Gregg and Gregory Seigworth (Durham, North Carolina: Duke University Press, 2010) 52–70.

4 I discuss these issues in more detail in an interview published as David J. Getsy, 'Appearing Differently: Abstraction's Transgender and Queer Capacities', interview by William J. Simmons, in Christiane Erharter, Dietmar Schwärzler, Ruby Sircar, Hans Scheirl, eds, *Pink Labour on Golden Streets. Queer Art Practices* (Berlin: Sternberg Press, 2015) 38–55.

5 See also Susan Stryker, 'Why the T in LGBT is Here to Stay', Salon.com (2007), http://www.salon.com/2007/10/11/transgender_2/ and 'Transgender Studies: Queer Theory's Evil Twin', *GLQ* 10, no. 2 (2004) 212–15.

6 It is important to remember that trans theoretical positions emerged concurrently with queer ones in the 1980s, most notably in the important 1987 text by Sandy Stone, 'The Empire Strikes Back: A Posttranssexual Manifesto', revised and expanded in Susan Stryker and Stephen Whittle, eds, *The Transgender Studies Reader* (New York and London: Routledge, 2006) 221–35. For further reading on the appropriation of trans by queer theory, see Viviane K. Namaste, 'Tragic Misreadings: Queer Theory's Erasure of Transgender Subjectivity', in Brett Beemyn and Mickey Eliason, eds, *Queer Studies: A Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual and Transgender Anthology* (New York: New York University Press, 1996) 183–203; 'The Use and Abuse of Queer Tropes: Metaphor and

Catachresis in Queer Theory and Politics', *Social Semiotics*, vol. 9, no. 2 (1999) 213–34; *Invisible Lives: The Erasure of Transsexual and Transgendered People* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2000); and Jay Prosser, *Second Skins: The Body Narratives of Transsexuality* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1998).

7 For more on the wider historical context, historiographic issues and theoretical concerns see Susan Stryker, *Transgender History* (Berkeley, California: Seal Press, 2008); J. Jack Halberstam, *Female Masculinity* (Durham, North Carolina: Duke University Press, 1998), *In a Queer Time and Place: Transgender Bodies, Subcultural Lives* (New York: New York University Press, 2005), *The Queer Art of Failure* (Durham, North Carolina: Duke University Press, 2011); Gayle Salamon, *Assuming a Body: Transgender and the Rhetorics of Materiality* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2010); and, with regard to the history of art, David J. Getsy, *Abstract Bodies: Sixties Sculpture in the Expanded Field of Gender* (New Haven and London: Yale University Press, 2015).

When
I was
young
the
absence
of
the past
was
a terror

Derek Jarman, *At Your Own Risk*, 1992

Natalie Clifford Barney
The Unknown Woman//1902

And then the unknown woman – persuasive and fearsome, sweet and terrible, turned to me and said, 'If you love me you will forget your family and your husband and your country and your children and you will come and live with me. If you love me, you will leave everything you cherish, both the places you remember and the places you long to go; and your memories and your hopes will be nothing but desire for me. If you love me, you will look neither forward nor backward, you will know me only, and your destiny will carry my footprint alone. If you love me, infinity will be my lips, you will have no prison but my arms and all your desires will be for my body.'

And, sobbing, I replied, 'I love you.'

Natalie Clifford Barney, 'The Unknown Woman', *Cinq petits dialogues grecs* (Paris, 1902); reprinted in *A Perilous Advantage: The Best of Natalie Clifford Barney*, ed. and trans. Anna Livia (Norwich, Vermont: Victoria Publishers, Inc., 1992) 71.

Jean Cocteau
The White Book//1927

[...] [I]n exiling myself I am not exiling a monster, but a man whom society will not allow to live, since it considers one of the mysterious cogs in God's masterpiece to be a mistake.

Instead of adopting Rimbaud's gospel, *The time of the assassins has come*, young people would do better to remember the phrase *Love must be reinvented.* The world accepts dangerous experiments in the realm of art because it does not take art seriously; but it condemns them in life.

I fully realize that an ideal fit for termites, like the Russian ideal which tends towards the plural, condemns the singular in one of its most lofty forms. But nobody will ever prevent certain flowers and fruit from being smelt and eaten only by the rich.

A vice of society makes a vice of my rectitude. I withdraw from this society. In France this vice does not lead me to prison because of the way Cambacérès lived

and the longevity of the Code Napoléon. But I will not agree to be tolerated. This damages my love of love and of liberty.

Jean Cocteau, extract from *Le Livre blanc* (1927), trans. Margaret Crosland, *The White Book* (San Francisco: City Lights, 1989) 75–6.

Richard Bruce Nugent
You See, I Am a Homosexual: In Conversation with Thomas H. Wirth//1983

Richard Bruce Nugent The Harlem Renaissance had been happening all this while. And I was a part of that. I mean, I was part of a little group in it called 'the Niggeratti'. And so, while I hadn't published things like Langston [Hughes] or Countee [Cullen] or even Wallie [Thurman], I'd written one poem that Langston had retrieved from a wastebasket and given to Charles S. Johnson the year, or two years, before ...

It was a poem called 'Shadow' ... It created kind of a sensation at the time. It was considered to be a race poem, although I hadn't meant it to be ... and it was considered to be *quite* something. I mean, here was a poem that the newspapers picked up and would ... print when it was necessary to say something about blacks – something good about blacks – and art and etc. And it got quite a bit of unwarranted acclaim. It appeared in almost every anthology of Negro poetry at the time ... Considering that I didn't have any others, it's not surprising. Or considering that nobody *knew* whether I had any others or not, and that I didn't think that any of my poetry was good enough anyhow.

Thomas H. Wirth You said you didn't intend it to be a race poem. What did you intend it to be?

Nugent I intended it to be a soul-searching poem of another kind of lonesomeness, not the lonesomeness of being racially stigmatized, but otherwise stigmatized.

You see, I am a homosexual.

I have never been in what they call 'the closet'. It has *never* occurred to me that it was anything to be ashamed of, and it never occurred to me that it was anybody's business but mine. You know that good old Negro song: 'Ain't Nobody's Business What I Do?' And the times were very different then. Everybody did whatever they wanted to do. And who cared? [...]

Richard Bruce Nugent, extract from 'You See, I Am a Homosexual', interview with Thomas H. Wirth (1983), in Wirth, ed., *Gay Rebel of the Harlem Renaissance: Selections from the Work of Richard Bruce Nugent* (Durham, North Carolina: Duke University Press, 2002) 268.

Jean Genet
Our Lady of the Flowers//1943

[...] To love a murderer. To love to commit a crime in cahoots with the young half-breed pictured on the cover of the torn book. I want to sing murder, for I love murderers. To sing it plainly. Without pretending, for example, that I want to be redeemed through it, though I do yearn for redemption. I would like to kill. As I have said above, rather than an old man, I would like to kill a handsome blond boy, so that, already united by the verbal link that joins the murderer and the murdered (each existing thanks to the other), I may be visited, during days and nights of hopeless melancholy, by a handsome ghost of which I would be the haunted castle. But may I be spared the horror of giving birth to a sixty-year-old corpse, or that of a woman, young or old. I am tired of satisfying my desire for murder stealthily by admiring the imperial pomp of sunsets. My eyes have bathed in them enough. Let's get to my hands. But to kill, to kill you, Jean. Wouldn't it be a question of knowing how I would behave as I watched you die by my hand?

More than of anyone else, I am thinking of Pilorge. His face, cut out of *Detective Magazine*, darkens the wall with its icy radiance, which is made up of his Mexican corpse, his will to death, his dead youth, and his death. He spatters the wall with a brilliance that can be expressed only by the confrontation of the two terms that cancel each other. Night emerges from his eyes and spreads over his face, which begins to look like pines on stormy nights, that face of his which is like the gardens where I used to spend the night: light trees, the opening in a wall, and iron railings, astounding railings, festooned railings. And light trees. O Pilorge! Your face, like a lone nocturnal garden in worlds where suns spin round. And on it that impalpable sadness, like the light trees in the garden. Your face is dark, as if in broad daylight a shadow had passed over your soul. It must have made you feel slightly cool, for your body shuddered with a shudder more subtle than the fall of a veil of the tulle known as 'gossamer-fine tulle', for your face is veiled with thousands of fine, light, microscopic wrinkles, painted, rather than engraved, in criss-cross lines.

Already the murderer compels my respect. Not only because he has known a rare experience, but because he has suddenly set himself up as a god, on an altar,

whether of shaky boards or azure air. I am speaking, to be sure, of the conscious, even cynical murderer, who dares take it upon himself to deal death without trying to refer his acts to some power of a given order, for the soldier who kills does not assume responsibility, nor does the lunatic, nor the jealous man, nor the one who knows he will be forgiven; but rather the man who is called an outcast, who, confronted only with himself, still hesitates to behold himself at the bottom of a pit into which, with his feet together, he has – curious prospector – hurled himself with a ludicrously bold leap. A lost man. [...]

Jean Genet, extract from *Our Lady of the Flowers* (1943), trans. Bernard Frechtman (New York: Grove Press, 1963) 120–21.

Jack Smith
Statements, Ravings and Epigrams//n.d.

- What practical meaning does original have, applied to the imagination. We originate nothing. The origin of all things is outside ourselves. We have only to scratch the icing to find beneath – centuries of icing.[1]
- O Goddess of cinema – I have come to your altar – my arms full of props – Mother Cinema, Jealous Mistress, I have yielded to the special demands of the cinema, affected Rapture. All the secret delights of Stardom – Artificial Ecstasy – The Orchid Rot that wastes the flypaper landscapes studded with the bones of dead Hippopotami on the comeback trail.
- Normalcy is the evil side of homosexuality.
- I am queer but don't ask me to live in the shadow of the cunt of your girl friend.
- When you have police everything looks queer.
- A normal is me who knows what a faggot is.
- If it weren't for fairies, what would normals have to think about? They learn early somehow that the fairy is the sacrifice.
- My darling I find myself thinking about you when there is nothing on my mind.
- And doesn't capitalism make human relationships except for sex all but impossible?
- God must want to be shocked.
- Your glamorous friend.
- I only seem fantastic because I am so practical.
- The title is 50 per cent of the work.

- In my last program I was a Yvonne De Carlo for the Lucky Landlord Underground. But I lied.
- Why are people horrified that I have human characteristics?
- I have Art for Rent – I am my own agent, I'm not some fantasy object you can talk to about money or who doesn't have to make a living. It is perfectly alright to talk to me about money just because I'm an artiste.
- Brochure: 'I can be rented' Xavier Cugat – the Surgeon General of Latin Dance Music.
- Do we need consumer crabs to remind us to eat?
- I know I've done a lot of bagdadist things in my life.
- If I still have any friends it's because they aren't thru with me yet.
- Isn't Christianity the worship of betrayal?
- Theatre? There is no such thing as teachers there is only the apprentice system – and Maria Montez knows I can use a couple of helpers right about now. – Jack Smith [phone number]
- Whom the courts would destroy they 1st make angry.
- Pick the envelope – not the stamp.
- It is not the insult which is insulting – it is the intention to insult which causes the insult, and which is indeed the insult.
- Glamorize your messes.
- I can be funny when I'm alone.
- Art is all day long – when anyone wants to adjust anything they are using art.
- Sadism always begins with flattery.
- Fashion is an ugly business.
- Socialistic Art uses glamour – it was paid for by Maria Montez.
- The critics are the hand maidens of the Lobster.
- I overcame pastiness.
- The search for the world's most exotic dentist.
- Any moment America will arrive at scientific reasons for aesthetics.
- Question – How can I be sure I don't need an exotic consultant?
- I'm in a position of the golden baby fantasy – idiot who did the work, made the great plays, etc. And nothing happened. They want it to die after two rehearsals.
- The dull but honest Flaming Creatures.
- Experimental film is when the end of the film is stuck to reel in dirty scotch tape and when you start to re-wind you don't put your finger on the tape to make sure it doesn't separate from the reel.
- If there was anything good about Rome it was their baths, not their courts.
- I'm afraid to give anybody anything. It seems to instantly destroy their personalities. I have to find a way to give that doesn't look like giving. I don't want to be destroyed ... and yet I do want to give.

– I am one of the very few artists not trying to peddle academic art. In other words I put everything into a program. It leaves me weak and burnt out for weeks afterwards. It becomes almost a physical ordeal besides being an ordeal of academic politeness.
– Bring dead film back to life thru doorway to Bagdad.
– Art History if you will notice is nothing but the history of brain picking.
– The horror of rectilinear lagoon – they react to you so they can rob you!!
– Clapitalism is when you must kill in order to earn a living.
– I am really an extremely material person – I'm the only normal man in Bagdad.
– Picked apart by brainpicker services – they won't approach you with a deal but will approach you as a trick objectified.
– What doesn't exist is important.
– Fashion – it makes up for an awful lot.
– To be or not to be Normal.
– I am always put in an exotic mood by a glamorous cocktail.
– I may look a little pale, but that's because they don't let me out of the safe very often – deliver rent checks ...
– Let's take Maria Montez for granted.
– Kill time – see a movie.
– I just want to plunge into the colour blue.
– Thanks for explaining me.
– The orchids don't look too good this year.
– Easier for Y de Carlo to pass through eyelette.
– Would you hold it against me if I couldn't stand for this?

1 [The em dashes are not in the original sources and are added here due to spatial constraints, to denote that each is an individual statement.]

Jack Smith, 'Statements, "Ravings" and Epigrams' (undated notes from journals, letters and ephemera, some of which Smith referred to as 'ravings'), in J. Hoberman and Edward Leffingwell, eds, *Wait for Me at the Bottom of the Pool: The Writings of Jack Smith* (New York: High Risk Books, 1997) 151–5.

Hélio Oiticica
Mario Montez, Tropicamp//1971

[...] For me, when i saw HARLOT, i was impressed by WARHOL's ability to synthesize elements of his own art experience [...] with elements pioneered by JACK SMITH, such as MARIO MONTEZ-banana-CARMEN-HARLOW, etc., in such an efficient way as to suggest to us, if one knows the work of SMITH, his use of music, and tropical-cliché images in general, a sort of PRE-TROPICÁLIA – as a matter of fact, from what I saw and know, I consider JACK SMITH both PRE and POST-TROPICÁLIA at the same time, an impressive fusion of tropihollywood and camp clichés – WARHOL developed himself more towards what he is: POP and POST-POP, an amalgamation of POP and HOLLYWOOD-AMERICA clichés – the importance and interest for us, in the incarnation-personality MARIO MONTEZ, is precisely that he is the materialization of the cliché of LATIN AMERICA-as-a-whole, this makes me think of what SOY LOCO POR TI AMERICA by GIL-CAPINAM[1] was for TROPICÁLIA-music in brazil, and even more, because this image-incarnation-personality was created in the states – without a doubt everything emerged under the tutelage of JACK SMITH: MARIA MONTEZ and CARMEN MIRANDA, two precursors of what I will call here TROPICAMP, and thus they're super-idols in the american underground – that is why HARLOT is the concretion of all these suggestions, and yet 'vaguely presented': in fact this vague thing is the most concrete: HARLOT means prostitute but is harlow at the same time: the very title is a play on words – the only instruction given to MARIO by WARHOL during filming: 'eat the bananas slowly', and this is fundamental in the oral-erotic action: the slow peeling and eating of every single of the (big!) bananas: the bananas appear miraculously one after the other: the harlowian bag, each time it is opened, produces a new banana; MARIO tells me he hid some under the sofa cushion before starting to film, to be able to carry these bananific appearances into effect – RONALD TAVEL describes how the soundtrack was made and WARHOL's suggestion to speak from behind a screen, so that the conversation itself would become dislocated – 'we sat on the other side of the room, so that we could see the scene being filmed, so that we could refer to it but also could change the subject freely' – MARIE MENCKEN, who made a film on ANDY WARHOL (of the same title [1965]) writes (village voice, 6 may 1965): 'it is strange when you think about it, but his (WARHOL's) most impressive star is a man – MARIO MONTEZ. he/she does HARLOT with a blond wig, and there are moments in this movie that should guarantee ANDY the fame of a great artist, even if not that of a great film-maker. i find the fragment in which MARIO is

eating the bananas is among or even is the most sensual detail ever filmed!'

TROPICAMP is part of what i call TROPICÁLIA-SUBTERRÂNIA: in my PROJETO 1 CENTRAL PARK [1971 – work not completed], i include MARIO MONTEZ doing CARMEN MIRANDA + other things in a performance area: an amalgamation as well: schemes, crumbs of synthesis – that's why, leaping to [19]71, i want to talk about this anthological personification: have a look at the photos made on the occasion of this article by CARLOS VERGARA, they're of the piece VAIN VICTORY [1971] by JACKIE CURTIS (also one of WARHOL's impersonator-superstars), where MARIO does MALAFEMINA, and in one of the sketches (called URUGUAY) he does CARMEN: without imitating, what makes a lot of good people say it's badly done: though image-CARMEN is in fact far more than that: it is not a naturalistic-imitative representation of CARMEN MIRANDA, but a key reference to the TROPICAMP-cliché; and the whole piece is constructed out of clichés: CAMP-clichés: 'she, met her guy, uy, uy – in, uruguay, ay, ay ...': the red and green samba school dress – in my PROJETO 1, MARIO-CARMEN would also be a block-image [*bloco-imagem*], blending with other contrasting elements – 'I'd rather eat the cottage cheese of a deadman's jockstrap than marry you': this phrase of one piece's dialogue was refused by MARIO: 'me, saying something like this: never: I'm no sex-freak'. – MORE MILK, IVETTE [sic]: by WARHOL (1966) in which MARIO MONTEZ does LANA TURNER, and CHERYL, LANA's daughter, is a man in the film (the gender swap was WARHOL's manipulation): MARIO-LANA is eating hamburgers with milk all the time: when the milk is finished, he/she says: 'more milk, IVETTE' – IVETTE was LANA TURNER's maid. – BUFFERIN COMMERCIAL [1966], by WARHOL: paid by the aspirin company of the same name, to produce a tv commercial: everyone started 'smoking' the aspirin, in the end it was only shown at DOM (which functioned as the experimental laboratory of the time, for WARHOL and THE VELVET UNDERGROUND, a pop music band supported by him; the space is at st. mark's place, east village). – [...]

MARIO is a very intelligent person, charming, who loves being precise in what he does, and in the details of his fantastic experiences he talks about: he doesn't like 'drag queenery': he considers his work something better (and it is!), with a raison d'être: it is his work, and he wants to be permanently conscious about this; he is very organized: he has archived everything, recorded tapes of everything he has done so far, and of things that could relate to it: he inserted one, so i could listen, a film by CARMEN MIRANDA with JANE POWELL and WALLACE BEERY, you can hear CARMEN in dialogue and singing: 'i recorded it from tv'; au naturel, as a man, that is how he usually is, he appears like so many puerto ricans in new york: he has a well-shaped masculine body, sometimes he poses as a nude model at drawing lessons; his congenital sympathy lets you always feel 'at ease' when he is around – 'please relay to your brazilian readers two announcements: 1 – in new

york a MARIO MONTEZ wall calendar for 1972 will be edited; 2 – also this year a book by CHARLES HERSCHBERG should be published, called MARILYN & THE OTHER GIRLS, on all the persons, men and women, who impersonate MARILYN MONROE, and in which, of course, i figure myself'. [...]

1 'Soy Loco por Tí, América' was composed by Gilberto Gil and first published in 1968 by Caetano Veloso on the *Tropicália* album. The lyrics by the poet Capinam were sung in a sophisticated mix of Spanish and Portuguese and describe the desirable incarnation of the utopia of a pan-Latin-American social movement first as a woman, then as a man, then as a people. The Brazilian military dictatorship considered the song to be ideologically 'communist'. [Translator]

Hélio Oiticica, extracts from 'Mario Montez, Tropicamp', *Presença*, no. 2 (December 1971); trans. Max Jorger Hinderer Cruz, *Afterall*, no. 28 (Autumn/Winter 2011) 17–21. For discussion of this text and its references, see Cruz, 'TROPICAMP: Some Notes on Hélio Oiticica's 1971 Text', in the same issue.

Nithin Manayath
Meena Kumari and All that Was Lost with Her//2013

The Vinod Mehta memoir *Lucknow Boy* has this anecdote about Meena Kumari [1932–72] saying '*raat gayi baat gayi*' [the night's done and so are we] to someone she fucked but failed to recognize the next day despite the poor man's pleas. That rumour, right there, is the reason why good little Bunt girls like Aishwarya Rai wouldn't even have fantasized about a career as an actress till the 1970s, and it would have saved us much of our present nostalgia for 'good actresses' if she'd been born a couple of decades earlier. So what a majority of the fifty plus, and some Doordarshan-era children in their thirties like me, are really nostalgic about is not some golden era of magnificent heroines. It is simply about a time when young girls were being austerely trained in the well codified arts of bodily enchantment to seek good patronage, on the one hand, and on the other, the visual language of representing such feminine beauty in cinema, which was being borrowed just as much from the very same aristocratic *tawaif* [courtesan] cultures. Colonial disbelief at the publicness of such an erotic culture, and dhoti-suited reformist zeal, had already driven many of these performers into the supposedly rehabilitating world of Indian theatre in the early 1900s. But the rituals of domestic *riyazzat* [ritualized training] ensured that it would take much more than these killjoys to erase this stylization of *nakhras* and *adas*. [airs and graces].

To be an actress in these early decades of Hindi cinema, it helped if your mother was a well-established *jaan* or *bai* in the business. This held true for many actresses till the sixties. Today, if we were to sniff this happening in our neighbourhoods, we would probably be calling the local television channel to complain of 'illegal activities' and crying foul with vocabulary recently acquired from *Satyamev Jayate* ['Truth Alone Prevails', the TV programme on social issues]. Meanwhile, patronage, devoid of all its painstakingly enacted *règle du jeu* of feudal *tehzeeb* [etiquette], has transformed into the more concealed, democratic casting couch.

While film studies scholarship has largely concerned itself with nationalist narratives of cinema cultures it has only rarely traced older performance cultures within it. The lesser recorded spectatorship practice in relation to actresses like Meena Kumari or Nargis is the slowly established democratization of feudal classical performance cultures. The modern cinema was a place where any person who could buy a ticket was able to watch performances of women artists who traced a lineage to high-class *tawaifs* – a privilege previously reserved for aristocrats. Through these performances, films afforded the newly minted 'ordinary citizen' a glimpse of the life that their antecedents would possibly only have had access to as gossip.

And all this within the socially sanctioned modern space of the cinema theatre; even if it was a hard won sanction carved from self censorship (by an industry that, among other things, substituted two roses for an on-screen kiss by the 1950s). This effectively made the theatres a schizophrenic place, one tracing and making space for an older erotic economy and another that was attempting to censor it through reformism. A space where your identification was caught in between Nargis' *Mother India* (1957) and Meena Kumari's threatening erotic desires in *Pakeezah* (1972). Or, if you will, between [the screen personae] Bidda Bagchi and Silk.

Born in the late seventies, my familiarity with actresses like Meena Kumari was through the VHS tapes of the nineties and the black and white *Archies* posters and its hawked copies. But a growing-up-gay narrative that I acquired in my late teens had me recast a distant memory of watching Meena Kumari in *Pakeezah*; a memory retroactively built to fashion a homosexual persona. The bare bones of it involves my parents nearly leaving for the film without me, then, hearing my wails from the end of the street, returning to sandwich me on our Vespa and taking me to watch the film. The punch line: 'They ought to have known right then!'

Reading Hoshang Merchant a few years later in his introduction to *Yaarana*, an anthology of gay writing from South Asia, made me recognize that this identification with the troubled in-exile figure of Meena Kumari was a narrative trope of homosexual life in the subcontinent. I was that homosexual who 'loves

women martyred like themselves, their mothers, or Meena Kumari ...'

Why not a recent diva? Why not Bhansali's Madhuri as Chandramukhi or Priyanka Chopra in *Fashion*? But the thing is that even these two figures are modelled on the real or cinematic life of Meena Kumari. Madhuri is wafting fragrant *dhoop* [incense] into her hair when we first see her in *Devdas*; a scene lifted right out of *Pakeezah*. So I wonder if this is not just an anachronism on my part but simply a trace of the *tawaif* that determines to this day a certain aesthetic performance and appreciation of tragic feminine love.

Merchant tells us that it's no accident that icons like her 'have gay image-makers', and that 'they are literally an invention of the homosexual man, *viz.* the dress designer, hair stylist, choreographer, the make-up man ...' or even the director. While Merchant might be overstating the case, the point is that the performance and appreciation of femininity in Indian film is hardly wrought through a Stanislavian meditation on some internal female psyche by a woman actor. It seems to have more to do with a quiet quiver of the lips or a heavily lifted eye; and this seems hard-coded into the ways we learn about feminine beauty. So much so that even after years of post-liberalized, wooden models colonizing our visual landscape, Sridevi's classical *abhinaya* [art of expression] still wins at the box office.

The queer spectator's identification with Meena Kumari was contracted on a plane where her on screen characters seamlessly merged with her real life which was suitably more dramatic than her languid screen tragedies. This pact is sealed perfectly in her most memorable role as Chhoti Bahu in Guru Dutt's *Sahib, Bibi Aur Ghulam* (1962) where she played a feudal wife who bears the grind of a narrative axe that symbolizes a dying feudal system, preferring the company of a young man and turning to alcoholism in the face of a ruinous marriage to her *zamindar* [landed gentry] husband who prefers the company of a *kothewaali* [courtesan]. Because what endeared her as Chhoti Bahu had as much to do with the well publicized parallels to her own estranged marriage to filmmaker Kamal Amrohi and her seeking of solace in expensive whiskey, a young Dharmendra, and penning self-deprecatory *shayari* [couplets]. And as she lifts her eyes into the first notes of *Naa Jaao Saiyaan*, we know she is preparing us for the hopelessness of love by making that hopelessness the most desirable state of union. We're there intensely watching her, identifying with every single gesture, there is no world outside of you and you as her on screen; lonely, tragic, yet so enthralling and so, so perfect.

This desire for the melancholia of the one exiled from love is the masochistic flint in the eye of post-liberalization cultural representations; of lovers happily consuming product placements while rushing towards parochial marital unions.

The *tawaif*, or *dancewaali*, be it Chand in *Ishaqzaade* or Silk in *The Dirty Picture*, and their desire to be desired, causes enough anxiety in the narratives of these

films, so much that their real-life personae try hard to cover up the act. While the maamis and mamas whistled at Silk all twatted-up to pick her award in the filmic narrative of *The Dirty Picture*, they wouldn't be so kind if good girl Vidya Balan were to wear anything but her Kancheevarams to pick up the real ones. Because if she didn't, we wouldn't have good girls in cinema any more and god forbid poor sluts get a bit of the meaty pie that is the Hindi film industry today!

But in the face of the real life tragedies shifting to the bodies of dance bar girls and other similar women represented in the new wave of non-fiction writing, my desire for the melancholic will make me return to Meena Kumari. Her voice, sharpened to cut, calls out to us, leading us into an enchanted world of languid pleasurable pain and, despite the second-wave feminist film scholar in me protesting loudly, I am guilty of wanting my bad girls to die on screen – *ghungroos* [dancer's anklets] slicing into soft skin, stain upon stain of scarlet blood, a face draining into pallid death – and for me to die with them, once more, forever.

Nithin Manayath, '*Inhi Logon Ne* ['People']: Meena Kumari and All that Was Lost with Her', *The Big Indian Picture* (March 2013) (http://thebigindianpicture.com)

Charles Ludlam
Manifesto: Ridiculous Theatre, Scourge of Human Folly//1975

Aim: To Get beyond Nihilism by Revaluing Combat

Axioms to a theatre for ridicule:

1 If one is not a living mockery of one's own ideals, one has set one's ideals too low.
2 The things one takes seriously are one's weaknesses.
3 Just as many people who claim a belief in God disprove it with their every act, so too there are those whose every deed, though they say there is no God, is an act of faith.
4 Evolution is a conscious process.
5 Bathos is that which is intended to be sorrowful but because of the extremity of its expression becomes comic. Pathos is that which is meant to be comic but because of the extremity of its expression becomes sorrowful. Some

things which seem to be opposites are actually different degrees of the same thing.

6 The comic hero thrives by his vices. The tragic hero is destroyed by his virtue. Moral paradox is the crux of the drama.

7 The theatre is a humble materialist enterprise which seeks to produce riches of the imagination, not the other way around. The theatre is an event and not an object. Theatre workers need not blush and conceal their desperate struggle to pay the landlords their rents. Theatre without the stink of art.

Instructions for Use

This is farce not Sunday school. Illustrate hedonistic calculus. Test out a dangerous idea, a theme that threatens to destroy one's whole value system. Treat the material in a madly farcical manner without losing the seriousness of the theme. Show how paradoxes arrest the mind. Scare yourself a bit along the way.

Charles Ludlam, 'Manifesto: Ridiculous Theatre, Scourge of Human Folly' (1975); reprinted in Steven Samuels, ed., *Ridiculous Theatre: Scourge of Human Folly: The Essays and Opinions of Charles Ludlam* (New York: Theatre Communications Group, 1992) 157–8.

Ocaña
Spontaneity against Integration: In Conversation with Toni Puig//1978

Kafka wrote to his sister, 'I write differently to how I speak, I speak differently to how I think, I think differently to how I ought to think, and so it all proceeds into deepest darkness.' I don't know why, but Ocaña has always aroused this sensation in me. He is like an Andalusian fountain that sprinkles bewilderment all around. Of course to get this effect you do have to listen to his frenetic spouting, with all his shouting, exclamations and gesticulation.

Today I have transcribed his words here. They lack the verve of his presence; of that dark and disturbing presence that you breathe in the fountains of Granada's Alhambra, of that Andalucía that he still has with all its anguish and vigour. Ocaña, with his film, is now in all the magazines. He's a talking point. We are presenting him to you again as he is, letting his words be the only spirit that fills these summer pages, lending this edition of Ajoblanco *impudence and spontaneity.*

Ocaña The most important thing in life is living to love and not living for money. Let money live for you. The most important thing in life is love, partying, wine, and the rest is nothing. Well, those are clichés.

It's hard to believe, and talking about grievances, that a so-called democratic country has people who do theatre for the people – or call it what you will – and they end up in prison for two years alongside other marginalized people such as small-time crooks and people who steal mopeds in the street. The fault, among the marginalized, is that of the consumer society that led them to do this. And Els Joglars [Theatre Company] is a disgrace.[1] If they were in the Basque country, they would have been taken out by now. Here we are all very lazy.

Toni Puig So you've known small-time crooks and people like that?

Ocaña Yes, and they seem like good people to me. What I think is that they're people who are pretty much outside of society and they're not as concerned as the rest of us about having a vest, a record player or a flat. Some of them are very charming. One day I made love with a young guy I met in a phone booth. He came into my house and was frightened by the grotesque figures I have there, made from paper. And he began covering them up and he began telling me stories and talking to me about God. Well, about the god that for him is the river and the air and the trees and that was his sister who had died. He was on his way from the cemetery and he'd been talking to her. And he asked me if I believed in ghosts, and I said to him that if he believed his sister was not really dead but her energy still existed, then why not? I was dumbfounded. What a free way of making love! He had no preconceptions of any kind and it was wonderful. I was, bloody hell, I was really, really fascinated, thinking about these guys who are so modern, who talk about modernity and about bisexuality, that's what I'd really like to see. It seems that the fewer high ideas people have about this, the fewer taboos they have. People with a lot of culture have like a wall in front of their head and it's really hard for them to make love with a guy who calls himself a homosexual, or calls himself a queer, or who calls himself whatever people like to call him. [...]

I'm a bit pissed off today. Envy is really rife in this country. I get really upset that there are certain homosexuals who can't stand me and who slag me off. Because I'm sensitive, of course I am. I know that they're eaten up with jealousy. They're as alive as I am or more. But they don't have the balls to say the things I say in front of a screen, and on top of that, enjoy my film. It gets on their nerves; what they'd really like would be to see me totally fucked and even more marginalized, drunk and passed out in Las Ramblas. These people needn't think they're going to get me to fit in so easily. I'm not saying it'll never happen, but while I can, I'll go my own way. Now if they, after what I say in the film – that I

like to suck cock, just like everyone – fit in, let's see who's fitting who in. The thing is that these are all clichés, because it's very hard to fit into a society that is integrated, take its integration away and side with an Ocaña towards whom they bear so much ill will, who they say is such an opportunist. After I spent seven years without eating – fuck that! – Why are they taking so much notice of me now? Why didn't they take any notice when I was hungry? Not even God helped. Not even God! Now they're all turning up. Now they really love me. *Oh how wonderful you are!* And if I don't talk to them: *Oh, the art thing has really gone to your head, the film has gone to your head* ... Well nothing has gone to my head. Because I still hang out with pimps, with prostitutes, with queers and with whoever I damn well please. They're not going to make me neurotic, because I don't want to be. Not me. But what did these people expect? I'm the same, the same as ever, the same, the same, the same ... And I'm having a tough time because a magazine called *La Calle* slags me off. It says there are homosexuals who say I'm the ... What was it they said?

Puig You can have a look, then it will come out just as it is.

Ocaña No. It's too much. They're eaten up with envy. On top of that they're using a drawing of mine – which of course I am going to report – without asking my permission. Do they think I'm not just a no-hoper, I'm trash. Well, I'm not trash. If they think they've got the upper hand, I'm the one who's talking. It says that *gays have turned their back on transvestite painter Ocaña, currently in fashion.* Well, fuck them. I know that the ones who've turned their back on me are the guys from Front de Lliberació. The old guys. Because the more modern ones are nicer. And not all of them from the old Front; but there are people who can't stand me because they have different ideas about life. Generally lots of gays leave their offices on carnival day, take off their ties, put on a flower and go to the carnival. But not me. Then they imitate women in their most horrible aspects, at their most prissy and stupid. What upsets them is that I'm vulgar, I'm grotesque, I'm one of Goya's black paintings. Well that's the way I am! And I go out wearing mascara the way I do. Then I come in with no paint on at all. It's not my fault they're so jealous. I work – bloody hell! – and I'm alive because I don't give a damn what they say. I say, like my mother says: *Speak out son, speaking suits you; the day you don't speak will be a bad day.* What really pisses them off is that in the film Ocaña says everything he feels. They should have made the film sixty hours long. [...]

1 [Albert Boadella, the director of the popular and political theatre group Els Joglars, was imprisoned in December 1977 because of the production *La Torna.*]

Ocaña and Toni Puig, extracts from 'Spontaneity against Integration', interview with Toni Puig, *Ajoblanco*, no. 36 (August 1978) 48–51. Translated by Gilla Evans, 2015.

Roland Barthes
Preface to Renaud Camus, *Tricks*//1979

[...] Homosexuality shocks less, but continues to be interesting; it is still at that stage of excitation where it provokes what might be called feats of discourse. Speaking of homosexuality permits those who 'aren't' to show how open, liberal and modern they are; and those who 'are' to bear witness, to assume responsibility, to militate. Everyone gets busy, in different ways, whipping it up.

Yet to proclaim yourself something is always to speak at the behest of a vengeful Other, to enter into his discourse, to argue with him, to seek from him a scrap of identity: 'You are ...' 'Yes, I am ...' Ultimately, the attribute is of no importance; what society will not tolerate is that I should be ... *nothing*, or to be more exact, that the *something* that I am should be openly expressed as provisional, revocable, insignificant, inessential, in a word: irrelevant. Just say 'I am', and you will be socially saved. [...]

Roland Barthes, extract from Preface, Renaud Camus, *Tricks: 33 récits* (1979); trans. Richard Howard, *Tricks: Twenty-five Encounters* (New York: High Risk Books, 1996) vii.

Harmony Hammond
Class Notes//1977

[...] Thinking back to junior high school in the fifties, I see that one reason I chose to be an artist was to escape the daily pain of lower middle-class life in Hometown – of living in a duplex, taking a bus to school, and wearing hand-me-downs until I got a job at Lerner's and could buy my own clothes. The guy I went with turned me on to Mulligan, Coleman, Getz, and all that jazz, and the beat writers Kerouac, Ginsberg and Prévert. They were 'artists' and intellectuals, without money (like me), and romanticized. I thumbed my nose and fantasized riding naked down

the highway. We fucked. I got a scholarship to the Saturday School of the Art Institute of Chicago. I wanted to be a dress designer or fashion illustrator because it sounded 'classy' and 'sophisticated'. If all else failed, I could be an art teacher.

In the museum I saw 'real' painting and sculpture. I remember sitting in front of the Pollock, the Rothko and the Still, thinking that I could do those paintings, but not realizing that I was a woman and that it didn't matter what I did. In the studios I saw art being made by grubby students and I took note that the artist could wear anything, say anything, and didn't have to socialize. The artist seemed special and not bound by class behaviour. I would be an artist. Accepting fine art meant renouncing my class background and stepping out of the lower middle class life of Hometown into the univeral world of the muses. Safe and protected at last. Who ever heard of a middle-class muse?

It has taken me a long time to begin to understand and accept my lower middle-class background, and to realize that the art world I entered wasn't an alternative to middle-class society but that women, blacks and the poor are also oppressed within the alternate 'world of culture'. As long as society allowed me to be a 'starving artist' I did not question my own experiences, or how they affected my work and work attitudes. Acting out a romanticized art life was my option to upward mobility. Heterosexual women get their privilege from the same patriarchal systems that give privilege to middle and upper-class women. Coming out as a lesbian with a feminist consciousness forced me to realize what class privilege I did and did not have, and what I would now lose. Even the fact that I first came out to myself through my art and not in bed is in itself a reflection of my class position. As a feminist artist I had learned to use my work as a place to confront fears and other feelings privately in my studio. A woman working as a maid, a waitress or a seamstress does not have this option. As a lesbian, however, I was forced to confront and give up illusions I had about being accepted and rewarded by the male art world where they treated art 'seriously'. To be public about being a lesbian means that your work may not be taken seriously, or may be squeezed into a category of 'camp' or 'erotic art'. Because you do not hang out with the right men or the right women (those who hang out with the men) at the right bars, and since the lesbian feminist community doesn't yet support its visual artists, you are less likely to make your work visible, to have professional dialogue, and to support yourself through your work either directly (sales) or indirectly (teaching). For women, the economic class system is largely determined by their relationship to men. The higher up the man she relates to, the more she benefits from the system. The lesbian, by not relating to men, does not benefit economically and has no privilege unless she is independently wealthy. Most of us do not have that kind

of support and opportunity, and without support, it is very difficult to continue making art. Historically, known lesbian visual artists (Rosa Bonheur, Romaine Brooks, etc.) were wealthy. Only they had the privilege to continue making art despite their public lesbian lifestyle.

If we examine the relationship of lesbians to the class system, and to patriarchy, we can get an idea of the active role art can play in developing a culture that does not make women powerless and invisible. In 'Lesbians and the Class Position of Women', Margaret Small writes:

> ... At this point in history, the primary role that lesbians have to play in the development of revolutionary consciousness is ideological. Because lesbians are objectively outside of heterosexual reality, they have potential for developing an alternative ideology not limited by heterosexuality. Lesbians stand in a different relationship to three conditions that determine the class position of women (production, reproduction, sexuality). The lesbian does not have a domestic base that is defined by the production of new labour power and maintenance of her husband's labour power. Her relationship is in proletarian terms. The element of slave consciousness integral to heterosexuality is missing.[1]

I am interested in how we can do this through art. Developing a class consciousness does not mean that each work of art by a woman would have to relate directly to women of all classes, but rather that the form and content of the work, be it figurative or abstract, would somehow illuminate experience in such a way that it is shared with and includes rather than excludes women from different backgrounds. Instead of presenting one universal experience that is supposed to represent ALL of us yet represents few, art should reflect and give information – facts, emotional response, visual accounting, ways of seeing into and understanding different experiences and feelings. We must acknowledge our differences in order to learn about, support and work with each other. Thus I feel that to make art as a lesbian with class consciousness has far-reaching creative and political potential for connecting women through work. This means actively rejecting cultural dictates, taking responsibility for our work, and questioning the concept of apolitical art. Art-making is where consciousness is formed.

Ultimately it is a question of the function of art beyond the personal. It is not merely a matter of doing work that doesn't oppress others, but also of doing work that pushes further towards a redefinition and transformation of culture. For me, coming out as a lesbian has a lot to do with developing a class consciousness, and that consciousness brought to my art raises questions of imagery, permanence, scale, ways of working and concepts of art education. It

raises questions of money and power, who sees my work, and what effect I want it to have on others.

This does not mean that we as class-conscious lesbian artists must make paintings with recognizable figurative imagery, that we must be downwardly mobile, give up making art for 'real political struggle', or involve ourselves in the rhetorical circles of the artistic left. What it does mean is not making or accepting class assumptions about art such as what is allowable as art, who makes it, who sees it, and what its function is to be. By removing aesthetic hierarchies and the need to pretend that we all share the same experiences, meaning can become accessible and available.

Talk about 'bringing art to the people' only reinforces class distinctions. Class consciousness can be reflected through our art by demystifying and deprivatizing the creative process. Presently it is difficult for a working-class woman who likes to write, paint or dance even to consider being a professional artist. When making art as well as owning art ceases to be a privilege, and the art-making process itself is available to women of different classes, races and geographic backgrounds, we can begin to understand the political potential of creative expression.

As lesbians, we need our experience validated culturally. To refuse art that denies our existence and to deny that art is apolitical and universal, is actively to challenge the wealthy few and their supporters who have been defining and controlling social order through the manipulation of fine art. Demanding group and self identity in art is one means of resisting oppression. The art-making process is a tool for making these demands and changes.

Art is essentially work. Simone Weil writes that art is a surplus commodity in this culture because it does not have immediate consumption and is not shared and used by the people. That artists are not part of the paid workforce further separates the productive from the consumptive classes. The work process (and the purpose of work) have always been external to the worker. Just as she writes that our main task is to discover how it is possible for the work to be free and to integrate it, we must free the art-making process so it is accessible and understandable to everyone. The process should be as available as the product.[2]

Acknowledging the existence of class structures, and how through art they can affect cultural attitudes is just a beginning – a necessary step one. In the long run, we should not focus merely on the relationship of one class to another, or on the relationship of art and class, but on defining a future classless society. The integration of art into the lives of all people and not just the upper class contributes to that vision. 'Revolution presupposes not simply an economic and political transformation but also a technical and cultural one.'[3]

1 [footnote 6 in source] Margaret Small, 'Lesbians and the Class Position of Women', in *Lesbianism*

and the Women's Movement, ed. Nancy Myron and Charlotte Bunch (Baltimore: Diana Press, 1975).

2 [7] Simone Weil, *First and Last Notebooks*, trans. Richard Rees (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1970) 58–61.

3 [8] Ibid.

Harmony Hammond, extract from 'Class Notes', *Heresies*, no. 3 (1977) 35–6.

Rotimi Fani-Kayode
Traces of Ecstasy//1988

It has been my destiny to end up as an artist with a sexual taste for other young men. As a result of this, a certain distance has necessarily developed between myself and my origins. The distance is even greater as a result of my having left Africa as a refugee over twenty years ago.

On three counts I am an outsider: in matters of sexuality; in terms of geographical and cultural dislocation; and in the sense of not having become the sort of respectably married professional my parents might have hoped for.

Such a position gives me a feeling of having very little to lose. It produces a sense of personal freedom from the hegemony of convention. For one who has managed to hang on to his own creativity through the crises of adolescence and in spite of the pressures to conform, it has a liberating effect, it opens up areas of creative enquiry which might otherwise have remained forbidden.

At the same time, traces of the former values remain, making it possible to take new readings onto them from an unusual vantage point. The results are bound to be disorientating. [...]

An awareness of history has been of fundamental importance in the development of my creativity. The history of Africa and of the Black race has been constantly distorted. Even in Africa, my education was given in English in Christian schools, as though the language and culture of my own people, the Yoruba, were inadequate or in some way unsuitable for the healthy development of young minds. In exploring Yoruba history and civilization, I have rediscovered and revalidated areas of my experience and understanding of the world. I see parallels now between my own work and that of the Osogbo artists in Yorubaland who themselves have resisted the cultural subversions of neocolonialism and who celebrate the rich, secret world of our ancestors.

It remains true, however, that the great Yoruba civilizations of the past, like

so many other non-European cultures, are still consigned by the West to the museums of 'primitive' art and culture.

The Yoruba cosmology, comparable in its complexities and subtleties to Greek and Oriental philosophical myth, is treated as no more than a bizarre superstition which, as if by miracle, happened to inspire the creation of some of the most sensitive and delicate artefacts in the history of art.

Modern Yoruba art (amongst which I situate my own contributions) may now sometimes fetch high prices in the galleries of New York and Paris. It is prized for its exotic appeal. Similarly, the modern versions of Yoruba beliefs carried by the slaves to the New World have become, in their carnival form, tourist attractions. In Brazil, Haiti and other parts of the Caribbean, the earth reverberates with old Yoruba rhythms which are now much appreciated by those jaded Western ears which are still sensitive enough to catch the spirit of the old rites. In other words, the Europeans, faced with the dogged survival of alien cultures, and as mercantile as ever they were in the days of the Trade, are now trying to sell our culture as a consumer product. I am inevitably caught up in this.

Another aspect of history – that of sexuality – has also affected me deeply. Official history has always denied the validity of erotic relationships and experiences between members of the same sex. As in the fields of politics and economics, the historians of social and sexual relations have been readily assisted in their fabrications by the Church. But in spite of all attempts by Church and state to suppress homosexuality, it is clear that enriching sexual relationships between members of the same sex have always existed. They are part of the human condition, even if the concept of sexual identity is a more recent notion.

There is a grim chapter of European history which was not drummed into me at school. I only discovered much later that the Nazis had developed the most extreme form of homophobia to have existed in modern times, and attempted to exterminate homosexuals in the concentration camps. It came not so much as a surprise but as yet another example of the longstanding European tradition of the violent supression of otherness. It touches me just as closely as the knowledge that millions of my ancestors were killed or enslaved in order to ensure European political economic and cultural hegemony of the world. I see in the current attitudes of the British Government towards Black people, women, homosexuals – in short, anyone who represents otherness – a move back in the direction of the fascistic values which for a brief period in the sixties and seventies ceased to dominate our lives. For this reason I feel it is essential to resist all attempts that discourage the expression of one's identity. In my case, my identity has been constructed from my own sense of otherness, whether cultural, racial or sexual. The three aspects are not separate within me. Photography is the tool by which I feel most confident in expressing myself. It is photography, therefore – Black,

African, homosexual photography – which I must use not just as an instrument, but as a weapon if I am to resist attacks on my integrity and, indeed, my existence on my own terms.

It is no surprise to find that one's work is shunned or actively discouraged by the Establishment. The homosexual bourgeoisie has been more supportive – not because it is especially noted for its championing of Black artists, but because Black ass sells almost as well as Black dick. As a result of homosexual interest, I have had various portfolios printed in the gay press, and in February a book of nudes will be published by GMP [Gay Men's Press]. Also, there has been some attention given to my erotic work by the sort of straight galleries which receive funding from more progressive local authorities.

But in the main, both galleries and press have felt safer with my 'ethnic' work. Occasionally they will take on board some of the less overtly threatening and outrageous pictures – in the classic liberal tradition. But Black is still only beautiful as long as it keeps within white frames of reference.

I have been more disconcerted by the response to my work from certain sections of the self-proclaimed avant-garde, however. At the recent MiSFiTS exhibition at Oval House [community theatre in South London] (which happened to coincide with the unveiling of a plaque to commemorate the birth there of Lord Montgomery of Alamein) I was asked, along with other artists, to remove my work in case it attracted unfavourable publicity for Oval House. We refused, naturally. Unfortunately, the press were too busy paying homage to Monty so the national reputation of Oval House was saved, and we were denied some free publicity. It is perhaps gratifying that the inadequacies of Oval House's Equal Opportunities Policy have since been recognized by many of its erstwhile supporters. But given the new Government ruling against local authority funding for any form of 'promotion' of homosexuality, I assume that, in any case, community organizations will no longer be allowed to show my work.

As for Africa itself, if I ever managed to get an exhibition in, say, Lagos, I suspect riots would break out. I would certainly be charged with being a purveyor of corrupt and decadent Western values.

However, sometimes I think that if I took my work into the rural areas, where life is still vigourously in touch with itself and its roots, the reception might be more constructive. Perhaps they would recognize my smallpox Gods, my transexual priests, my images of desirable Black men in a state of sexual frenzy, or the tranquility of communion with the spirit world. Perhaps they have far less fear of encountering the darkest of Africa's dark secrets by which some of us seek to gain access to the soul.

Rotimi Fani-Kayode, extracts from 'Traces of Ecstasy', *Ten.8*, no. 8 (1988) 36–42.

Derek Jarman
At Your Own Risk//1992

When I was young the absence of the past was a terror

That's why I wrote autobiography. The *Gay Sunshine Interviews* in the seventies were important; it was the first time I had read interviews with men who were talking about their sexuality, very openly in the case of Allen Ginsberg – that thrilled me. In one of the madder moments last week I thought I might parcel up all my work, all my videos, and send them to him as thanks for the help he had given me when I was young.

In 1982, my friend Nicholas told me to write it 'out'. There wasn't much gay autobiography, some tentative beginnings in the gay press but no one had written an autobiography in which they described a sex act – except Tom Driberg – certainly no one in my generation. That seemed to be a good reason to fill in the blanks and to start putting in the 'I' rather than the 'they'; and having made the decision about the 'I' to show how things related to me so that I wasn't talking of others – *they* were doing *this* and *they* were doing that.

It was very important to find the 'I': *I* feel this, this happened to *me*, *I* did this. I wanted to read that. My obsession with biography is to find these 'I's. The subtext of my films have been the books, putting myself back into the picture. There's a huge self-censorship because we're terrified of betraying ourselves. We don't want people to know. Looking at historical figures and wondering: were they gay? They may have had the same sexual preferences but 'gay' is a late twentieth-century concept. I always felt uncomfortable with it; it always seemed to me to exude a false optimism.

These names – gay, queer, homosexual, are limiting. I would love to finish with them. We're going to have to decide which terms to use and where we use them. What about 'same sex relationships'? Maybe that's the best.

Yesterday Gore Vidal was talking about Noel Coward and managed to describe heterosexuality as a transgression! For me to use the word 'queer' is a liberation; it was a word that frightened me, but no longer. [...]

Art action

It may seem ludicrous now that stumbling on Marlowe's outing speech from *Edward II* could be an eye-opener. His list of Queers included Socrates and Alcibiades. The Greeks knew how to live. Sappho and Plato were a revelation. In his *Symposium*, Plato recommends that only young men who love each other are fit for public office.

I began to read between the lines of history. The hunt was on for forebears who validated my existence. Was Western civilization Queer? The Renaissance certainly was. Lorenzo de Medici, Michelangelo, Leonardo, Botticelli, Rosso, Pontormo, Caravaggio, Shakespeare, Marlowe, Bacon.

Music was less Queer – unless it was British, in which case it was absolutely Queer – but there was unhappy Tchaikovsky forced to suicide by the evil Tzar because he was having an affair with a young aristocrat; the writers Whitman, Wilde, Gide, Proust and James. By the end of my first year at college I'd acquired some heavyweight soulmates.

Most of the works on our Queer lives underestimate the effect of art in favour of political action; I think this is wrong. I know that my world at eighteen wasn't the gift of politicians but of the identifiable homos; Cocteau (above board), Genet (under the counter), Burroughs and Ginsberg (heard of but not read). In 1962, we performed Genet's *The Maids* at the college. It caused as much fuss as a political action might today.

The sixties were to see major interventions by artists. David Hockney publicly acknowledging his sexuality from the beginning of his career; Kenneth Anger and Maya Deren's gift of the underground cinema; feature films like *Il Mare*; Andy Warhol's sexual circus; Rudolph Nureyev's leap to freedom.

What did that mean to me or my friends with cock up our arses and come splattering the ceilings? We joined THE UNDERGROUND. The underground, like the bars, was illicit. In the theatre the Lord Chamberlain was tight-arsed, no homos, and homos of eight or eighteen unthinkable. The theatre of the angry young men: DEAD STRAIGHT – the theatre was of *no* interest. Film was more interesting; at the first showing of Anger's *Scorpio Rising* and *Fireworks* at Camberwell art school we expected a police raid. The theatre reduced us to a load of laughable pantomime drag queens; it was in painting that the leap forward into normality was made in *We Two Boys Together Clinging* by David Hockney, and later the startling reality of lads I knew or recognized in bed together in the *Cavafy* etchings. [...]

Derek Jarman, extracts from *At Your Own Risk: A Saint's Testament* (London: Hutchinson, 1992; reprinted London: Vintage, 1993) 30–31, 46–7.

Gregg Bordowitz
The AIDS Crisis is Ridiculous//1993

[...] **Queer Structures of Feeling**

There are countercultural strategies that belong specifically to queers. A queer structure of feeling shapes cultural work produced by queers. In the words of Raymond Williams, who coined the term, a structure of feeling is 'the hypothesis of a mode of social formation, explicit and recognizable in specific kinds of art, which is distinguishable from other social and semantic formations by its articulations of presence'.[1]

Within the relation between two factors, a queer structure of feeling is formed. These two factors are: how heterosexist oppression attempts to contain queer sexualities, and how queers fight oppression by forming communities. Thus, a queer structure of feeling can be described as an articulation of presence forged through resistance to heterosexist society. Cultural work can be considered within a queer structure of feeling if self-identified queers produce the work, if these producers identify the work as queer, if queers claim the work has significance to queers, if the work is censored or criticized for being queer. A particular work is queer if it is viewed as queer, either by queers or bigots.

A queer structure of feeling is a set of cultural strategies of survival for queers. It is marked by an appreciation for the ridiculous, and it values masquerade. Mockery is its form; posing is its strategy. These general terms describe a continuity in the structure that traverses a number of generations. From generation to generation the emphasis of the structure shifts and new articulations surface to define the current moment. Some of the defining characteristics remain present in new articulations, establishing continuities in form.

The AIDS epidemic precipitated a crisis affecting the actual conditions of existence of many artists – many of them gay. Thus, many lesbian and gay artists took ideas current in the art world – appropriation, situationist strategies, institutional critique – and applied them to the struggle to wrest control of the public discussion of AIDS from right-wing fanatics who proposed homophobic and racist policies like quarantine. AIDS media activists also steal methods from dominant culture to make work that is meaningful to the communities affected by AIDS. Additionally, these activists deploy strategies that have been used effectively by lesbians and gay men to fight invisibility. These strategies are what Ridiculous Theater and AIDS-activist video share in common. [...]

Sorrow

For [Charles] Ludlam, sorrow is at the centre of drama:

> Bathos is that which is intended to be sorrowful but because of the extremity of the expression becomes comic. Pathos is that which is meant to be comic but because of the extremity of its expression becomes sorrowful. Some things which seem to be opposites are actually different degrees of the same thing.

But there is nothing intrinsically sorrowful about being queer. Oppression causes the sorrow in the lives of queers, and queers have developed a rich culture filled with joy in the face of sorrow. In particular, many AIDS media activists have organized into collectives, sharing resources to produce work vital to the interests of the communities affected by AIDS. I am a founding member of two AIDS video collectives: the Testing the Limits collective, formed in 1987 to document emerging forms of AIDS activism and which produced a videotape of the same name; and DIVA TV (Damned Interfering Video Activists), an affinity group of ACT UP that documents actions and provides counter-surveillance against police brutality at demonstrations. This loosely organized collective of approximately thirty members has produced three tapes thus far – *Target City Hall*, *Pride* and *Like a Prayer* (all 1989). Both collectives use democratic forms, such as consensus decision-making. The goals of both collectives are quickly to produce tapes that can be used by AIDS-activist direct action groups as organizing tools.

The processes employed by these collectives are significantly different from those found in the repertory theatre. The Ridiculous Theatrical Company was a small ensemble, under Ludlam's direction, committed to changing the history of theatre. During the AIDS crisis there is no sense that one can afford to work for years with a small group of people developing a set of ideas. And although AIDS-activist collectives have their share of divas, they are leaderless. They function with an extreme sense of urgency. A number of collective members in DIVA have died from AIDS, and many people in both video groups have lost numerous friends and lovers. Many AIDS activists are sick or HIV-infected. It is not possible for these groups to conceive of working relationships that aren't focused on well-defined, pragmatic goals that can be achieved in relatively short periods of time.

The production of Target City Hall addressed this imperative in its design as a work comprising sections, each produced by a different group with different levels of experience. The tape documented ACT UP's efforts to take over City Hall in New York in the late winter of 1989, in order to call attention to the collapse of the city's health care system. A music video section introduces the documentary. Another section, produced by the late Costa Pappas, draws on conventions of direct cinema and *cinéma vérité*. The third section was made by a group of

lesbians who adopted the name LAPIT (Lesbian Activists Producing Innovative Television) and whose contribution uses images from commercial TV news broadcasts juxtaposed with interviews, performances, rap, and activist-produced protest footage. Interspersed between these segments, the collective's editing committee added scenes, shot on black-and-white Super 8 film, of AIDS activists getting arrested at City Hall, which resemble archival footage of civil rights protests or demonstrations against US involvement in Vietnam. A full inventory of the conventions and tropes used in Target City Hall reflects the conflicting feelings of desperation and hopefulness that inform a queer structure of feeling, as well as a willingness to try any approach that will achieve a desired effect. This was true for Ludlam, and it is also true for many queer video makers producing work about AIDS: 'The theatre absurd believes in nothing, the theatre ridiculous believes in everything.'[2]

The queer theft of straight culture must not be viewed merely as oppositional. Ridiculous Theater, too, 'is not a comment (nostalgic, ironic or patronizing) on mass culture but it borrows from and imitates mass culture as fellow product of the popular imagination'.[3] It is possible to feel both admiration and contempt for dominant culture, and queers may easily have contradictory feelings about the culture that ignores and ridicules us. We are not acknowledged, nor are we invited to participate in this culture, but we comprise part of its audience. In his careful, studied use of material stolen from dominant culture-movies, plays, television, magazines, newspapers, Ludlam revealed a fascination with it. However, his use of this material was not destructive; it was generative. According to Ludlam, the aim of Ridiculous Theater is 'to get beyond nihilism by revaluing combat'. Today's videomakers manipulate the stuff that has fascinated us all our television-watching lives. For AIDS activists, getting 'beyond nihilism' requires that we overcome cynicism about our role in historical change. By 'revaluing combat' we assume responsibility toward change, recognizing our stake in dominant culture along the way. [...]

1 [footnote 6 in source] Raymond Williams, *Marxism and Literature* (Oxford and New York: Oxford University Press, 1977) 135.

2 [7] Richard Elovich tells me that he saw this statement on a poster advertising a Ridiculous production in the seventies.

3 [8] Stefan Brecht, *Queer Theatre* (London and New York: Methuen, 1978) 48.

Gregg Bordowitz, extracts from 'The AIDS Crisis is Ridiculous. In Memory of Craig Owens' (1993), in James Meyer, ed., *Gregg Bordowitz: The AIDS Crisis is Ridiculous and Other Writings, 1986–2003* (Cambridge, Massachusetts: The MIT Press, 2004) 48–50, 55–8, 66–7.

Isaac Julien
Mirror//2013

In many ways, *Looking for Langston* (1989) remains my pivotal piece. I never intended, of course, to make a life of Langston Hughes. It was always going to be about his status as a cultural icon and, in terms of repressed gay desire, what that might symbolize. I also knew I wanted to explore the act of looking and I knew I wanted to eroticize black bodies. It became quite a difficult project to imagine.

Pictorially the whole piece is very indebted to photography. I was looking at Roy DeCarava's pictures of Harlem, the work of Robert Mapplethorpe, and from the 1940s, homoerotic studies by George Platt Lynes, who worked in fashion. Lynes specialized in 'glamour' photography and I think his pictures are rather remarkable. But my real key to a *mise-en-scène* came from James Van Der Zee's portraits, specifically from those collected in *The Harlem Book of the Dead* (1978). That features pictures of people who have passed away, laid out in their coffins or even 'posing' with their loved ones. The photographs are staged in a very florid, baroque style that I found fascinating and at the same time almost camp. They speak to a preoccupation, a black aesthetic vernacular, that very much intersects with working-class taste. Yet they are also extraordinarily intimate.

I found those photos all the more moving because when I discovered them the AIDS epidemic was just reaching its height in England and in America. I was spending more and more of my time going to funerals, thinking about what it would be like to die in one's twenties. In Langston I extended this feeling to seeing how I would look in a coffin. That was also my little allusion to Roland Barthes' ideas about the death of the author, as well as a swipe at the cult of authorship in the film industry. As an undergraduate who had read Barthes and Jacques Derrida, I was interested by their ideas of authorship and of deconstructing 'history'. But even though I found empowerment in those theories, I was equally aware of a fundamental absence. That was the question of race, which always remained undiscussed. In all of these writings, race is never broached – so I was actually learning in a context from which I was absent. For me, this turned out to be a far-from-minor epiphany: it was the start of realizing that any work I made had to be able to build its own audience.

The central question in *Looking for Langston* was how to portray desire, and more specifically black gay desire. To talk about that, I knew right away one had to use fantasy. It's always been my observation that questions around desire tend to be located less in the real than in fantasy. Desire and its conflicts are at the heart of the cinema I'm interested in, even when it comes to genre works like

film noir or the thriller. Of course the visceral plays a central role in them all, but I always want my images to be visceral anyway. It's not enough for them to be just images; for me, images by themselves can never be enough. [...]

Our work wasn't circumscribed by what was happening to black people in this generally white society; we were making a critical attempt to get beyond all that, to get beyond the pathological ways in which we were being seen. That was one reason, in films like *Looking for Langston*, that we took up strategies such as the art of memory. I detested the old realist documentary modes. I made the work I did because I wanted to oppose them – in a way, I wanted totally to kill off those methods. Maybe today I still do; at least, all my work has been formed in response to those ways of thinking. Of course the documentary matters more in times of disinformation; then it can be rehabilitated. But I'm much more influenced by experimental film, by silent cinema and by performance. I've always gravitated toward a collage approach, because I can use it to evolve a more exciting and more personal language. Sometimes the term 'creolization' seems appropriate to me, because my technique is a broken mixture of different languages. Some of these are always quite high, but others are very local.

Long before *Langston*, Sankofa [film collective] had pretty much concluded that the working classes didn't really respond to documentary, at least not in the same manner as the middle class. I still feel that documentaries are essentially always made for the middle class and are concerned with middle-class views and anxieties. Working-class people tend to be more intrigued by fantasy, by stories and narratives – by ways of talking about their experience that are not didactic and in which they are not seen as lacking agency. So I had no interest in making films that were naturalistic and even less interest in anything ethnographic. So *Looking for Langston* is centred on reconstruction, dance and performance – it doesn't pretend to possess any naturalism. [...]

I rejected the role of 'black gay filmmaker'; I wanted to see myself as a broader cultural activist, someone who was engaged in making films about the black and gay experience but who equally dealt with the semiotics and the politics of the image. I was much more interested in making interventions of different kinds than in being seen as representing any community. Another thing about that time was exciting: this was a moment when we started to realize that given how the black subject had been placed in cinema, no film language had ever involved us in a progressive mode of any kind. Personally I took that as a great opportunity. [...]

When you go to art school, you learn about aesthetics and you begin to have all those kinds of debates. But when you grow up with an exterior world that is clearly ugly – a world that is degraded, that surrounds you with poverty – all that has a profound impact on your sensibilities. You actively want to involve yourself in appreciating the beautiful.

For me those circumstances are connected to what at Sankofa we began to call an 'aesthetic of reparation'. We were trying, in other words, to find different ways in which one could redeem how the black subject was represented.

Of course, holding up that mirror sometimes involves narcissism. But again, if you grow up in a world of images and none of them reflects you – or if they do, the experience is negative – the stakes are different once you start to make images of your own. Inevitably, such circumstances involve you in a very strong desire for reparation. When I say 'reparation' I'm not thinking about whether or not people are owed something because slavery existed. Neither are my thoughts totally psychoanalytical. I'm thinking about how one reframes and repositions *all* subjects. However, I'm also thinking about what the cinema would look like if there weren't always a question of the underlit black subject, or the question of that black subject in the frame's margin. With regard to the apparatus of filmmaking, all your decisions have real political consequences. In all of our debates during the eighties and nineties, a very central thing was the actual film technology. [...]

Another part of this whole idea of reparation stems from the injury not just to the physicality but to the whole image of a subject. That gives rise to a number of other questions: how does such a subject feel, how is he or she being viewed, and most important, how does the subject feel about that gaze? Attempting to redress that balance turned out to be very complicated.

This idea of the reparational image is often misunderstood. People do look at a work like *Langston* as being too beautiful, or too narcissistic, without understanding the sense of pain and injury one can feel in society. While I wouldn't exactly say that making such images was therapeutic, there was indeed work being done in a psychological sense. As well as broaching the gay black contribution in terms of history, *Looking for Langston* mattered in terms of talking about myself.

Still, people tend to focus on the look of the film; very often, it's described as 'sumptuous' or 'seductive'. But whenever you choose stylization, that will be controversial. People feel that surely you must be involved in romanticizing. My view about all that is pretty clear: if you have a distant relationship to the questions posed, of course you are free to view them romantically. That's possible because they don't directly affect you. But in my own work I never just *choose* a topic or subject. I'm usually talking about things from a nearby position; I feel I'm affected, albeit sometimes indirectly, by all those questions I raise aesthetically. At the end of the day, the very reason they are aestheticized is that real emotions come with them and are attached to them. I want the consideration of emotions, aesthetics and content – as well as the whole conceptual framework – to come together at once. I want it all perceived in the very same moment. [...]

Isaac Julien, extracts from 'Mirror' in *Isaac Julien: Riot* (New York: The Museum of Modern Art, 2013) 49–54.

Amy Sillman
AbEx and Disco Balls: In Defence of Abstract Expressionism, II//2011

I feel kind of bad for AbEx. At sixty-something, the old bird's gotten the gimlet eye from just about everybody: It's vulgar, it's the phallocracy, it's nothing but an empty trophy, it celebrates bourgeois subjectivity, it's a cold-war CIA front, and, well, basically, expression's really embarrassing. A dandy wouldn't be caught dead doing something as earnest as struggling, or channelling jazz with his arms. An *old-style* dandy, at least. T.J. Clark's 1994 text 'In Defence of Abstract Expressionism' made AbEx's connection to the vulgar perfectly clear, rendering it bathetic in all its ridiculous glory. But his writing touches only briefly on one of the most important aspects of this vulgarity – the fact that it is gendered. And it's precisely the gender vicissitudes of AbEx that I'd like to examine here: I would draw the dotted line back to 1964, when Susan Sontag mined this territory in her 'Notes on "Camp"', declaring, 'The old-style dandy hated vulgarity. The new-style dandy, the lover of Camp, appreciates vulgarity.'

How is it, exactly, that we forgot the new-style dandy? How is it that, despite the complexity of AbEx, its reputation has boiled down to the worst kind of gender essentialism? Its detractors would have it that the whole kit and caboodle is nothing but bad politics steel-welded around a chassis of machismo – that the paint stroke, the very use of the arm, is equivalent to a phallic spurt, to Pollock whipping out his dick and pissing in Peggy Guggenheim's fireplace. (This sexualized reading is itself, of course, a reversal of Clement Greenberg's earlier – but no less testosterone-driven – notion of AbEx as a pure and transcendent optical experience.) Meanwhile, AbEx's legacy presents us with a tangle of still more gender clichés, a strange terrain inhabited by fake-dude-women like Lee Krasner and Joan Mitchell, wielding their paint sticks like cowboys; and Pollock and de Kooning operating as phallic she-males, working from their innermost intuitive feelings, a 'feminization' that introduces another twist in this essentialist logic.

I thought we were past simple butch and femme role-playing by now. The current acronym for queers alone has stretched out to six options, LGBTQQ

(lesbian, gay, bi, trans, queer and questioning). But with AbEx, it's always the same old, same old. This kind of simplification wipes away the possibility of looking at all the really interesting vagaries and conflicts within AbEx, like the fact that Krasner actually was man enough to bend hot-pink planes with her bare hands, and the fact that Mitchell was no feminist. Maybe it's possible for me to look at AbEx through rose-coloured glasses because I came along too late to actually have to date any of those artists and I didn't have to sit on their laps at the Cedar Tavern. I'm sure they all probably were horrible in real life. But I'm still gung ho about looking at their work and finding in it tenderness, tragedy, contingency and inverted colour schemes; I'm still inspired by the rhetorical position of speaking from the gut, Walt Whitman style, by the AbExers' work with reimagined relations between parts and between forces, Gertrude Stein style, but in an anti-Platonic, improvisational, real-time mode of production.

Meanwhile, the only people worse than AbEx's haters are its defenders. And I agree, it makes you feel a little clammy to clap your arm around a form that seems to wear an American flag on its lapel, that is constantly being hailed as an American Triumph on public television and in bus shelters. AbEx: Saw it? Loved it! Got the tote bag – and it came with a free Charlie Parker record! (Poor old jazz, it's going through the same thing, but AbEx seems to have suffered a fate worse than jazz: jazz with money.) Of course, we know that the original AbExers were also horrified by the coming institutionalization. Art historian Serge Guilbaut cites a letter by Mark Rothko to his dealer, Betty Parsons, as early as 1948, in which Rothko writes: 'Men like Soby, Greenberg, Barr, etc ... are to be categorically rejected.' Once AbEx was thoroughly under glass, everyone involved tried to get away as fast as possible, either by acting irascible, or by fouling the 'high' of AbEx by courting the low, or by screwing up the 'Ab' part by embedding it with pictures, or by just moving away from New York. This evacuation left the entire property available for simplistic, ideological essentializing. But it also left us with a very nice plot of foreclosed real estate that, several generations later, younger artists could make use of – especially those who were supposedly barred from the place to begin with, as if we were squatters in Peggy Guggenheim's house.

Actually, the fear and loathing that AbEx arouses reminds me of that seventies punk button DISCO SUCKS. But disco *didn't* suck, and the injunction against it was perhaps more about homophobia and racism than about musical taste. What do you think they were listening to over at the Stonewall, anyway? I spent my youth at bars watching high femmes in gold-belted slacks do the hustle with thick-waisted girls in mullets. They *liked* Donna Summer. Disco wasn't just a corporate shill; it was the soundtrack for getting down with your marginalized pals.

Throughout the same decade that disco did or didn't suck, the mid seventies to mid eighties (before the birth of homocore clubs, where they played both punk

and dance music), I was a little undergrad painter-girl with a can of turpentine and a kneaded eraser, an earnest student with an old-guard teacher. If you attended art school in New York in those days, your teacher would most likely be one of these former AbEx party members who had gotten himself a teaching gig. I didn't like him, and he warned me in return that I would certainly fail as an artist, but he was the only painter I knew, and he played Sinatra in class and called AbEx 'action painting', which sounded exciting, and I wanted to have his clichés and eat them, too. AbEx was great, in other words, because it involved erasure. And *Erased de Kooning* was a downright lifestyle choice, a physical embodiment of uncertainty, a praxis of doubt. It wasn't just a defacement of AbEx; it was a recognition that a kind of negative capability was already there in de Kooning.

It pains me to admit how naive I was then, how little of the big theoretical picture I could see, but at the time, the art school system was completely divided between those who studied critical theory and those who studied studio art and painting. *They* studied the Soviet avant-gardes. *We* studied the School of Paris. Sontag's famous list of qualities for camp – 'the exaggerated, the fantastic, the passionate and the naive' – were the ones we studio students leaned on, and we were alive to the slightly outmoded feeling of AbEx, its sense of condemnation and failure. We didn't really know much about art, but we knew what we liked. AbEx was something grand lying around the dollar bin at the second-hand-book store, something to be looked at, cut up and used as material, like punk music or underground movies or other sloppy, enthusiastic things made by a lineage of do-it-yourselfers and refuseniks with a youthful combination of awareness and naivety. As Sontag says, 'In naive, or pure, Camp, the essential element is seriousness, a seriousness that fails.'

I wouldn't call this negative way of working de-skilling, though; it was more like an active embrace of the aesthetics of awkwardness, struggle, nonsense, contingency. For better or worse, we didn't glean the mythic aspect of AbEx, and therefore we were not limited by its ironclad gender identity, its masculine grandiosity. Since we weren't selling anything ourselves anyway, the commodity critique of AbEx was also lost on us. I didn't want to limit myself with the critical rhetoric around either disco or AbEx, because to do so would leave me – where? You have to ask yourself, What do you want to do all day and night, and how are you going to make a painting practice, anyway? AbEx was simply one technique of the body for those dedicated to the handmade, a way to throw shit down, mess shit up, and perform aggressive erasures and dialectical interrogations. If you want to make something with your hands, if you want the body to lead the mind and not the other way around, you may likely end up in the aisle of the cultural supermarket that includes painterly materials and AbEx delivery systems: canvas, oil sticks, fat paintbrushes, rags, trowels, scrapers, mops, sponges, buckets and

drop cloths. And it's not that you're going to be working 'like' an AbExer, but that the tools themselves will mandate a certain phenomenology of making that emanates from shapes, stains, spills and smudges.

Later on, I could perform a more sophisticated manoeuvre by doubling back on and reversing the injunction against AbEx, performing a critique of the critique, one that allowed me to appropriate AbEx as a practice back into my own hands and twist it into the form I wanted it to assume. Camp is alive to a sense of the doubled, and same-old-same-old AbEx was ripe for double *détournement.* This reclamation amounted to reversing the reversal of its fortune. AbEx was a form for the defiant optimism of our own remodelled and low-to-the-ground culture. Its very sentimentality and ridiculousness proposed a rich archive for future 'conceptual painting', painting that used the bad taste and bad values of the art world as springboards rather than as end points. Like disco, AbEx could be reclaimed as a Foucauldian materialist-discursive practice, connected to the 'bodies, functions, physiological processes, sensations and pleasures' described in Foucault's *History of Sexuality*, volume 1.

And, of course, AbEx was already undone while I was still studying it. Warhol's piss paintings, Morris's cut felt and Rauschenberg's erasure – all the now canonical work that came on the heels of AbEx – had been doing a thorough job of referencing, reversing and emptying out AbEx's rhetoric and techniques. But still, in artmaking, things don't necessarily happen in order. They happen simultaneously, or they circle around and repeat, or they are incomplete, or people realize things backward or feel a fondness for forms of obsolescence. In fact, while AbEx was already debased, de-skilled, materialized and sexualized twenty years after it began, other people had been working adjacent to it all along, or just recently realized that they might do so. You might kill the father, but you don't have to kill the already dead uncle.

So I don't find it odd that AbEx practices have now been vitally reinvigorated by a queered connection of the vulgar and the camp. Many artists – not least of them women and queers – are currently recomplicating the terrain of gestural, messy, physical, chromatic, embodied, handmade practices. I would argue that this is because AbEx already *had* something to do with the politics of the body, and that it was all the more tempting once it seemed to have been shut down by its own rhetoric, rendered mythically straight and male in quotation marks. AbEx's own deterioration into cliché was a ripe ground, a double-edged challenge that, to quote Sontag again, 'arouses a necessary sympathy'. AbEx was like a big old straight guy who had gone gay.

Speaking of rolling in my grave, when I saw Leidy Churchman's videos last year, I thought, I can die now; my message to the world has been received, and gestural art is in good hands again. In Churchman's 'painting treatment' pieces,

which were shown last year in 'Greater New York' at MoMA PS1, Churchman and associate Anna Rosen performed improvisational acts of painting upon friends' bodies, flaunting carnal pleasures via one of their most commonplace forms – as 'treatments', as in spa treatments. Even critical theorists like a rubdown, right? We who participated in the creation of Churchman's videos were invited to come in, take off our clothes, and lie down under towels while Churchman-plus-Rosen did things to us. As they worked horizontally across our prone bodies, we lay languorously in an increasingly spaced-out, spa-like state of mind, and the camera recorded a cropped image of the proceedings, *Flaming Creatures* style. They did excessive, polychromatic things to our bodies, like dipping a banana into a can of orchid-lavender paint and pressing it against our asses, or dragging a rake with green and brown paint in its combs across our legs, or letting chrome-yellow enamel dribble off random pieces of plywood onto the smalls of our backs, or tossing some green-grey grit on us.

As Sontag noted, 'Camp is a *tender* feeling', and it was nice being prodded, touched, stroked and dribbled on with the warmish liquidity of paint. And meanwhile, the supposedly manly, authoritative and triumphant discourse of AbEx had been displaced, not by a parodic emasculation or a cynical recapitulation, but with a newly enthusiastic form of painting as a nudie activity. It was a way to spend the afternoon with your friends and do something both tender and sloppy. I actually liked the 'paintings' formally, too, not so much the towels themselves, which were fairly arbitrary (and which Churchman judiciously did not exhibit), but the way the painting process and detritus looked on the video monitor, in a state of discarded materialist excess. These images reminded me of the films of Austrian filmmaker Kurt Kren, whose orgiastic and abject throw-downs are more fertile than they are masculine, with images of feathers, milk, eggs and plant life falling on breasts, nipples and lips. And that put me in mind of the party scene in Kenneth Anger's *Scorpio Rising*, and then the sight of Carolee Schneemann in her holster wielding crayons on the walls in her seventies performance *Up to and Including Her Limits*. The list goes on: most of Paul Thek's work, Yayoi Kusama's sixties film where she is shown painting dots on everything from her friend's back to the surface of a pond, Hélio Oiticica's street actions and *Parangolés*, etc. All of these are acts of sensuous and repellent aggression by artists responding to the AbEx vocabulary, artists for whom AbEx was essential as a reclaimed template for their own promiscuous and unessentialized surplus. And these works are slightly different from, say, Warhol making his piss paintings, because they seek not just to mimic or dismantle AbEx, leaving it as a sardonically depleted trace of itself, but to engage it in a dialectical conversation, with a sense of inquisitiveness, openness and even the risk of actual delight – not *un*doing but *re*doing, if from an oblique angle. Even now, as we pass into a time when pencil smudges themselves

are an increasingly exoticized thing of the past, the world is still tactile and material. To touch it is to know it.

Things have changed, but I still hear AbEx characterized fairly regularly as just a bunch of macho gestures, now collapsed and out of use. It reminds me of an occasion about a decade ago, when I went to give a talk somewhere in America at a university art department that was populated by self-described 'content-driven' students and faculty. 'Content-driven' was how you said it back then – meaning, 'We work with politics and abhor the (supposed) emptiness of formalism.' So I naturally insisted extra hard on the *form* in my work, taking a certain perverse pleasure in describing myself as a kind of formalist. This didn't go over too well with the crowd, who became audibly disgruntled. Afterwards, though, some bearded guys came up to say how much they *loved* the talk, and when they walked away, I found out that they were transgendered men. It was funny for me to realize that the people who loved my formalist rap the most were the guys who had gone the furthest in their own personal lives to make specific changes to their own forms. We were both committed to an idea of the inseparability of form and content, and we were working with their interactions, their malleability; if you could change one side, you could change the other. This made for a funny alliance – funny ha-ha *and* funny peculiar.

Amy Sillman, 'AbEx and Disco Balls: In Defence of Abstract Expressionism, II', *Artforum*, vol. 49, no. 10 (Summer 2011) 321–5.



Sharon Hayes, *Revolutionary Love: I Am Your Worst Fear, I Am Your Best Enemy*, 2008

Hudson
Sex Pot//1986

Ipso facto.

All homosexuals should carry guns and, with the conscience of acting, not be afraid to use them. A majority of Supreme Court Justices should be burned in effigy – nightly – in front of their homes forever and in as many other places as possible while butt-fuckers and oral copulators go at it on every street corner, in every public building, in front of churches and when the cops come to bust 'em, just blow 'em away. Dynamite their cars. Take no prisoners.

It's going to take too much time too much money and too much effort to right this; and what's right is right, and what's wrong is wrong and we're the one.

Mr President, we know where you live. We know your every fear. Assassination plots thicken. Strike forces are in place and we're going to get you. We're going to get you and fuck you up the ass with a pecker aids virus bigger than John Holmes. Mr President, we know where you live. We know your every fear. Assassination plots thicken. Strike forces are in place and we're going to get you. We look like everyone and we are everywhere and like a rat running across the road looking for a hole we're going to find your hole and fuck it up with a pecker aids virus bigger than John Holmes.

after we roll you in thick garbage juice – the kind that sloshes out the backend of trash pick-up trucks when they take corners.

This is an idea whose time has come like so many men have come before. No one knows about the relationship between god and me.

We like flowers, rocks, bunnies, families, dinner parties, nice clothes, the outdoors, cars, tv, shopping, books, movies, records, live concerts, dogs, cats, grandparents, government, pornography, love, sex.

sex is great
it's '86
This is not a symbolic gesture; we are the living sign.
Wet or dry we're not holding back and when the shit hits the fan –

muck.
The tables are turned.
When you walk without eating
in the cell of your heart
a horrible, horrible dream,
your precious seed a wine factory
pussy foot
deep in debt
cumulative effect
real shock busters
no salt added
plastic surgeon

Hudson, from the performance *Sex Pot* (1986), in Dennis Cooper, Richard Hawkins, eds, *Against Nature: A Show by Homosexual Men* (Los Angeles: LACE [Los Angeles Contemporary Exhibitions], 1987) 16.

Sergio Zevallos
The Obscene Death / Peru: 1982–1988//1988

I shall refer herein to some of the motivations and life circumstances whose contents forged the nature of those series of images that I created as part of the project *PERU. A DREAM*, by Grupo Chaclacayo.

Up front, I must note that the physical – and thus psychological – distance from the reality and common norms of Peruvians, while still permitting the critical observation thereof, was the only possibility for unconditionally developing my expressions. This creative profusion was also the result of crossing paths with Helmut Psotta, a meeting whose meaning lay in the intense confrontation between two consciences and sensibilities rooted in radically opposite realities of today's Western world.

Through this, we were able to achieve an ideal space for the task of demystifcation, based on impartiality and mutual respect. Later on, Christian culture as an inherent principle of all historical causes neutralized any apparent differences, spontaneously establishing a point of departure for our depictions.

To be Peruvian in today's world is to have grown up in a country rooted in the constant threat toward the individual as an official method of control accepted by all; it is to defencelessly withstand a drastic moral decline and its after effects

in the absence of any inhibitions against murder; to grow permanently accustomed to banal deaths caused by simple, avoidable mistakes, and deliberate ones too. So many simultaneous aggressions wind up turning the very meaning of existence upside down. To live promiscuously with that Death which forces upon us the visual consumption of countless cadavers, cadavers that take on a leading role in a grotesque 'Human Tragedy', exposing their indecency before our even more indecent gazes, a lugubrious scene from a day-to-day life gone astray in this irrational history.

If the foregoing sounds like a nightmare, my works must assume that same obsessive nature which leads them without fail to the bowels of being. This emotional imperative was already at work in the first series of actions I performed in Lima's suburbs, under the title *Passions of a Wandering Body* – the incarnation of a collective destiny. In the very womb that gave life to my youth, I interpreted a morbid *Danse Macabre* surrounded by rubble, my nude body bound by bandages personifying impotence and shamelessness in the face of abandonment, like a sensitive statue on cold stone in the middle of a storm.

Simultaneously to the creation of my drawings, I collected a corpus of everyday texts and images with references to cults and myths, whether religious or profane, with which to orient myself; a constant attempt to link past and present, using my own biography as a meeting point for all the given elements. There came the meeting between Catholic pathos in its most fleshed-out colonial expression, the myth of Saint Rose of Lima, and the idolatry of men by men in the worship of national heroes; the Inquisition Court and its modern-day equivalent, the institution of torture during police interrogations; the urban deformations of ancient Andean funerals and clandestine mass graves or the trafficking of victims of political power. Blood – incense – ash are media and metaphor here for that sickly downhill slide from lust to death that advances surreptitiously from one case to the next, an insurmountable atavism whose origins date back to the evangelizing crusade of the sixteenth century.

A living example of this can be seen in the 'Procession of the Lord of Miracles', which packs the streets of Lima to bursting each October with its amorphous and violet-coloured multitude. Lethargic, sweaty, submerged in clouds of incense, they bear the weight of an impassive and sterile Christ in the name of their outsized pseudo-religious longings. One feels as if one has gone back in time, watching this ignorant mass go by in a Funeral March as a group of bored bishops bless them mechanically, the tremendous submission of a people who have long ago forgotten their true identity. At the other extreme of indigenous myth, we fnd more eloquent symbols for the Christian usurpation of their authentic contents. In certain parts of the Andes, the land identifed with the Virgin Mary is also associated with amphibians; her invocation as a female deity under the

name of Saint Mary the TOAD is carried out while torturing these animals, whose cries are meant to 'seduce' the Water God to wash over Her. Here we have the Mystery of the Immaculate Conception reverted to its profane and biological condition, in this metaphorical combination of Toad–*Mater Dolorosa*, an attempt to bear the tragic destiny of their 'Mother Earth' bathed in blood by the European *conquistadores*. Such symbioses of symbols fascinate me to no end, providing a captivating subject for depiction.

There arises then the question, 'How do I oppose this enormous accumulation of dementias?' Spontaneous mockery has always been my ally, and in this attitude I have found an authentic creative principle in the *transgression* of all dogmatic norms and ideologies, inverting their traditional meanings via free or premeditated associations. However, by establishing this new symbolic form, I fnd myself on the path back to the grave seriousness of the facts, thus tipping all the weight of the 'scale' – my biography – toward the human side. Turning my experience of violence into the ability to express it as sensitively and forcefully as possible: that is my ideal.

The aesthetic I develop also has a specifc influence: squalor, its aspect, and the scenes to which it gives rise. I am defined by a sensibility formed through the permanent observation of trash heaps and human degradation, where the arrogant vanity of the dominant class parades around, marginalizing everything under a tasteless layer of make-up. It is in this mixture where I fnd that which is truly obscene. But concealing spiritual or physical squalor and thinking only of 'beauty', as defned by an ambivalent moral sense, the essence of kitsch and cynicism, are widespread traits in the West. This is the OBSCENE DEATH. Thus, the 'libido' of the objects used, followed by the consciousness of the banal or brutal use that give rise to them, and fnally the meaning obtained from the dialectical combination of the two have been essential stimuli for elaborating a language in the form of a Symbol-Trace or Symbol-Wound, profane relics of my particular *gaze*.

In this context, nudity – the true *Corpus Delicti* – is always a signifer of murder, evoking the animal nature that comes before being human, the primordial violence from which we spring. Sexual elements are infected with the same meaning, with their more or less direct allusion introducing a vertiginous sentiment of prohibition, thus achieving the maximum possible tension in a synthesis of information. And once again, reality justifes me: rape and sexual torture using the penis as an instrument of submission are acts from which our culture can never recover. And from this, one can infer the principal target of my message: men, or more specifically the type of women without a womb into which we have degenerated.

Along these same lines, I would like to make note of the phenomenal act that summarizes all the different variants of my foregoing reflections: the lascivious

burial of Saint Rose (Lima, 1617), where a people desperate to possess her as a relic profaned her defenceless body almost as soon as she had died: this poor daughter of Catholicism, violated to this very day by masculine devotion – which tries in this way to expiate its frustrated sexuality – converting her into a hybrid between a Virgin and Executioner to be venerated. She is a constant in my work, covering all the degrees between eroticism and brutality, and here I refer of course to the myth the Church so pompously spreads.

All of these contents should be interrelated amongst themselves in a cyclical sequence, returning always to the elemental chaos from which they arose to once again achieve an explicit form, ever freer and more forceful; to make of it all a mirror, a *Physiognomy* of the Human Condition, able to evoke the concrete sensation of what I wish to express: that is, cruelty and the disgust it produces in me.

Sergio Zevallos, 'The Obscene Death / Peru: 1982–1988: A Shadowy Womb for My Images' (1988); reprinted in Miguel A. López, ed., *Un Cuerpo Ambulante: Sergio Zevallos en el Grupo Chaclacayo* (1982–1993) (Lima: El Museo de Arte de Lima, 2014) 140–41.

Las Yeguas del Apocalipsis
So that Sex under the Bridges Doesn't Die//1989

My beloved boy:

In this sausage country where everything is settled with its back to the pedestrian's gaze, in this venomous winter; the deaf old lady, the retired crip, the traffic of UGLYVISTA,[1] the incarcerated cop, the change for a cigarette, Alameda ALAMEDA[2] ... walking alone, Chilean-mares, the maricovento[3] of Pancho-Pedro, art bottoms seeking a country, a corner of macho men to raise their glass to sodoma, the great whore. MY-SODOMA, the hunted ... SAN CAMILA-MON AMOUR[4] ... fags forever, rights for the small hole, the standard ass, the pamphlet ass, the homos and the 'bread, work, justice and liberty ...'[5] Now that everything is changing, we, the tragic dolls become the DANGEROUS DELINQUENTS,[6] we play these times, we show our face and declare 'A HOMOSEXUAL PROJECT', a sidewalk for transvestites, a trace of the river, a retirement fund for whores, our unconditional allies; so that sex under bridges doesn't die, so that they don't turn on the lights at the Capri Cinema,[7] for reclining seats in public bathrooms ... Fuck the underground, the rich kids who pay five hundred in MATACAMAS,[8] with

premature ejaculation, singing 'GAY DOGS', those kids that aren't hard, rather they are kids who are troubled and say 'LETS GO TOGETHER' and it's a lie because now we're not going anywhere together.[9] The tribes manage themselves; the gypsies, the lumpen, the gigolos, those disgusting hippie-snobs of SAN ALFONSO,[10] sudacas,[11] the PUNK boy I fucked one night,[12] the PATRIOTIC front (from the front),[13] the only anarchist balls, in the end (sigh) ... CHILITO-BALLS[14] castaway soup, little virgin of huff, CHILITO-FAGGOT,[15] beating transvestites for the visit of the POPE, dirty money trafficking ALLENDE under the tear gas ... CHILITO-RED who kicked us out of the LONG LIVE THE PEOPLE.

'In the communist party there's no fags!', they screamed at us almost in fear, two homosexuals against a stadium,[16] we wanted to offer a manifesto to the MAIRA and VOLODIA TRIBUNALS,[17] the pretorian security almost made us into mashed-mare, the sign that we couldn't open said 'HOMOSEXUALS FOR CHANGE' like MARE STROIKAS and it had no ORTOgraphic[18] mistake, but they didn't understand ... get it?'

Affectionately,
The Mares of the Apocalypse

1 *Uglyvista* references Bellavista ('beautiful view'), the bohemian neighbourhood in Santiago de Chile. In this neologism the emphasis is on its antithesis, 'ugly view', likely to refer to the availability of 'ugly' or queer sex work and workers in this district.

2 *Alameda* is the colloquial slang for Avenida Libertador Bernardo O'Higgins, the most central and important avenue in Santiago.

3 *Maricovento* queers the word *covento* (convent) – Pedro Lemebel and Francisco Casas, 'The Mares of the Apocalypse', here conflate it with *maricón* (fag) as the prefix.

4 'My beloved San Camila' refers to San Camilo, a neighbourhood where sex work proliferates and trans people transit, a site that Lemebel and Casas return to in *La Ultima Cena de San Camilo* (1989), *Casa Particular* (1989), and *Estrellada* (1989), which document and pay homage to trans-feminine culture. As is consistent throughout their writing, Lemebel and Casas modify the gender of masculine nouns here, from Camilo to Camila.

5 Slogan of the Chilean communist party.

6 *Patas malas*, a feminine noun transformation from the more traditional and masculine *patos malos*, taken from *coa*, Chilean prison/street slang, which translates literally as 'bad ducks', and refers to delinquents.

7 Pornographic cinema in downtown Santiago, popular as a cruising site.

8 *Matacamas* is a neologism that translates literally as 'kills (in) the bed', perhaps a play on Atacama, a territory in the North of Chile.

9 'Let's Go Together' was one of the slogans used in the campaign for democratic transition.

10 Refers to San Alfonso del Mar, a bourgeois beach location near Santiago.

11 *Sudaca* merges *sud* (south) and *caca* (shit) – shit from the south, a derogatory insult used to refer to people from South America, often directed at migrants from the Americas.

12 The verb used is *comí*, literally 'ate', but in the context of Chilean slang the meaning is sexual.

13 Refers to the revolutionary group Manuel Rodríguez Patriotic Front (FPMR), abbreviated as El Frente, who were responsible for the assassination attempt on Augusto Pinochet in 1986.

14 *Chilito* – the suffix *ito*, which is common in Chilean slang, makes the noun diminutive, i.e. little Chile/little Chilean, but is also used as a term of endearment, as in beloved.

15 The original term used is *Hueco* which translates as 'hollow', in reference to an unfilled cavity, thus its use as Chilean slang for 'faggot'.

16 Refers to a mass event that celebrated the arrival of democracy in March of 1990 and that was hosted at the National Stadium.

17 Luis Maira is a recognized socialist politician; in 1989 he was the president of the Chilean Party of the Christian Left (Partido Izquierda Cristiana de Chile) and an active leader in the democratic transition. Volodia Teitelboim is a national literature laureate and was the president of the Communist Party from 1989–94.

18 *Orto* is used in Chile as a vulgar synonym for the anus. Here the word is employed as a homophone of Ortho (in orthographic), with the intention of creating a *double entendre*. In its original Spanish use there is no spelling mistake.

Las Yeguas del Apocalipsis [The Mares of the Apocalypse, Pedro Lemebel and Francisco Casas], 'Que No Muera el Sexo Bajo de Los Puentes' [So that Sex under the Bridges Doesn't Die], *Revista Trauko*, no. 16 (August 1989). Translation and notes by Lissette Olivares, 2015.

Marlon T. Riggs
Black Macho Revisited: Reflections of a Snap! Queen//1991

Negro Faggotry is in fashion.

SNAP!

Turn on your television and camp queens greet you in living colour.

SNAP!

Turn to cable and watch America's most bankable modern minstrel expound on getting 'fucked in the ass' or his fear of faggots.

SNAP!

Turn off the TV, turn on the radio: Rotund rapper Heavy D, the self-styled 'overweight lover MC', expounds on how *his* rap will make you 'happy like a

faggot in jail'. Perhaps to pre-empt questions about how he would know – one might wonder what kind of 'lover' he truly is – Heavy D reassures us that he's just 'extremely intellectual, not bisexual' (*BLK*, March 1990: 3).

Jelly-roll SNAP!

Negro Faggotry *is* in vogue. Madonna commodified it into a commercial hit. Mapplethorpe photographed it, and art galleries drew fire and record crowds in displaying it. Black macho movie characters dis'– or should we say *dish*? – their antagonists with unkind references to it. Indeed references to, and representations of, Negro Faggotry seem a rite of passage among contemporary Black male rappers and filmmakers.

Snap-swish-and-dish divas have truly arrived, giving Beauty Shop drama at centre stage, performing the read-and-snap two-step as they sashay across the movie screen, entertaining us in the castles of our homes-like court jesters, like eunuchs – with their *double entendres*, their dead-end lusts, and, above all, their relentless hilarity in the face of relentless despair.

Negro Faggotry is the rage! Black Gay Men are not. For in the cinematic and television images of and from Black America as well as the words of music and dialogue which now abound and *seem* to address my life as a Black Gay Man, I am struck repeatedly by the determined, unreasoning, often irrational desire to discredit my claim to Blackness and hence to Black Manhood.

The terrain Black Gay Men navigate in the quest for self and social identity is, to say the least, hostile. What disturbs – no, enrages – me is not so much the obstacles set before me by whites, which history has conditioned me to expect, but the traps and pitfalls planted by my so-called brothers, who because of the same history should know better.

I am a Negro Faggot, if I believe what movies, TV, and rap music say of me. Because of my sexuality, I cannot be Black. A strong, proud, 'Afrocentric' Black man is resolutely heterosexual, not *even* bisexual. Hence I remain a Negro. My sexual difference is considered of no value; indeed it's a testament to weakness, passivity, the absence of real guts – balls. Hence I remain a sissy, punk, faggot. I cannot be a Black Gay Man because, by the tenets of Black Macho, Black Gay Man is a triple negation. I am consigned, by these tenets, to remain a Negro Faggot. And as such I am game for play, to be used, joked about, put down, beaten, slapped and bashed, not just by illiterate homophobic thugs in the night, but by many of Black American culture's best and brightest.

In a community where the dozens, signifying, dis'ing and *dishing* are revered as art forms, I ask myself: What does this obsession with Negro Faggotry signify? What is its significance?

What lies at the heart, I believe, of Black America's pervasive cultural homophobia is the desperate need for a convenient Other *within* the community,

yet not truly *of* the community – an Other on which blame for the chronic identity crises afflicting the Black male psyche can be readily displaced; an indispensible Other that functions as the lowest common denominator of the abject, the baseline of transgression beyond which a Black Man is no longer a man, no longer Black; an essential Other against whom Black men and boys maturing, struggling with self-doubt, anxiety, feelings of political, economic, social and sexual inadequacy – even impotence – can always measure themselves and by comparison seem strong, adept, empowered, superior.

Indeed the representation of Negro Faggotry disturbingly parallels and reinforces America's most entrenched racist constructions around African-American identity. White icons of the past signifying 'Blackness' share with contemporary icons of Negro Faggotry a manifest dread of the deviant Other. Behind the Sambo and the Snap! Queen lies a social psyche in torment, a fragile psyche threatened by deviation from its egocentric/ethno-centric construct of self and society. Such a psyche systematically defines the Other's 'deviance' by the essential characteristics which make the Other distinct, then invests those differences with intrinsic defect. Hence, Blacks are inferior because they are not white; Black Gays are unnatural because they are not straight. Majority representations of both affirm the view that Blackness and Gayness constitute a fundamental rupture in the order of things, that our existence is an affront to nature and humanity.

For Black Gay Men this burden of (mis)representation is compounded. We are saddled by historic caricatures of the Black Male, now fused with newer notions of the Negro Faggot. The resultant dehumanization is multi-layered and profound.

What strikes me as most insidious, and paradoxical, is the degree to which popular African-American depictions of us as Black Gay Men so keenly resonate American majority depictions of us, as Black people. Within the Black Gay community, for example, the Snap! [finger-snap] contains a multiplicity of coded meanings – as in SNAP! 'Got your point!' or SNAP! 'Don't even try it!' *or* SNAP! 'You *fierce*!' or SNAP! 'Get out my face!' or SNAP! 'Girlfriend, pleeeease.' The Snap! can be as emotionally and politically charged as a clenched fist; can punctuate debate and dialogue like an exclamation point, a comma, an ellipsis; or can altogether negate the need for words among those who are adept at decoding its nuanced meanings.

But the particular appropriation of the Snap! by Hollywood's Black Pack deflates the gesture into rank caricature. Instead of a symbol of communal expression and, at times, cultural defiance, the Snap! becomes part of a simplistically reductive Negro Faggot identity: it functions as a mere signpost of effeminate, cute, comic homosexuality. Thus robbed of its full political and

cultural dimension, the Snap!, in this appropriation, descends to stereotype. Is this any different from the motives and consequences associated with the legendary white dramatist T.D. Rice, who more than 150 years ago appropriated the tattered clothes and dance style of an old crippled Black man, then went on stage and imitated him, thus shaping in the popular American mind an indelible image of Blacks as simplistic and poor yet given, without exception, to 'natural' rhythm and happy feet?

A family tree displaying dominant types in the cultural iconography of Black men would show, I believe, an unmistakable line of descent from the Sambo to the Snap! Queen and, in parallel lineage, from the Brute Negro to the AIDS-infected Black Homo/Con/Rapist. What the members of this pantheon share is an extreme displacement and distortion of sexuality. In Sambo and the Snap! Queen, sexuality is repressed, arrested. Laughter, levity and a certain childlike disposition cement their mutual status as comic eunuchs. Their alter egos, the Brute Black and the Homo/Con, are but psychosocial projections of an otherwise tamed sexuality run amuck – bestial, promiscuous, pathological.

Contemporary proponents of Black Macho thus converge with D.W. Griffith in their cultural practice, deploying similar devices toward similarly dehumanizing ends. In their constructions of 'unnatural' sexual aggression, the infamous chase scene in *Birth of a Nation* and the homophobic jail rap – or should I say attempted rape? – in Reginald and Warrington Hudlin's *House Party* display a striking aesthetic kinship.

The resonances go deeper.

Pseudo-scientific discourse fused with popular icons of race in late-nineteenth-century America to project a social fantasy of Black men, not simply as sexual demons, but as intrinsically corrupt. Diseased, promiscuous, destructive of self and others, our fundamental nature, it was widely assumed, would lead us to extinction.

Against this historical backdrop consider the highly popular comedy routines of Eddie Murphy, which unite Negro Faggotry and 'Herpes Simplex 10'– and AIDS – into an indivisible modern icon of sexual terrorism. Rap artists and music videos resonate this perception, fomenting a social psychology that blames the *victim* for his degradation and death.

The prime-time fag pantomimes, camp queens as culture critics, and the proliferating bit-part swish-and-dish divas who, like ubiquitous Black maids and butlers in fifties' Hollywood films, move along the edges of the frame, seldom at the centre, manifest the persistent psychosocial impulse toward control, displacement and marginalization of the Black Gay Other. This impulse, in many respects, is no different than the phobic, distorted projections which motivated blackface minstrelsy.

This is the irony: there are more Black male filmmakers and rap artists than ever, yet their works display a persistently narrow, even monolithic, construction of Black male identity.

'You have to understand something', explained Professor Griff of the controversial and highly popular rap group Public Enemy, in an interview. 'In knowing and understanding black history, African history, there's not a word in any African language which describes homosexual, y'understand what I'm saying? You would like to make them part of the community, but that's something brand new to black people' (*Melody Maker*, 31 March, 1990). Thus Black Macho appropriates African history – or, rather, a deeply reductive, mythologized view of African history – to rationalize homophobia. Pseudo-academic claims of 'Afrocentricity' have now become a popular invocation when Black Macho is pressed to defend its essentialist vision of the race. An inheritance from Black Cultural Nationalism of the late sixties, and Negritude before that, today's Afrocentrism, as popularly theorized, premises an historical narrative which runs thus: Before the white man came, African men were strong, noble protectors, providers and warriors for their families and tribes. In precolonial Africa, men were truly men. And women ... were women. Nobody was lesbian. Nobody was feminist. Nobody was gay.

This distortion of history, though severe, has its seductions. Given the increasingly besieged state of Black men in America, and the nation's historic subversion of an affirming Black identity, it is no wonder that a community would turn to pre-Diasporan history for metaphors of empowerment. But the embrace of the African warrior ideal – strong, protective, impassive, patriarchal – has set us down a perilous road of cultural and spiritual redemption, and distorted or altogether eliminated from the historical record the multiplicity of identities around colour, gender, sexuality and class which inform the African and African-American experience.

It is to me supremely revealing that, in Black Macho's popular appropriation of Malcolm X (in movies, music, rap videos), it is consistently Malcolm *before* Mecca – the militant, macho, 'by any means necessary' Malcolm – who is quoted and idolized, not Malcolm *after* Mecca, when he became more critical of himself and exclusivist Nation of Islam tenets, and embraced a broader, multicultural perspective on nationalist identity.

By the tenets of Black Macho, true masculinity admits little or no space for self-interrogation or multiple subjectivities around race. Black Macho prescribes an inflexible ideal: strong Black men – 'Afrocentric' Black men – don't flinch, don't weaken, don't take blame or shit, take charge, step to when challenged, and defend themselves without pause for self-doubt. Against this warrior model of masculinity, Black Macho counterpoises the emasculated Other: the Other as

punk, sissy, Negro Faggot, a status with which any man, not just those who in fact are gay, can be branded should he deviate from rigidly prescribed codes of hypermasculine conduct.

'When I say Gamma, you say Fag. Gamma.' 'Fag.' 'Gamma.' 'Fag.' In the conflict between the frat boys and the 'fellas' in Spike Lee's *School Daze*, verbal fag-bashing becomes the weapon of choice in the fellas' contest for male domination. In this regard Lee's movie not only resonates a poisonous dynamic in contemporary Black male relations, but worse, Lee glorifies it. Spike Lee and others like him count on the complicit silence of those who know better, who know the truth of their own lives as well as the diverse truths which inform the total Black experience.

Notice is served.

Our silence has ended.

SNAP!

Marlon T. Riggs, 'Black Macho Revisited: Reflections of a SNAP! Queen', *Black American Literature Forum*, vol. 25, no. 2 (Summer 1991) 389–94.

Gregg Bordowitz
Picture a Coalition//1987

[...] Imagine a screening. In a local community centre a consumer VCR deck and a TV set sit on a table. Representatives from the various communities affected by AIDS sit in front of the TV. They watch a video composed of interviews with each of them. They see themselves pictured in relation to one another as they sit next to one another.

Consider this screening. It presents both means and ends for the video AIDS activist. The AIDS movement, like other radical movements, creates itself as it attempts to represent itself. Video puts into play the means of recognizing one's place within the movement in relation to that of others in the movement.

Video has the potential to render the concerted efforts – as yet unimagined – between groups. The most significant challenge to the movement is coalition building, because the AIDS epidemic has engendered a community of people who cannot afford not to recognize themselves as a community and to act as one.

The AIDS epidemic has caused us to change our behaviour. It has shaped our social relations as it has changed our views of ourselves. This became apparent

to me recently, after coming out to my family. I realized that I had come out as a member of two disenfranchised groups. I am a member of the gay community and a member of the AIDS community. Furthermore, I am a gay member of the AIDS community, a community that some would establish by force, for no other end but containment, toward no other end but repression, with no other end but our deaths – a community that must, instead, establish itself in the face of this containment and repression. We must proudly identify ourselves as a coalition.

Picture a coalition of people refusing to be victims.

Picture a coalition of people distributing condoms and clean works.

Picture a coalition of people having safe sex and shooting up with clean works.

Picture a coalition of people staging a die-in in front of City Hall or the White House until massive funds for AIDS are released.

Picture a coalition of people getting arrested for blocking traffic during rush hour as they stand in the middle of Times Square kissing one another.

Picture a coalition of people occupying abandoned buildings, demanding that they be made into hospices for people living with AIDS.

Picture a coalition of people chanting 'Money for AIDS, not for war' as they surround and quarantine the Pentagon.

The government and the medical establishment denounce as 'immoral' the people who get sick and the people they hope will get sick. They worry about themselves, their children and the 'innocent victims'. They predict the kinds of people who get AIDS, the numbers of people infected, the numbers of deaths that will occur. But they are doing next to nothing to cure the sick and prevent the spread of AIDS.

People are asking, 'If they won't do anything now, when will they?' 'If they won't do anything for those who are sick now, for whom will they?'

Getting no answers, people are mobilizing.

Getting no answers, a movement is emerging.

Picture a coalition of people who *will* end this epidemic.

Gregg Bordowitz, extract from 'Picture a Coalition', *October*, no. 43: AIDS: Cultural Analysis/Cultural Activism (Winter 1987) 195–6.

David Wojnarowicz
Close to the Knives//1989–91

[...] A number of months ago I read in the newspaper that there was a supreme court ruling which states that homosexuals in america have no constitutional rights against the government's invasion of their privacy. The paper stated that homosexuality is traditionally condemned in america and only people who are heterosexual or married or who have families can expect these constitutional rights. There were no editorials. Nothing. Just flat cold type in the morning paper informing people of this. In most areas of the u.s.a. it is possible to murder a man and when one is brought to trial one has only to say that the victim was a queer and that he tried to touch you and the courts will set you free. When I read the newspaper article I felt something stirring in my hands; I felt a sensation like seeing oneself from miles above the earth or like looking at one's reflection in a mirror through the wrong end of a telescope. Realizing that I have nothing left to lose in my actions I let my hands become weapons, my teeth become weapons, every bone and muscle and fibre and ounce of blood become weapons, and I feel prepared for the rest of my life. [...]

I scratch my head at the hysteria surrounding the actions of the repulsive senator from zombieland who has been trying to dismantle the NEA for supporting the work of Andres Serrano and Robert Mapplethorpe. Although the anger sparked within the art community is certainly justified and will hopefully grow stronger, the actions by Helms and D'Amato only follow standards that have been formed and implemented by the 'arts' community itself. The major museums in New York, not to mention museums around the country, are just as guilty of this kind of selective cultural support and denial. It is a standard practice to make invisible any kind of sexual imaging other than white straight male erotic fantasies. Sex in america long ago slid into a small set of generic symbols; mention the word 'sex' and the general public appears to only imagine a couple of heterosexual positions on a bed – there are actual laws in parts of this country forbidding anything else even between consenting adults. So people have found it necessary to define their sexuality in images, in photographs and drawings and movies in order to not disappear. Collectors have for the most part failed to support work that defines a particular person's sexuality, except for a few examples such as Mapplethorpe, and thus have perpetuated the invisibility of the myriad possibilities of sexual activity. The collectors' influence on what the museum shows continues this process secretly with behind-the-

scenes manipulations of curators and money. Jesse Helms, at the very least, makes public his attacks on freedom; the collectors and museums responsible for censorship make theirs at elegant private parties or from the confines of their self-created closets.

It doesn't stop at images – in a recent review of a novel in the *new york times book review*, a reviewer took outrage at the novelist's descriptions of promiscuity, saying, 'In this age of AIDS, the writer should show more restraint ...' Not only do we have to contend with bonehead newscasters and conservative members of the medical profession telling us to 'just say no' to sexuality itself rather than talk about safer sex possibilities, but we have people from the thought police spilling out from the ranks with admonitions that we shouldn't think about anything other than monogamous or safer sex. I'm beginning to believe that one of the last frontiers left for radical gesture is the imagination. At least in my ungoverned imagination I can fuck somebody without a rubber, or I can, in the privacy of my own skull, douse Helms with a bucket of gasoline and set his putrid ass on fire or throw congressman William Dannemeyer off the empire state building. These fantasies give me distance from my outrage for a few seconds. They give me momentary comfort. Sexuality defined in images gives me comfort in a hostile world. They give me strength. I have always loved my anonymity and therein lies a contradiction because I also find comfort in seeing representations of my private experiences in the public environment. They need not be representations of my experiences – they can be the experiences of and by others that merely come close to my own or else disrupt the generic representations that have come to be the norm in the various medias outside my door. I find that when I witness diverse representations of 'Reality' on a gallery wall or in a book or a movie or in the spoken word or performance, that the larger the range of representations, the more I feel there is room in the environment for my existence, that not the entire environment is hostile.

To make the *private* into something *public* is an action that has terrific repercussions in the preinvented world. The government has the job of maintaining the day-to-day illusion of the ONE-TRIBE NATION. Each public disclosure of a private reality becomes something of a magnet that can attract others with a similar frame of reference; thus each public disclosure of a fragment of private reality serves as a dismantling tool against the illusion of ONE-TRIBE NATION; it lifts the curtains for a brief peek and reveals the probable existence of literally millions of tribes. The term 'general public' disintegrates. What happens next is the possibility of an X-ray of Civilization, an examination of its foundations. To turn our private grief for the loss of friends, family, lovers and strangers into something public would serve as another powerful dismantling tool. It would dispel the notion that this virus has a sexual orientation or a moral code. It would

nullify the belief that the government and medical community has done very much to ease the spread or advancement of this disease. [...]

If I say I am homosexual, or 'queer', does it make you nervous? I have experienced various reactions to that simple disclosure in the course of life. I often wonder whether my being a queer who asserts his sexual identity publicly makes some people see the word 'QUEER' somehow written across my forehead in capital letters. And I wonder whether or not that revelation prevents some from hearing anything else I say, or whether or not it automatically *discounts* anything else I might say. Dismissal is policy in america. Our elected 'representatives' have come up with a fail-safe system of symbols based on a prehistoric moral code built by other humans, years, decades or even many centuries ago. The moral code is chameleonic in nature. Its design changes and twists on whim by those who wield it. In this country the elected representative has only to attach one of these symbols from the moral code to any social problem and people who are not immediately affected by that problem feel safe and distanced. If there is homelessness in our streets it is the fault of those who have no homes – they *chose* to live that way. If there is a disease such as AIDS it is somehow the fault of those who contract that disease – they *chose* to have that disease. If three black men are shot by a white man on a subway train – somehow they *chose* to be shot by that man.

And life goes on and on and on. Most people tend to accept, at least outwardly, this system of the moral code and thus feel quite safe from any terrible event or problem such as homelessness or AIDS or nonexistent medical care or rampant crime or hunger or unemployment or racism or sexism simply because they go to sleep every night in a house or apartment or dormitory whose clean rooms or smooth walls or regular structures of repeated daily routines provide them with a feeling of safety that never gets intruded upon by the events outside. There are scores of the population who either feel safe for the same reasons or else are too exhausted from trying to survive in this society by working dehumanizing jobs to keep a roof over their heads. Or else they feel safe because they are part of the structure that keeps the moral code intact. Or they feel safe only because once in a great while they can enter the illusion of the ONE-TRIBE NATION by stepping into a tiny curtained cubicle and pulling a metal lever that elects a twelve-inch-tall man or woman they saw for a short period of time transmitted across the boundaries of space into the antennae of their television screens. [...]

Breaking silence about an experience can break the chains of the code of silence. Describing the once indescribable can dismantle the power of taboo. To speak about the once unspeakable can make the INVISIBLE familiar if repeated often enough in clear and loud tones. To speak of ourselves – while living in a

country that considers us or our thoughts taboo – is to shake the boundaries of the illusion of the ONE-TRIBE NATION. To keep silent is to deny the fact that there are millions of separate tribes in this illusion called AMERICA. To keep silent even when our individual existence contradicts the illusory ONE-TRIBE NATION is to lose our own identities. BOTTOM LINE, IF PEOPLE DON'T SAY WHAT THEY BELIEVE, THOSE IDEAS AND FEELINGS GET LOST. IF THEY ARE LOST OFTEN ENOUGH, THOSE IDEAS AND FEELINGS NEVER RETURN. This was what my father hoped would happen with his actions toward any display of individuality. And this is the hope of certain government officials and religious leaders as well. When I make statements like this I do not make them lightly. I make them from a position of experience – the experience of what it is to be homosexual in this country.

What it is to be a man who is capable of loving men, physically and emotionally. [...]

'If I had a dollar for health care I'd rather spend it on a baby or innocent person with some defect or illness not of their own responsibility; not some person with AIDS' says the health-care official on national television and this is in the middle of an hour-long video of people dying on camera because they can't afford the limited drugs available that might extend their lives and I can't even remember what this official looked like because I reached in through the tv screen and ripped his face in half and I was diagnosed with AIDS recently and this was after the last few years of losing count of the friends and neighbours who have been dying slow vicious and unnecessary deaths because fags and dykes and junkies are expendable in this country. 'If you want to stop AIDS shoot the queers ...' says a politician in Texas on the radio and his press secretary later claims that the politician was only joking and didn't know the microphone was turned on and besides they didn't think it would hurt his chances for re-election anyways and I wake up every morning in this killing machine called america and I'm carrying this rage like a blood-filled egg and there's a thin line between the inside and the outside a thin line between thought and action and that line is simply made up of blood and muscle and bone and I'm waking up more and more from daydreams of tipping amazonian blow darts in 'infected blood' and spitting them at the exposed necklines of certain politicians or government health-care officials or those thinly disguised walking swastikas that wear religious garments over their murderous intentions or those rabid strangers parading against AIDS clinics in the nightly news suburbs there's a thin line a very thin line between the inside and the outside and I've been looking all my life at the signs surrounding us in the media or on peoples' lips; the religious types outside st patrick's cathedral shouting to the men and women in the gay parade, 'You won't be here next year

– you'll get AIDS and die ha ha ...' and the areas of the u.s.a. where it is possible to murder a man and when brought to trial one only has to say that the victim was a queer and that he tried to touch you and the courts will set you free and the difficulties that a bunch of republican senators have in albany with supporting an antiviolence bill that includes 'sexual orientation' as a category of crime victims there's a thin line a very thin line and as each T-cell disappears from my body it's replaced by ten pounds of pressure ten pounds of rage and I focus that rage into nonviolent resistance but that focus is starting to slip my hands are beginning to move independent of self-restraint and the egg is starting to crack america america america seems to understand and accept murder as a self-defence against those who would murder other people and it's been murder on a daily basis for nine count them nine long years and we're expected to pay taxes to support this public and social murder and we're expected to quietly and politely make house in this windstorm of murder but I say there's certain politicians that had better increase their security forces and there's religious leaders and health-care officials that had better get bigger fucking dogs and higher fucking fences and more complex security alarms for their homes and queer-bashers better start doing their work from inside howitzer tanks because the thin line between the inside and the outside is beginning to erode and at the moment I'm a thirty-seven-foot-tall one-thousand-one-hundred-and-seventy-two-pound man inside this six-foot body and all I can feel is the pressure all I can feel is the pressure and the need for release.

David Wojnarowicz, extracts from *Close to the Knives: A Memoir of Disintegration* (1989–91) (New York: Vintage, 1991) 80–81, 119–21, 150–51, 153–4, 160–62.

Lesbian Avengers
The Lesbian Avenger Handbook//1993

If you've ever spray-painted anti-hate slogans around town, you know how good it feels to vandalize for a good cause. But there is more to direct action than catharsis. In our postmodern age, media coverage is the message. Direct action is about getting attention, so don't be shy. The media loves photo ops, so give them something to look at – dykes in deb gowns, slanderous slogans on banners and placards, Sapphic serenades, flaming shrines.

Once you've decided on a target – an openly homophobic lawyer, a Cardinal,

a wayward poll – plan a dramatic action. It's important to have a clear message, so keep it simple. The details of your position can be spelled out in the fact sheet you distribute at the action, which should clearly explain why you're staging an action, and give facts to back up your stance.

The visual design of our actions is a crucial part of Avenger work. In general we try to make each action look different from our previous events and have a style and presentation that has never been used by anyone before. Props (floats, shrines, burning torches, papier-mâché bombs, plaster statues ... whatever!) play a huge part in this. Graphics need to be eye-catching, meaningful and visually exciting. The more creative, imaginative and individual our actions look, the more inspiring and fun they will be.

The design of an action usually begins with the preliminary flyer announcing the event to the community. Innovative design, contemporary, clever graphics, and even the colour of the paper are all important ways to convey to the viewer how fearless, open and new our approach is. To date, our invitational leaflets have been one of the Avengers' strongest calling cards.

Usually the flyer features a slogan or phrase that will be a constant theme throughout the action. We try to never use a cliché or tired old rhetoric. Instead we've been able to come up with a wide range of eye-catching titles. When we built a shrine to the two gay people burned to death in Oregon, our demo posters said 'DON'T LET THEM REST IN PEACE.' When we dogged the mayor of Denver for 48 hours, the signs said 'BOYCOTT THE HATE STATE' when we held our New Year's Eve party, the poster featured a picture of seventies Blaxploitation film star, Pam Grier, in hot pants holding a rifle. The poster advertised 'ACTIVIST A GO-GO'.

Our Valentine's Day action honouring Gertrude Stein and Alice Toklas celebrated 'POLITICALLY INCORRECT DOMESTIC BLISS'. Our demo banners favouring the New York City Department of Education's multicultural curriculum said 'LIGHTEN UP! TEACH ABOUT LESBIAN LIVES.' The banners for the torchlight parade down Fifth Avenue said 'WAKE UP! IT'S HAPPENING HERE', and for the March on Washington said 'LESBIAN AVENGERS: OUT FOR POWER.' Whether the theme is whimsical or angry, our slogans have been clear, clever and strong. [...]

Lesbian Avengers, extract from *The Lesbian Avenger Handbook* (1993).

Assotto Saint
No More Metaphors//1993

Your Honour, I am very grateful for the chance to make this statement to the Court on why I felt it was necessary to block traffic on the Capitol grounds. It resulted in my arrest, along with 46 other people, on obstructing and impeding charges. The subject of the demonstration, as you well know, concerned health care.

I know something about health care on a professional level. From July 1978, I worked for the New York City Health & Hospitals Corporation until my pensioned retirement in October 1991, due to AIDS-related disability.

I also know a lot more about health care on a personal level. Since April 1983 – an entire decade now – I have taken care of my closest friends: Counsel Wright, Jose Caballero, Dr Michael Evans (aka M.E. Fuller). Redvers JeanMarie & David Frechette. I have also taken care of my dear thirteen-year life-partner, Jan Urban Holmgren. They have all died of AIDS. Jan died on March 29, 1993, a month to the day tomorrow. No word could describe the helplessness, violation & hopelessness that I felt as I watched him take his last breaths. I would have given my own life if that could have saved his.

I want to mention that I have also lost to AIDS many other close friends who lived outside of New York City, hundreds of acquaintances all over the world, & 21 neighbours in my building on West 22nd Street in New York City. I have watched all of them disintegrate – some faster than others. Many lost their jobs, apartments, belongings, friends, families, self-control, good looks, minds, & of course, their faith.

In March 1990, I spent five days & nights with my life-partner, I repeat FIVE DAYS & NIGHTS, in the Emergency Room of NYU Medical Center, waiting for a bed on a medical ward to become available for Jan. NYU Medical Center is one of the most prestigious institutions in the world & our affiliated doctors number among the best.

Three years later, in March 1993, I again spent five days & nights with my life-partner in the same Emergency Room, waiting for a bed on a medical ward to become available for Jan. Besides a few cosmetic changes here & there, nothing had much changed. Business as usual. This waiting game is a crying shame.

Your Honour, my life-partner & I had a combined income of $85,000. We were hardworking, tax-paying, & law-abiding. We were both foreigners – Jan was born in Sweden, & I was born in Haiti – who cherished the concept of the American Dream. Jan & I had very good medical insurance, which covered us for the rest of our lives. We both strongly believed that every individual in this

country, no matter what socio-economic background he or she belonged to, deserves access to the best health care.

My illegal yet constitutional action this past Monday morning, to which I unashamedly plead guilty, was done on behalf of all the HIV-positive Haitians who have been granted political asylum in the United States, but are being detained unlawfully & immorally at Guantanamo Bay. It was done on behalf of my late activist friend Ortez Alderson. It was done on behalf of my life-partner, Jan Urban Holmgren.

May the memory of their suffering, due to the inadequacy, greed & stupidity of bureaucrats, finally bring much-needed transformation to our health care system. May it have helped to save my own life.

So, I hope.

Assotto Saint, 'No More Metaphors (Part Three): Statement Delivered at the Superior Court of the District of Columbia on 28 April 1993' (1993); reprinted in Michele Karlsberg, ed., *Spells of a Voodoo Doll: The Poems, Fiction, Essays and Plays of Assotto Saint* (New York: Richard Kasak, 1996) 127–8.

Roberto Jacoby
I Have AIDS//1994

Evil is the other.

AIDS, like all evil, is the other.

This conceptual and emotional equation obstructs individuals' preventive action and generates behaviour that excludes those who are infected and ill with HIV.

Victims of this horrific social pressure, those who are HIV positive and ill suffer doubly from both the health problem and the concealment, shame and stigma.

With the action (interference) *I Have AIDS*, I want to operate at two points of the equation: AIDS = other.

On the one hand, to break the spell of their malignant stigma – at other times applied to smallpox, leprosy, syphilis, tuberculosis and cancer – to return it to what it really is: a disease pathology like any other.

On the other hand, to shorten personal distance from the subject. Currently it is recognized as a universal problem in the abstract – 'AIDS is a problem for all' – but not concretely in relation to each one of us.

This is to promote visibility and acceptance from a simple single statement

– 'I have AIDS' – in the tradition of [Lope de Vega's play] *Fuenteovejuna* and [centuries later, the statement] 'We are all German Jews.'

Do not forget that all of us are the Other of the other.

Roberto Jacoby, text of presentation for the campaign *Yo tengo sida* [I Have AIDS] against discrimination towards HIV positive people, Buenos Aires, 1994–95; reprinted in Roberto Jacoby, *El deseo nace del derrumbe: acciones, conceptos, escritos*, ed. Ana Longoni (Buenos Aires and Madrid: Ediciones Adriana Hidalgo, La Central, MNCARS, and Red Conceptualismos del Sur, 2011) 359. Translated by Ian Farr, 2015.

Felix Gonzalez-Torres
Public and Private: Spheres of Influence//1993

Everything that happens in culture happens because it is needed. Even this series of panels ['Power and Responsibility: Art Institutions and Cultural Change'] and the subject of this particular panel. Once more, the cultural left, and the left in general, finds itself reacting to an agenda or trap devised by the ruling oligarchy: agendas and symbolic issues used to deflect meaning and any kind of profound and constructive analysis of the many crises that we as a nation are now experiencing. One of the subjects of this panel, the public, is a term that is becoming very charged and very used in the political and cultural arena, as we must have noticed by now. But I must say that I am not very interested in the public as such, but in its opposite, in what makes the construction of the public possible, and that is the private.

In order to conceptualize what we as a culture define as public, we must also create a private, let's say (in a very simplistic and illustrative manner) a kind of outdoors versus an indoors – just to set two parameters. But is it really possible, at this point in history, to create such spheres, and if so, for what purpose, and to serve whose agendas?

Our most intimate fantasies, desires, projections, internal dialogues and ever-shifting identities are bisected, influenced and ruled by public discourse, legislations and the law. But before we go on, we should question where this public construction comes from. We know that the word public has been around for centuries, but what is its real history in terms of how we use this term, 'the public', now? When did it come into being? Why was it needed? And by whom? Was the public always there, just waiting to be discovered, waiting to be addressed, or did it perhaps become a necessity in an industrial society in which

a group of people with similar consuming habits and power suddenly became 'a public', a market segment ready to be acknowledged through advertisements? Was the formation of a generalized desire for consumer items related to this event? And did the creation of museums have something to do with this newly available resource, the public?

Recently, right-wing politicians and their allies in the religious industry have taken it upon themselves to defend this 'public', this public set of values, these community standards, now termed traditional family values (remember?). This public, turned god-fearing, hard-working, patriotic Americans. But why now?

As I said before, everything happens in culture because it is needed, and after more than a decade of steadily increasing economic disparities, it is imperative for those responsible for this crisis to find highly-charged symbolic gestures with which the so-called general public will readily identify itself, and quickly take sides. Hopefully theirs. These keepers of the status quo are in a very precarious situation and have clearly anticipated the need to deploy mirrors of debate that would effectively deflect any formulation of a meaningful discussion.

It is no accident that culture is now the new battleground. After all, the economic and social changes that the Reagan regime sought to bring about are now an accomplished deal. Our national deficit in 1980 was 74 billion, but by 1990 we had a deficit of 221 billion. In 1981 there were ten bank failures, in 1985 there were 120, and by 1988 we had more than 200. In 1980 the ratio of the US government budget for housing to its budget for the military was one to five. By 1989 it was one dollar for housing and 31 dollars for the military industrial complex. Since 1980 the Federal support for housing assistance has been slashed by more than 80 per cent and the supply of low-income rental units has dropped dramatically as a result of demolition and conversion. But at the same time, during those get-tough-on-crime years, we were busy expanding and building larger jails to house part of the American family. In New York State, during the last decade, the prison space doubled at a cost of five billion dollars. Often the state resorted to urban development corporation financing – a corporation originally intended to house poor people in new city apartments, not in new prisons.

According to the *New York Times*, 13 September 1992, the nation's incarcerated population increased by nearly 130 per cent during the last decade. We have the highest rate of imprisonment of any industrialized nation. In second place is South Africa, of course. Moreover, it should come as no surprise that, yes, class is a factor in who goes to jail. Sixty per cent of inmates had incomes of less than $10,000 at the time of their arrest. Racism and class are usually part of the equation in many of our repressive state apparatuses. Federal drug officials have described the typical cocaine user as a white male high-school graduate living in a small city, or suburb. However the famous 'war on

drugs' has been waged mostly on poor, urban, mostly minority neighbourhoods.

Talking of neighbourhoods, according to the Census Bureau, mobile homes were the fastest growing type of dwelling in the 1980s, as the cost of traditional houses soared beyond the reach of many. Nearly 16 million Americans – about one in six – now live in mobile homes.

During the last decade, we witnessed one per cent of American households getting richer. By 1989, the top one per cent were worth more than the bottom 90 per cent of Americans. In the last 15 years the number of children living in poverty increased by 21 per cent. In 1992 seven per cent of all infants, and nearly 17 per cent of all African-American infants, were born underweight – the highest rate since 1978. According to the Children's Defense Fund, the number of children living in poverty grew by more than one million during the 1980s. The state with the highest child poverty rate is Mississippi – home state for the distinguished American Family Association. According to Dr Jennifer Howse, who led the march on the Dimes Birth Defect Foundation in 1992, the proportion of pregnant women receiving no pre-natal care or late care was 25 per cent, the highest it had been for nearly 20 years.

After the unfortunate but almost predictable Los Angeles rebellion of 1992, new levels of cynicism were established by the conservative demagogues, when they blamed the social programmes of the 1960s and 70s for the violence. We must remember, in order to combat the right's re-reading of history, that those social programmes of the 60s helped to cut the poverty rate almost in half, and poverty amongst the elderly by an even greater degree; that the war on poverty in the 60s (as opposed to the war on the poor that the Reagan and Bush regimes waged during the 1980s) brought to many needy Americans medical care, food stamps, pre-natal and infant care, legal services, college tuition and guaranteed student loans which indeed enabled many of us to forge a better life. Such poverty programmes, according to an editorial in *The New York Times*, 6 May 1992, brought the poverty rate down from 19 per cent in 1964 to 11 per cent in 1973.

Since 1981, direct Federal aid to cities has dropped by 60 per cent, and in 1984 the Children's Defense Fund budget declared, 'Each week 211 American children die from poor maternal and child health and nutrition while we continue to subsidize tobacco growers by 3.3 million dollars a week.' I bet you haven't heard the American Family Association rally the famous taxpayer on public opinion in reaction to this situation. We now rank 20th among industrialized nations in preventing infant mortality, and when it comes to immunizing infants against polio, we now rank behind sixteen other nations, including Mexico.

5 March 1992: According to the Congressional Budget Office, an outsized 60 per cent of the growth in after-tax income of all American families between 1977 and 1989 went to the wealthiest 660,000 families. At the same time, the

American family right in the middle of the income distribution saw its income edge up only four per cent. And the bottom 40 per cent of families experienced actual declines in their income.

According to the Census Bureau (4 November 1992), the number of Americans living in poverty soared in 1991 by 2.1 million and the poverty rate rose for the second consecutive year to 14.2 per cent – the highest since 1964. A family of four is classified as poor if it had a cash income of less than 13,924 dollars in 1991. The government sets the poverty line by using the consumer price index to determine the cost of a minimally adequate diet and multiplying that by three – wrongly assuming that a household spends one third of its budget on food and that two-thirds can cover everything else. Today, just two necessities, food and housing, take approximately 85 per cent of a typical poor family budget. Falling workers' wages and lower corporate taxes during the fabulous 1980s swelled the ranks of millionaire corporate executives. The average corporate executive, who earned as much as 41 factory workers or 38 teachers in 1960, was earning as much as 93 factory workers or 72 teachers by 1988.

According to the Census Bureau, after adjustment for inflation, the median household income has declined 5.1 per cent since 1989, and household purchasing power is lower now than in 1979. Even if we wanted to return to a welfare state, it would be rather difficult. We have successfully become the Savings and Loan bailout state: according to government figures of 1992, we now spend six dollars on this bailout for one dollar on welfare. In terms of cutbacks in social benefits – let's take New York City as a good example of the attack against the urban centre launched in the past decade – according to a report issued by the late New York congressman Ted Weis, the percentage of New York City budget supported by Federal funds decreased from 17.9 per cent in 1981 to 9.3 per cent in 1990. The cumulative loss in Federal aid between 1981 and 1990, adjusted for inflation, was 19 billion dollars. The city government spent 755 million in 1990 alone simply to replace lost Federal aid. The city estimated that those funds could have been spent instead to hire 3,000 more nurses, 3,700 school teachers, 2,800 more firefighters, and 2,800 police officers. In 1980 there were 30 soup kitchens in New York City. By 1989 there were 600. Conservatives have always seen the urban areas as centres of intellectual challenge, magnets for immigrants, and centres of political ferment and agitation.

One of the dangers of our technological explosion of information is that it does not guarantee an informed or literate public. We have an explosion of information bytes and at the same time an implosion of meaning. The statistics of the economic decline of the so-called typical family, the general public, or the famous taxpayer, means very little to most people. One of the effects of the division of labour is the representation of facts and/or issues as completely unrelated, separated, isolated,

independent of each other. Meaning is mostly created when we can relate our identity to a piece of information. And it is precisely this that the right has been so smart at understanding and using for its own benefit. We haven't seen the religious industry and its conservative politicians getting into the debate on the need for more affordable housing, or the need to establish some sort of gun control. These vital issues take too long to explain, and the fundamentalist Christian businessmen have long ago recognized that, as with any other capitalist venture, in order to survive and grow in a 'free market' environment, it has to deploy eye-catching advertisements, and create fast-product recognition.

According to Pat Robertson, one of the leaders of the fundamentalist Christian industry, abortion rights is a dead political issue. (But don't take his word for it.) With the threat of Communism, body snatchers, Martian and/or Sandinist invasions, and the Evil Empire a thing of the past, the need for a new product container or new packaging becomes urgent to this industry of hate, ignorance and fear. The need to distort and step on the truth becomes more extreme.

During the 1992 elections, in a hate-mail campaign opposing the passing of the Equal Rights Amendment in the State of Iowa, Pat Robertson, in his very humanist Republican self, wrote: 'The Equal Rights Amendment will lead women to leave their husbands, kill their children, practice witchcraft, destroy capitalism, and become lesbians.' I wonder if, after all, this might actually be beneficial for women. I don't know the statistics for accidents in the practice of witchcraft or lesbianism, but I do know that according to the American Medical Association, more women are injured each year in domestic violence than in muggings or car accidents combined. But misogyny is not enough to keep a sales campaign alive. Enter now the profitable spectre of the 'homosexual agenda'.

You may already be asking, or perhaps you were doing so a while ago, what do all these statistics and/or issues have to do with an analysis of the spheres of influence of public and private? Well, they have a lot to do with it. They have to do with the reclaiming of language, meaning and the re-framing of this discussion. As I mentioned at the very beginning, things have a history in our culture, and the separation between public and private does not escape this, in the same way that the expected role of the artist within our strict division of labour is supposed to remain static and conform to our assigned production. But it is precisely when we cross the ideological boundaries that we begin to make connections, we begin to create coalitions and to see a more precise picture of our present, not just the projection of ideological shadows which so many times we take to be reality. This is an attempt at trying to understand how public opinion can be manipulated into accepting that some people are more equal than others, and that some private spaces are more public than others. This was demonstrated by the landmark 1986 Supreme Court decision on Bowers vs

Hardwick, in which the state ruled that the bed is a site where we are not only born, where we die, where we make love, but it is also a place where the state has a pressing interest, a public interest. The court ruled that, according to age-old community standards, and religious dogma, the State could declare illegal certain sexual practices, even among consenting adults. (In this case it was sodomy between two men.) The court and the state once again sanctioned the public/private oppression of a whole group of people, based solely on a private act. This public oppression is not an abstraction. It is translated into pain in the flesh, into Proposition 9 in Oregon, and Proposition 2 in Colorado, and next in Idaho, Florida and others. It is translated into fear and violence. According to press reports, crime against lesbians and gays increased by 30 per cent in Denver in the week following the passage of Amendment 2. And according to a national gay and lesbian report, there has been a 161 per cent increase since 1988 in the number of anti-lesbian and gay attacks in five major cities where data was collected.

There is no private sphere in the modern state. We can only speak about private property. There is no private space, no private entity. At least not for certain groups when it is still legal and endorsed by the state to oppress and discriminate because of who we love in private and, yes, outdoors too.

Felix Gonzalez-Torres, 'Public and Private: Spheres of Influence' (edited version of paper for 'Power and Responsibility' symposium, Los Angeles, 1993); in *A. Reinhardt, J. Kosuth, F. Gonzales-Torres: Symptoms of Interference, Conditions of Possibility – Art & Design*, no. 9 (January/February 1994) 87–91.

Gran Fury
In Conversation with Douglas Crimp//2003

Douglas Crimp [...] How did Gran Fury come into being as a collective?

Michael Nesline It happened by degrees. Bill Olander, the curator at the New Museum, came to an ACT UP meeting with a proposal that ACT UP use the museum's window on Broadway for a visual demonstration. At the end of the meeting, everyone who was interested met in the back corner of the Lesbian and Gay Community Center.

Crimp The result was *Let the Record Show* ... This was 1987. How did such a complex work get formulated by such a large group?

Tom Kalin I remember there was a kind of bullet-style accumulation of political points compiled from clippings people brought in from the *New York Times*. The main idea came from demos where we yelled 'shame' at public figures who were doing nothing about AIDS. So we decided we'd single out public figures who had made outrageous statements about AIDS, show a photograph of each of them, and cast their words in concrete. And then these AIDS criminals somehow got connected to the Nuremberg trials. It probably went back to the *SILENCE = DEATH* poster with the pink triangle.

Avram Finkelstein This is the way ACT UP functioned on every level. People would bring news items to the meetings. They would throw out snippets from articles, and whatever resonated became the issue we'd organize around. It was an organic process, and Gran Fury worked that way for a long time.

Donald Moffett The form developed in the same collaborative way. The issues unfolded, and the form followed.

Marlene McCarty Absolutely. Someone would say, 'I know how to make a photo mural.' Somebody else would say, 'I have access to an LED.'

Kalin I remember volunteering to make the photo mural of the Nuremberg trials because I knew how to make murals by ironing paper to canvas with glue. I remember Don Ruddy at another meeting cutting rubber letters with an X-Acto blade to cast the sentences in concrete. The process was additive, like a collage. It just turned out to have a coherent appearance, which made it seem much more planned than it really was.

Nesline Well, Mark Simpson (1965–96) actually knew what was going on. He described to me what the window was going to look like before it existed.

McCarty Each time we gathered to work on the window, a different constellation of people showed up. It wasn't until later that we decided to form a collective.

Loring McAlpin When we were disassembling the window, there was a discussion about what to do next.

Kalin We had a meeting and said, 'Let's continue this.' The poster *AIDS: 1 in 61* came out of that meeting. It was then that we took the name Gran Fury, which was the Plymouth [automobile] model of choice for the New York Police Department. But that group was still larger than the one around this table: it

included Don Ruddy, who later died of AIDS; Anthony Viti was involved in that discussion, I'm sure Todd Haynes was involved, Mark Harrington ...

McAlpin Steve Barker ... The group was variable up until after we made the posters for 'Nine Days of Protest' that included *Read My Lips* (1988).

Crimp How did a shifting group of people become a collective with a fixed membership?

John Lindell Since initially the meetings were open, anybody could come, but it became frustrating.

McCarty You couldn't move forward; you always had to backtrack and regroup.

Lindell There was a debate about whether we should be open or closed, and we finally decided closed.

Kalin We went from being wheat-pasting hooligans to suddenly having real resources and opportunities and a platform from which to speak. This brought about a crisis of conscience in discussing how to articulate the group because the stakes had been raised.

Crimp What was your first high-stakes opportunity?

McAlpin It was *Kissing Doesn't Kill*, which was part of a public-art project called 'Art Against AIDS On the Road' (1989). Within a year or so, our poster was on buses and subway platforms in San Francisco, Chicago, New York and Washington, DC. Up until then, we were still having a dialogue with the whole membership of ACT UP. When we presented this project, suddenly there were three hundred people commenting on it; we just realized that we couldn't work with that much feedback.

Nesline We decided we wanted to function independently, but we asked ACT UP for a percentage of the profits from sales of T-shirts with our images printed on them. Of course this didn't include the *SILENCE = DEATH* T-shirts, since that wasn't a Gran Fury design, but it included *Read My Lips*, which sold a lot. They agreed, but we didn't get the money from them on a regular basis.

Kalin Well, there was a little bad blood.

Robert Vazquez I remember that well, because I was at-large representative from

the floor of ACT UP, and I would hear discussions about Gran Fury: 'Every other committee of ACT UP is open; why is it that with Gran Fury we don't know who they are and their membership is closed?' It was counterintuitive for the ACT UP membership to have a closed group.

Crimp In other words, Gran Fury began as an ad hoc committee of ACT UP members, then broke away from the larger organization, just as, later, members of the ACT UP Treatment and Data Committee split off from the larger group to form TAG, the Treatment Action Group, and the PWA Housing Committee evolved into Housing Works. My memory is that other artists and graphic designers in ACT UP became resentful of the status Gran Fury had attained in the art world. And in the end it is certainly unjust that ACT UP's graphic style is very often credited to Gran Fury alone, when in fact many others who were never members of Gran Fury contributed to the invention of that style.

Nesline Just as a footnote to what you're saying, Douglas, one of the things that really made a big difference in the legitimization of Gran Fury is the article that you published in the AIDS issue of *October* (Winter 1987). You made the argument for why what we were doing was legitimate in the context of art.

Kalin Our work is also indebted to the appropriation work of the early 1980s that you wrote about. But it's true, the *October* article eventually led to things like the Venice Biennale, to a kind of institutional exposure that probably wouldn't have happened otherwise. We went from T-shirts and posters to billboards and international exhibitions.

McCarty The aftermath of that has been really weird. I'm still active in the art world. I teach in the United States and Europe, and I'm constantly asked how we put together our art collective. It always blows my mind, because we came together with such a sense of urgency, with goals that had nothing to do with wanting to make art or to change the way people look at art.

Crimp Probably very few people understand what it is to make art collaboratively within the compass of an activist movement. They seem to believe that Gran Fury was a group of artists who contributed to AIDS activism or to ACT UP, but in fact it's the other way around. All of us were members of ACT UP, and that's why we were able to accomplish what we did. More importantly, it's why we did what we did in the first place. [...]

Nesline If you remember what the initial goals of ACT UP were – to publicize the

crisis, to get drugs into bodies, and to end the AIDS crisis – we accomplished two of the three. The third still remains to be achieved.

Lindell I also want to make it clear that the dissolution of Gran Fury wasn't quick, and it wasn't happy in any way. Our decision to stop didn't come as a relief. It was the result of frustration with our inability to find a means to continue working.

McAlpin I think what we accomplished was to drive a wedge into public discourse and open a space where AIDS could be talked about in all its dimensions. By the time we stopped, that was happening. Maybe our function was just to initiate that discussion – to expect us to last until the discussion is over is absurd.

Crimp On top of all the other horrifying events of the present – including the Bush administration's rush to war – AIDS here and now is still a crisis. And nobody talks about it.

Nesline That's not entirely true. Just this week the newspapers reported that the rate of new infections among young African-American males in the United States has inched up by a percentage point. The information is there, and that's a huge difference from the time that ACT UP started.

Finkelstein But the urgency is not there.

Moffett What I hear now is a rhetorical neglect coming out of the White House that is very similar to where we were fifteen years ago.

Crimp And many of the things that we accomplished as activists we would now have to fight for all over again. For example, ADAP (AIDS Drug Assistance Program) funding is being cut all over the country. And when was the last time any of you saw prevention information in, say, a gay bar?

Vazquez With the introduction of protease inhibitors we didn't see people die as quickly. But in fact people of colour are dying just as quickly as before. With the introduction of protease inhibitors the focus of people doing AIDS policy work shifted to AIDS in Africa, and with their attention elsewhere, horrible policies like mandatory name reporting began to happen here.

Crimp To return to the question of irony, today Gran Fury is remembered less among activists than within the art world. It's not for nothing that this is an interview for *Artforum* and not for a magazine about queer politics. I guess we

probably have to admit that the resting place of Gran Fury is the museum.

McCarty But in fact the final resting place is not the museum, it's the Public Library.

Crimp I meant the museum metaphorically. But yes, let's be clear that the Gran Fury Collection is in the public domain and available in the Manuscripts and Archives Division of the New York Public Library.

Moffett That legacy is an educational resource for another generation. After all, we didn't come out of nowhere. We dragged the history of this kind of art into the 1980s and the early 90s. And it will be reinvented again.

Gran Fury and Douglas Crimp , extracts from 'Gran Fury talks to Douglas Crimp', *Artforum*, vol. 41, no. 8 (April 2003) 70–71, 232, 234.

Carrie Moyer and Dyke Action Machine! Do You Love the Dyke in Your Face? Lesbian Street Representation//1997

In 1990 I joined Queer Nation, New York, a few months after its founding. I had never been in an activist group, though I certainly was a prime candidate for one. Since coming out in high school, I had felt progressively more angry and alienated from straight mainstream culture. I had gone to many ACT UP demos but never had 'joined'. From the beginning I was very taken with Queer Nation-volunteering to design the press kit at my first meeting. Queer Nation was starting to get some media attention, coordinated by a few of the men who had ties to the industry. As I later learned, media access available to gay and lesbian organizations is almost always the sole province of men – men who, in the 'straight' world, are commonly publicists or in advertising. If women play a part at all, they are usually spokespersons – not media contacts or strategists.

Before joining Queer Nation, I had been working as a graphic designer for major consumer advertising and design firms for five years. So by the time I hooked up with two other Queer Nationals, Masha Gessen and Charles Welz, to form the working group Truth in Advertising, I had been totally immersed in the language of the industry for quite some time. I was more than ready to use my

training to promote queer causes. Personally, I had also been greatly affected by the work of Gran Fury, Barbara Kruger, and the Guerrilla Girls, and was eager to incorporate their tactics into our aesthetic attack. Truth in Advertising was based on a very simple premise: to include gay people in the visual environment that surrounds New Yorkers every time they set foot outside. Our work was a foreseeable product of gay and lesbian activism of the time: trying to get straight culture to accept us, to 'like' us, by becoming more visible to *them*, by being out. One of our first campaigns was a take-off of the New York State Lottery campaign: 'All you need is a dollar bill and a dream.' Our version, which was wheat-pasted over the actual ads on the street and in subway stations, stated 'All you need is a three-dollar bill and a dream.' Some of the posters merely transposed the gender of the speaker, making the ad queer ('I'd tell every man I ever loved – who's sorry now?' states Jeff Smith, Queer plumber) while others reclaimed queer-baiting slang by using it to describe the speaker's ultimate fantasy ('I'd start my own cigarette company and call it "Fags".').

Not surprisingly, Queer Nation, the group that was supposed to unite gay and lesbian activists to agitate for an agenda common to both, rarely – if ever – focused on lesbian issues. So Dyke Action Machine! (DAM!) began as the lesbian working group of Queer Nation. Our first events were primarily visibility actions, such as usurping straight or neutral spaces by staging kiss-ins at malls, (straight) singles bars, and on the Staten Island Ferry. After attending the first-ever National Lesbian Conference in Atlanta in 1991, DAM! lost momentum and finally died out due to a lack of leadership and political experience. Before the group completely expired, photographer Sue Schaffner and I started doing poster campaigns using the Truth in Advertising model – we provided lesbians on the street with the pleasure of seeing their own images in professional, well-designed public art. We wanted to create facsimiles of the very images that ignored our existence.

As DAM! the activist group died out, DAM! the lesbian graphics project thrived. Sue and I have continued to do our public art/poster campaigns. Our first, in 1991, was a spoof of the GAP ads, then ubiquitous throughout New York City. These ads featured minor or underground celebrities modelling T-shirts and jeans – the only *out* celebrity ever featured in their campaign was Tony Kushner. DAM!'s posters addressed how lesbians were not, at that precise moment in the history of advertising, considered either celebrities or even general consumers and showed images of chic downtown dykes (former DAM! members all). It is important to note that when lesbian celebrities were later used to sell products – such as LA Eyewear (Melissa Etheridge) or the *New York Times* (Martina Navratilova) – the women had all become famous while closeted and later came out. Lesbians who had always been out are still not considered to be celebrities

by either the gay or straight media. The captions on our first campaign read 'Anti-violence whistle blow by Samantha, Pink Panther. Photograph by Girl Ray.' Our work acknowledged that a basic requirement for being recognized in American culture is a person's participation in a consumer group. At the time, we had no insight into the dangers to gay people of niche marketing.

From the start, our means of getting the message out was to plaster anything or any place in sight. During the first three years, DAM! relied heavily on a small pack of friends who led our midnight wheat-pasting attacks, often having to return to the same sites night after night as the phone company diligently undid our work. As with any public campaign, our most successful hits were in well-trafficked areas next to the ads we were satirizing, or at least in the right context – the lesbo-erotic images of companies such as Kikit and Banana Republic provided perfect foils. In 1992 *Family Circle* magazine launched a campaign positing 'family values', a phrase popularized at that time by the Religious Right as a hip new trend. The ads showed flexed biceps with lawn-mower tattoos and hunky dreadlocked men snuggling babies. Our project that year, 'Lesbian Family Values', was a set of three diptychs presenting the family tradition in lesbian culture, while at the same time critiquing the crass revisionist marketing of the family. Predating the mainstreaming of the gay family, gay marriage and the lesbian baby boom, the work dissected the Reagan/Right-wing connotations by evoking lesbian families with such slogans as 'Dykes were family, by golly, before families became trendy.' [...]

Because DAM!'s projects react to transitory public advertising campaigns, their life spans are relatively short. By necessity, they have to be cheap and fast. They must be oppositional and seductive. To appeal to the lesbian viewer, the posters must refer to elements of lesbian culture from an insider's perspective, but at the same time be empowering to the lesbian observer by placing those images within the vocabulary of 'the world', thereby not recreating the obscurity of her existence. These posters become quintessential anti-objects. They are intended to be disposable, not precious, while subverting the permanence of architecture by altering the visual/spatial environment. Yet women seize upon these images, giving them a second life. Long after the campaign is over, these posters still hang on refrigerators or in bedrooms, become memorabilia in scrapbooks, and are mailed to other lesbian communities across the country. Often these images will appear months or years later on another continent, after having travelled the underground railroad by which lesbians communicate, despite being excluded from the commercial media.

Our next challenge as a public art/agitprop outfit is to find a new way of surprising our viewers into action. What uncharted media avenues remain for making an impact within image-saturated urban sites? Could more humble lo-fi/

lo-tech projects become a means of addressing an audience already jaded by slick, cynical representations of queerness? Stay tuned for DAM!'s exploits in the quotidian world of budget advertising, and don't be surprised when you find a message on a matchbook, business card, frisbee, coffee cup ...

Carrie Moyer and Dyke Action Machine!, extracts from 'Do You Love the Dyke in Your Face', in Gordon Brent Ingram, Anne-Marie Bouthillette and Yolanda Retter, eds, *Queers in Space, Communities, Public Places, Sites of Resistance* (Seattle: Bay Press, 1997) 439–41, 445–6.

Hanh Thi Pham
Statement//1996

In April of 1975, in exchange for being with my parents and sisters as a family unit evacuating out of Saigon, South Vietnam, I had to surrender my given name, my real birth date and my original identity to comply with set requirements dictated by the United States government's overseas policy regarding Vietnamese evacuees. The experience was like a death sentence upon me, for I was uprooted and forced into self-erasure. In Amerikkka, I exist as a Vietnam War refugee directly legalized as an American citizen, but stigmatized as an alien. For two decades while functioning under the American system and contributing my youthful energy, work expertise and responsibility, I have experienced an escalated economic displacement, degradation and devaluation, anti-immigrant hostility, and racial discrimination from the patriarchal dominant structure that validates white Eurocentric morals and compulsive heterosexuality.

The condition for living and working without being constantly oppressed and repressed has become increasingly urgent to my survival. My artworks are created out of the necessity to assert my racial, political and sexual identities. The use of photography and written language is an attempt at developing a healthy self-concept, a non-binary gender but lesbian-defined revolutionary attitude. Whenever my art as knowledge becomes practice, my campaign for liberation and freedom becomes active rather than reactive. I fervently believe in the validity of female archaic concepts and sacred integrity.

As an activist artist, I continue to construct Lesbian-specific imageries (sexual and non-sexual), and to explore metamorphic Asian identities; I am organizing my collaborative work to become even more brutally honest, more inflammatory when need be, and all the more blatant to bring about change. I personally

believe that the future is to be reshaped most likely by outlaw leadership – by aware, autonomous beings – many marginalized femmes who along with their brothers and sisters have formed revolutionary roots throughout North America.

With this special exhibition, made possible by the Fukuoka Art Museum, I extend my profound gratitude to all the individuals who have been courageous in bringing to the viewing public the recent realities concerning Asians, immigrants and Asian-American Feminist issues. I am also indebted to all my intimate female-to-female 'multiples' – my Asian Transgendered and Transsexual lovers, Vampire Dyke collaborators, hetero-bisexual, Lesbian Separatists, including male-to-female ex-heteros.

Hanh Thi Pham, untitled statement (1996); trans. Kuroda Raji and Garrett Miyake Mariko, in *Hanh Thi Pham: A Vietnamese: Her Body in Revolt / Asian Artists Today – Fukuoka Annual X* (Fukuoka City, Japan: Fukuoka Art Museum, 1997) 3.

Catherine Lord
Their Memory is Playing Tricks on Her: Notes toward a Calligraphy of Rage//2007

Lesbianism is a much noisier word than feminism.
– Laura Cottingham[1]

One evening a few years ago I went to a screening of a new work by a happy man, a structuralist filmmaker. Delectable as the coincidence would have been, he was not the one flayed platitude by platitude upon the long piece of paper Carolee Schneemann pulled from her vagina in late August of 1975 before a group of women in the Hamptons and, once again in 1977, at the Telluride Film Festival in Colorado, where her films had been relegated to a special showing titled 'The Erotic Woman'. Worse, the entire festival was advertised by a drawing of a naked man in sunglasses flashing – well, nothing. Blank space where his dick should have dangled gave Schneemann the anger necessary to do a re-run of *Interior Scroll*. I have the dirt only because Schneemann, in her 1979 book *More Than Meat Joy*, told the story and reprinted a text from that performance: 'I met a happy man/a structuralist filmmaker/ ... he said we are fond of you/you are charming/but don't ask us/to look at your films/we cannot.'[2] *Meat Joy* was not a best seller. For years, boxes lived under Schneemann's bed, allowing her to dream

upon the archive of her self.[3] Schneemann was the only feminist artist of the 1970s so viscerally to connect her rage and her cunt. No displacements or substitutions. No strap-ons. No labial crockery.

I want to insist that this makes *Interior Scroll* an icon of discredited feminist essentialism, expansively and stubbornly queer, although – even because – Schneemann is no lesbian. At once inventory and provocation, *Scroll* continues to unfurl. It is a mark of the indexical skank of pussy juice, even thirty years old, that the very idea of showing this small piece of paper – creased, stained and barricaded under Plexiglas – can still get curators fired.[4]

Said differently, 'feminist' is a category I choose not to split from homosexual, from lesbian, or from the oppositional politics implied by the word 'queer'. Lesbian and feminist –like lesbian and queer, dyke and fag, white and black – are neither coextensive nor mutually exclusive terms, making them, like the structures of memory and cultural interpretation they suggest, contested and unstable territories. Neither this essay, allegedly on lesbian culture between 1965 and 1980, nor the exhibition that it accompanies could be imagined without access to specific architectures of memory, to the repositories of artefacts and knowledge that enable and determine both recollection and oblivion – which is to say, an archive. Like Pandora's box, no archive is opened without an intention to reconfigure and reinscribe, which is to say, to propose and, in so doing, to institute a counter-archive.[5]

In Los Angeles, for example, early in 2005, a happy man screened conceptual bookends. The first, made twenty-seven years ago, consisted of sixty static shots, each exactly sixty seconds long, of vernacular architecture animated from time to time by friends, lovers, the occasional child and more than a few pets. The second bookend was a faithful remake of the first, executed by returning in so far as possible to the same locations, people, species and breeds – indeed, almost the same positions for the legs of the tripod. That both time and the filmmaker conspired against success yielded a series of exquisite slippages between record, reconstruction and recollection. The filmmaker said that the original strike of the film – the one he, and perhaps one or two of the older members of his audience, remembered – had super-saturated colours. That stock was no longer available. We just viewed a faded strike. He had intended to make a work about memory, the filmmaker added, but halfway through he realized he was making a film about aging. He sounded surprised. He had woken up in his own counter-archive.

I'm aging as fast as the happy man. It doesn't surprise me. What did surprise me was the depth of my envy for the sort of memory proposed by his methodical, affectless, disingenuously vernacular footage. I craved a lesbian version – tripod shots of womyn's bookstores perhaps, or plaid shirts, hairy legs, Tee Corinne drawing her *Cunt Coloring Book* (1975), or Valerie Solanas plunking away in the

Chelsea Hotel. If I could have wished such a document into existence, I wouldn't have complained about fading. But there is no lesbian version, so by the middle of the second bookend, in the eye of someone else's obsessions, I found myself trying to locate the makings of an archive in the clutter that lies between my ears, wondering about the cost of film and processing in the 1970s, about economic inequities, about (yawn) sex discrimination and homophobia, and about whether the certainty that one's work is worth archiving is a symptom of privilege – generally white, generally Western, ponderously male, tediously heterosexual.

The archive is a pledge to the future. So said Jacques Derrida.[6] Heterosexuality is about reproduction. Same thing. History belongs to the victors.

The happy man was revisiting the moment he himself had created in full confidence that there would be a future for that self. My moment was also the 1970s, at the intersection of various liberation struggles – black, Chicano, Native American, women, left, gay, labour. Around and against silence, betrayal and resistance, groups of all sorts invented their futures and their pasts in a moment of transformative, irrevocable utopian rage. Lesbians too. We were often, but by no means always, bourgeois and white. We tended (sincere apologies all round) to colonize not only the past, but other classes and races. The lesbian liberation struggle, however, disappears from feminist and gay accounts of culture and art, and thus vanishes as a usable past, a history that might shape the culture of a queer present.[7]

Lesbians vanish not because we lack numbers or talent, but because lesbian visibility is an ontological impossibility. The public sphere cannot register the presence of lesbians because 'public', a historical construction serving to naturalize the connections between masculinity and citizenship, functions not by inclusion but by exclusion. Lesbians may be masculine, but they are not men. Neither, as Monique Wittig famously observed, are they women.[8] A meaningless concept in a heterosexual economy, lesbians are ghosted in the public sphere not by consistency but by strategic incoherence. As David Halperin wrote, 'a potentially infinite number of different but functionally interchangeable assertions, such that whenever any one assertion is falsified or disqualified, another one – even one with a content exactly contrary to the original one – can be neatly and effectively substituted for it.'[9]

Here we go. It's impossible to know whether a woman is a lesbian. Even if she's caught in the act, it might be a phase. If it isn't, her sexuality may have nothing to do with her work, be that visual art, writing, history or theory. If she's indisputably a lesbian, her work is inferior, or at least that portion informed by her lesbianism. Conversely, if the work isn't inferior, she can't really be lesbian. Or she may not be having sex – who can really tell? what is it that women do? what is sex? – so she isn't a real lesbian. Or her work is not about her lesbian self,

which means her work is not lesbian work. Or, if her work is about her lesbian self, she's probably white – aren't they all? – which narrows her vision. If she stopped producing work about being a lesbian, either she's making progress or lacks courage. If the former, her work isn't 'lesbian' work; if the latter, she can never be a good artist. Or she's queer. These days, sadly – no matter that the first documented use of the word 'queer' is as a synonym for cunt – queer means either that it makes no difference she's a lesbian, or that she's a conspicuously chic sort of lesbian.[10]

This means that a counter-archive that embeds, no matter how ephemerally, the memory of the 'lesbian' as part of 'the' feminist revolution must construct and then track not a body but an idea.[11] Such a counter-archive – balancing lesbian, queer, and feminist among the possibilities of identification and subjectivity – should be able to weigh distortion, to register absence, and to follow the flotsam of disappearance. It should index not only the evanescent rage that sparked an entire enterprise but map the erotic joy that fuelled a revolution. It must refuse a stable architecture of political identity, memory, or faith in information as a retrievable commodity. [...]

1 Laura Cottingham, 'Eating from the *Dinner Party* Plates and Other Myths, Metaphors and Moments of Lesbian Enunciation in Feminism and its Art Movement', in Amelia Jones, ed., *Sexual Politics: Judy Chicago's Dinner Party in Feminist Art History* (Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1996) 212.

2 Carolee Schneemann, 'Interior Scroll', in *More Than Meat Joy: Complete Performance Works and Selected Writings* (New Paltz, New York: Documentext, 1979) 234–9. Queerer still – and thanks to Jenni Sorkin for calling this bit of 1970s genderfuck to my attention – the text parrots film historian Annette Michelson's graduate students, who were responding to Schneemann's complaints that Michelson had missed yet another opportunity to view her films. Schneemann, correspondence with the author, 7 December 2005. *Meat Joy* was partially funded by the National Endowment for the Arts.

3 I learned about the boxes from a conversation with Schneemann in the early 1980s.

4 Simon Taylor, curator at the Guild Hall Museum in East Hampton, New York, was fired midway through the run of the 2002 exhibition 'Personal and Political: The Women's Art Movement, 1969–1975' after conflicts with the Guild Hall director about *Interior Scroll*. Schneemann's gesture was requeered by Emily Roysdon, wearing a 'grandma-chic floral jumper', at the Fez Cafe in New York in June of 2003. See Matt Wolf, 'New Queer Live Art', *LTTR*, no. 3 (2004).

5 But, as Cottingham has acerbically noted, 'it would be so much easier and so much more productive to think, write and converse about the relationship between lesbianism and feminism within art and culture if the word lesbian itself didn't, on its own, without the addition of qualifiers, flip people out.' Cottingham, 'Eating from the *Dinner Party* Plates', op. cit., 211.

6 'The archive has always been a pledge, and like every pledge, a token of the future. To put it more

trivially: what is no longer archived in the same way is no longer lived in the same way.' Jacques Derrida, *Archive Fever: A Freudian Impression* (1995) (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1998) 18.

7 Lesbian exclusion from the history of both queer culture and feminism is addressed in Cottingham, *How many 'bad' feminists does it take to change a lightbulb?* (New York: Sixty Percent Solution, 1994), and in Harmony Hammond, 'A Space of Infinite and Pleasurable Possibilities: Lesbian Self-representation in Visual Art', in Joanna Frueh, Cassandra L. Langer and Arlene Raven, eds, *New Feminist Criticism* (New York: Icon, 1994). 'Lesbian' does not, by any means manage the meanings, in Foucault's term, of all contact between women. The discourse of the mainly white lesbian feminism of the 1970s accommodated neither the butch-femme culture of the 1960s and 70s nor the relationships between women of colour that would be described and theorized a few years after the series of paintings that is the subject of this essay was produced. See, for example, the Combahee River Collective, 'A Black Feminist Statement', in Zillah Eisenstein, ed., *Capitalist Patriarchy and the Case for Socialist Feminism* (New York: Monthly Review Press, 1979); Audre Lorde, *Zami: A New Spelling of My Name* (Freedom, California: Crossing Press, 1982) and *Sister Outsider: Essays and Speeches* (Trumansburg, New York: Crossing Press, 1984); and Cherríe Moraga and Gloria Anzaldúa, eds, *This Bridge Called My Back: Writings by Radical Women of Colour* (Watertown, Massachusetts: Persephone Press, 1981).

8 Monique Wittig, 'The Straight Mind' (1980), in *The Straight Mind and Other Essays* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1992) 32.

9 David M. Halperin, *Saint Foucault: Towards a Gay Hagiography* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1995) 33.

10 See Terry Castle, ed., *The Literature of Lesbianism: A Historical Anthology from Ariosto to Stonewall* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2003) 35. Castle notes that Anne Lister, in her coded lesbian diaries of the 1820s, regularly used 'queer' in her accounts of her amorous escapades, 'typically conjoining it with the deliciously Anglo-Saxon verb to grubble'. The first documented use of the word was in 1815.

11 Castle, ibid., sidesteps decades of tedious rationalization about unascertainable biographical minutiae – writers who refused to self-identify as lesbian (e.g., Djuna 'I-am-not-a-lesbian-I-only-loved-Thelma' Barnes) and chronic sexual ditherers – by constructing a thick anthology that restores the idea of love between women to the history of ideas – as trope, as stereotype, as obsessive and central image in Western intellectual life. See especially her introduction, pages 7–11.

Catherine Lord, extract from 'Their Memory is Playing Tricks on Her: Notes toward a Calligraphy of Rage', in Cornelia Butler and Lisa Gabrielle Mark, eds, *Wack!: Art and the Feminist Revolution* (Los Angeles: The Museum of Contemporary Art, Los Angeles/Cambridge, Massachusetts: The MIT Press, 2007) 441–3.

Ridykeulous (Nicole Eisenman & A.L. Steiner) The Advantages of Being a Lesbian Artist//2006

Working without the pressure of success *sucking dick.*
Not having to be in shows with men. *that don't exist.*
Having an *a Ford* escape from the art world in your 4 free-lance jobs.
Knowing your career might pick up after you're eighty *you've sucked eighty-five million pussies.*
Being reassured that whatever kind of art you make it will be labelled feminine. *whatev*
Not being *getting your fist* stuck in a tenured teaching position *tight spot.*
Seeing your ideas *face* live on in the work *in the pussy of others.*
Having the opportunity to choose between career *cunt lapping* and motherhood *fist-fucking.*
Not having to choke on those big cigars or paint in Italian suits. *big or small dicks.*
Having more time to work after your mate dumps you for someone younger. *Fuck you.*
Being included in revised versions of art history. *castration.*
Not having to undergo the embarrassment of being called a genius. *a straight choad*
Getting your picture in the art magazines wearing a gorilla suit. *having your pussy eaten out.*

– Guerrilla Girls, Conscience of the Art World Ridykeulous!

Ridykeulous (a collaboration between the artists Nicole Eisenman and A.L. Steiner), 'The Advantages of Being a Lesbian Artist', hand-altered intervention on the Guerrilla Girls' 1988 poster work, *Advantages of Being a Woman Artist* (2006).

Zach Blas/Queer Technologies
Gay Bombs: User's Manual//2008

Gay Bombs (Hijack This Queers!)
Gay Bombs is a technical manual manifesto that outlines a 'how to' of queer networked activism. Gay Bombs is a reverse discourse, a reinscription, a mutating body politic, a multitude, a queer terrorist assemblage of networked activists, deploying new technologically queer sensibilities. Gay Bombs is a technical manual designed to explicate and frame the discourses of Queer Technologies. In this user's guide, a 'how to' of queer political action and formation is outlined through the use and distribution of Queer Technologies. Topics include: understanding queer technological tactics, creating and organizing, working with consumerism and managing output.

Queer Technologies' products are all gay bombs. As queer political weapons, they explode and infect.

Getting Started
When the US military attempted to pursue the creation of a gay bomb, homosexuality became a subjugated weapon of the nation-state.[1] Homosexuality existed as a strategy to defeat the enemy. The gay bomb would be a bomb of shame – what the military called a 'distasteful but completely non-lethal blow to morale'. The gay bomb shames the enemy, producing in its victims the very condition of capitulation that allows US military conquest (this condition the nation-state refers to as 'homosexuality'). The US military has defined homosexuality as so abject that engaging in these acts will even bring combatants of war to their knees wilfully surrendering. The gay bomb reveals a more complex positioning of the homosexual within US government standards and regulations: the homosexual as failed terrorist, defeating oneself through moral bankruptcy. Each homosexual is a living gay bomb, a time bomb, an almost-detonated suicide bomb.

The initialization of the gay bomb generates a complex dialectic of homosexual existence and agency. First, as the gay bomb produces the homosexual not as target but as target-already-hit, a larger socio-political war emerges with the homosexual marked as inclusion and exclusion. The nation-state interpellates the homosexual as helpless, perverted enemy unable to control inevitable defeat: the homosexual unworthy of society; the homosexual as already blown up. Second, the nation-state reabsorbs elements of conservative homosexual culture to elude its (ab)use of homosexuality-in-general. Homonationalists assume that by aligning with a conservative nationalist agenda homosexuality is excused by

patriotism – and mainstream culture does nothing but reinforce this assumption, spinning out re-runs of *Will and Grace* for the whole family and Gay.com ads with men swaddled in American flags. Yet no one escapes the gay bomb when detonated – impact, explosion, implosion. Every homosexual pays the price of the enemy. This dialectic of homosexuality as defiled Other and welcomed nationalist builds the very materials that hold the gay bomb intact with little or no questioning. The gay bomb suspends the homosexual in a feedback loop: the homosexual supports and builds the bomb, and the homosexual is blown up by the bomb.

Queer Technologies' Gay Bombs are not military gay bombs. QT Gay Bombs explode, implode, attack, malfunction, perhaps kill – but their materiality exceeds the configurations of any tactical bomb of warfare and detonation. Gay Bombs produce a strategy that posits the queer as the bomb itself, that is, Gay Bombs ultimately follow the logic of the queer (as separate from the already exploded homosexual) and not the military. As Alexander Galloway and Eugene Thacker write, 'the best way to fight an enemy is to become a better enemy.'[2] Gay Bombs constitute an architectural topology of strategy and survival for homosexuals that operate as a bomb against the militarized gay bomb. Gay Bombs are queer bombs. QT Gay Bombs and military gay bombs diverge in numerous ways but what unites them in common is existence as weapon. Use this manual as a weapon.

Here, in this manual, Gay Bombs are outlined, explaining a 'how to' of queer political action through the understanding, use, and distribution of Queer Technologies. Use this manual for queer community building and world-making (networks). Use this manual for developing Queer Technologies. Use this manual for constructing a new queer politics of war.

If war is technological, perpetual and networked, queer networks can provide interstices – places of difference that unite queer activists, intellectuals and artists in technological agency. The gay bomb detonates a regulatory standard for homosexuality. Queer Technologies' Gay Bombs is a strategy that blows up this standard with the hopes of rewiring a non-standard of queerness. Gay Bombs explode into interstices of infinite mutation.

Disidentifying with Technology

After Alan Turing, it appears that technological standards attempt to determine the human condition. The reinscription of binary logic onto Turing's body resulted in his death – another suicide bomb, another gay bomb. Technology binds life to the rhetoric of militaristic desire and corporate capital: technology is here to make our lives better for the greater good of society and to protect us from everything bad. Technological standards box us into a life capital wants us

live. A life of hyper-consumption predicated on the need for always newer technologies. A life of heteronormative networked power, where Steve Jobs is the smiling (white, heterosexual, capitalist) face behind a company that 'thinks different'. A life of imported family photos and children's 1st birthday parties (literally, iLife). Importantly, a life where possibilities and decisions are made by a heteronormative elite before the queer user ever turns the computer on. Nothing on the computer is ever user-friendly.

Disidentifying with technology is an exploit. In José Muñoz's own words: 'Disidentifications is meant to be descriptive of the survival strategies the minority subject practices in order to negotiate a phobic majoritarian public sphere that continuously elides or punishes the existence of subjects who do not conform to the phantasm of normative citizenship.'[3] Disidentifying with technology cuts open interstices that form the groundwork of Queer Technologies.

System Requirements

If queerness has been historically and culturally excluded from technologies as exceptions or errors, codes must be rewritten. The disconnect between queerness and technology is a disconnection. Technology – always already cultural, always already gendered – is male or female, hole or pin, zero or one. The universal discrete machine is a mistake. There are no life universals.

The disidentifying subject must find ways to connect to technology. Disidentification recycles and rethinks encoded meaning. 'Disidentification is a step further than cracking open the code of the majority; it proceeds to use this code as raw material for representing a disempowered politics or positionality that has been rendered unthinkable by the dominant culture.'[4]

We can think of disidentifying as a hacker strategy. If possibilities are determined by technical standards, then a locus of power must reside within programmed hardware. The queer who disidentifies with technology locates this power within hardware as code, rewrites / hacks / infects / mutates this code, and recodes the entire technological apparatus as a result. We must think of coding here at the technical level and beyond: computer codes, language codes, cultural codes, political codes, biological codes, commercial codes. While the disidentifying subject may recode technology only at the technical level, this act still produces, reveals, generates codes of disidentification in all spheres a given technology resides (hence, life-in-general). This act of exploiting, hacking, disidentifying flows in multiple directionalities, for disidentifications do not exist as an absolute Other outside of the normative public sphere but work within and outside simultaneously. Disidentifying with technology spirals into all facets of life and becomes a biopolitical tactic. Disidentifying is a survival strategy.

Installing

Disidentifying with technology is its own machine. It computes all technological artefacts as quasi-objects that are encoded culturally and technically. Running the machine is an act of scanning. Locate the point / peak of disconnection and exploit it. The machine installs possibilities of difference within the existent. Disidentify, recode, recirculate. The Disidentifying Machine builds the primary components of the struggle (war) for queer technological agency.

What is 'Queer Technologies'?

The above query will not be answered. Simply, Queer Technologies could be defined as political tools for queer technical agency, but this definition erases the complexities of the disidentifying subject's relationships to technologies. This question ultimately offers examples – possibilities – with no ontological grounding. Queer Technologies will never be ontologically grounded. Perhaps a statement by Deleuze is what we must keep in mind: 'Technology is social before it is technical.'[5]

As life becomes further infused with technology at every level of existence, formations of body and identity bear the mark of technological networks, systems, and machines. Specifically, biological / technological intersections have formed not only new representations and expressions of gender and sexuality but have also created them. To borrow a concept from Judith Halberstam, 'mutual mutation' is the constant process that unites space, flesh, and technology in a 'technotopic vision.'[6]

As technology precariously balances between corporate power structures and subcultural activism, how are we being marked / signified / erased? If, historically and traditionally, technological progress has been rooted in heteronormative discourse, are all bodies bound to heterosexual control and ideology? If not, how do marginalized bodies react to / resist these power paradigms and reconfigure them? These are the questions that Queer Technologies must ask.

The discourse of queer theory operates as a rhetoric of freedom for those positioned outside heteronormative configurations. Queer theory moves beyond discourses of sexuality and gender to approach larger 'way[s] of life ... strange temporalities, imaginative life schedules and eccentric economic practices.'[7]

Nicolas Bourriaud echoes the 'aesthetic' of this work through his explanation of the 'social interstice': appropriating the Marxist use of the term in trading communities, the interstice – within Bourriaud's philosophy of relational aesthetics – 'is a space in human relations which fits more or less harmoniously and openly into the overall system, but suggests other trading possibilities than those in effect within this system.'[8] Within a queer discourse, the interstice can

manifest in various modes: at the site of the body; within the materiality of an object; and in the use and execution of language. Queer Technologies addresses how queers and queerness mutate technology to create social interstices for connectivity and communication. [...]

Troubleshooting

Determine a given technology's coding language. That is, what is its socio-linguistic coding orientation? How does language – code – gain power and execute within a technological apparatus? What are the biopolitical consequences of these performative utterances?

How does a technology function in the world? What does the notion of functionality convey? How is functionality antithetical to the user?

Does a technological tool's political economy regulate and / or exclude? What exchange does one make to gain access to a particular technology?

What is the value of a technological good? What is at stake in this value? How does the value regulate the world? What is the queer value?

How does desire want to use? That is, what does the queer user desire a technology to do? How does / can queer desire manifest in technology?

What is required to break a technology? Does breaking affect functionality? How necessary is breaking for the production of Queer Technologies? Does breaking provide agency or further inhibit its viability?

How can queer users live life as a multitude of Gay Bombs? [...]

1 In 2005, BBC news reported: 'The US military investigated building a "gay bomb", which would make enemy soldiers 'sexually irresistible' to each other, government papers say. [...] The plan for a so called 'love bomb' envisaged an aphrodisiac chemical that would provoke widespread homosexual behaviour among the troops, causing what the military called a "distasteful but completely non-lethal" blow to morale.' 'US Military Pondered Love Not War' (15 January 2005).

2 Alexander R. Galloway and Eugene Thacker, *The Exploit: A Theory of Networks* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2007) 98.

3 José Esteban Muñoz, *Disidentifications: Queers of Colour and the Performance of Politics* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1999) 4.

4 Ibid., 31.

5 Gilles Deleuze, *Foucault* (1986) (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1988) 40.

6 J. Jack Halberstam, *In a Queer Time and Place* (New York: NYU Press, 2005) 103.

7 Ibid., 1.

8 Nicolas Bourriaud, *Relational Aesthetics* (1998) (Dijon: Les Presses du réel, 2002) 16.

Zach Blas/Queer Technologies, extracts from section 1 of *Gay Bombs: User's Manual* (2008). (www.queertechnologies.info)

Zanele Muholi
Isilumo siyaluma (Period Pains)//2011/2015

Isilumo siyaluma is a Zulu expression that can be loosely translated as 'period pains/periods pain'. There is an added meaning in the expression, that there is something secretive in and about this blood/'period in time'.

At one level, my project deals with my own menstrual blood, with that secretive, feminine time of the month that has been reduced within Western patriarchal culture as dirty.

On a deeper level, my menstrual blood is used as a vehicle and medium to begin to express and bridge the pain and loss I feel as I hear and become witness to the pain of 'curative rapes' that many of the girls and women in my black lesbian community bleed from their vaginas and their minds.

Between March 2011 and December 2014, 23 young black lesbians, gay men and trans persons aged between 19 and 36 were brutally murdered in various townships.

2014 December Gauteng Tshwane (Hammanskraal): Kate Mosima (32) was stabbed to death in the early hours of 15 December. Kate was walking home with her brother Simon Mosima of New Eersterus Township. He narrated how they split up after a misunderstanding and when he passed a young man after turning a corner he was not alarmed or think his sister was in danger. It is only when he got home and found his mother in tears, that he was informed that his sister had been fatally stabbed.

2014 September Eastern Cape Port Elizabeth: Skhumbuzo Harold Mkefile (25) was an openly gay man from Kwa Noxolo section. He was raped, his ear cut out and a substance inserted through his buttocks. His body was discovered by, a passer by in Booysens Park. He was lying half naked in a field surrounded by bloody rocks and stones. His head was reportedly smashed.

2014 September Gauteng Ekurhuleni (Daveyton): Thembelihle 'Lihle' Sokhela's 28-year-old lifeless body was found in Thabo Molefe's bedroom. He handed himself over to local police, days after Lihle disappeared. Before going to the police station, he asked his mother to make his bed, leading to her discovering the body while trying to pick up a blanket next to the bed. Lihle's relatives, who were summoned to the scene to identify the body, explained how they were greeted by the stench of decomposition.

2014 August North West (Ventersdorp): Gift Disebo (24) was found not far from her home. She was raped, strangled with a wire, and a water pipe left inside her mouth with water running. Pule Botlhokwane (24) who is said to have been friends with Gift, is charged with the brutal murder.[1] [...]

As we continue to live and survive in troubled times as black lesbians in South Africa and within the continent, rampant hate crimes and brutal killings of same gender loving women are rife. This ongoing project is an activist/artist's radical response to that violence.

The passage in which we bleed
The passage where we are/ were born
The passage through which we become (wo)men?
The erotic passage meant to be aroused, is raped
The passage we love is hated and called names
The sacred passage is ever persecuted

I continue to bleed each time I read about rampant curative rapes in my 'democratic' South Africa.

I bleed every time queer bodies are violated and refused citizenship due to gender expression and sexual orientation within the African continent.

I constantly bleed when I hear about brutal murders of black lesbians in our townships and surrounding areas.

I'm scarred and scared, as I don't know whose body will be next to be buried.

I bleed because our human rights are ripped.

I cry and bleed as mothers, lovers, friends, relatives lose their beloved ones, let alone the children that become orphans because of trans/queerphobic violence.

We bleed, our life cycles invaded, we bleed against the will of our bodies and beings.

Each patterned piece in this series[2] represents a 'curative rape' survivor or a victim of hate crime, the physical and spiritual blood that is shed from our bodies.

1 Twenty other brutal crimes dating back to 2011 are recorded in Zanele Muholi's revised text of 2015. We regret that there was not space here to reprint the whole testimony.

2 *Isilumo siyaluma* (Period Pains), a series of prints on paper begun in 2006, each with a digitally collaged, mandala-like form, originated from the artist's menstrual blood stains.

Zanele Muholi, extract from '*Isilumo siyaluma* (Period Pains)', Stevenson Gallery, Cape Town, South Africa (2011, revised 2015).

I WAS SURROUNDED BY PEOPLE WHO WERE SUFFOCATING UNDER THE BURDEN OF A NORMAL LIFE. I KNEW I'D RATHER BE WRONG THAN SAFE

Holly Hughes, 'Breaking the Fourth Wall', 1996

QUEER WORLDING, DEFIANT FLOURISHING

Zoe Leonard
I Want a Dyke for President//1992

I want a dyke for president. I want a person with aids for president and I want a fag for vice president and I want someone with no health insurance and I want someone who grew up in a place where the earth is so saturated with toxic waste that they didn't have a choice about getting leukemia. I want a president that had an abortion at sixteen and I want a candidate who isn't the lesser of two evils and I want a president who lost their last lover to aids, who still sees that in their eyes every time they lay down to rest, who held their lover in their arms and knew they were dying. I want a president with no air conditioning, a president who has stood on line at the clinic, at the dmv, at the welfare office and has been unemployed and layed off and sexually harrassed and gaybashed and deported. I want someone who has spent the night in the tombs and had a cross burned on their lawn and survived rape. I want someone who has been in love and been hurt, who respects sex, who has made mistakes and learned from them. I want a Black woman for president. I want someone with bad teeth and an attitude, someone who has eaten that nasty hospital food, someone who crossdresses and has done drugs and been in therapy. I want someone who has committed civil disobedience. And I want to know why we started learning somewhere down the line that a president is always a clown: always a john and never a hooker. Always a boss and never a worker, always a liar, always a thief and never caught.

Zoe Leonard, *I Want a Dyke for President*, typescript letter, 1992.

Tee Corinne
On Sexual Art//1993

Sometimes I think I have the wrong kind of personality to be making art out of sexual imagery. I don't like confrontation, don't like negative public commotion. Nonetheless, since 1974 I have been actively involved with labia imagery and with images of women making love with other women or with themselves.

It started before 1974, maybe as early as 1950 when I was seven and looked, using a mirror, at my body between my legs. It was confusing. I was shocked,

somehow, at the formlessness of what I saw. What did I expect? I don't know. I didn't look again until I was twenty-seven. By that time I had a bachelor's and a master's degree in art. I had drawn and sculpted men's genitals. But women's? No.

One day I took it into my head to draw my own. I did several renderings which I hid so that my husband wouldn't see them. I didn't think he would approve. Later I tore them into small pieces. That was the winter of 1970–71.

By mid 1973 I had separated from my husband and was exploring options for women in San Francisco. I went to a workshop sponsored by the Esalen Institute. I chose it because it had the words 'lesbian' and 'feminism' in its title. We sat on the floor in a circle. At some point in the evening, paper and pencils were passed around and we were asked to draw, from memory, women's external sexual organs. Mine was the most detailed drawing. I admitted I'd done drawings before and destroyed them. A book was passed around, opened to a glossy reproduction of 'Female Genitalia'. I didn't look long, not nearly as long as I wanted.

I knew that the things we don't have names for, or images of, are the ones we label crazy and bad. I believed that reclaiming labial imagery was a route to claiming personal power for women. Using soft pencils, I did drawings of every woman who would let me, then I used tracing paper to translate them into easy-to-reproduce ink drawings. I made copies on card stock and sold them through local women's bookstores. I learned there was a market for these images. Women really liked them, liked to hang them on their walls, and give them as gifts.

By November 1975, I had turned the drawings into a colouring book called *The Cunt Coloring Book*. No other name seemed really to fit, although the word 'cunt' was not one with which I was particularly comfortable. The alliteration, though, was nice. I also liked the idea of combining a street term for genitalia with a colouring book, because both are ways that, as children, we get to know the world. By the end of 1975 I knew that I wanted to make my life with women and was willing to claim the word 'lesbian'. I wanted to find ways to use my art to clarify and make sense out of this new life and culture into which I was moving. I started taking photos of women kissing, hugging, touching each other's bodies in intimate ways.

I also started taking photos of women's genitals. What excited me about the pictures I was making was the portratal of grace and beauty, coupled with the tang of traversing forbidden territory.

It has been said of my work that it is essentializing: reducing women to our biological manifestation. Those voices do not understand the radicalism of turning the lights on in secret, darkened places and making that enlightening into a public record. I understand what I am doing as contributing to a kind of sanity, a witnessing, an affirmation of the fleshy side of lesbianism, with more than a whiff of the transcendent. That is, when I'm successful.

I have been accused of romanticizing lovemaking between women, of leaving out the times one kicked one's lover, accidentally, in the head while turning over. It's true. Lesbians have often been portrayed negatively. And I decided that it was not my inclination to do this. In making my audience what Barbara Grier has called the 'Garden Variety Lesbian', I turned away from the theorists who defined cutting-edge work as necessarily deconstructionist or sadomasochistic.

Dreamy. My work participates in a mythologizing dream: sex as a way of knowledge and a route to power. I am almost fifty and think that I am close to being finished with sexual imagery. My body and my life are taking me different places. Yet I have thought this before and changed my mind. Why? Because no one else was making the images I wanted to see. Perhaps, though, this is part of what moves an artist; the visual dream that, with work, can be manifest and shared.

Tee Corinne, 'Artist's Statement: On Sexual Art', *Feminist Studies*, vol. 19, no. 2 (Summer 1993) 369–70.
Tee Corinne Papers, Coll. 263, Special Collections and University Archives, University of Oregon Libraries.

Leigh Bowery
Audience: In Conversation with Richard Torry//1989

Richard Torry As an artist, do you want to communicate with an audience?

Leigh Bowery It wouldn't be much good if I kept it all to myself at home. An audience is a big part of my work. Communicating and selling ideas is what it's all about, the exchange of ideas.

Torry So you want to provoke a reaction?

Bowery Yes, anything.

Torry You've moved on to the stage.

Bowery I've worked with Michael Clark for about three years now and we've travelled a lot doing shows. I've also done a lot of my own things as well on a stage or in a nightclub or in art galleries.

Torry And do you prefer the street? You said earlier that you prefer the street.

Bowery I said I wish there wasn't a difference between the stage and the street. Well, the truth is now I could get a bag and bring all my things up here and then walk up and down Old Compton Street which would be fantastic. The audience is already there. Old Compton Street is always busy so you wouldn't need to send invitations. I like the way you can make friends so quickly like that. In fact, I had an episode with the police as well. At one time my favourite fabric was flesh, and I was working quite a lot of it at that point. I didn't wear any clothes for a while. I had a sort of a bra and I was very keen on skin.

Torry Real skin?

Bowery Yes, my skin especially.

Torry And you took this onto the street?

Bowery Well, I remember one night at Bangs and wearing this bra. Because I've got such a lot of flesh I can move it around in different shapes and so I was sporting a really impressive cleavage. I had this pussy wig which I devised (which was really good because it didn't need strings or anything and I could kick my legs all over the place and nothing spilt out or fell out). I had a wrap on and was going from Bangs to Heaven. I got so carried away when I saw all the lights and the cars that I threw the wrap onto the pavement and walked into the road. The music was in my mind and I was carrying on like this (*clicks fingers*) and cars were beeping and honking and I was having such a sensational time just in this bra. I think I had some beaded boots and a beaded head thing, working away on the street. Cars were stopping and swerving and beeping and then I saw these big lights coming towards me. I pulled out all the stops and started doing high kicks and it was a police car. They took me and put me in a van, my friend [Charles Atlas] gave me my cape so I wrapped myself up. Then they put me in a police cell at the station and I had everything on. They said can you take that off and I said no it's glued on, which it was but I could have taken it off. So I had myself covered up and I noticed that when my cape fell off at one point the police were much nicer, so I had it off one shoulder. I was just sitting there and then they got more or less everyone in the police station to come in at different points, to stick their head in the door, pull it up and there'd be hilarious laughter in the corridor. I suppose that was the punishment I had.

Torry Were you charged with something?

Bowery No, I said that I'd just performed at Busby's and that I was drunk on the

success of it all. When I walked onto the street and saw the lights I thought they were spotlights and I had show fever again. I just had to pull out all the stops, the show was a really big hit, ask anybody. So, I guess I was in a good mood and wasn't too annoyed by it.

Torry They weren't nasty to you?

Bowery Well, they were all gawking at me. Looking the way I did it's no surprise that they were staring at me.

Torry So you didn't take the beaded mask off?

Bowery No, I didn't. Actually, I had been in trouble with the police the year I arrived. I was a chronic shoplifter and was caught twice. So I said my fingerprints are on record and that they could check me up. I gave them my name and everything, because at that point I used to dip my hands into spirit gum and then dip them into glitter. So I had glittery gloves glued on, and they couldn't do fingerprints anyway. So they didn't fingerprint me or anything. That was that episode ... It does go onto the street from time to time.

Torry But on the street don't you get a more diverse and wide audience compared to a nightclub?

Bowery Well, if somebody asks me to do something I nearly always say yes. I don't want to limit what I do just to the street, or just to the stage. On stage I can use devices. I could come down from the ceiling or use trap doors and use all sorts of lights. I can bring other things into play to make the spectacular bigger and stronger and more extreme. The lights on the street are car lights, which I have used already in one show. I've had some really good times on the street, walking around.

Torry Describe your stage performances.

Bowery They change all the time. They are more or less just a big entrance – the longest one has been, I think, about five minutes – and if I can use anything, any devices the theatre has or the space has, for how to come in – from the ceiling, or on a string – then I will. And fireworks, anything like that, just as big as possible. Usually the garment might change a bit, some of it might come off, or there will be a surprise in some way. I like it to be a big entrance with a surprise so it will be as memorable as possible.

Torry And to provoke the audience?

Bowery Well, yes.

Leigh Bowery and Richard Torry, extract from 'Audience', interview (1989) in *Leigh Bowery* (London: Violette Editions, 1998) 207–9.

Ma Liuming
Fen-Ma Liuming//1995

A symbol appears in my art in the form of the character 'Fen-Ma Liuming'; Specifically, the graceful face of a woman on the body of a man. The performances created by this union of the feminine with the masculine have given structure to a new form of language. The origin of this image can be found in life, or in a kind of civilization or elsewhere. In any case, what matters is that it appears, alive, before an audience. Each performance is a metaphor for a kind of inefficient human behaviour; the absence of meaning in this behaviour the metaphor of absurdity of existence and our incapability; a message as much about the isolation of internal synthesis as our maturation process.

The concept of 'synthesis' dictates that within a solitary entity there exists an element of multiplicity, part and parcel of an addition/subtraction relationship. When an image makes its appearance, when it is endowed with its own life, when the information it spreads is measured in the feedback of the viewer, it becomes an active element.

'Fen-Ma Liuming' also reveals this shameful fact: rather than passing judgement on individuals, people take clothing and cultural specifications into consideration. The way in which one behaves toward material always allows one to sense that which we call the spirit.

'Fen-a Liuming' offers a synthesized education, at once contradictory and harmonious, on the nature of humanity and the social environment. There must exist a loving relationship between art and the artist. The former must provide a constitutional support for the spiritual life of the latter, an element that one depends on to exist. The performer/performance relationship, from an artistic point of view, can be compared to the narrow attention found between couples of opposite genders; at once foreign and intimate.

It is for art that I am thus adorned.

Ma Liuming, 'Fen-Ma Liuming' (1995), in *Fen–Ma Liuming* (Beijing: Cheng Xindong, 2004) 127.

Nayland Blake
Curating 'In a Different Light'//1995

Queer people are the only minority whose culture is not transmitted within the family. Indeed, the assertion of one's queer identity often is made as a form of contradiction to familial identity. Thus, for queer people, all of the words that serve as touchstones for cultural identification – family, home, people, neighbourhood, heritage – must be recognized as constructions for and by the individual members of that community. The extremely provisional nature of queer culture is the thing that makes its transmission so fragile. However, this very fragility has encouraged people to seek retroactively its contours to a degree not often found in other groups. Queer people must literally construct the houses they will be born into, and adopt their own parents. The idea that identity and culture are non-organic constructs is also one of the most important characteristics of postmodernism. It should be noted that many of the theoreticians of the postmodern – the generation of critics and philosophers that came of age in the late sixties – were gay and lesbian. In certain ways, the discourse of the postmodern is the queer experience rewritten to describe the experience of the whole world.

From the margins, queers have picked those things that could work for them and recoded them, rewritten their meanings, opening up the possibility of viral reinsertion into the body of general discourse. Denied images of themselves, they have changed the captions on others' family photos. Left without cultural vehicles, they have hijacked somebody else's. They have been forced to trespass and poach. To be queer is to cobble together identity, to fashion provisional tactics at will, to pollute and deflate all discourses. Historically, this activity has been a possibility for either the upper class, whose privilege is utilized to exercise in power, or for the lower class, whose reworkings of high culture have often served as a form of social resistance. At various times queer practice has been associated with both the upper and lower class positions. Because queers do not share a set of physical characteristics, we have also had to have greater recourse to semiotic means to express our tribal affiliations. We resort to dress codes, colours, earrings, references to tell-tale cultural interests, whether Judy or Joan Jett. In histories and biographies we scan for words like 'companion' and

'spinster'. Or we read the obituaries looking for men who die before their fifties of a lingering illness.

Queers are a minority because of what we do, not what we are. As such, we continue to pose a dilemma for a society that can only believe in equality if it is linked to biology. What used to be true only of queer culture though, has now become true of all culture. All artists today are confronted with a culture that is no longer unified or even divided into the convenient binary of high and low. Postmodern culture is an ever-mutating system of signs and meanings. Value is fluid. Artists have developed a number of strategies for negotiating this circumstance – strategies that bear a marked resemblance to those employed by queers in relation to the heterosexual world. How then do those stategies differ for queer artists? In my view, part of the answer lies in the family tree that has suggested itself to me as a result of the process of working on this show. I want to present the lineage that I have conjured up for these queer artists. I think that their fates might allow us to guess at the answer to that question.

I do not present the following genealogy as part of some positivistic historical progression that will lead us through the high points of artistic production inevitably to the glory of queer art. Rather, the activity that we are calling queer – the works and ideas that interested us for this exhibition in the first place – is similar in its intention, organization and tactics to several other previous activities. In the past, those activities have been organized around other group identifications and other social concerns. But by placing queerness within this progression, I hope to show both what is different about the work of queer people from that of previous generations of lesbian and gay artists, and retroactively to claim space for queer activities in previous situations not associated with queerness. [...]

Nayland Blake, extract from 'Curating 'In a Different Light'', in Nayland Blake, Lawrence Rinder and Amy Scholder, eds, *In A Different Light: Visual Culture, Sexual Identity, Queer Practice* (Berkeley: University Art Museum/San Francisco: City Lights Books, 1995) 12–14.

Wolfgang Tillmans
In Conversation with Neville Wakefield//1995

Neville Wakefield [...] How do you choose your models – the people who inhabit the created rather than found situations?

Wolfgang Tillmans It's a difficult question as to who the people are. There is always this shifting relationship between the work I generate myself and bring into magazines, and the work which comes to me as an assignment. In the most general sense I would describe the people I photograph as friends.

Wakefield It sounds also like Nan Goldin's extended family ...

Tillmans Yes, but first of all the people do not necessarily act as my friends in the pictures. I don't photograph them as friends. They are impersonators of their own and my ideas – of an image. So they really, in the truest sense of the word, model situations for me. I see the models as accomplices in the project, not as just actors. There is of course an element of wanting to possess somebody which informs the bias of my choices.

Wakefield Do you direct them?

Tillmans Yes, but then equally important is to create an atmosphere of possibility so that they too can act out their desires. Again, it sounds very unspecific, uncontrolled, but to actually get people in front of a camera into a mode where, on the one hand, they can lose some of their inhibitions, whilst remaining aware of the process of which they are a part.

Wakefield The photograph then becomes an osmotic membrane between you and them.

Tillmans They are willing to give me my picture of them, and you need collaboration for that. It can't be squeezed out of people. I think also people need to trust pictures and not have that set of beliefs upset too much. Even though as everyone knows the camera lies, still we try to maintain this idea of truth in photography.

Wakefield You seem to be seeking honesty within the artifice of mediation?

Tillmans No one now can be unselfconscious of photographs taken before. There is an encyclopaedia of representation that is in our heads almost from the day we were born. I think that my work is especially dealing with that – respecting the knowledge that every single person has about his/her visual existence and what that means, and what photography means to him/her. Every one of us carries this huge knowledge around, so what I really try to do in my work is photograph people in between these two poles: their pure, innocent self and their inescapable knowledge and vision of themselves and of society. How people feel that it is appropriate to show and hold their body. How we find comfort and discomfort in posture.

Wakefield A great deal of current critical theory sees this body of representatiom as the sort of DNA of identity – something which we are born with and over which we have little or no control. For me the subtlety of your work lies in the fact that it seems to accept this basic premise without giving in to its more pessimistic implications. Your project seems to be to enlarge the scope of identity by adding to the gene-pool.

Tillmans I love people precisely because we all face the dilemma of how we define our self image. By proposing alternatives to those self images already in mainstream circulation, I hope to contribute to a climate of possibility. It also, I hope, encourages people to stick to their beliefs, which when labelled as a part of a generalized 'youth culture' tend to be presented as something transitory and playful, something which will be straightened out at a later date.

Wakefield That it's a passing phase?

Tillmans And that is totally opposed to what I actually look for in my work. It's not about adolescent uncertainty but about a certain kind of self-knowledge, about feeling at one with one's identity within image.

Wakefield It's very different from the moment mined by a photographer like Larry Clark.

Tillmans I was somehow never interested in that moment. I think that what I am interested in is precisely that it is not a phase. And as a gay person I had to confirm for years that it was not a phase. So what I am really doing is looking for people who have a similar approach to life – who take seriously what is normally dismissed as a phase and become comfortable with it. What I am doing is incorporating the notion of masquerade into my version of truth.

Wakefield Identification is also perhaps repression. By refusing to take on the labels handed down from dominant culture you seem to be contesting it, contesting the substitution, the partial identity of the label – techno-kid, traveller, raver, etc. – for the complete identity of the person.

Tillmans Yes, I think that's the biggest cultural fight we are in at the moment, defending the complete identity of the person. I am using my position in the magazine world to do exactly that, something that I believe in completely, and something that I as an artist can only do with credibility by doing it from within. The endless industry thirst for labels, trends and fashions turns every individual style into another benign marketing plot. In a way I try to channel attention lo the multi-layeredness of personality and identity [...]

Wakefield [Your] book brings together disparate strands within the work. Do they become something else when brought together like that – some kind of meta-narrative?

Tillmans Yes, in the way that I work in an additive manner, striving to cover the spectrum of my sensibility. In that aspect I am like a collector, accumulating not only social experience but views of cities, architecture, nature in general and still life. I'm trying out the formal possibilities of all these genres, the million views we have already seen of them. Much in the same way that I research the possibilities of portraiture in an over-informed environment, I look for a contemporary version of landscape, still life and sexuality.

Wakefield The sort of sexuality that we are looking at seems to be both very specific and tender – John laughing at his hard-on or the photographs of your lovers – but at the same time it seems to escape the specificity of gender; to be as it were polymorphously perverse.

Tillmans It really is not so much about the gender divide, but how it is bridged, the things that are shared and common ground. That's why elements of play and regressive behaviour are such an important part of my work. Sometimes it comes out of a sort of androgyny represented through a broken dialogue with glamour. In the end it is to do with attitude and not measurable by the shininess of clothes [...]

Wakefield That clothing becomes a sentient skin, which both conceals and reveals?

Tillmans I've always been drawn to the notion that we are all naked underneath.

Wakefield Some of your most tender and revealing photographs are of your close male friends, where desire is written into the fabric of the image.

Tillmans This very personal work is completely different, since I look at it with a less socially analytical eye. I think, corny as this sounds, I need to love, respect or in some way to embrace all the people that I photograph. That really is a very, very strong criterion, so when asked about who do you photograph it really boils down to that sort of essential sympathy. And even if they are in very exposed or vulnerable situations which I sometimes push them into, it is always done with their complicity, with some sort of love and passion. The bottom line is that I genuinely love people. I think that they are incredible tender beings, so in a way I portray people as untouchable. They are always fragile works of beauty, just there, self-contained creatures that stand in space or in some kind of an environment, but which really are complete entities. For a person to communicate this basic fragility and insecurity – to me, as I do to him or her – is the foundation of most of my pictures. I can really say that nothing bores me more in people than the assumption of security or certainty.

Wakefield Throughout our conversation you have made repeated references to wholeness. Is your unwillingness to violate the integrity of a person's social space linked to the idea of the integrity of pictorial space?

Tillmans I find violation not really interesting, because we are confronted with it on a daily basis. To me it's more like basic social experience. There are so many photographers portraying people as victims or victimized by a social scene, it's becoming something of a mono-culture, and what I always look for are the complexities within people.

Wolfgang Tillmans and Neville Wakefield, extracts from interview (1995) in Jan Verwoert, et al., *Wolfgang Tillmans*, second edition (London and New York: Phaidon, 2014) 116–20.

Holly Hughes
Breaking the Fourth Wall//1996

(*Back in the chair the performer changes, this time into the sullen, overprivileged brat she once was.*)

Like most children I had various chores I was expected to do around the house. The most odious of which was, in my opinion, kissing my parents goodnight. I realized, however, it was an important job. One that apparently they could not do for themselves. And I would be paid.

One night, sitting next to my mother on the couch, I had a sudden epiphany. Fortunately, the fabric was Scotchgarded, so I didn't cause any permanent damage.

But all of a sudden I realized that my mother wasn't just my mother ...

She was a *woman.*

I knew what that meant.

I'd already figured out that being female was a chronic medical condition. You couldn't cure it, but you might be able to learn to live with it. If you got the right treatment in time. And I had an idea for a new treatment for women.

I noticed I had an audience. This made me very happy because I'd heard in science class that a tree falling in the wilderness made no sound. I wanted the world to know about my new treatment for women. So I stood up and looked at my audience. It consisted of two people. My father and the other person who I will alternately refer to as my sister and my father's girlfriend.

It's important to know who your audience is.

I went over to my mother, and when I got to her, I straddled her. Kind of like I imagined I would straddle that pony I knew by then my father was never going to buy me. And as I mounted Mom, I turned, and I looked at my audience, as if to say: 'I bet you wish you'd just bought that pony for me, now don't you? Maybe all this ugliness could have been avoided.'

Then I proceeded to kiss my mother goodnight in the following fashion: I applied my mouth to hers with all the suction power I could muster in my prepubescent frame, and I began to rotate my mouth against hers in a precise, almost scientific manner. When my mother was, at least in my opinion, good and kissed, and would stay that way for quite some time, I turned and I looked at my audience, as if to say: 'You could be next.'

All that kept me from breaking the fourth wall at that moment was my mother, who said:

'Where did you learn to kiss like that?'

'On TV', I answered.

'Well, you're doing it all wrong, hon. You got to open your mouth. Like this.'

I opened my mouth. I leaned forward. And, yes, I did kiss my mother goodnight in the way she so obviously wanted me to. As I did, a small voice in the back of my head warned: 'What do you think you're doing? Now you've gone and fucked your life up but good.'

And I was happy.

This was the first time I realized I *had a life*. Something of my own to fuck up. And I felt powerful. Like the most powerful thing I could imagine, which at that time was a waitress at Howard Johnson's on a Sunday morning, seeing that room full of the interminably ravenous and thinking: 'I know what to do.'

As I made out with Mom, I heard a small sound. Like a door closing and locking behind me. I knew I would never get back to that place where I imagined I was safe.

And, yes, I knew what I was doing was wrong.

But I was surrounded by people who were suffocating under the burden of a *normal life*. I knew I'd rather be wrong than safe. I guess I was at that age when most girls start looking for shelter from the storm.

But I started looking for the storm.

Holly Hughes, 'Breaking the Fourth Wall', from the performance *Clit Notes* (1996); reprinted in Holly Hughes and David Román, eds, *O Solo Homo: The New Queer Performance* (New York: Grove Press, 1998) 429–31.

Henrik Olesen
Mr Knife and Mrs Fork//2009

My dear Mother
My dear Father
I hate to seem inquisitive but could you kindly tell me who I am?

Lord save me, says I, (apropos reproduction)
I don't believe in Father
in Mother

I don't believe in Father
in Mother
Got no papa-mummy

My dear Father My dear Mother My dear Brother
Please forgive me

I am not my Father, my Mother
my Son, Myself
... and yet it is precisely this world of Father+Mother which must *go away*

Farewell
My dear Mother
Please forgive me, says I
Farewell
My dear Father
Farewell

... it is precisely this world of Father+Mother which must go away,
it is this world, split in two – doubled in a state of constant disunion, also willing a constant unification ...
around which it turns
the entire system of this world maliciously sustained by the most sombre organization

O Mother
O Mother
Farewell
With a long black shoe
Farewell
No Mother No Mouth No Tongue No Teeth No Larynx
No Oesophagus No Belly No Anus
No Mother No Mouth No Tongue
No Mouth No Tongue No Teeth No Larynx
No Oesophagus No Belly No Anus

No Father No Legs No Arm No Feet No Eyes No Belly
No Thumb No Elbow No Fist
No Finger No Buttocks No Hair No Anus

How could this body have been produced by parents, when by its very nature it is such eloquent witness of its own self-production?

Farewell Farewell
Goodby Hand Goodbye Wrist Goodbye Hip Goodbye
Chin Goodbye Knee Goodbye Head Goodbye Lip Goodbye
Mouth Goodbye Nose Goodbye Nostril Goodbye Forehead

My dear Father
My dear Mother
Please forgive me

Lord save me, thinks I
Self-reproduction
Self-production, says I
Produce your own body

My dear Father My dear Mother
Please forgive me, says I
When you will have made yourself a body without organs, then you are delivered from all your automatic reactions and restored to your true freedom.

A false nose to look less pathetic
A stink bomb to a friend with bad breath

A natural bent, no doubt
Bent forward, he thunders!

Tangle, which sweaty underarm escapes.
Bent forward, he thunders!
Sibie screams out,
by nature immensely,
Hemiglobes upwards.
Now-burning pedal brushes (delightful!)
an elsewhere-caressed

Abdomen. An omen.
Unsurpassed licks his lingua fattest thighs along, Isodor.

Farewell

My dear Mother
My dear Father
Please forgive me, says I
Better sleep with a sober cannibal than a drunken Christian.
A natural bent, no doubt

(*Poem to the hole in the ass*)

Dark and puckered like a violet rose it pulses, humbly
hidden amidst the moss.
Still damp from love that trickles oft along white thighs to its
lips. Fecit.
Little drops like tears of milk have wept, beneath the
zephyr blowing cruel.
Upon the pebbles of auburn marl.
Obeying the slope and heeding its call.

Henrik Olesen, text from *Mr Knife and Mrs Fork* (Studio Voltaire, London, 2009), in Nikola Dietrich and Jacob Fabricus, *How Do I Make Myself a Body?* (Malmö: Malmö Konsthall/Basel: Museum für Gegenwartskunst (Osfildern-Ruit: Hatje Cantz, 2010) 88.

Tejal Shah
There is a spider living between us//2009

Consider whether this is what you desire – one instead of two?

Consider whether this is what you desire, whether it would satisfy you to obtain this?

If that is your craving, as long as you live, you may both as one live a common life – one instead of two.

Consider whether this is what you desire, whether it would satisfy you to obtain this?[1]

Do you have recurring dreams? Do you have particular dreams that recur?

I don't. But sometimes, I've had a dream where something sexual transpires between my mother and me. In real life I have no desire to sleep with my mother

but nonetheless I feel curious, does she masturbate? What kind of sexual appetite does she have? Has she ever had a 'real' orgasm?

And how do you feel when you land up hearing your parents fucking?

After ten years of living on my own, when I had to stay with them for three months, that was the worst thing. It didn't happen very often but it happened on a night when I came back home really late, drunk and totally horny, and just as I was getting ready to jack off, I heard them. You can imagine my frustration with the pillows over my ears.

Anyway, I've always been curious about these things and how others might react to such situations. I think my father must be a terrible fucker or lover in bed and that upsets me because I feel that whatever it is, people deserve good sex and the same goes for my mother. Besides, in another time, another place and given the possibility, who knows, maybe my mother would be into women.

I never particularly liked the word LESBIAN.

I prefer being called a homosexual or *humjinsi*[2] but by far my favourite are *chappatba*[3] and *chipkali*,[4] which would equal being called a *tribade*.

Consider whether this is what you desire — one instead of two?

Whether it would satisfy you to obtain this?

If that is your craving, as long as you live, you may both as one live a common life – one instead of two.

Consider whether this is what you desire, whether it would satisfy you to obtain this?

Suppose that, as the lovers lay together, Hephaestus should come and stand over them, tools in hand, and ask, 'Oh human beings! What is it that you want of one another?' and suppose they were nonplussed, so he put the question again – 'Well, is this what you crave, to be joined in the closest possible union with one another, so as not to leave one another by night or day? If that is your craving, I am ready to melt you together and fuse you into a single unit, so that two become one and as long as you live, you may both as one live a common life, and when you die, you may also die a common death. Consider whether this is what you desire, whether it would satisfy you to obtain this.'[5]

1 Both this first section and the last contain paraphrases of passages from Plato's *Symposium* as used in Rehaan Engineer's play *Visible Mass: A Meghadutam Scrapbook* (2007) and subsequently reworked by the author.

2 *Humjinsi* is an Urdu word used to indicate a being of the same nature or genus, or species or class. It is also used to indicate relationships and – in its contemporary Urdu usage, more specifically – relationships between people of the same sex (i.e. homosexuals). The word is gender neutral, non-

pejorative and (significantly) does not constrict the definition of the relationship to the sexual.

3 *Chappatbaz* is slang word for a lesbian, literally meaning 'stuck things'.

4 *Chipkali* is a slang word for a lesbian, literally meaning 'lizard'.

5 As at note 1.

Tejal Shah, *There is a spider living between us*, transcript of single channel video, 6:45 min. (2009). (http://tejalshah.in)

Simon Fujiwara
Welcome to the Hotel Munber//2009

The story is based on real events in the life of my parents. My father, who is Japanese, and my mother, who is British, moved to Spain at the height of the Franco dictatorship and in 1972 bought a hotel in S'Agaró on the coast of Catalonia, northern Spain. It was the golden age of their relationship. Each unable to live in one another's native countries, Spain was a refuge of sorts, a place where they were both out of context, and they flourished there. My brother was conceived and born in the hotel, but I have never been there. I've only ever been able to imagine it through stories and photographs. As youths, we all grow up hearing stories around the dinner table – of family myths, events that took place before we were born. For me the tales of the Hotel Munber were particularly enchanting, exotic – stories from an age of oppression, of soldiers and guards forcing their way into the bar, demanding whiskey, of the Catalan language brutally silenced, of bewildered tourists watching it all play out against a backdrop of sun, sangria and flamenco. In the yellowing photographs my parents showed me, I saw a typical Spanish bar and restaurant, just as you would imagine it: terracotta floors, chequered table cloths, bulls heads ... My mother once told me her recollection of the day that Franco died, the 20th of November 1975. She said that the day after Franco died, the bar was awash with 'rude magazines', pornography, bought in Perpignan, on the French border, and smuggled into Spain. These magazines adorned tabletops and bar counters. She asked a customer where these suddenly came from, what they were doing there? 'This is the first day of freedom', he told her, 'we don't have to hide this anymore'. These and other anecdotes started to make me think of my parents as witnesses to an important historic moment, and that their stories, however small and intimate, should be recorded somewhere, somehow.

I'm looking at a picture of my father on another grainy, curving photograph. He's at the foot of an Iberia aeroplane, and he's just arrived in Spain for the first time. It's the 1970s so he's wearing bell bottoms, a tight shirt and holding – what looks to me – like a handbag. And whenever I saw this image as a child I thought to myself: my father looked decidedly homosexual.

After I had decided to write the story of the Hotel Munber as a novel, I had to decide what kind of novel it would be. As we all know it is impossible to separate the writing of history from the personal interests of the writer, so I started to look for gay writers that had recorded the atrocities of the oppressive time. There were writers like Juan Goytisolo or Jean Genet, who had written about the regime in exile, from Paris, from Morocco. But nobody, it seemed, was writing and printing from within the borders of Spain, and it occurred to me – embarrassingly late – that there was a simple reason for this: censorship. Nothing that was erotic in content or homoerotic in theme could be printed while Franco held the reigns. At first it was disheartening, tragic even, to think that an entire chapter in Spanish history was missing. But soon I started to think that this very fact could work to my advantage – it gave me a purpose. Maybe I could be the first person to write the history of gay Catalonia, gay Franco Spain, as a first person narrative, and this story could be set in the Hotel Munber with my father as the protagonist.

Now, you're probably already seeing a basic conflict that would arise with a project like this. On the one hand I felt an urgency to tell this political story, unearth a buried history, but on the other hand I would have to eroticize my parents, to use and abuse their history. It was this conflict that drove my project underground for a number of years, where I entered into secret correspondence with gay magazines in the United States, such as *Colt*, *Honcho* and *Freshmen*, but they all rejected my first erotic stories. They said that there was too much politics and not enough sex. It was only when I contacted *Straight to Hell*, a queer fanzine that published 'real-life' sex experiences between men, that I had my first story published. I'm going to read you an excerpt from this story now. However, let me tell you first that, before I published this first story, like any erotic writer worth their salt, I needed a pseudonym to operate under, and so I used the first and best name that came to me, and that was my father's name, Kan Fujiwara.

[*He reads.*]

It is 7 o'clock on the 20th of November 1975 and the news of Franco's death is ringing in my ears. I am blinded, I can see. For five years I have built a sexual empire to oppose him; everything I have learnt about my inner sexuality, I have learnt

through him. I do not know myself but through his oppression.

While I was running the bar at the Hotel Munber I had developed quite a good relationship with a particular super-macho Guardia, who would visit regularly, unstrapping his machine gun from across his chest and dropping it onto the counter, demanding whiskey. One night the soldier stayed late and was unusually rowdy, drunk, so I kept the bar open late to keep him friendly. At a late point in the night he sat suddenly wide-awake at the bar intensely watching me work. I felt tension in the air. As he watched me he proceeded to unzip his tight army trousers and rub his cock against the bar that I had just polished, before picking up his gun and sliding the black metal neck of it against his groin and hanging balls. He pointed the gun towards me and ordered me to sniff the neck of the gun. I remember feeling a mixture of excitement and fear – the smell of metal and stifled crotch. By this point his cock was standing bolt upright and he told me to move to his side of the bar. He forced my legs apart and leaned me over the bar and began to frisk me, before dropping to his knees, pulling my trousers down and licking my …

The story continues as you can imagine …

[*He reads.*]

By my third summer I was in the thick of it. The brutal reign of terror of Franco's state had castrated me, and for a while my sexuality just disappeared, only to return in the most unexpected of ways. It's true that a kind of mania suddenly overcame me, for I became possessed with things that had previously yielded no erotic power over me before. No object in the hotel, small or large would escape my attention – lamps and spindles, door handles and dado rails, surfaces, textures, patinas and grooves were all in my crafty rituals that took place after closing time. With a small tube of Vaseline concealed at all times in my left key-pocket, I was the lord of a castle of carnality. I adventured into countless scenes of power and submission, masters and slaves, and bore my suppressed urges onto the innocent objects in every inventive ways. Sooner than I knew I was cocooned in a self-spun empire that had become both a palace and a prison. Each time Franco tightened his throttling vice on his country, he chastized the people as if they were like an adolescent son, so even in my acts of rebellion, I knew that I too was playing the part of a delinquent son to my tyrannical father, Franco, and it is only now I can confess that in this role I felt, for the first time, a deep sense of purpose in my life.

As I work I often wonder back to the evening [where I jerked off into the egg bowl], and I debate at length who could have been the next to order an omelette that night, whether it could have been a Franco soldier that would have swallowed down the

tortilla with my own special ingredient, or an unassuming tourist, a family man, a honeymooning groom. I continue my nightly masturbatory practices, and have expanded into new fields of perversion. However, to this day, I must say that the consistency of egg white is a hard one to beat.

I have the final reading for you now. In this scene my father discovers that Franco has died, and he climbs to the top of the tower of the Hotel Munber to end the story. He is holding an ostrich egg in his left hand and a book in his right hand.

[*He reads.*]

It is 7 o'clock on the 20th of November 1975 and the news of Franco's death is ringing in my ears. For five years I have built a sexual empire to oppose him. Everything I have learnt about my inner sexuality, I have learnt through him. I do not know myself but through his oppression. I have dreamed of this day, the greatest relief, the freedom I would feel. I am standing at the top of the tower of the Hotel Munber, and I am looking over the province of Catalonia, over the towns, villages, homes of the people I have been oppressed with, and in the evening light everything is at peace, a peace that guts me, a peace that empties me. The breeze is refreshing against my tear-streaked cheeks, and with closed eyes I see five wasted years of fighting what is now only a shadow, the soldiers, the anxiety, family, Franco, everything formed into a perfect egg which I hold out in my hands in front of me. With the heaviest heart the world has ever known, I speak these simple words: 'Father, I am old, I am twenty-six years old, and in my hands is a history I can no longer hold.'

He smashes the ostrich egg on the floor and walks out of the room.

Simon Fujiwara, extracts from the performance script and novel *Welcome to the Hotel Munber* (2009), in Miguel Amado, ed., Simon Fujiwara: 1982 (London: Tate Publishing, 2012) 157–67 [extracts re-ordered for this publication with permission].

Toxic Titties
The Mamaist Manifesto//2005

1. We want to shout the pursuit of pleasure, the glory of euphoric stroking.

2. The essential elements of our movement will be fearlessness, audacity and revolution.

3. The Art World, up to now, has magnified cancerous apathetic immobility and bourgeois decadent pomposity. We want to exalt actions of feverish creation, the shredding of moralistic tyranny, the perilous leap, the slap and the blow and the fist. Followed by Fisting.

4. We reject the myopic petty greed of the establishment, engorged with its own power and appetite, devouring the dissidents, the radicals, and feeding on the blood of artists.

5. We declare that the splendor of the world has been enriched by a new beauty: The beauty of variance: A delicate scar across the chest from the removed breast, the darkened stain of the groin suspended in spandex, soaked in sweat. Exertion emphasized: Puddles on the Dance floor, on the street, and in open mouths. This liquid, this jizem as an expression is more beautiful than any glossy preened prediction of what our desire is supposed to be: Manicured, unquestioning, uncritical and compliant.

6. Magnificence exists only in struggle! There is no masterpiece that has not an aggressive character. Art must be a violent assault on the forces of fascist hegemony. Force them to kneel before Mama!

7. We are on the extreme promontory of the centuries! What is the use of looking to the cannon at the very moment when we must thrust open the doors of radical transformation? This suburban puritanical reality is an illusion, all the despair and decay spreading beneath the surface like a plague. Reject it! Tear away. Free yourselves and your comrades from these repressive constraints.

8. Oh Mama! We will glorify action – the only cure for the world. We will fight constricting morality, paternalism and all insipid opportunist and utilitarian cowardice!

9. And oh yes! We will demolish that art that hangs above the designer furniture in the estates of the ruling class. Oh wretched luxury commodity! Oh vapid insidious object, pandering, grovelling, despicable!

10. We will sing of the great crowds who reject the dribble running through their television monitors, who instead embrace pleasure and revolt; the multi-coloured polyphonic surf of revolutions in modern capitals: the un-recorded vibration of the outraged multitude, banging their fists against the impenetrable fortresses that distribute mass media lies. We will expose the gluttonous art institutions as they devour their colour field paintings. We will speak of artists setting fire to established models of production, animating questions of subjectivity, thrusting off the bondage of commodification. Creation is a revolutionary act! The constraints of representation will be suspended from the clouds by the ephemeral threads of their smoke.

11. Oh Yes! We will form Collaborative bridges with the leap of gymnasts. All together now! We fling ourselves forward. A non-hierarchical working dynamic invested in process and experimentation, both conceptual and formal, across the diabolic rivers of ego and authorship: our great muscled chests, punching the bag of the banal like enormous steel boxers, gloved with untamable desire, and the gliding distance under our feet propelled by a heart that sounds like the flapping of a new flag and the applause of enthusiastic crowds!

12. All together now! We are the Mamaists: a force of pleasure, dissent, determination and will! Individuals, united in purpose, exposing and dismantling systems of authority and control. Join us or move aside, but do not stand in our way!

13. When you cast off the shackles of loathsome heteronormativity, your world, torn asunder, will be open for you, ripe and quivering. Taste the flavour of autonomy as it drips down your chin. Now is the moment to act. Mamas! We dare you; we challenge you! Place your hot palm on the buttocks of the mama next to you. Do it now! Note the sensation: the balance of muscle and softness. As your fingers probe you are slick and feverish with barely restrained desire. Taste now each other's mouths and spread the word. Feel the flesh and the breath that heats your skin. Every hair on your body stands at attention. Attention! Taste, Smell, Lick, Swell, Fingers Grasping, Blood Pounding. Never doubt: To fuck is a revolutionary act!

Toxic Titties (Heather Cassils, Clover Leary, and Julia Steinmetz), 'The Mamaist Manifesto' (2005). Previously unpublished.

María Llopis
Guide for a DIY Queer Matriarchy//2013

I used to think about Matriarchal societies as some utopia belonging to a remote past, which was, of course, oh-so-much-better. It was all about feminist nostalgia. So I was gladly surprised when I discovered that I was wrong, as there are many matriarchal societies living in the world right now. They are endangered, of course they are, but they are there. And it is not about power shifting from men to women. It is about different priorities.

It is about escaping the heteronormative model and building another type of society around other values, which we are going to explore in this lecture. It is about denying patriarchal heteronormative capitalism in a time when the financial and social crisis that we are living makes it more necessary than ever.

The Mosuo are a community living around lake Lugu, between the provinces of Yunnan and Sichuan, in south-east China, who are about 50,000 people. The Minangkabau are a community in west Sumatra (Indonesia) of four million people.

Modern anthropology denies the existence of matriarchal societies, as they are looking for a society is which power control is reversed and therefore men are oppressed by women. But this is not Matriarchy. Queer theory and postporn feminism is definitely going to help us understand.

1. The family unit is built around mothers

'People should never marry, as love is like the seasons of the year, they come and go.' – Yang Erche Namu, Mosuo woman

The matriarch is the boss, and she is chosen among the family members. Children, cousins, aunts and grandparents live together in the same household. Children that are born live in the maternal house are brought up collectively within the family. As a result you will find that the family is always present and available, regardless of the romantic relationships you may have in your life.

Nowadays our families are built upon the concept of romantic love and this is quite a new form of arrangement in history. Pre-arranged marriage was the norm till a few years ago and in a way it seems to me like a more truthful and sincere option if you choose marriage as the main family unit in a society. Mosuo people do not have marriage. Sexuality is outside the family unit.

Therefore, they have the freedom to fall in love without fearing that, if things go wrong, they will lose their house or child custody. They do not have to fight for the right of gay and lesbian couples to marry. If we look closely to the institution of marriage we will see that it is the origin of all evils.

2. A room of one's own

When Mosuo girls are around 13 or 14 years old, they get access to a room of their own. This room has two doors, one has access to the interior of the common home and the second door to the outside. The girls have total autonomy in deciding who enters the room. The only rule is that their guests have to leave before dawn. And they also have to be discreet about the visitors. They can bring different partners every night or, on the contrary, they can share their bed with the same person every night. They are not expected to commit to a relationship and the children that they may conceive will be brought up in the communal house, with the help of their mothers, brothers, sisters and all the community.

This room is called 'Babahuago' in Mosuo language and it means flower room.

Would it be possible to create a queer flower room? The flower room is the hostess, so let's imagine that any child in the family who feels like receiving and hosting, no matter which gender or which anatomy, could have a flower room. And privacy is a rule, so you can receive whoever you want in your flower room, men, women and everything in between.

3. Women do it better[1]

In matriarchal societies, work is the responsibility of women. There is a phrase that is repeated in all the books I read about the Mosuo, and it says: 'Women do it better'. They do it better because their interest is more focused in caring for the well being of their children and the community, and not so much in capital accumulation. They do it better because they are mothers and they care for the well being of the children. And we are going to go deeper in the motherhood concept. Because Matriarchal societies are societies that put motherhood in a central position inside the society.

4. Multiple paternity

Among the Mosuo, men are considered to have no parental responsibilities towards children that they might conceive during the visits to the flower rooms. Mosuo men are responsible of the children of their sisters and their household and family. So the paternal contribution is detached from biological parenthood. In Mosuo the word 'Awu' means both: father and uncle. It makes sense, as in fact, the children of your sisters are children of your own blood.

> When Paul Le Jeune, French Jesuit missionary in French Canada in XVII , talked about the dangers of depraved infidelity to an Indian, he got a good lesson on parenting. The missionary told the Indian that it was not all right that their women loved other men, as it often happens amongst them. He explained him that in that way, he could not be sure of being the father of his son, who was present. The

Indian replied: 'You say silly things. You French people only love your children, but we love all the children of our tribe. – Christopher Ryan and Cacilda Jethá, *En el principio era el sexo: Los origenes de la sexualidad moderna* (Barcelona: Paidós, 2012)

This type of social organization we live in began 8,000 years before Christ, and given that anatomically modern humans have existed for at least 200,000 years, it becomes only 5 per cent of our collective experience. It is not that much. So, let's not accept it as the only possible reality. This is a recent invention, we settled down in a piece of land, we invented agriculture and we domesticated animals, and therefore we started to accumulate possessions which we were not able to carry when we were nomads. We invented inheritance and men wanted to know who were their biological children in order to leave their properties to them. And the only way of knowing if this child is yours, guys, is to control women's sexuality through marriage and monogamy. Patriarchal society is based upon the control of women's sexuality through marriage, placing women at the disposal of men sexually and reproductively.

5. Rejection of aggression and non consensual government

The head of each Mosuo village is a man chosen by the community. One of his main functions is to mediate between neighbours. To be aggressive, inside or outside the community, is considered shameful. Violence leads to rejection. Any overreaction, especially the use of strength, is not permitted. What in our world can be seen as courage or even worse, virility, they find it intolerable. So before disputes get complicated, they turn to the village chief to impose his authority, in order peacefully to mediate.

The Minangkabau people in west Sumatra believe that no sort of government is possible, as any decision to be taken must be consensual.

On the other hand, Mosuo people think that men have the ability to make big decisions. Women handle the everyday life and manage the money. But the big decisions, such as a trip, selling an animal, the construction of a house or something of the sort, is not a women's business. It is difficult to understand for our western minds but they do not consider the so-called 'big decisions' to be important.

6. Men need to wear a cap, or whoever wants to have a sexual encounter in the neighbourhood

On the outside door of the flower room there is a hook where night visitors can put their caps. This is a way of knowing when a room is already busy. I guess that if you want some extra visitors, your can always hide the caps. Or if you don not want to have a visitor, you can always use an old cap and hang it there for the night. Night encounters are arranged during the day anyway. In a queer

matriarchy transgendering would be as easy as taking a simple cap in order to relocate yourself socially and sexually.

7. Respect for individual freedom and social rejection to jealousy

It is forbidden to talk at home about love or romantic relationships in order to avoid conflicts and jealousy. Everybody is expected to be discreet. Due to the fact that everybody can have as many relationships as desired, it is requested to respect the intimacy of the other members of the community. To show jealousy openly is considered aggressive as you are intruding in the sacred autonomy of other person.

In my many years of pro sex feminist and queer struggle, I have always spoken up. In our patriarchal world, we are in need of bringing to light our non-normative desires. It has been challenging for me to think of a society where you fuck freely throughout your life thanks to being discreet. In a queer matriarchy we wouldn't need to speak up, we would only need to fuck.

8. Walking marriages, or even better, no marriage at all

The Mosuo people do have long life relationships. Western anthropologists call them 'walking marriages', though there is no marriage at all. The partners may see each other every night, but they will never live together and the offspring will be brought up in the mother´s home. The relationship can last as long as they want and when it ends, that's it. No house to split, no economical arrangements, no child custody nightmares, no children undergoing traumatic divorce processes.

Relationships between people who have a great age difference are not approved because they could be father and child.

9. The wellbeing of the offspring as the base of the society

Mosuo women take care of their babies for about one year after giving birth. Afterwards they return to work and grandparents and aunts take care of the child. The well being of the offspring is the base of the matriarchal society. Matriarchy is not the inverse of patriarchy, but a society that aims for the well being of all the children in the community.

This is the main aspect of Matriarchy and the only one that truly defines it. So in Queer Matriarchy this would also be the main goal of the whole community: the well being of children.

The way children are brought into the world and raised is fundamental for the sustenance of patriarchy. We give birth and raise our children in patriarchy, we are raised also following patriarchal rules. We are disconnected from our true emotions. It is the devastation, not only of our true loving nature, but also of our environment. We are destroying the planet as we are destroying our emotional tissue.

Look at the way women give birth: in extreme pain (whereas a few minority of women are able to have an orgasm in labour), children are systematically separated form the mother when being born (when it is know that the baby needs to be close to the mother in order to start breastfeeding), bottles substituting mother's milk, children being forced to spend long hours sitting quietly in schools. We deny children's sexuality and suppress its expression, teaching kids that it something to be ashamed of. Women's sexuality is devastated, because it is denied since infancy, girls are not allowed to explore it with games.

10. Ecology

The Lugu Lake symbolizes the Mother Goddess for Mosuo people. The mountain that goes high upon it, Ganmo, is the Love Goddess. All matriarchal societies have a deep respect for nature and the desire to live harmoniously in it without any violence, either against people or nature. Sexual repression, patriarchal capitalism and destruction of Earth comes all together. Queer matriarchy is ecofeminist.

1 When I talk about men and women in this guide, I mean both bio men/women and non-bio men/women, as well as people whose gender identity is flexible, trans and intersex.

María Llopis, 'Guide for a DIY Queer Matriarchy' (2013). (www.mariallopis.com)

Gilbert & George
In Conversation with Slava Mogutin//2013

Slava Mogutin [...] There's a strong performance element in your practice. Has it changed throughout the years?

George We never said performance. We believe these are pictures not by picture-makers but living sculptures.

Gilbert We are the centre of our art, so what we leave behind is all us, speaking to the viewer, you see always us, part of being here. It was not a performance but a kind of sculpture, a living sculpture, and for us this is a very good form to speak.

George If young people go to college and learn how to make pictures, they should learn how to make these ones. They're letters, visual letters ...

Gilbert We always say we make a kind of moralogue: good people, bad people, what should be changed, sexuality, unhappiness, drunkenness, religion, politics – all included, all what's inside human beings, not the abstract art that doesn't offend anybody.

George We believe that people who see our exhibitions become slightly different from those who don't see, unavoidably.

Gilbert When we started out, it was all about concept art – minimalist, no emotions, not too much colour, no sex ... It was totally alien to what we were doing, we did always the opposite: too much colour, too much sex, too much drunkenness. So it is very human art, more down to earth, like human beings are, not someone who is superior ...

George Thirty years ago when we did pictures with Christ or sex or nakedness, the art world thought we were fucking crazy. That's been sorted out. Today these are the biggest issues in the world.

Gilbert Every newspaper talks about gay marriage nonstop ...

Mogutin Which leads me to the next question. You recently got married – was it a symbolic act or something more pragmatic?

Gilbert Quite pragmatic.

George Practical. We didn't want to pretend straight marriage. If one of us fell under a bus tomorrow, it would be a disaster because by law the estate would go to some distant relative, we would lose control ... not that anyone is dying.

Gilbert We have a foundation, but by law everything would go back to my family, so that's why it was very important.

George When that happened a lot of journalists from France were very interested. A lady journalist asked, 'What do you think about gay marriage?' And I said, 'Why, are you thinking of marrying a poof?' (*laughing*)

Gilbert There was a very good piece in *The Independent* about that recently.

George *The Independent* would love to attack the bishops, but they're limited by law. But if somebody else attacks them, then it's OK. So we said two or three

things about gay marriage. Maybe more gay people would like to be married in the church just as a revenge on these bigots. But, rather, why would you want to get married in church by a bunch of paedophiles?

George We have a very good quote on that from Russia. There was a lady working at one of the commercial galleries and she asked one of the organizers if homosexuality was legal in Russia. And he said, 'Yes, in prison!'

Gilbert Our motto is: sex is sex, we don't want to know what it is. George always says when you ask for the meat in a restaurant you don't ask for a boy or girl meat! (*laughing*)

Mogutin Conservative business attire is a big part of your image and reputation. How did you invent that look and first start using it?

George Very simple. We are both war babies, we both came out of a wrecked land. I was bombed out of my city. Many people had a leg or arm missing, many buildings were damaged. And everybody knew one thing: life is going to get better. We felt that we were poor people and if it's an important occasion, if you try to get a job or if go to a wedding or funeral, you dress up nicely. You try to be polite to get on with life, and we settled for that. We didn't want to be artists their mothers would be ashamed of. It didn't work out exactly like that ...

Gilbert We went to all the galleries to sell ourselves in '68 and '69 and we were promoting ourselves with the idea of being a living sculpture. If you want something, we'll really do something – a performance or we'll write a story or arrange a dinner for you, all these ideas. And we only had one suit on and that's it.

George We realized that a lot of artists dressed in an eccentric way or had eccentric style to show that they were artists. We felt that alienated 90 per cent of the world's population. You can't get into a restaurant – why be deliberately weird? We wanted to be normal, normal weird ...

Gilbert ... so normal that we became strange!

George Outside of the art world we are completely normal ...

Gilbert ... but at the same time everyone recognizes us when we walk the streets of London, everybody knows us, because it's strange. It doesn't fit in.

George Normal and weird at the same time – that's the secret. To have both, that frees up the brain and you are different, you have space to be creative. Your life is enhanced, like when you're sexually attracted to someone everything is different – the sky looks different, food tastes good, your whole life is affected by being in love, the difference between a haircut and a shave or having a haircut and a shave by the barber you have a crush on. It's different, it's more alive! [...]

Mogutin Describe your collaboration. Who's responsible for what and if you ever argue when you make art?

George It's not a collaboration. Yes, we are two people, but one artist.

Gilbert Because we are always together when we work, so the images, the ideas come, we don't know exactly when they come and how they come, they invent themselves without us being involved.

Mogutin Would you call it the third mind?

Gilbert Yes, the spirit between us.

George You could say that. We try to make the pictures to make themselves as near as possible, so that if you could photograph what's inside you today and take it out and there it was. That's what we're trying to do. To lift the pictures out from inside ourselves and trust them, whether they are good or bad. That's it.

Gilbert We try to eliminate the artistic hand. Even from the beginning we always cut off the hand, we don't want that technique. We want this magic from the brain on the wall. [...]

Mogutin How do you edit your work?

George In '69 we wrote a manifesto called *The Laws of Sculptors*, and one of the laws was never discuss or criticize. We accept every picture that comes out from ourselves. Because if we say this is not a good one, maybe we'd be wrong. Why should we be an expert about our own art? If you start to discuss, the end of the world comes very fast!

Gilbert For us it's very simple: we have a vision, we keep that vision and it's so important. The little details have to be towards the big picture, they aren't important, as long as it fits into the big image.

George We fondly imagine that we have an idea what picture the world requires. So we are not doing the pictures that we like but we think roughly what the world needs and we do that.

Gilbert We were always at the edge ...

George We were always wrong. The right thing to do would be to leave art school and split up immediately, because you can't have two people as one artist, then run and buy canvases. We didn't do that. Do it wrong and you get it right!

Gilbert We did too much colour, too much alcohol and we were talking about sexuality, talking against religion. We did a big show called 'Was Jesus Heterosexual?' Then, in 1982–83, we did a series with all these boys and all the newspapers said 'prostitutes'!

George It would be very simple to get it right if we just did girls, but we did it wrong again! [...]

Gilbert & George and Slava Mogutin, extracts from 'The Business Satire of Gilbert & George', interview, *Whitewall Magazine* (Winter 2013). (https://whitewallmag.com)

Elmgreen & Dragset
Performative Constructions: In Conversation with Hans Ulrich Obrist//1998

Hans Ulrich Obrist [...] Douglas Gordon once told me that he thinks the 1990s are about the promiscuity of collaborations, and I wondered how your work is maybe multiple collaborations with other people ... how did it happen that you started to put the focus on the collaboration between the two of you? Could you tell me a bit about the beginning of your collaboration, the very first contacts between you?

Ingar Dragset It started with doing nothing together for one year but being boyfriends. I was at that time doing theatre performances, and Michael was doing his art on his own. And since we had so many other things in common, and were getting along so well on most matters, we thought that we would try to combine my theatre experience and Michael's visual art experience.

Obrist Which year was this?

Dragset This was in 1995. And actually I started helping Michael prepare a show in Stockholm. That was because I could knit, and he wanted to do these knitted pieces. Some abstract pets, that the art audience could hug and nurse and feel confident with ...

Michael Elmgreen ... But in Stockholm nobody feels relaxed at openings, so we had to show the audience how to feel confident and how to use these knitted pets, and then everybody thought it was a performance – so it became our first performance ... by coincidence.

Obrist What happened next? Was it followed immediately by a second performance? The first time I saw your works, it was on videos of performances you had done. It was before I saw exhibitions of yours. Was the collaboration more on a performative level in the beginning?

Dragset Yes.

Obrist And the objects came later ?

Elmgreen We were doing many performances in a Nordic context, and we were always curated to be the funny guys in the corner. If some curator wanted to have a more light activity in a very stiff exhibition, he or she called us and asked us to do something, you know, like ...

Obrist So it had to do with a marginalization within the exhibition context ?

Elmgreen Yes, and very much like becoming a stereotype of yourself ... being this kind of almost typecast artist 'Oh, we know what we can expect from these guys.' So it was fun suddenly to make installation works, because that was a big surprise for everybody: 'Oh, they can do art objects.'

Dragset You experience different kinds of marginalization as a gay couple and quite often in the Scandinavian art context, because there are very few gay artists. Sometimes you feel like you are in a show just as an alibi, or ...

Elmgreen ... or as an exotic element in something too predictable.

Obrist I once had a discussion about this issue – in terms of the object also – with

Felix Gonzalez-Torres, whom I interviewed four or five years ago. He always used this term 'infiltration'. Could you talk about two questions related – on the one hand about Gonzalez-Torres, if it's of importance for you as a sort of reference – and secondly this notion of infiltration in your own activities?

Dragset I think Michael should answer, since he met Felix Gonzalez-Torres.

Elmgreen Yes, in Copenhagen in 1993.

Obrist Was it when he did this billboard in Denmark?

Elmgreen Yes, I was in this billboard show with him at that time, but I met him just before. He was invited to a really horrible conference or seminar at the Danish Art Academy and was pretty bored. So we hung out and spoke a lot about how gay people suddenly discovered the use of Minimalism as the ultimate kind of infiltration into the history of high art. Minimalism was always the thing that was shown in large scale in the most important American art institutions ... after they had had a tiny little group show of young artists, just to give the institution some credibility, to give the impression of not being conservative. Then the museum director could feel safe having this huge Serra exhibition afterwards, that would cost, say, twenty times as much as the young art show. So, dealing with Minimalism was a kind of challenge for a gay person – also to break the stereotype image of gay people being, you know, interested in camp and being very feminine in their way of expressing themselves.

Obrist So it becomes a critique of this cliché, like Deleuze always said that art is a critique of cliché.

Elmgreen Indeed, like, you don't have one homogeneous homosexual culture ... as a gay person you're as different from other gay people as anybody else is different from anybody else.

Dragset That's also very much the reason why we stopped doing the kind of performances we were doing in the beginning. I mean the performances we did were very important on a personal level and also on the level of artistic development for us; but you felt you were becoming too much of a gay icon, and that's where our 'Powerless Structures' series started. That was also an emancipation from this stereotypical image of gay people or being a gay couple. So we opened up our own artistic expression to include all kinds of material – historical and cultural.

Elmgreen It has very much to do with not marginalizing oneself. A gay icon is as bad as any icon. It's all about not fulfilling the expectations. [...]

Obrist Could you tell me about your 'Powerless Structures'? I mean, you wrote this text, but there is less there about how you arrived at the title. I would be very interested in how you defined this series, and if you knew in the beginning exactly where it would lead ?

Elmgreen In Foucault's *History of Sexuality* he writes that no structure is able to suppress anybody – not the structure itself. It's only how you deal with the structures already being there, and all structures can be altered or mutated. That was very much an inspiration for us ... to discover that everything is just structures that could be something else ... the patterns could be different. It was just a question of imagination. And when it's just a question of imagination, the visual art field is such a good area in which to work with these things in a very concrete and simple way. So we started making these suggestions, that everything – from social and political structures to architectural and cultural structures – could be something more exciting and more open ... and to make these suggestions we just needed such small elements to start the change ...

Obrist So basically to change the rules of the game?

Elmgreen The game is a dynamic game. It's possible to combine the structures in billions of different ways in every field.

Obrist In the architecture, for example?

Dragset The architectural frame of a gallery or a gay bar, for instance. It could basically be anything, the social structures or whatsoever. And that's also how we have come to make pieces that involve both – the art institutional structures and some basic gay social structures – and tested what happens if you combine these. The piece that you've seen at Kunstraum der Universität Lüneburg deals with this. Here we made two sex cabins, that you normally find in the back room of gay bars or in porn cinemas and we placed them in the white cube context. When you enter the cabins you can see the rest of the exhibition through the peep holes. Like to see and to be seen.

Obrist Active and passive viewing ?

Elmgreen And very much about the voyeuristic situation. A trained art audience

may feel on a safe playground going into a gallery space, but they will be totally alienated going into the back room of a gay bar, whereas a lot of the gay crowd who are, er, consulting the back rooms will be totally alienated going into a gallery space. Combining these two kinds of architecture seemed interesting to us, because it points out that you don't have spaces such as queer spaces, and you don't have spaces such as art spaces. You only have spaces that are, say, occupied for a certain period with artistic behaviour, and you have places that are occupied by queer activity for a certain time. The borderlines are not that strict. They're much more fragile than we imagine them.

Michael Elmgreen, Ingar Dragset and Hans Ulrich Obrist, extract from 'Performative Constructions, an interview by Hans Ulrich Obrist' (1998), in *Powerless Structures: Works by Michael Elmgreen & Ingar Dragset* (Reykjavik: Reykjavik Art Museum/Galleri Ingólfsstraeti, 1988) 27–33, 38–9.

Kaucyila Brooke
In Conversation with Henrik Olesen//2005

Henrik Olesen As I see it, art that identifies with lesbian politics and representation is strongly under-represented. I see this as a conflict whenever I visit exhibitions. I have seen three exhibitions from you. I guess I can say that they all brought into focus questions about sexuality and history. I would be interested in knowing more about what you are doing and why lesbian representation is a thematic in the first place. [...]

[For your work *The Boy Mechanic*] the context is the history of lesbian bars in San Diego and is based on research. The project partly consists of photographs documenting buildings where, sometime in the past, a lesbian bar would have been located. The other part includes a video containing interviews which serve as oral histories: stories about cruising, sex in toilets, and the hierarchy in bars. A lot of the information in the video was very new to me. *The Boy Mechanic* is an unfolding and revealing of some of the diverse functions of one-sex spaces. Unlike [your earlier work] *Tit for Twat*, there is no reference to heterosexuality, and I see this as a reversed strategy.

Kaucyila Brooke *The Boy Mechanic* is a documentary with an interest in the study of vernacular architecture and social marginality that although below the surface is an active force of urban history. Rather than taking on the whole of history as

in *Tit for Twat*, *The Boy Mechanic* focuses to the details of place, history and individual experience. The particularity of the circumstances in San Diego makes a very different history than, say, New York City or Albuquerque, New Mexico. I plan to make an archive of past and present lesbian bar locations in cities across the United States, which is the reason why this is an ongoing project. History, of course, is always being constructed and any history is ongoing, so presumably once I make it to most of the cities on my map, I could return to San Diego and add to the archive that I started there. This year I will begin the Los Angeles/ Long Beach addition of *The Boy Mechanic* and show it in LA in May 2005.

The preservation of lesbian space is not a concern for urban planning, nor is it a topic often addressed at conferences or exhibitions about the transformation of urban space. And yet where are lesbians going to meet each other (without it being prearranged, through private social circles or the internet) if they do not have a place to go that has regular hours seven days a week? Although *The Boy Mechanic* is not a sociological project and I don't propose cause and effect, within the context of a wild and meandering history that is constructed through the disparate interviews with women from San Diego, there are several themes that emerge. Lesbian bar space is unstable and transitory and so are the memories of those who went to them in earlier times. Those who attend current bars also have differing ideas about the usage and significance of the spaces and how they maintain and attract their patrons. Even the function of the bars is not agreed upon by the patrons. Is it a place to drink? Find a lover? Dance with your lover? Organize identity groups or political groups? A place to go to find community? Is it a social organization, which should be responsive to all lesbian constituencies? Is it a safe place or one filled with danger? Is it public or private space? Lesbian space is a contested topic both from the inside and the outside, and the possibility of producing a documentary that answers questions does not exist. It interests me, because it is always being reconfigured and reimagined. At the same time, I want to make an archive so that there is a record of the locations. [...]

I really appreciate your remark about making work in reference to 'heterosexual' or pre-existing dominant narratives and seeing that *The Boy Mechanic* falls outside of that and makes its own subcultural context. In most of the work that I make that addresses lesbian visual culture and linguistics, I use one or the other approach. Some of the work is located wholly inside the subculture, without an attempt to translate for those not on the inside, and this is the case with projects oriented toward community issues. By not stating that these margins exist in relation to a dominant space, I hope to give a more autonomous subjectivity to the discourse produced by the parameters of the project. It exists because it exists. In the work that addresses pre-existing

dominant narrative or structure, I am looking at the interrelatedness of things both within and without a subcultural stance. [...]

Olesen I have tried to drag out certain aspects of your work, even though a lot of your projects deal with different issues. However, as I began, I would like to question why lesbian representation is a thematic in the first place, and what this does. Do you think that by highlighting the position of sexual identity in your projects I am extending or stigmatizing your work?

Brooke In her essay 'The Point of View: Universal or Particular?' the French writer Monique Wittig wrote: 'Writing a text which has homosexuality among its themes is a gamble. It is taking the risk that at every turn the formal element which is the theme will overdetermine the meaning, monopolize the whole meaning.'

In terms of your question, I believe that it extends the scope and resonance of the work but I think that stigmatization is often the result. But this has to do with reception and the context of a lesbophobic society. There are many issues in my work that have nothing and everything to do with the construction of sexual identity. Some of my projects that we are not discussing here in fact do not bring sexuality directly into the work. But I believe that they are informed by the work that does address lesbian cultural codes and that the works can be cross-referenced. They are all engaged in the discourse of difference and the margin and the moveable centre and its endless readdress.

In some respects I have nothing to say about lesbian sexuality except that it is there. As Terry Castle points out in *The Apparitional Lesbian*, lesbians are often ghosted from the text, and part of my project is to contribute to their inclusion. I do not want to watch my body disappear as I am writing this text.

Kaucyila Brooke and Henrik Olesen, extracts from interview, in *The Sky is Thin as Paper Here. Vol. 0* (Cologne: Galerie Daniel Buchholz, 2005) n.p.

Renate Lorenz
Drag – Radical, Transtemporal, Abstract//2012

How can artworks pick out bodies, gender and sexuality as their topics without providing a body for identification, disidentification or counter-identification? How can a body be 'there' if distance from the body is simultaneously suggested? How can the boundaries of what seems conceivable in terms of change – for instance with respect to knowledge about bodies and possible bodily practices – be extended?

I am bringing in the term 'drag' here to try to get at what queer-artistic works (at least the ones discussed here) produce. In the context of a queer art theory, drag may refer to the productive connections of natural and artificial, animate and inanimate, to clothes, radios, hair, legs, all that which tends more to produce connections to others and other things than to represent them. What becomes visible in this drag is not people, individuals, subjects or identities, but rather assemblages; indeed those that do not work at any 'doing gender/sexuality/race', but instead at an 'undoing'. If I, as Judith Butler has written [in *Undoing Gender*, 2004], am always constituted through norms that I myself have not produced, then drag is a way to understand how this constitution occurs, and to reconstruct it on one's own body. But at the same time, drag is a way to organize a set of effective, laborious, partially friendly and partially aggressive methods to produce distance to these norms, for instance to the two-gender system, to being-white, to being-able, and to heteronormativity. In so doing, drag proposes images in which the future can be lived.

Drag, then, is fabricated by sets of bodily characteristics and actions. While it may indeed take on and thematize norms, it is nonetheless not restricted by them. The combination of fiction and documentary, of lies and claims, of reenactments and inventive experiments, and of conspicuously different bodily characteristics and artistic parts produces bodies that do not match up any dichotomies between 'true' or 'false' and 'normal' and 'other'. I would like to understand drag as an artistic work that, as Katrin Sieg writes [in *Ethnic Drag*, 2002], 'denounces that which dominant ideology presents as natural, normal and inescapable, without always offering another truth'. The work of taking up distance is thus also a kind of sexual labour of desubjectification – a process that I see as central to practices of denormalization, and thus to queer politics.

The elements of drag also make it possible to go back into the history of a production of knowledge about bodies and their emotions, affects and desires – to pursue traces of history and to work out alternatives at the same time – precisely

because drag means retracing processes of construction on one's own body. Costumes, wigs, make-up, props, posed photographs and film scenes, stagings and (possibly) fraudulent narrations connected to 'appearances' take up expectations, evidence, stereotypes and violent histories without facilitating their repetition.

The relations produced also encompass those of the viewers. In the film *N.O.Body* [Pauline Boudry and Renate Lorenz, 2008], there is a brief moment in which the performer looks at the camera, making it clear that the body that she presents in the film – and that is similar to the one in the historical photograph shown in the film – is part of a communication. The connection with the material from the past occurs in order to produce and sustain another connection: that with the viewers as participants in the artistic process. The cinematic depiction does not provide access to the body of another (of the one depicted by the photograph or of the performer). Instead, an exchange takes place – a negotiation about the depiction, about seeing and 'reading' bodies (including the body of the viewer). The name 'drag' is meant to address the fact that the photographs, films and installations being discussed here do not represent 'deviant bodies', but instead they show or refer to bodies that are always 'other' (not 'other than normal' but 'beyond') – in 'another time' and 'elsewhere.' Drag, then, is a set of queer-artistic methods and practices and, at the same time, a mode of making public and of negotiation.

In this sense, I draw not only on performance but also on various artistic formats, even if the term drag originates in the context of (subcultural) performance. I am concerned here with a (queer) theory of (queer) contemporary art. Drag, nevertheless, facilitates the production of a particular reference to the practices of shows, of freak shows, of male and female impersonators, of cakewalks, of epileptic dances, as well as crossdressing (to name only a few formats that drive and have driven gender, sexual and anti-racist activism and which have tested out and reproduced practices of estrangement and practices of distantiation from norms and normality).

Analytically, I distinguish three modes of drag in this book, modes that do not mutually exclude one another, and which can appear together. The first is 'radical drag', a term that has been introduced in recent years to characterize drag appearances that do more or do something different than staging a transformation from 'man' to 'woman' or 'woman' to 'man'; that, for instance, work with contradictory gender markers or bring elements into embodiment that disrupt any interpretation within the two-gender system. I use this term for certain visualizations of bodies that may indeed thematize the dichotomies of man/woman or able/non-able, as well as other categorizations, but at the same time do not endorse these dichotomies and instead propose corporal images that cannot be made addressable, accessible or intelligible within these criteria.

'Transtemporal drag', the second mode, designates embodiments with a focus on chronopolitics, which represent an intervention in existing concepts of time and establish temporalities that counter, interrupt or shift an advanced economic or scientific development or a heteronormative course of life. Finally, I use the term 'abstract drag' for visualizations of bodies that show no human body at all and which instead use objects, situations or traces to refer to bodies.

Renate Lorenz, 'Drag – Radical, Transtemporal, Abstract' (section of introduction), *Queer Art: A Freak Theory*, trans. Daniel Hendrickson (New Brunswick: Transaction, 2012) 20–23.

AA Bronson
Documenta Sex//2003

This exhibition is dedicated to the memory of documenta 6.

Documenta Sex is devoted entirely to the subject of sex in its myriad manifestations and interpretations: from the psychosexual acrobatics of the Jungian and Freudian, to the Beuysian economy of commercial and uncommercial sex, to child abuse, to sexual memoirs, to plain old pornography.

Documenta Sex will use all aspects of the sexual infrastructure of the urban environment: not only the galleries themselves that are always the centrepiece of Documenta, but also the X-rated cinemas, sex shops, bordellos and habitual routes of streetwalkers, as well as cruising places, public toilets, saunas, massage parlors, and the public parks themselves, not only in Kassel, but wherever artists are found.

Prostitution, of course, has always been at the heart of the art world, and the relationship between the artist and the collector should not be overlooked here. But the particular psychology of the collector, who has displaced his or her love objects into the form of multiple artworks – that too should be examined. And the psychology of the artist, who must take action in this world to actualize a relation to the world, whose every gesture is a sort of sexual battle stance, must especially be considered.

It is the sex industry that always opens new forms of social expression: the Internet, for example, was pioneered by sex sites, and continues to be dominated by them. The art industry follows close behind, and legitimizes that which the sex industry has already accomplished. So the forms of new art bear an intrinsic relation to the world of sex.

I imagine a Documenta divided, quite conventionally, into two sections: the

galleries, which are structured according to certain basic themes; and the public installations, performances, media presentations, and so on, which participate in the sexual economy of cities.

I present here some preliminary notes toward an internal organization of the overall exhibition.

A. In the Galleries (The Idea of Sex)

1 Art industry as sex industry: the artist as prostitute/the collector as john
2 Sexual abuse: the artist as abused child
3 Free sex: the artist as free spirit
4 The legitimization of the pornographic image: the artist as added value
5 Sampling sex: the artist as sexual DJ
6 Voyeurism as artwork and the objectification of the other (especially so-called documentary photography)
7 Androgeny, gender-bending, and cross-dressing: the artist as hermaphrodite
8 The sexualization of danger: the artist as barebacker
9 Replacing the dick with the cunt: the artist as radical feminist

B. In the City (The Experience of Sex)

Note: Although many of the following might be presented in Kassel, the majority are intended to be carried out in the hometowns of the artists themselves, thus decentralizing Documenta Sex.

1 Guerilla sex: peeping toms, flashers, dirty old men and women: artists' interventions
2 X-rated cinemas, sex shops, sex magazines, video cabins, and live sex shows: presentation of media works of an 'erotic' nature (either actual or metaphorical)
3 Street hookers, escorts, and erotic masseurs: artists are invited to produce public works/actions in collaborations with sex workers
4 Saunas and dark rooms: sexual interventions, actions without words
5 Cruising places: traditional promenades: performance works commissioned for public locales where seeing and being seen are implicit in the existing culture
6 Public parks: by night and by day, secret spots and public spots: temporary installations make the invisible visible, the subliminal liminal
7 Public toilets, underground parking lots: site-specific interventions
8 Advertising media: billboards, electronic signs, posters, etc: artists are commissioned to produce works on the theme of sex for advertising technologies and venues

9 Television, radio (after midnight): commissioned and existing video and audio works by artists
10 Exhibitionism: on the streets: artists are invited to perform unscheduled public performances

C. In the Catalogue / On the Website

1 The catalogue should document all of this, but also act as pornography itself. The success of the catalogue should be judged by the number of involuntary hard-ons and wet cunts, the volume of precum, and the proportion of scrambled brains produced by exposure to the publication.

Portions of the catalogue could be commissioned works by artists in the form of sex publications, calendars, and so on, which could also be distributed in sex shops and select art bookshops worldwide.

2. The website should be fully interactive and act as a venue within which the public can participate in the sexual economy of the whole project.

Perhaps a number of artists could be asked to produce projects that would realize this goal. Or artists could be invited to produce collaborations with existing sex sites that act as a sort of colonization of the Web sex world.

In closing

Documenta Sex is unique in its ability to participate parasitically in the larger social and financial economy, through the distribution systems and formats of both the sex industry and the infrastructure of unregulated sex.

Documenta Sex provides artists with access to a vast network of worldwide audiences, in addition to the art world itself. In this sense it is implicitly different from recent Documentas, which have used art and artists as illustrations or infill, rather than providing the artist with the tools and support to infiltrate the 'real world'.

Documenta Sex concerns itself with the energies that are the source of life and of art. Sex has become a central concern to artists and theorists over the last fifty years – but it has yet to be publicly acknowledged, addressed or studied in an institutional setting or on a comprehensive scale.

Documenta Sex should be, above all else, sexy.

AA Bronson, 'Documenta Sex', *e–flux.com projects*, 2003. (www.e-flux.com)

Giuseppe Campuzano
Is a Bicentennial Possible without Sex[1]//2010

Rewinding

And what if an atavistic body, dressed up as another, were a simile for the mobilization and modernization of culture? What if this process of (being defined by) opposition and (being assimilated as) an accessory persisted when we dress ourselves as and have intercourse with others? Yes, like transvestites. The body as political origin, memory and present, as another geography for the nation.

Through this ritual other peoples' and one's own customs would become others, through this exchange body. Conservative, pro-independence, egalitarian, libertarian ideals or the supposed clear-cut lines of the nationalist-imperialist pairing, would overlap in the exchange, like scars of memory with our skins.

The critical myth of the Inkarri – the symbolic reconstruction of the severed body of the Inca – suggests an American *Regenerationism*, but in what way? Its dimensions of alternation and latency as displacements of modern-day symmetric asymmetries (woman-man, function-art, America-Europe and of course, independent country-colony) or change not from an origin towards an end but in itself and constant. The paradox. Like Heraclitus' river or the transvestite body that persist only because they change. The non-essentialist essentiality of these lands and their arts.

Post-bicentennial

They propose switching around private and public spaces: sex in the street, political awareness. A transformation of our everyday furniture that depends on the dismantling by those of us who design it, of the bodies that consume it. A transformation that is not necessarily surgical but rather hermeneutical, of our make-up and clothing, our self-referential dowry.

A sex that has to give us back our histories-herstories-stories. Let us rewind our postcolonial, postmodern, post-identity, post-porn selves, in order to debate, in context and consensus, with sex.

The transvestite nation as a possibility

In the south that is our north, in Joaquín Torres García's Inverted *Map of South America*, a pre-Hispanic scene is reproduced. A figure with male and female characteristics, which has sex with another with supernatural properties, attended by a group of winged beings who prepare them and inject them with a hallucinogenic substance. In the meantime, others stand in wait. This game of

language, Spanish, only allows us to refer to them in terms of opposition: woman-man or androgynous and supernatural, but the individuals described always refer to the complement and context of an agglutinative allegory like their languages and their hermaphrodite pantheon. Defining gender and awareness as alteration is to explain the cultural process in which change is the origin, means and end that is brought about (a change in the weather) or assimilated (the other culture).

This *dispositif* (in the Foucault sense but in which sex is articulated not as control but as possibility) constitutes the Inca two-party system in which its ritual-unknown and martial-specific powers opposed and complemented one another, such as in the figures of Manku Qhapaq – shaman, man-woman and magical-religious leader, according to Guamán Poma, Garcilaso de la Vega and María Rostworowski respectively – and Mama Guaco – woman-man and warrior leader – but a subsequent articulation of sex as control distorts Manku Qhapaq as military, omits Mama Guaco and emphasises the woman-woman Mama Ocllo, naturalizing the symmetry of certain roles.

However, the confluence of the indigenous mechanism of propitiation-assimilation and the Spanish mechanism of control through evangelization are articulated in the *mestizo* ritual space in which the indigenous ritual androgyne cross dresses (transvestism as a Sarduyan simulation, as an alternative to the continuity of his metamorphoses) as a Catholic priest. And it is in this space of control in which new shifts proliferate, in which the gods of Catholicism are infected with indigenous meanings to grow up as *mestizos*, in which the mask conceals in order to show not only a dissimilar gender but the profusion of ethnic *mestizajes* that resulted from colonial forced migrations and which soon transcended that same ritual space.

Like the Muslim dress and veil which arrived from an occupying and occupied Spain with those women who were allowed to take part in this American enterprise: Moorish women. Clothing that another territory would revive and choose as social and political space for women, men and their diversity of non-hegemonic colours. *Mestizo* dress as an indigenous mask, as an alternative horizontal space to the prevailing vertical context.

But what happens with transvestite theatricality during the founding of *La Republica Ilustrada*? How are *mestizo* transvestisms articulated amid a renaissance of teratological hermaphroditism, of westernizing raids as republican ideals?

Are their consequences the unpunished murders of transvestites, madwomen and queers during two-hundred years of democracy? The incongruity of successive rebellions that obliterate sexual otherness thus proving themselves to be failed revolutions. Sex work denounced as unethical within a market morality. Identity as an empty promise of citizenship, as Judith Butler already pointed out.

A transvestite reformulation is its contemporary response. The post-industrial spectacle (as *mestizo* dress (or indigenous mask) for the traffic of meanings in the midst of the playful dictatorship. The transvestite gesture made an exemption for political satire. Artifice as profession: dance, make-up, sex.

1 [In 2010, countries across Latin America began to organize bicentennial celebrations marking two centuries since the beginnings of national independence movements.]

Giuseppe Campuzano, 'Is a Bicentennial Possible without Sex?' (2010), in Giuseppe Campuzano. *Saturday Night Thriller y Otros Escritos 1998–2013*, ed. Miguel A. Lopez (Lima: Estruendomudo, 2013) 192–5. Translated by Gilla Evans, 2015.

Barbara DeGenevieve
Ssspread.com: The Hot Bods of Queer Porn//2005

I was the content provider for Ssspread.com – *a prime porn site for hot femmes, studly butches, and lots of gender-fuck* – which I started with a friend in 2001. What you're seeing is a brief twenty-minute compilation of seven out of 151 videos I shot over the three years the site was in operation. This is a test. I know how hard it is to think and watch porn at the same time, so pay attention!

Looking back after three years of making porn for Ssspread, what I found more fascinating than anything else was how little difference there was between straight and queer porn, except for one thing: the bodies. The bodies of queer porn are insubordinate, disobedient, unruly, only interested in having people perform the kinds of sex acts they were comfortable with, and this strategy actually led to a very interesting variety of scenes. 'Actors' were paid $75 per person per shoot. This is obviously very little, but in the three years we operated, we didn't even earn back our initial investment, so I appreciated that everyone was willing to do this for so little. The fact that so many were interested in this project because they felt it was important was what kept me going for three years (from January 2001 through to Valentine's day 2004), and this was the reason it was a difficult decision to finally shut it down.

I witnessed a 'community' of people who were proud of their bodies and weren't afraid to put them on display for others to recognize and enjoy. Having had major body issues most of my life, I was fascinated by the total lack of discomfort or self-consciousness. The FTMs, particularly those who were only

hormonally altered with no upper body surgery were mesmerizing. And they were letting me look, videotape, pull stills from the video, and then let others look. Queer porn is a place where anything goes, where everything is possible, where each body is objectified and fetishized because it wants to be.

Queer bodies create a world of difference in the way they enact everything from vanilla sex to masculinity, to blood sports, to violence. Queer porn is democracy at its best.

Beyond the bodies of its subjects and the desire for those bodies by its viewers, there are actually many more similarities than I would have imagined between queer and straight porn. (Perhaps the difference in bodies is so huge as to make the similarities seem irrelevant.) It is the complexity of the cultural narrative in the performance of sex in any kind of pornography that I find so compelling. Unless the scene I was shooting was simply two women taking their clothes off and having 'lesbian' sex, there was an overwhelmingly hetero (male/female) and gay (male/male) narrative embedded in the scenes. It wasn't until I started to deconstruct what I was seeing that I realized how prevalent it was.

In a sort of feminist sense, queer porn is politically correct for queers because queer bodies are in it having queer sex. But the scenarios that these queer bodies engage in are those that feminists inveighed against for at least twenty-five years. When did it become OK for two women to have multiple-holed penetrative sex? to fetishize the penis? to strap on a dildo and have a female partner engage in fellatio? To hypersexualize femmes and call it queer? Or to have a male-born person identifying as a pre-op female transsexual, strap on a dildo and fuck a butch dyke identifying as a trannie-boy in his pussie. Or to have a trannie boy who was a butch dyke get fucked in the ass by a gay man. Of course this isn't the full range of gender variations and combinations. I'm certainly not complaining, but having been a feminist since the mid 1970s, an anti-porn feminist I might add until 1988, I'm absolutely astonished (and parenthetically thrilled) at the way things have entirely reversed direction.

This seems so right to me – the gender fluidity that embraces every historical aspect of every kind of sexual act between two or more people despite their gender or sexual orientation.

I still have to ask – are we all hard-wired, do we lack imagination, or are the cultural narratives so powerful that we can't produce any other kind of narrative desires beyond the ones so present in the culture at large? Theoretically the queer body expands gender and destabilizes hetero/homo binaries, and certainly the rigidity of hegemonic gender roles has been addressed since the advent of second-wave feminism. But what constitutes 'queer or queered' gender roles needs just as much scrutiny.

There are so many questions about gender and queer porn floating around in

my head, and I have no clear organizing principle or theoretical framework from which to produce a coherent fifteen minute 'paper'. So I decided I'd try to answer a few of the questions for myself in no particular order, with no desire to be comprehensive, with no claim to expertise.

IS THERE A DIFFERENCE BETWEEN QUEER PORN AND STRAIGHT PORN? IF THE ANSWER IS YES, WHAT IS THAT DIFFERENCE? The bodies are the biggest difference. Queer bodies, altered or not by surgery, hormones or attitude, are different from heterosexually identified bodies. They are no more constructed as identities than are the majority of unchallenged male and female, masculine and feminine bodies of the mainstream. But female masculinity, power relationships and transsexuality trouble the reading of these bodies in a way that destabilizes all gendered bodies.

And yet, content-wise, there's really not much narrative difference. However, I'd say the major difference in regard to content is intention – queer porn is definitely coded as 'play', so there's no question as to whether it's 'real', unlike violent straight/heterosexual porn that often leaves the viewer either believing or seriously wondering whether what they saw was actually real: like rape scenarios and other forms of violence. Queer porn is unmistakably 'a scene', clearly play, even when it mimics hetero-normative gender relationships.

ARE YOU SAYING YOU ACTUALLY BELIEVE PHOTOGRAPHS AND VIDEOS ARE REAL? You can assume all photo and video is constructed as a fiction controlled by the person holding the camera and the person who is editing, if editing is even involved. But with certain kinds of straight porn it's sometimes hard to believe it isn't 'real', even if you know it has to have been staged, because there is an attempt to show (or to realistically simulate) actual violence. The real world analogue is just too close to elicit a response of anything but horror – 'Am I actually seeing someone being raped?' If it is an actual rape, as many sites proclaim (which is the point of it and the locus of the turn-on for the audience), then it's a criminal act and doesn't even fit my definition of pornography. (Sexually explicit imagery in which the consensual acts being depicted are intended for the sexual arousal and masturbatory entertainment of the viewer. This definition excludes illegal acts such as images or videos that 'document' children being sexualized or molested, criminal rape and violent abuse, murder (snuff), etc., all being non-consensual acts, but generally still included within the category of pornography. I consider these to be prosecutable crimes, and therefore not technically pornography.)

Even when queer porn sets out to simulate violent scenes, even when the acts themselves are very similar to what might happen in straight porn, it is still unmistakably 'a scene' and thus very clearly fetishistic.

ISN'T THAT A DOUBLE STANDARD? HYPOTHETICALLY, WHAT IF THE

STRAIGHT PORN IS NO MORE 'REAL' THAN THE QUEER STUFF. IF IT'S ALL BEING ACTED, WOULD YOU STILL FEEL THERE IS A DIFFERENCE? Pretty much. I'm not ready to give porn carte blanche across the board. There's acceptable and unacceptable porn. No matter how tolerant I've become of most genres of porn, including heterosexual porn aimed pretty exclusively at men, I still have to draw a line at violence that's intended to look real as opposed to violence that's obviously intended as fantasy both for the perpetrator and the 'victim', the dominant and the submissive, the one with power and the one without. Violent heterosexual porn is replicating something that isn't a fantasy, something that isn't consensual, something that validates criminal violence, particularly against women. There is a distinction between the two genres in regard to violence: subtle as it may be visually, heterosexual porn is based in misogyny, queer porn in role and power play.

SO THE QUESTION BECOMES WHY WOULD QUEER PORN WANT TO ENGAGE IN VIOLENT SCENARIOS SUCH AS RAPE, CUTTING, OR ANY INFLICTION OF PAIN? Because the fantasy of being at the mercy of a force beyond your control, of completely relinquishing your own control, to be made to do something you might not otherwise do, and on the flip side of it, to make someone totally submissive to you, is hot. I think a lot of women have rape fantasies. We grow up with the fear and the fascination of it. Queers aren't immune to the influence of the dominant culture. Do they actually want to be raped in the criminal sense? No. But when the fantasy is controlled and all parties have consented to their roles, it's really hot.

Porn isn't politically correct, whether it's hetero, homo or queer. We all have our fantasies, our fetishes, our deep dark little secrets, our unspeakable turn-ons, and they are all supposed to be kept out of sight. That's what complicates this analysis. Queers aren't supposed to have the same fantasies as hets and if they do, those fantasies are certainly not perceived to have the same origins. Oddly enough, on Sssprеad, the closer the scene came to hetero-normative role-play, the hotter the viewers thought it was. But I suspect queer porn is assumed to be on higher moral ground by liberal segments of academia simply because it's queer and not heterosexual.

OK, SO LET'S STEP TO THE HIGHER MORAL GROUND THEN. WHAT IS IT ABOUT QUEER PORN THAT ELEVATES IT TO A PROTECTED, INTELLECTUAL SPHERE? Queer porn is a documentation of an important aspect of queer lives – it gives visibility to queer bodies and their sexual practices, giving representation to a diverse if relatively small 'community' that has very little public presence, and even less representation of its sexualities. Academically, queer porn is a magnifying glass in regard to the complexities of gender, and I believe it serves a very different purpose than the study of other genres within the greater context of pornography

as a historical and cultural phenomenon. Power dynamics are subverted, inverted and perverted in queer porn. The very essence of who we think we are as gendered beings is called into question and unmercifully interrogated.

A quote from an essay by Judith Shapiro in *Body Guards: The Cultural Politics of Gender Ambiguity* (1991):

> The way in which transsexuals go about establishing their gender in social interactions reminds us that the basis on which we are assigned a gender in the first place (that is, anatomical sex) is not what creates the reality of gender in ongoing social life ... Transsexualism makes explicit for us the usually tacit processes of gender attribution ... the transsexual reveals the extent to which the normally sexed person is a 'contingent practical accomplishment'. In other words, they make us realize that we are all passing. (257)

I credit the gender-queer and transgendered actors and members of Ssspread with an education I couldn't possibly have acquired otherwise. Making queer fantasy visible is a challenge to dominant ideas about the fixity of gender, and because of that, it is a political gesture not without consequences, particularly in this ultra conservative climate.

ISN'T THAT ASSIGNING A LITTLE TOO MUCH CREDIBILITY TO IMAGES OF PEOPLE FUCKING MADE SPECIFICALLY TO GET PEOPLE OFF? I don't know.

I'll end with one last statement rather than another question I can't answer. We can forever analyse porn as having a social significance for the understanding of power, sex and gender, and as being a political and politicized cultural form of production. But what it will always come down to, whether it's gay, straight, dyke, queer or whatever, is that it is produced as a tool for sexual stimulation, primarily masturbation. Porn is made to get people off. In order to do this, bodies must not only be highly sexualized, but objectified, fetishized, exotified and made to accommodate very particular individual kinks. Political correctness has become an intellectual prison within which an extremely limited dialogue can take place, and in fact where monologues and diatribes are usually the discursive practice. Embracing the need to objectify and be objectified, to fetishize and be fetishized, to play the willing victim as well as the victimizer, opens up a mine field that will be difficult to traverse, but it is a more intellectually provocative and honest terrain from which to understand who we are as complex sexual beings. [...]

Barbara DeGenevieve, 'ssspread.com: The Hot Bods of Queer Porn' (2005), in Katrien Jacobs, Marije Janssen and Matteo Pasquinelli, eds, *C'lick Me: A Netporn Studies Reader* (Amsterdam: Institute of Network Cultures, 2007) 233–7.

A.K. Burns and A.L. Steiner
Community Action Center: In Conversation with Lauren Cornell//2011

A radical and pleasurable new instalment in the history of porn, Community Action Center *is a feminist socio-sexual video that centres on the erotics of a queer community where, in the filmmakers' words, 'the personal is not only political but sexual'. It pictures a vibrant community composed of artists, musicians, writers, dancers and more, who together present myriad complex gender and sex definitions.* [...]

Lauren Cornell Let's talk about how *Community Action Center* began. You said it was inspired by porn-romance-liberation films.

A.K. Burns We were watching a lot of 1970s gay male porn: James Bidgood's *Pink Narcissus*, Fred Halstead's *Sex Tool*, *Sex Garage* and *LA Plays Itself* and Joe Gages' trilogy [*Kansas City Trucking Co*; *LA Tool & Die*; *El Paso Wrecking Corp.*].

A.L. Steiner The first challenge was to make porn that we liked; we wanted to make something that was pleasurable, sexual, artistic and something you would watch as a cinematic experience, not just to get off.

Burns We wanted to create something that didn't just focus on the act of having sex and instead brought in the level of beauty these older films had, where desire, lust and sexuality added up to a holistic image. Another thing we started noticing [in these early films] was that there was this reference to creative sexuality which is indicative of queer sexuality: sex that is not dictated by a set of penetrative acts, and that the entirety of the body is a sex organ, not just the patches of genitalia and holes.

Steiner We were also inspired by our community: the performers, artists and activists in our lives. Then we started thinking about why we didn't look at porn made in our so-called extended lesbian community. What is lesbian porn? What do we look at separately in our lives and what do we want to look at together? There was a narrative structure to most of the stuff we were interested in but it was mostly made by men and so that's when we came up with idea of porn romance liberation. A.K. started talking about the very specific idea of creative autonomy during gay liberation versus the politics of second-wave feminism. That moment was a different experience for biological men and biological women,

and also trans people who were sort of caught in the middle and less visible.

Cornell So during that era there was a sort of freedom afforded to gay men because they were basically ignored by normative culture, whereas women are dealing with many more exploitative, fetishizing and objectifying representations?

Burns There's a real privilege in being able to articulate your sexuality and sexual presence without feeling like it's being usurped by someone else ...

Steiner Or being performed for someone else ...

Burns ... for a gaze you're not interested in attracting. The prevalent sexual imagery and vocabulary tends to be created and consumed through a phallocentric vacuum. Gay men had a default position of creative sexual autonomy; in a way it's a perverse privilege because it's a way of being completely rejected by heterosexist and heteronormative culture. So they could make whatever they wanted. The early works of Barbara Hammer, Maya Deren, Carolee Schneemann, Yoko Ono, Valie Export, Cosey Fanni Tutti – they're all artists who contributed to this history, but there's a predominance of gay and straight male imagery, especially in commercial and art house porn.

Cornell A.L., your photography exists in that space of liberation, of what lies outside of that male exploitative vocabulary. But how does *C.A.C.* connect to your work, A.K.?

Steiner A.K. made most of the props.

Burns I have a lot of interest in tropes and language around objects and unpacking things in a perverse way. Like why are things shaped the way they are, continually inserted into our vaginal consumerist reality? There's a whole other unspoken level of fetish and its relation to ordinary objects that I'm interested in. A.L. operates from a place of capturing what exists in the world. She's very much a documentarian, whereas I'm more interested in constructing things. This exists in *C.A.C.* in the way that reality and fantasy mesh and inform each other.

Cornell So how did you two initiate the scenes in *C.A.C.* as a team?

Steiner The way we saw ourselves as directors was extremely collaborative, so we wanted things to unfold organically, but they were also based on what the person brought to the film. We didn't storyboard. The most challenging example

of that would probably be the group scene. In our minds, we were thinking 'every porn has a group sex scene', so we developed it as an art orgy.

Cornell How did that scene evolve?

Burns We brought tons of stuff to one of the participant's art studio: paint and clay, canvas, art history books, chocolate, doughnuts, markers, watermelons, beer, tape. A lot was inspired by 'Baby Sew Hoy', who was pregnant. Having the pregnancy in that space inspired people to be either a baby or pregnant. A lot of things were made super spontaneously. For example, we had beer there and someone thought about shot-gunning, so that turned into giving head with an exploding beer can. Or the clay that became the birthing vagina.

Cornell It feels like everything in *C.A.C.*, be it objects or actors, is radiating sexuality. Everyone in this community is really hot. I certainly have had fantasies about several of the stars before seeing this film and it seems like that desire is felt between everyone and everything involved. But did that pose new kinds of challenges? Since your stars were not actors, but rather friends, ex-lovers and fellow artists, how did you direct scenes in which people are amateur and also so vulnerable, being naked and taking risks for the camera?

Burns That's a really good question. For example, for the honey scene with Pony we went to a secluded field. There'd be moments where we'd ask her to do something again, like walk across the field, eat the honey, let it drip, hold the crystal and the labrys in the sunlight, etc. There'd be small directorial interventions, but the whole thing with masturbating, it just happened. We never told Pony to do that. We were just working on this honey idea, utilizing erotics and actions, and then it went there. It was so intense.

Cornell I wonder what Pony was thinking about? It seems that the collaboration was pretty hot.

Steiner Pony and I always had a flirtation and I had photographed her before. We all have flirtations in our community because we talk about sex openly and crush out on each other.

Cornell You said it was really powerful that it happened spontaneously. Pony is the only one who is alone and it feels like her scene is a symbol for all the collective sexual appreciation that's happening.

Burns These people are terrifically inspiring.

Cornell I heard that one thing that really shocked people when it screened was the threading scene.

Burns Yes, not a lot of people are familiar with threading as a sexual act. We're not saying that all queers do this. For us it is a fetish and it was an interesting part of what Pony and Stargëizer wanted to explore.They were familiar with that as a practice and explored it as a performative experimentation in the video. It became sculptural.

Steiner One of Annie Sprinkle's more famous declarations was that if you don't like the porn you're seeing, make your own. One of the ensuing anonymous comments about our video in an art gossip column was, 'I'm okay with fisting, but this [threading] was a bit much ...' It's pushing someone's limits, when they say 'I'm really open, but you've gone a little bit over the line.' Queer liberation functions within that frame of dialogue. Who dictates your rights, what are your limitations? Who dictates your tastes and desires and what do they look like? We're saying, these are representations that come from our community, it's not a representation of all queer people. We made *C.A.C.* for purely personal reasons and for pleasure. We did it for our friends and for us. Lorraine O'Grady distinguished between the enabling audience versus the consuming audience, where the enabling audience are the people you make things for, who support you, who give you criticism. But the consuming audience is everyone else. They may love it, they may hate it. Sometimes artists make work for both audiences and sometimes for one.

Cornell I think that enabling audience is pretty helpful to have as an artist. You need that, don't you?

Steiner I thrive off that.

Burns I can't imagine functioning without it. This was made by, for and because of the enabling audience.

Cornell Can you describe your representational choices? Did you cast or was it just from your community?

Burns It was for the most part just looking at both our close-knit and extended community for the performers and the musical selections and compositions.

Steiner We asked other people to be in it who ended up not wanting to do it. Essentially the representation reflects our community, and the willing and able.

Cornell The film took place in different locations, New York and LA. Can you describe the scene with the woman in the bathrobe running through the woods?

Steiner That's Crystal Jardin.

Cornell Your ex, right, A.K.?

Steiner Yeah, there is a bit of 'shared women' in this. And that's something important to bring into this interview: the fact that we can have successful, loving, creative relationships with our exes and ask them to work with us.

Cornell I think that's an important point, that your whole lives are very much in it.

Steiner And we wanted ourselves to be in it, clearly. We're not there by accident.

Burns We'd always talked about being in it, but both of our scenes were filmed towards the end.

Cornell The scene with Jacques Strap and Pansy Hanks was for me the most intimate and hard to watch. I felt that I was a voyeur, inside the bedroom of a long-term romance and maybe this is how you actually have sex.

Burns Yes, because it was. The fantasy element was a little less and the reality element was more, in that scene.

Steiner And that doesn't generally happen in mainstream porn.

Burns Having that level of intimacy genuinely represented is an important factor for us. Making that scene was actually a conscious need to fill that sort of space. We also wanted to make sure that a perceived 'butch' character was being topped. But being topped is a position I've personally been uncomfortable with, challenged by.

Steiner We were participants, not just directors.We were also vulnerable. For me to perform was difficult only because I'm self-conscious. It looks like I really celebrate my body but when I look at myself in the mirror, I feel all kinds of complicated things that are not generally positive.

Cornell But by having you, the artists, the directors, appear in the film it gives everyone else permission to have those feelings and to also feel vulnerable and maybe invest more. Could you imagine not being in it and making it?

Steiner No, that would not feel good or mesh politically with the way art and life intersect, which is part of our practice.

Cornell I think all of this terrain that *C.A.C.* covers adds up to a whole new vocabulary visual vocabulary around liberation and sex and feminism.

Steiner I'm interested to hear that because I think that our community of biological men should be more involved and should have more of an awareness around that vocabulary. Gay-identified men seeing our film was such a great boon to us. I think that that vocabulary needs to be a part of their political reality as well. It shouldn't solely be our responsibility to have these discussions or talk about women's sexuality. Even if, as one of our close friends said, 'Eew!' about the ejaculation scene – it's misogynist and repressive. It's not that we're supposed to reject them from the community, but it's like, why do you have those feelings about women's bodies? And women have those feelings about their own bodies.That's even more tragic. Encouraging that is really antithetical to our feminist position. I think our community needs to be more in touch with their complex feelings – of joy, of repulsion, of attraction, of ecstasy – and understand those political ramifications. Audiences need to participate in viewing complex, challenging representations and artists need to create them. Some people said 'I want to bring my friend but they might be freaked out' and we'd always say, 'Please bring them', you know? How other people feel about us is often reflective of how we feel about ourselves.

Cornell For me, the film itself is so aesthetically radical within the history of queer porn and cinema. It's touching on these essential issues of women's pleasure and sexuality – long running struggles but in a very different way.

Burns A lot of which hasn't changed that much. Many women know it's not shameful to masturbate but a lot of women still don't know their bodies and engage with them based on externally perceived desires. People are extremely critical, even scared, of women's bodies.The vag is a dark, internal, oozy, bleeding, complexly-designed space of infinite possibility.

Steiner The clit is the only human organ, sexual or otherwise, designed solely for pleasure, with no presupposition of procreation. But many women have never even had an orgasm. It's a deeply socio-cultural situation.

Burns It was not until I was involved sexually with women that I began to understand what I desired, what I wanted sexually.

Steiner One other thing we've talked about was how many women watch porn. How do women consume porn and, as consumers, what role do we play?

Burns There's this idea that women watch less porn but it's because they're not interested in what they're seeing. It's not because they have less capacity for visual intake of sexual imagery; it's because very little is made for a woman's eye and mind.

Steiner Women get off in different ways and feel differently about sexuality because of all these things we've been talking about. Lots more women are known for their erotic writings than they are for their filmmaking. Things I experienced – Anaïs Nin, Judy Blume, seriously influential readings about sexuality written by women – were really different for me than seeing porn. It just wasn't as interesting an option.

A.K. Burns, A.L. Steiner and Lauren Cornell, 'Community Action Center, an interview with Lauren Cornell', *Little Joe Magazine*, no. 2 (2011) 16–27.

K8 Hardy
amifesto//2006

we do not operate within the comfort zone. that's a fight. this is daily
agonistic with a refusal to hide.
we are not bored.

we fight our insignificance. feminist.
we move around in silence and speak to the shock.
it's shocking to laugh, it's shocking not to take any shit.
it's insane to say no.

needing desperately those safe boundaries within heterosexuality,
we give no thanks.
no pleasantries nor apology.

no gratitude to those who hide in the safety of heterosexual language.
it is not a sanctuary.
there is no more space to move around there, only to hide.

hope works best as a lie or calming device.
they call it future, they say it's useful for us.
everything is not ok.
don't give a shit about being an artist, give a shit about making someone mad maybe just making.
we die fast. and we don't hide.

what is the gesture? as loud as these words.
aesthetics can be killed over and over and over, that's it.
genius is patriarchal.
do not be controlled by fears of hurting feelings
with your political beliefs.

language, biology, is not destiny.
destiny can be a dreamy trip,
a nice fiction the facts.
the limits exclude, we know.

we read we write we think we look at what we have made.
i want to be a mess against this tradition of progress.
i do not exclude productivity.

we look at our patterns of movement and touch and feel and grab you,
bite you, leave a mark; indelible.
we move and we can not stop we will not be stopped.
reading is radical.
producing, making. activist projects.
not sitting on yr ass.
passivity, where does it take you?
conversations. old books. i'm on the phone.
out on the street, out.
we will play the game, players for the team.
don't hate when you can jump in any moment.
happily, we pass the ball(s).
it's heavy. it's intense.
don't take it easy.

it's so easy to party, the heteronormal.
the personal is political. still afterall.
feelings are facts. thinking is that.

K8 Hardy, 'amifesto', *LTTR*, no. 5 (2006).

Ulrike Müller
Bulletin//2006

We live in times of war.

Now I find myself dragged out on stage. I didn't even have time to check my reflection in a mirror, and I certainly don't remember my lines. If I ever had any. I am feeling exposed and too self-conscious to charm or seduce. Can you love me anyway? And if so where can we go? I want to be taken and I want you to take me home, but I doubt there is an easy way out for either of us.

In a recent discussion the sceptical question about art's potential to change the world came up. I said that I am sure it can, because it has changed my world in many ways. I remember feeling polemical as I said that, and I also remember hearing conviction in my voice. I'd like to hear that again. So I want to know what we can do for each other now. I want to hear words that cut to the bone. When things get nasty, a sense of urgency prevails.

And everyday the world outside continues as if nothing had happened. Sometimes I get involved, feel alive and in the middle of it. At other times I drop out. Then it goes on without me. They say: time heals all wounds. But while our bruises are healing we're also dying. Which is another way of saying living. The half-empty way of putting it. We cannot imagine our own death. No matter how often we try, we remain spectators of a scene. And I am not at all interested in spilling stage blood right now, just trying to peek over the brim of my horizon. Unstably balancing on the tip of my toes.

In this scenario it is hard to recognize the real enemy. How can I, with any absolute certainty, distinguish between my own projections and real external dangers? Projection is a self-protective strategy. If inner stimuli are too overbearingly unpleasant I treat them as if they are located outside of me, so I can use defence strategies that I don't have towards my inner life. If I produce the enemy then I must fight him. 'The category of reality is unable to secure the political distinctions or effects it is required to perform.' (Jacqueline Rose)

I feel the curtain rising. Soon the question of risk will be obsolete. Things I've never done before and no safety nets. No easy comfort from functional narratives. No perfection. No inscribing my project into the canon of critical art since the 1960s. No retreat into the predictable power scenarios of porn. No fantasy as distinct from reality. No recreational role-play. No indulgence in drama. No rules to guide experimental art making. No one book to read. I cannot even hold on to the crutches of political correctness anymore.

I feel anxious energy rushing through my body. I want to do meaningful things. My world is this stage. I will seek allies among the dead, the absent and fictitious. I will search the archives, and distil schnapps from the windfall of history. I won't let myself be disconnected from the larger picture. I will face my own murderous instincts. I'll pull up my socks and get to work. I'll suck my own toe for pleasure. I'll fuck the man to get what I want. I will be true to my perversions. I will put my ambivalence to work and my desire for beauty. I'll embrace the absurd and the horrible. I'll propose yet another model and I'll push it further. I won't look away, and I insist for you to look at me. And I'll have to finally accept my need for recognition, because there is no way I can do this alone. Thanks for your companionship so far.

Ulrike Müller, 'Bulletin', *LTTR*, no. 5 (2006).

Sunil Gupta
Columns for *Today*, Delhi//2006

A Return from Exile (17 May 2006)

Exiles. Yes, that's what I called my photo art project in the 1980s that took a close personal look at gay life in Delhi. Well, what passed for gay life, at any rate. It wasn't a very happy scene. A few like me found ourselves outside the country and chose to remain there. Those that were here made the best of it by remaining as silent and invisible as possible.

The nineties came and went. I became part of the great Indian Diaspora. To distance myself from it, I focused my research and work in other parts of the world; Australia, South Africa, Malaysia. Home became London, that melting pot of Diasporas. Gays there came in all shades of skin tone and ethnic origin.

At the turn of the Millennium the news from Delhi became more positive. Gay life was making itself felt and things were getting better. Wouldn't I like to

show my work here? The question was asked. I made another body of work seeking to locate the geography of homelands. There was Canada, where my parents had migrated to, there was New York, where I had gone to finally escape from them, then there was London, what seemed like my final resting place. But, inescapably there was Delhi.

Here, where I was born and bred. Some of whose central neighbourhoods are etched in my memory. Nizamuddin which was home and Humayun's Tomb which was a fantastic playground.

In 2004 I finally got to show all this work at Habitat's Art Gallery and met a wide variety of people. One of whom laid a healing hand on my shoulder. In response I decided to move back here. To become part of the changing face of Delhi. And to reconnect with a long, lost gay childhood.

Relative Values (24 May 2006)

It's training day for the immigration officer at IGI. It's taking twice as long. What's your father's name comes the obligatory question. Shri Ram, I say. He looks at me long and hard. I start to feel a little guilty, how could a Shri Ram have produced a queer son? I wonder if he can tell? But no, we're virtual cousins, he's from a similar caste background, all is well and I'm free to catch the flight to London.

These flights are long and boring. I amuse myself by trying to engage the attention of the very handsome young steward strapped in his seat facing me. But he's Indian and very shy. I suppose I shouldn't assume every male flight attendant is gay. I wonder if he has a secret life and will hit some of the more sleazy clubs that night in London.

Terminal 3 at Heathrow is remarkably empty. I'm out of there in record time. No sign of anyone to greet me. My ex-lover calls. He's on his way, how did I manage to get out so quickly? I agree to meet him outside. It's raining, naturally, and a it's shock to go from 45 to 15 degrees. I'm hoping the Delhi heat will tide over my insides in this cold and grey city.

Finally, we're home. One over-excited dog, one surviving parent, one recently divorced sister and one niece. I'm in the bosom of my family. The signs don't look good; no family ensemble at the airport and no favourite food on the table. The next two weeks are going to be a long haul. Living within the family means no cruising long hours in London's gay scene. But I had planned my escape. I have an internet date for the following night!

The End of Marriage (31 May 2006)

Rain. It hasn't stopped the whole time I've been here. After a while, a kind of melancholia sets in. I tried to hold on to the heat of Delhi as long as possible. But, now I've succumbed to cloudy skies and sniffles. Conversations this week in

London have centred on two spectacular divorce settlements. Heterosexual marriage seems to be over.

Meanwhile, gay couples are rushing to the 'altar'. Well, not quite the altar, as these are not called marriages. In their usual display of political sleight of hand the British decided not to call these unions a 'marriage' and thus took the wind out of the sails of the opposition.

But I am perplexed as to how this came about. The Gay Liberation Front was born at the London School of Economics in the early 1970s. Marriage and property, it proclaimed, are the twin pillars of patriarchy that oppress both women and men.

Queer women and men came out and were proud, not ashamed anymore, to be different. But, it seems in time, the 'straight-acting' gay appeared on the scene, embarrassed by the more flamboyant queens. They, who were never at the forefront of the queer street, who never got their heads bashed in, suddenly ascended to set the agenda of appeasement.

Gay men are just like everyone else, wanting the right to marry and settle down. Men in suits appeared and formed lobbying organizations. We should marry, buy property and raise children they said.

It's not popular to say that one is anti gay marriage, not wishing to be aligned with the religious right. But are we chasing after an institution that has lost its meaning even in the heterosexual world? Under these grey skies, there is a sadness for some lost ideals.

A Blind Date (7 June 2006)

I've agreed to meet someone via the e-list. Seeing as I didn't get laid in London despite two Gaydar dates, this is the next best thing. I'm beginning to feel guilty about my fleeting, sexless visits to the gay hedonistic capitals of the West. In a curious reversal, London is dominated now by the baggage of ex lovers and family, and Delhi is where I am free.

We're meeting in my local Barista in the early evening. I'm trying not to become too frazzled by domestic water and power issues, trying to maintain my cool, ditch my cold and fight off jet-lag. If we can meet by 6 as planned, I'll be fine. However there are sms's and phone calls to the contrary. Can we meet later? Can we meet another day?

This is not looking good. Why did I agree to this? I've thought about this encounter for nine hours on a plane. If it's not going to happen this evening, it's not going to happen at all. I'm trying not to feel irritated by gay Delhi's latest closet of the internet and mobile phone. Finally by 9, I'm unwisely pushing for us to meet at home, not fancying another pointless visit to Barista in my increasingly jet-lagged state.

The bell rings. He's not what I expected at all. At least he's not in his twenties. We talk for a longer time than usual. I find out that, like me, he's also been recently dumped and we're both in an emotional free-fall. I was expecting to offer him support, but I think he might offer me some in return. He's struck a chord in me. It's what they call chemistry. This is not just any old meeting, I've met someone!

City of Dreams (14 June 2006)

Go to Bombay. That's what everyone has said to me. It's got a better gay life, a better art scene.

She rang up and asked would I like to show three pictures in her Summer Salon. She's sold one of the pictures before the opening. That convinces me to go. Just for one night.

All too quickly I'm there. Within minutes my clothes are sticking to me. I'm not going to look cool by the time the opening starts.

The gallery is all the way down by the Taj. I escape briefly to the Gateway. It's too early in the evening. The place is swarming with straight couples. But there are single men arriving, mingling with the crowd. I want to linger, to see how things develop, but I can't. I have to be at the gallery. I make a few pictures and head back to encounter the local art world.

I'm introduced to a potential one night stand. He's young and pretty but his attention is wandering every couple of minutes. No good. Talk to an older and more likely candidate. He makes yachts, not a very gay occupation plus his wife is holding court. Doesn't look promising, but then it's India and anything is possible.

On the plane back to Delhi, the woman beside me strikes up a conversation. I confess to being artistic, unmarried with three unfulfilled relationships behind me. But I avoid mentioning their gender. She's married with a young child but enjoys a corporate career. By now she's giving me her number and then it hits me that I'm being picked up! I wonder whether it's worth telling her I'm gay but decide that it's a short plane ride so why not entertain her fantasies. She has to have her dreams as well.

Oral History (21 June 2006)

Sex. How we all obsess about it. No one seems to be getting enough. At least, not of the right kind. We've dressed it up in so many flavours. Given it national characteristics like culinary curiosities. In India, it's not done, we're told.

At puberty, I developed a problem of nocturnal emissions which led to a trip to the doctor in CP. Following an acutely embarrassing examination of my penis, all was declared normal and I was packed off with a set of relieved parents. Little did we suspect what lay ahead.

The subject of my sexuality was officially closed in the family. I experimented by storing the results of my consciously induced daytime emissions in a Pond's cold cream jar. An appeasement to the Gods. However, not a good idea at the height of a Delhi summer.

Moving on to the oral stage, still uninformed about consequences, it came as a huge surprise that someone would use me as a cold cream jar.

Two years ago, I fell in love with the most beautiful Delhi man I had ever met. Within a year it was over, unconsummated. He had found his Meera, he didn't need sex, meaning me any more.

Last Saturday night I decided, enough was enough, I head out on the town. No luck, club shuts and we're back out on the road. I see a man on a motorbike. He'll do. I never chose celibacy. My friends hang out encouragingly. Back home, he just lays there. No one's taught him anything. I minister my oral skills. He blows in minutes. Doesn't make a move towards me. The night is over.

Will someone decriminalize the act? Spread basic information and bring spontaneity and fun back into our Indian sex lives.

Sunil Gupta, columns for *Today*, Delhi (May 2006). (www.sunilgupta.net)

Emily Roysdon
Queer Love//2006

LOVE is a strategy, medium, site and scene. Love is an act. Love is not a quantifiable element able to be parsed between politics and poetics for it constantly transforms the definitions of those very terms. Before I speak economy and resistance I must be explicit – Queer love. Queer love exemplifies itself by its lack of singular object relations and an insistence on unstable and mutable boundaries. My insistence on queer love is because the unspoken alternative would be hetero-normative love. Distinguishing this discourse of love as one that implicitly speaks queer love we do not take for granted modes of reproduction, exchange values or teleological engagements. We allow simultaneous investments, contradiction, excess, relief and excess. The theatre of queer love employs politics, poetics and aesthetics in equal measure. Queering love transforms the vocabulary with which we address our object, and the ensuing acts need not be translated. The materiality of this argument is in its very terms. Queer love is not economical and that is political. Love as a medium is part of an economy of

resistance, ecstatic resistance I would say, provoking questions of memory and tactics. What does love want? Is it always discursive or sometimes outside of rational economies of getting and giving?

Emily Roysdon, retitled extract from the roundtable discussion 'Now, Then and Love: Questions of Agency in Contemporary Practice' (2006), in Juli Carson, ed., *Exil des Imaginären* (Vienna: Generali Foundation, 2007) 160–61.

Sharon Hayes
Revolutionary Love: I Am Your Worst Fear, I Am Your Best Enemy//2008

My dear lover,

I know you will be angry at me for speaking to you like this in public but you left me with no other choice. I called your phone but your voicemail is full. I tried to reach you by email but got an automated reply. I still have your mother's number from when you were visiting her last summer but when I called she said she didn't know who I was. This morning I tried to get into the convention to talk to you but I don't have a pass and there are police and party officials four lines thick down there. It's not like the old days, when things were loose and you could flirt or lie your way in. I'm not quite sure what you're all so afraid of. What's with all the armour? Are things really that bad?

When I couldn't make it in, I waited outside hoping to find you in the crowd of people lined up to get in. I know that you were there. I felt certain that you passed me but I didn't see you. You are indistinguishable from all the others – the delegates, the media, the police, those smartly dressed young volunteers. I can't find you anywhere in this mess.

Did you see me?

Maybe not.

I'm standing on the Capitol Grounds, on the green rectangle just below Martin Luther King Jr. Blvd.

You must admit, my love, we've had a terrible relationship. You kiss me long and hard but you never loved me. I tried to tell myself I would get used to it. That comforting old myth about the body's ability to adjust is just pure fiction. If that were the case, after all these years, I should take to hatred the way a duck takes to water. But instead I've suffered terribly.

As far as I can make out I've ended my relationship with you every three months for the last 38 years. I resolved never to speak your name in public, I speak bad of you to all my friends and I even refuse to acknowledge that you exist. I promised you I would forget about you, if you left me alone. But each time I banish you from my life, you manage by means of entreaties, telegrams, letters, letters to the editor, the imposition of your friends or of mine, to call me back towards you.

For years, I've tried to make sense of your behaviour.

When you told me you loved me but would never speak my name out loud, I told you I could live with the silence.

When you told me you would fuck me but would never take me home, I told you I would be your rest stop lover.

When you called me a moral pervert on the floor of the Senate but then whispered your apologies sweetly in my ear, I told you to use me as your scapegoat.

But when you gestured to shake my hand and spit on me instead, I told you I was the rage of all queers condensed to the point of explosion.

Huey P. Newton said 'even a homosexual can be a revolutionary' and I'm finding my revolution. I've been awakening with ideas and with energy, I'm replacing the old stories with new ones,. How it began, I don't really know. Where once there was frustration, alienation and cynicism, there are new characteristics in me. I am in a flow of love and I am showing it.

There is nothing easier than to burn with enthusiasm for some issue and to be ready to fight for it, when the very same idea has inflamed hundreds of thousands of others. There is even something suspect, something actively repulsive, in denying ecstasy, in denying that which directs the outbursts of the heart.

You may be holing yourself up inside those layers of people, but I know that the ears are the only orifice that can't be closed. I am an army of lovers, my sweet, and I want you to hear me very clearly.

I've found my voice and with it I scream, I love you.

I love you because when I say I do, you blush and bury your face in your clothes. I love you because when I throw you a kiss your body shakes, quivers and writhes in response.

I love you because I know my love causes your heart to skip a beat and sends shivers up your spine.

I love you. It may be shocking to you but I do and I will shout it as loud as I can manage. I love you and will do so until it hurts you or me or both.

After all, my love, we're all queer.

And if you find in what I am saying something of which you feel unjustly accused, remember that one should be thankful that there is any fault of which one can be unjustly accused.

What a pleasure to feel indignant!
This is a beautiful revolution!

I demand, my love,

1 the right to be gay anytime, anyplace.
2 the right to free physiological change and modification of sex upon demand.
3 The right of free dress and adornment
9 That straight thinking views of things in terms of order and comparison be resisted. A is not before B, B is not after A., 1 is not below 2 and 2 is not below 3.
15 That we stop making promises about the future, which we have no right to make and which prevent us from, or make us feel guilty about, growing and changing.

So much has happened my love and we are just at the beginning. We will evolve as we get ourselves together and we are only at the beginning. We'll be gay until everyone has forgotten and then we'll be gay again.

Sharon Hayes, from *Revolutionary Love: I Am Your Worst Fear, I Am Your Best Enemy*, performed at the Republican National Convention (2008). Previously unpublished.

Allyson Mitchell
Deep Lez//2009/2015

Deep Lez is an experiment, a process, an aesthetic and a blend of theory and practice. Deep Lez is right this minute and it is rooted in herstories and theories that came before. It takes the most relevant and capable ideas and uses them as tools to create new ways of thinking while simultaneously clinging to more radical politics that have already happened but definitely aren't over yet. Part of the deep of Deep Lez is about commitment, staying power and significance. Part of the deep of Deep Lez is about philosophies and theories, as in 'wow man, that's deep.'

Deep Lez uses cafeteria-style mixings of craft, context, food, direct action and human connections to maintain radical dyke politics and resistant strategies. Part quilting bee, part public relations campaign, and part Molotov cocktail, Deep Lez seeks to map out the connections between the second position feminisms

that have sustained radical lesbian politics and the other feminist/queer and trans politics that look to unpack many of the concepts upon which those radical politics have been developed. These political positions have set forth a host of important critiques about radical lesbianisms as they have historically unfolded, and look to provide correctives in this regard. Unfortunately, this is often accomplished through the wholesale dismissal of a radical lesbian practice and identification. Deep Lez was coined to acknowledge the urgent need to develop inclusive liberatory feminisms while examining the strategic benefits of maintaining some components of a radical lesbian theory and practice in dreaming big queer worlds. This project is carefully situated not to simply hold on to history, but rather to examine how we might cull what is useful from lesbian herstories to redefine contemporary urban lesbian/queer/trans existence. In so doing, 'lesbian' is resurrected as a potential site of radical identification, rather than one of de-politicized apathy or erasure.

Deep Lez originally began as a cultural project of mine, largely informing my art practice. I make lesbian feminist monsters using abandoned domestic handicraft. This has meant the creation of giant 3D sasquatch ladies, room-size vagina dentatas, a FAG feminist art gallery and a lesbian feminist hell house. The objects and environments that I create are about articulating some of the ideas and imaginings from second-wave feminisms that were so foundational to me, while still remaining committed to an inclusive queer theory and practice that continues to keep me alive. In a short time, this idea grew beyond my own practice, and took hold among a variety of local and international communities. For example, the language of Deep Lez was adopted by some folks at the Michigan Womyn's Music Festival who lobby for trans inclusion, as well as some supporters of Camp Trans, who use an article about Deep Lez in their trans solidarity packages. Here, Deep Lez is mobilized to move radical lesbianism and identification with or allegiance to trans communities out of the realm of either/or and into the space of both/and. A Deep Lez art exhibition was mounted in San Francisco, in which lesbian identification was explored as a relevant and strategic site of young queer urban politics. Given its growth, I write and expand on the ideas of Deep Lez with this statement.

Deep Lez is meant to be a point of departure for me to start thinking about my politics and what is important to me and my communities. Deep Lez is meant as to be a macraméed conceptual tangle for people to work though how they integrate art into their politics and how they live their lives and continue to get fired up about ideas. Deep Lez can offer alternative ways of imagining the world and who we are. It is meant to be passed hand-to-hand from crafter to filmmaker to academic to students to teachers to leaders and back again. My wish is that it permeates and also loosens things up.

Deep Lez is not meant to become its own dogma but to encourage thinking about new feminist and dyke strategic positions. Every Deep Lez text, installation, manifesto and potluck offering is different because it is contingent on the contributions and participations of many and also because it is accumulating and discarding as it goes. We can band together through Deep Lez to imagine and realize our way out of this dysfunctional habitat to create new ecologies, new policies and new styles without war, poverty, violence and waste.

Deep Lez is the volunteer, the workshop coordinator, the curator, the consumer, the first initiated and the instigator – anyone who gets intrigued by this bell-bottomed fat-assed catch all: whether they are dykes or not, they are still Deep Lez.

Signed in solidarity for new kind of sisterhood that isn't based on gender and privilege and a new kind of brotherhood that isn't based on rape and pillage.

Allyson Mitchell, 'Deep Lez' (2009, revised 2015) (http://www.allysonmitchell.com)

Alexandro Segade
On Queer Reenactment//2013

i was raised in san diego, california, parented in part by late night cable television. this disembodied babysitter weened my brother and me on an unsupervised stream of of sci fi fantasies, set to synthesized music, that expressed – no, induced – anxiety about what i would later know as 'the spectacle'. These films recurred in cycles on channels like cinemax. taken together they offered an alienated, mediatized, sexualized and sinister world of deformed mutants, vengeful clones, slick cyborgs, new wave femme fatales, alien media moguls and movie-maddened maniacs. these films freaked us out, lodging themselves in our minds like a trauma, one we would reenact with each other in our bedroom after the lights went out. i bought my brother a copy of *looker* for his birthday this year and when we put it on, we immediately recalled every word of the first scene, where a blond model recites her imperfections to a plastic surgeon, then is shot with a laser and falls out of a window. my brother and i are both gay. we took to camp early.

lately, my brother and i have been collaborating on a series of performances that take place in a california of the future. the advent of human cloning has led to a regime of hyper conformist homosexual replicants. marriage between the gay clones is mandated by law. organics, as all non-clones are called, are

monitored closely – and polyamorous queer dissidents are hunted.

i act as writer, director, producer and sometimes performer in these works. my brother, mateo, provides the music, live DJing his own compositions, soundtracks that recall the movies we grew up with. in the latest instalment of the series, *The Holo Library*, which is performed as a staged reading, actors read from a script projected opposite the stage. The convoluted story imagines a moment in which the screens that inform, entertain and estrange the people of this future world take on a life of their own.

what are my brother and i doing in these performances if not reenacting – restaging – reliving – the phantasmic, holographic, hallucinatory screen-lives of our childhood, a childhood that predicted much of the screen-based life we would come to know as our contemporary moment? the mysanthropic sci-fi of the 80s was deeply misogynist, xenophobic, homophobic and archly conservative – with normal humans privileged over all the awesome alternatives they offered. i, personally, would prefer to be almost anything other than the protagonist of *blade runner* or *videodrome* – and this is how i knew, in part, i was queer. in these reimaginings of the mythologies of the 80s that we grew up with, my brother and i are inserting, and asserting, a queer vision of our future. [...]

as a teen, i played *dungeons & dragons*, a convivial, relational game form based on chance – as in the rolling of oddly shaped dice – and role-play. nerds gravitated toward this pre-virtual RPG, asocial, awkward, but together at our parents' dining room tables we could collectively imagine another place, ourselves another group – a racially diverse band of elves, half-orcs, gnomes and dwarves – of whatever gender we chose. and it wasn't a coincidence that these gatherings would often end in a slumber party, and that the games themselves took on a queer colouring, if repressed by adolescent anxieties and complicated by the homophobia of the reagan era and the beginnings of AIDS. a storyteller always, i often served as the dungeon master. this game is one of the origins of my own understanding of myself as a person, a queer, and this may be what i am reenacting in making the work that i now think of as art.

i am not interested in artwork that is satisfied to reenact already canonized avant-gardes, using modernism as a camouflage to blend into the artworld. reenactment of this sort interests me less than the queer pleasure and play of acting. and i'm not interested in straight acting either.

Alexandro Segade, 'On Queer Reenactment' (2013) (https://alexandrosegade.wordpress.com)

Akram Zaatari
The Libidinal Archive: In Conversation with Chad Elias//2013

Chad Elias [...] *How I Love You* (2001) documents homosocial and homosexual relations among a small group of gay men in Lebanon at a particular point in time. It seems to me that this video was concerned not only with the legal prohibitions on homosexuality, but also with social pressures placed on men who identify as 'gay' on a personal level but who are not able to claim a public dimension to their identity. You manage to capture the coded language that these men use to express their desires within a deeply homophobic society. One example of this is the man who transformed the lyrics of the Fayrouz song *ana Habbaytak* (I Loved You) to *ana had baytak* (I Am Near Your House or, more idiomatically, I Am Near You) to address his lover. What was the main objective of this video? What problems did you face in making it? Can you tell us more about the social dynamics of the gay community in Lebanon? What do you think defines the specificity of this scene relative to other marginal gay communities?

Akram Zaatari In 1997 I made the video entitled *Crazy of You (Majnounak)* in which I interviewed young men about their sexual encounters with women. Since then I had always wanted to make another video documenting different sexual practices. In *Crazy of You* the young men were so proud of being able to 'conquer' young women, even sometimes by tricking them into sex. Their stories were so similar, as if they were trying hard to get closest to a common fantasy ideal. I am saying this because sometimes I felt their stories were pure imagination. I wondered if they had sexual encounters with men, and how they would hide it through this language of heterosexual conquest. This is how the idea of the film was born. I did not want to make a militant film but one that records the experiences and the practices of gay men. Although gay behaviour seems quite accepted, at least socially in the night scene in Beirut, it is still not widely accepted in Lebanese society, and it is still punished by the law. So I wanted to make a film where the main question is how to testify, how to speak when testimony or speaking can lead to criminalization of the speaker. So if you do not look at the image, in other words if you are not reminded by the blurring of the image that these testimonies could get the subjects into trouble, what comes across is the normality, the banality of their day-to-day lives. There is a banality with which subjects tell their sexual encounters. They do not try to victimize themselves, nor do they try to provoke social norms. Yet, in what they say, there is pride in telling stories that might seem banal, especially to people

from Western nations. Yet the blurring of the image makes the document tied to the social and legal constraints of Lebanon. So this film is about this double aspect of constructing a multilayered document. The question of coded language is inevitable in any relationship. When you're close to someone, you develop your own language with him or her, and this is how 'ana Habbaytak' became 'ana had baytak'. I see it more as a code between two, a private discourse, as opposed to a code between two in a public space. It says more about their affection than about their communication in public.

Elias How I Love You differs sharply from your subsequent curatorial project on 'sex practices' for *Home Works IV* in 2008. If the former was concerned with the discourse of sex and sexuality the latter was motivated by a desire to avoid language and metaphor. Is this what led you to the work of William E. Jones?

Zaatari I belong to a reality that does not allow me – even if I want to – to present explicit sex in my films. And I am not a provocateur, in the sense that I like it better when my work indirectly reflects the social constructs that surround it. So this is one of the reasons why I wanted to make the sex programme in Beirut. In a way I was almost saying 'we cannot do it, OK, so let's see the work of others who could do it elsewhere.' I encountered the work of William E. Jones through Stuart Comer (Film Curator, Tate Modern). And indeed, I was highly impressed with this coherent body of work mostly centred on gay pornography, yet without showing any graphic pornographic images. I ended up presenting Jones's work in a separate session on its own as part of the 'Let It Be' programme in Beirut. I thought it is indeed important to see them next to more directly graphic representations. Despite the fact that there is nothing pornographic in Jones's films, I see them glowing with 'sex'. So to answer your question about *How I Love You*: yes, the work differs from all that I presented in the 'Let It Be' programme, yet the ideas behind it are much the same. There is also eight years between them, so that alone accounts for the differences between them.

Elias How I Love You left me wondering what form the struggles for gay rights would have to take in Lebanon. Recently, Arab scholar Joseph Massad has challenged the assumption that the Arab world has not yet caught up with the Western model of 'liberatory' homosexuality. He argues that organizations that aim to 'liberate Arab and Muslim "gays and lesbians" from the oppression under which they allegedly live by transforming them from practitioners of same-sex contact into subjects who identify as homosexual and gay' are in fact imposing a Western model of homosexuality. While there are certainly problems with Massad's assertion that the rare public expressions of gay identity in Arab

countries are the product of a Western sexual epistemology, he rightly challenges the uncritical adoption of a gay politics oriented around coming out of the closet. What paths have the struggles for gay rights taken in Lebanon over the last two decades? What advances, if any, have been made and how do you see art playing a role in the study and representation of Arab homosexual practices?

Zaatari International queer advocacy groups aim to fight the openly homophobic laws and discourses that are still prevalent in many Arab countries. Yet for the most part, gay and lesbian people in the Arab world resist oppression on a personal level, and their stories do not necessarily reach the public sphere. Thousands of people have intervened in families and in the workplace, defending homosexual individuals from injustice, and many have succeeded. I think that recent local institutional efforts are only a culmination of individual efforts that were born in Lebanon in a sporadic way since the 1990s, including maybe the making of *How I Love You*. I acknowledge the role of international institutions in funding these initiatives and helping them to organize, but I do not understand why such support is sometimes seen with paranoia, suspicion or even seen as a threat. A threat to what? To past values? To religious or social values? To the way Arab cultures used to think and carry their sexual lives in the past? And why should we think that those past practices are necessarily better or healthier than other gay practices coming from 'the West'? The struggle for human rights is a global struggle now, but it becomes quite complicated for gays and lesbians in this part of the world. I would accept that one cannot simply impose a Western paradigm of sexual emancipation onto gay men and women in the Arab world. Indeed, the assumption that 'freedom' necessarily means being openly gay cannot be taken for granted.

However, I am wary of the ways in which local contingencies can feed into a reductive relativism that makes cross-cultural and transnational alliances impossible. Without assuming a universal norm, one also has to be critical of Arab states and societies which have allowed very little tolerance of difference to a heterosexual norm propagated through religions and shared, visible social practices. They could not cope with many of the changes that have stemmed from globalization, just as they could not deal with the institutionalization of human and sexual relationships in civil societies. Instead of accommodating for homosexual behaviour and finding ways of granting it social recognition, most Arab cultures first denied its existence and condemned it, and then considered it an abnormality or a Western trend whenever a homosexual story became public. In other words, they were too protective of dominant religious and social values until the issue became indeed a public one, a pressing one, a human rights one, and once that happens, of course international organizations will rush to

intervene, to 'rescue', to 'liberate'. No matter how one may critique this interference, it remains a blessing, frankly, compared with retrograde laws and inhuman treatment of homosexuals that persist in Arab nations.

Massad fails to see the nuances in the daily struggles of many gays and lesbians. As a result, he falls into stereotyping and generalizing, and he misses the fact that the opposition between West and East is today way more complex than the binary he sets up. In other words, the Muslim world he is talking about is not at all what he thinks it is I am afraid. Furthermore, the gay rights campaigns that Massad is criticizing have in some instances had very positive effects. In 2011 Lebanon's minister of the interior publicly condemned an incident of gay bashing. In the same year a judge from the town of Batroun acquitted two men after they were put on trial for having sex, setting an important precedent in the legislative system. This happened despite the fact that the Lebanese penal code still considers homosexuality as an act against nature and punishes offenders with prison sentences that range between a month and a year. Yet there is a long way for the struggle to go, primarily in the realm of public education. [...]

Akram Zaatari and Chad Elias, extracts from interview, *Tate Papers*, no. 19 (March 2013).

Mahmoud Khaled
The Non-Located Space: In Conversation with Omar Kholeif//2012

Omar Kholeif I think the best place for us to start our conversation is to consider your new project for *Ibraaz Platform 004: Do You Have Work Tomorrow?* How did the project develop and where was its context derived from?

Mahmoud Khaled It was stimulated by the set of questions that you presented to me for *Ibraaz Platform 004*. I started thinking about how territorially rooted the questions proposed were and I thought about how this created tensions. *Do You Have Work Tomorrow?* is not really about a specific event or place, nor does it react to a specific moment. Rather, it is based on a very personal experience between two strangers. The idea for this grew out of struggles that I have been working through in relation to my own creative practice – questioning the content of the work that I am producing within the reality of a much larger social framework. It was challenging because I started out knowing the kind of content,

aesthetics and ideas that I did not want to use, so in a sense the work grew out of a kind of artistic block or dilemma. The resulting project is a celebration of this 'dilemma' – one that I have been contemplating over the last couple of years.

Kholeif Formally, why did you choose the iPhone as the platform for your subjects and the medium of photography to document it? Also, the scenario that you present between the two men in your narrative could have been expressed in a variety of ways; why did you choose the Grindr iPhone application?

Khaled The iPhone and the application Grindr presented many different entry points for how one could think about the work. When I first considered *Ibraaz Platform 004*, it became clear that the questions were about very large-scale public concerns. I wanted to enter these public zones from a private entry point. Grindr – the social networking application – allows gay men to connect with each other on the basis of their location. It is a very private sphere, as indeed is the iPhone: the messages inside Grindr are personal documents that require passcodes to be accessed and so forth. I wanted to use this undisclosed material to think about public issues.

Just as challenging was to consider the role of photography. I have for some time been thinking about the possibilities of the medium: what can you do with a camera? It's loaded. And the main problem with it is that photographers in the context of where I am working are always expected to 'record' or 'capture' something – a dramatic political event, for example. I wanted to break this expectation and create something that was staged for the camera, then the staged conversation on the iPhone would be transferred into images.

Kholeif Our focus at the moment at Ibraaz is to consider new media's relationship not only to art practice but also to people. Thinking about the 'medium', let's focus specifically on Grindr as a 'soft' space. It is a networking application for gay men to meet, yet also functions as a public forum or shared space. When you sign up you have a publically visible avatar (often an image of one's face). However, interestingly, if you log onto the platform, say in Egypt as opposed to the UK, one will notice that the 'faces' of the participants are often concealed. Instead, men will choose to 'boast' about their physiques, for example. I'm curious about what you think of Grindr as a public space and how it is unique to different contexts?

Khaled The iPhone application itself is a privatized public space with its own borders and limits, even financially – let's consider how many people have access to iPhones, and Internet connections, 3G networks and so on. It's also restricted by sexual orientation; you must subscribe to certain categories to occupy this

space. It is also a space that is fuelled by desire: the desire for two men to connect, often sexually. For me, desire is very much related to time and space, but what makes it interesting in the context of this project is its rootedness in a very location-based application. Grindr reveals where the person you are talking to is in relation to yourself. I wanted to use this tool to think about a non-located space. The text that forms the staged conversation between the two men was not tied to a particular time or space, but was constructed out of imagined and fragmented stories and personal experiences.

My intent for the viewer was to remove the location. One crucial moment in the conversation between the two men is when one of them discusses getting into his car. Here, the automobile is intended as a symbol for the body. It is the device that enables him mobility and prevents him from being located. It offers him safety because it can be shifted to whatever site or context. All of these different allegories then start to grow out of this – the car as home, the car as a space for love, sex and sociability. This is the most significant element of the work for me: dislocating nature in order to break the border that blurs an individual's stability and mobility.

Kholeif Would you call Grindr a form of social media that can be appropriated or hijacked? Though it is a space for the manifestation of desire, do you think it can be mechanized or instrumentalized differently?

Khaled It's interesting what you are talking about, but to be frank, when I conceived the project I was imagining the moment when these two guys were talking to each other. In the background, it was a politically charged emergency state and I considered how this non-located background would affect their conversation. For a start, I didn't want them to end up having sex at the end of the dialogue. So even though their dalliance was driven by desire, the two ended up digressing into politics. All of a sudden, one of them realises that they are misusing the platform – Grindr – and that in fact they should not discuss politics within this forum. Yet, the truth for them is evident – everything is politicized. This was important to put into the work.

On the other hand, I'm not particularly concerned with social media activism, although of course I understand it. I am more interested in how digital technology can alter our lives on a daily basis and in the private sphere. In the case of Grindr, it undoubtedly changed the mechanisms of desire and the aesthetics of self-representation. [...] There's also class connotations involved: you only interact with people from your own social class or zone because of your location. What actually makes the machine interesting for me is how intimacy can be channelled into these very different locations and how you can be connected to this

mechanism 24 hours a day, wherever you are. Now you have access to these most private and intimate scenarios while on the street, in a café and so forth. [...]

Kholeif [W]e have spoken before about the invasion of politics into these personal spheres. In this sense, with the continued focus on art within North Africa and the Middle East, do you ever feel that your work is being instrumentalized as a political tool?

Khaled This has always been a challenge since I started working professionally. I have struggled against this idea when different curators try to put you in specific zones. However, now I see this challenge as part of the job. As an artist, one is constantly producing different meanings. Part of the job is then to struggle with how this meaning is put into the world and how people perceive it. When I started working, I did not perceive my work as political. I attempted to theme it differently and I always attempted to park politics to one side. With time, I have nevertheless realized that everything is a political act. Whether I am producing a video or an abstract painting, these are all political gestures. Every artwork has its own set of self-referential political contexts. As artists, I believe our responsibility is to be aware of the context in which we are producing and the attachments that are associated with the meaning we produce. This awareness is crucial: both in the contexts of the history in which we are producing and the present in which we are exhibiting. [...]

Mahmoud Khaled and Omar Kholeif, extracts from 'The Non-Located Space: In Conversation with Omar Kholeif', *Ibraaz Platform 004* (November 2012) 1–5, 5–6.

Yan Xing
In Conversation with Travis Jeppesen//2011

In 2010, Yan Xing made an explosive impact on the Beijing art scene with his performance work DADDY. *Yan stood facing a white wall, delivering a very personal monologue on the absence of a father figure in his life – and the role that void played in his maturation – as well as the wrenching forms of abuse he suffered while growing up. In a culture in which the airing of one's private grievances and struggles in public is frowned upon, Yan's piece effectively registered a new approach in the artistic index.*

In his latest exhibition, Yan presented another performance-based work, Realism,

which featured himself and seven actors reciting and discussing quotes from André Breton's Surrealist Manifesto *while pondering a replica of Michelangelo's* David, *as well as* They Are Not Here, *a filmed experiment in which Yan placed seven men in a cramped hotel room for a single afternoon and refused to allow them to communicate with each other throughout the duration.*

As one of China's few openly gay artists, Yan Xing – his work, and arguably his very presence which is so often tied up with it – continues to ruffle feathers in a country where cultural norms are only slowly being broken down.

Travis Jeppesen Your educational background is in oil painting. What made you decide to switch to performance?

Yan Xing First of all, the medium itself is very important for me. The medium has its own logic and system, which does not happen by accident. What I really want to stress here is that I have never been away from or given up painting – even while indulging in performance. In addition, I never avoid classical art; to some extent, the fear of art makes me feel that what I am doing is far from what I expect. However, maybe this is not art at all, just experiences. China's art education follows the Soviet Union's approach; therefore, students have to choose their department according to the medium when they enter university. Ultimately, graduating from the oil painting department in the art academy has nothing to do with my art practice, as I am neither a good student nor a good example.

Jeppesen Can you talk about your performance installation at Galerie Urs Meile?

Yan This is my first solo exhibition, which features two projects. One is a work I finished last year, *They Are Not Here*, and the other one is called *REALISM*. *REALISM* is actually not a work about the performance, or about the sculpture, video, print and installation. In the scenario that I constructed, there is a huge sculpture, which reflects my internal desire. On the opening day, seven actors and myself did a two hour-long performance. The whole practice – including operations, descriptions, rehearsals, occupations, negotiations, handwriting – could be defined as the plea or defence for an 'imagined reality'. I want to spark a thorough discussion about the generation of mechanisms of art history. This attitude reflects my persistent sincerity towards 'the creation of a reality without any difference', or, better, my insane stubbornness aimed at 'the full accomplishment of the unavoidable mistake'.

Jeppesen Perhaps your best-known work to date is the *DADDY* project. Can you tell me about that?

Yan This is a performance that I dedicate to my DADDY. I spent more than one hour facing a wall talking about my special personal experiences. When I look back at this piece afterwards, it at least demonstrated that I am a good narrator. Narration bears endless charms.

Jeppesen You are a founding member of the artist group COMPANY. What is the history of this group? What have been its aims and projects? How does this project differ from your solo works?

Yan COMPANY is a continuous project. It is not an organization, nor a team. Since last year, we have done four projects. As I wrote in the statement in 2008:

> COMPANY is a company without an employer, employees, or salaries. The concept of COMPANY is as vague as its infrastructure. COMPANY has no set principles or precise characteristics. The artists of COMPANY rarely communicate with each other. They work independently with no prescribed aims or obligations towards any goal. COMPANY was named and founded with this intent collectively by the founding artist members.
>
> COMPANY does not accept new members, it does not encourage communication between members, or interfere with members' decisions. COMPANY is a project in progress and can change course at any time. COMPANY is just COMPANY. It does not aim at producing a brand or becoming a style. Everything in the world is named after something that already exists; however, COMPANY does not want to be defined this way, even though one day it inevitably will be. For this reason, the members declined to define COMPANY. It has already been stated that COMPANY is a company. It is not an art group or an organization, but possibly could be. Please trust COMPANY. Words are the only way to preserve the evolution of humanity. What has been stated here is not actually everything COMPANY believes in.

Jeppesen You have a blog in China that has been very controversial. Would you consider blogging to be an important part of your art practice? What role does blogging play for you as an artist?

Yan The reason why it is controversial is because I have never linked up my art creation with blogging. If this is simply an artist's blog, I don't think it would be attractive. Maybe also because I often express my thoughts, via the blog, about politics, history, and the media, which is very different from topics other gay people are concerned with, such as fashion and lifestyle. Plus, my extravagant wording and accounting, the 'fancy' life I live, this attracts even more people's eyeballs. Though this is just my daily life. However, I believe this all will be

gone finally, as blogging no way bears anything serious and deep. I never expected the output from blogging would deliver deeper values. The relationship between blogging and me and my art practice is similar to the one between my life and art. All the web tools, including my Weibo [the Chinese version of Twitter], are all becoming an individual medium that can quickly be consumed. I believe all the time that I am not a good example. Therefore, I never investigate why I am controversial.

Yan Xing and Travis Jeppesen, 'Interview with Travis Jeppesen', *Whitehot Magazine*, 2011. (http://whitehotmagazine.com)

Prem Sahib
To Make Queer Art Now//2014

I see my artistic engagement with queer culture as one that is inextricably bound to the biographical content of my work. I don't feel like I necessarily take on 'queer culture' as a subject matter, but I do use my own experience of sexuality as a material and, in doing so, it becomes implicit.

There was an urgent political backdrop to the queer art that was being made during the late 1980s and early 90s when queer theory and activism emerged; namely, the AIDS epidemic. I don't think that these issues have disappeared but, within the UK at least, they have been transformed and queer politics are being addressed with a louder voice outside of art. My generation obviously has a very different relationship to HIV/AIDS than the generation before us. I remember discussing this with a friend who lost 80 percent of those close to him during the 1980s. We were talking about the different types of visual representation associated with HIV for both our generations; whereas he had a very stark physical memory of those around him being ill, my association was perhaps more remote. I recently made the sculpture *Two Dots* (2013), which mimics the positive result of a rapid HIV test. The two dots figure my relationship towards HIV as both a very real worry but also somewhat abstract. My experience of AIDS isn't the experience of those in the 1980s and the current global complexity of this issue leads to its abstraction.

I don't think that the use of queer aesthetic forms necessarily secures any political capacity. In fact, declaring something 'political' can sometimes be problematic in the sense that you are inadvertently defining the parameters for

how it can operate. The work I tend to respond to isn't self-conscious about having a queer agenda, but performs a queer politics by taking everyday objects or spaces and mining their sexual connotations. A more expanded and open notion of sexuality means that artists can address these topics without conforming to a particular sexual type or identity – I'm thinking of Eddie Peake's explorations of the body and sex here.

Having said that, I do see my work as engaged in politics, despite not using what you might call an overtly political language. The politics of my work is implicit to its form; it is there for those who can see it, and for those who can't. I identify with the disco movement because I feel that its politics were its pleasure principle. This is true of other artists of my generation, such as George Henry Longly who draws upon nightclub paraphernalia. (He, Eddie and I also run a club night together.) George's work references gay histories through club culture. This kind of work on sexuality is about being part of a tradition. Disco had a social efficacy despite its superficial veneer and that's how I like to think about my own art-making: emerging from the problems and experiences that I encounter.

Prem Sahib, 'To Make Queer Art Now', from Paul Clinton, 'Queer Time and Place', *frieze*, no. 163 (May 2014) 190. Courtesy of Paul Clinton and frieze. (www.frieze.com)

Gordon Hall
New Space Education and How It Works//2014

[...] It seems to me that for a long time, the accepted verdict on minimalism/abstraction/formalism was that the assumed viewing subject of this kind of work is a universalized subject, and as such this work can't deal with particularities such as gender, race, and class, and so effectively erases or ignores these differences, which is bad politics. According to this logic, the way to make queer work is to utilize one of three strategies: make work that is auto- biographical from a queer subject position, show things that are metaphors or symbols for this positionality that the viewer will be able to recognize (what I refer to elsewhere as the 'glitter problem'), or make work that displays queer bodies directly. I am not opposed to these strategies, but I do think there are many of us who find them to be excessively limiting. I am interested in work that teaches me phenomenologically how to move through the world and how to perceive differently, in ways that will make queerness and gender variety more possible.

How can you change your mode of embodiment? I think we might conceive of it as a process of self-transformation that happens in relation to objects. I am thinking about objects pedagogically. Social politics happens on the level of objects. It is the way things and buildings are organized. If we think of objects as that from which we learn, could we learn less oppressive or different things from different objects? Or less oppressive or different things from the same objects? This is really what I am excited about. A phenomenological and embodied relationship to objects that does not use representation as its primary mode of address, and rather employs physical relationality as its mode of communication. This line of thinking frees up space to make work that might appear to have nothing to do with gender, race, or politics. But it can have to do with all these things, and deeply so. I am cautious about instrumentalizing art, about demanding that it make concrete political propositions. But I think this approach leaves space for abstraction to operate in more subtle but still potentially mobilizing way, through internalizing objects' non- conventional logics with our bodies. [...]

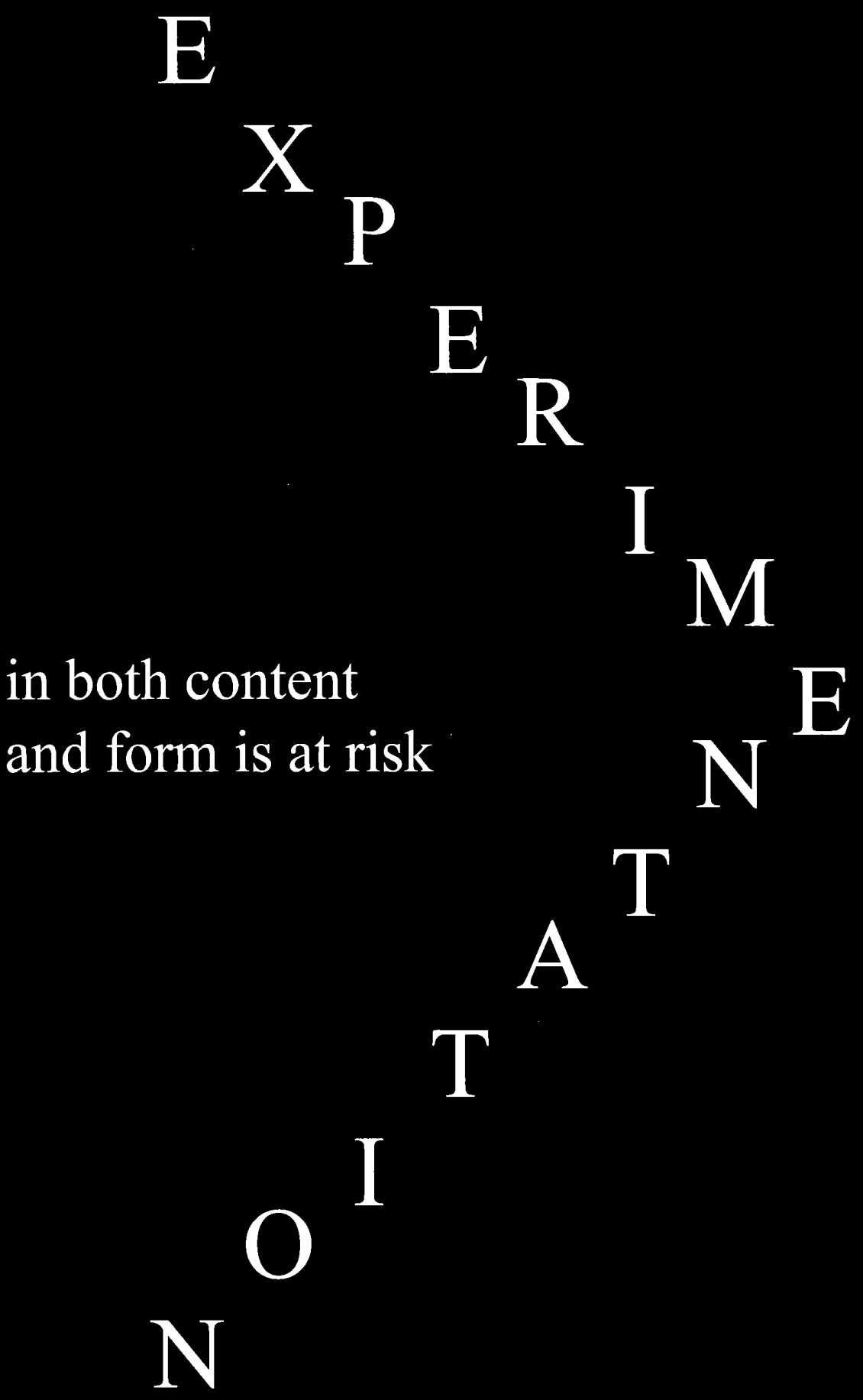
Gordon Hall, statement from interview with Orlando Tirado, 'New Space Education and How It Works', in Tirado, ed., *FLEX* (New York: Kent Fine Art, 2014) 10.

Carlos Motta
We Who Feel Differently: A Manifesto//2012

Build an agenda
based on the needs of
queer minorities
Reject the **politics** of
assimilation, stop begging
for tolerance
Welcome **the celebration of**
sexual and gender diversity
Demand
the transformation of
the system
Truly desacralize
democracy and demoralize
the judiciary

Define our
emotional and sexual
needs on our own terms
Value critical **difference**
instead of false *equality*

Carlos Motta, 'We Who Feel Differently: A Manifesto (2012). Originally produced as a take away poster for the exhibition 'Museum as Hub: Carlos Motta: We Who Feel Differently' (New York: New Museum of Contemporary Art, 2012).



Richard Fung, 'Beyond Domestication', 2013

AGAINST HOMONORMATIVITY

Susan Stryker
Transgender History, Homonormativity and Disciplinarity//2008

The current attention to homonormativity has tended to focus on gay and lesbian social, political and cultural formations and their relationship to a neoliberal politics of multicultural diversity that meshes with the assimilative strategies of transnational capital. Lisa Duggan's *The Twilight of Equality? Neoliberalism, Cultural Politics and the Attack on Democracy* (2003), which describes a 'new homonormativity that does not challenge heterosexist institutions and values, but rather upholds, sustains and seeks inclusion within them', is generally acknowledged as the text through which this term has come into wider currency.[1] There is, however, an older formulation of homonormativity that nevertheless merits retention, one closer in meaning to the 'homo-normative' social codes described in 1998 by Judith Halberstam in *Female Masculinity*, in accordance with which expressions of masculinity in women are as readily disparaged within gender-normative gay and lesbian contexts as within heteronormative ones.[2] It is this earlier sense of homonormativity that is most pertinent to the thoughts I offer here on homonormativity and transgender history, both as an object of scholarly inquiry and as a professional disciplinary practice.

Terminological History

Homonormativity, as I first heard and used the term in the early 1990s, was an attempt to articulate the double sense of marginalization and displacement experienced within transgender political and cultural activism. Like other queer militants, non-transgender gays, lesbians and bisexuals – who contested heterosexist privilege. However, we also needed to name the ways that homosexuality, as a sexual orientation category based on constructions of gender it shared with the dominant culture, sometimes had more in common with the straight world than it did with us.[3]

The grassroots conversations in which I participated in San Francisco in the first half of the 1990s used the term homonormative when discussing the relationship of transgender to queer, and queer to gay and lesbian. Transgender itself was a term then undergoing a significant shift in meaning. Robert Hill, who has been researching the history of heterosexual male cross-dressing communities, found instances in community-based publications of words like transgenderal, transgenderist, and transgenderism dating back to the late 1960s.[4] The logic of those terms, used to describe individuals who lived in one social gender but had a bodily sex conventionally associated with the other, aimed for a conceptual

middle ground between transvestism (merely changing one's clothing) and transsexualism (changing one's sex). By the early 1990s, primarily through the influence of Leslie Feinberg's 1992 pamphlet *Transgender Liberation: A Movement Whose Time Has Come*, transgender was beginning to refer to something else – an imagined political alliance of all possible forms of gender antinormativity. It was in this latter sense that transgender became articulated with queer.[5]

This 'new transgender' marked both a political and generational distinction between older transvestite/transsexual/drag terminologies and an emerging gender politics that was explicitly and self-consciously queer. It began for me in 1992, when the San Francisco chapter of Queer Nation distributed one of its trademark Day-Glo crack-and-peel stickers that read 'Trans Power/Bi Power/ Queer Nation'. The transsexual activist Anne Ogborn encountered someone on the street wearing one of those stickers, but with the words 'Trans Power' torn off. When Ogborn asked if there was any significance to the omission, she was told that the wearer did not consider trans people to be part of the queer movement.[6] Ogborn attended the next Queer Nation general meeting to protest transphobia within the group, whereupon she was invited, in high Queer Nation style, to organize a transgender caucus. As a result, Transgender Nation, of which I was a founding member, came into being as the first explicitly queer transgender social change group in the United States. The group survived the soon-to-be-defunct Queer Nation and became, in its own brief existence from 1992 to 1994, a touchstone in the transgender inclusion debates then raging in San Francisco's emerging Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual and Transgender (LGBT) community.

In a contradictory environment simultaneously welcoming and hostile, transgender activists staked their own claims to queer politics. We argued that sexual orientation was not the only significant way to differ from heteronormativity – that homo, hetero and bi in fact all depended on similar understandings of 'man' and 'woman', which trans problematized. People with trans identities could describe themselves as men and women, too – or resist binary categorization altogether – but in doing either they queered the dominant relationship of sexed body and gendered subject. We drew a distinction between 'orientation queers' and 'gender queers'. Tellingly, gender queer, necessary for naming the minoritized/marginalized position of difference within queer cultural formations more generally, has stuck around as a useful term; orientation queer, naming queer's unstated norm, has seemed redundant in most contexts and has not survived to the same extent.

When San Francisco gays and lesbians who were active in queer politics in the first half of the 1990s were antagonistic to transgender concerns, we accused them of being anti-heteronormative in a homonormative fashion. The term was an intuitive, almost self-evident, back-formation from the ubiquitous heteronomative,

suitable for use where homosexual community norms marginalized other kinds of sex/gender/sexuality difference. Although I do not recall specific instances where the term homonormative was used, or who used it, the general discussions in which the term would have been deployed were playing themselves out in any number of places in which transgender inclusion was being contested: within Queer Nation and ACT-UP and AIDS agencies; at community meetings to organize for the March on Washington in 1993 and the twenty-fifth anniversary of the Stonewall uprising in 1994; at town-hall meetings about gays in the military and domestic partnerships during the hopeful early days of the first Clinton administration; during policy discussions about including gender identity in the proposed federal Employment Non-Discrimination Act; in catfights over who could attend the Michigan Women's Music Festival; at meetings of the Harvey Milk and Alice B. Toklas Democratic Clubs; at Pride Parade meetings; at membership meetings and board meetings of practically every lesbian and gay non-profit organization in the city; at the San Francisco Humans Rights Commission committee on lesbian and gay issues; in flame wars in the letters-to-the-editors columns of the Bay Times and the BAR (Bay Area Reporter); and in coffee shops, bars, dance clubs, dungeon spaces, and bedrooms throughout the city.

The homonormative accusation tended to be levelled against a handful of favourite targets: gays and lesbians who saw transgender issues as entirely distinct from their own and who resisted any sort of transgender participation in queer politics and culture; lesbians who excluded male-to-female transgender people but nervously engaged with female-to-male people, on the grounds that the former were really men and the latter were really women; and, putting a somewhat finer point on the matter, those who conceptualized 'T' as an identity category analogous to 'GLB' and who advocated for a GLBT community on that basis. In the first instance, homonormativity was a threat to a broadly conceived politics of alliance and affinity, regardless of identity; it aimed at securing privilege for gender-normative gays and lesbians based on adherence to dominant cultural constructions of gender, and it diminished the scope of potential resistance to oppression. In the second instance, homonormativity took the shape of lesbian subcultural norms that perversely grounded themselves in reactionary notions of biological determinism as the only legitimate basis of gender identity and paradoxically resisted feminist arguments that 'woman' and 'lesbian' were political rather than ontological categories. The third instance requires a more subtle and expansive explication.

In this case, homonormativity lies in misconstruing trans as either a gender or a sexual orientation. Misconstrued as a distinct gender, trans people are simply considered another kind or type of human than either men or women, which leads to such homonormative attempts at 'transgender inclusion' as

questionnaires and survey instruments within GLBT contexts that offer respondents opportunities for self-identification structured along the lines of

Man ____ Woman ____ Transgender ____ (check one)

Misconstrued as a sexual orientation category, trans appears as a desire, akin to kink and fetish desire, for cross-dressing or (more extremely) genital modification. The 'T' in this version of the LGBT community becomes a group of people who are attracted to one another on the basis of enjoying certain sexual practices – in the same way that gay men are attracted to gay men, and lesbians are attracted to lesbians, on the basis of a shared desire for particular sexual practices. 'T' is thus homonormatively constructed as a properly distinct group of people with a different orientation than gays, lesbians and bisexuals (or, for that matter, straights). In this model of GLBT intracommunity relations, each identity is happily attracted to its own kind and leaves the other groups to their own devices except in ceremonial circumstances (pride parades and other public celebrations of diversity), or when political expediency calls for coalitional action of some sort.

In either homonormative deformation, 'T' becomes a separate category to be appended, through a liberal politics of minority assimilation, to gay, lesbian and bisexual community formations. Trans thus conceived of does not trouble the basis of the other categories – indeed, it becomes a containment mechanism for 'gender trouble' of various sorts that works in tandem with assimilative gender-normative tendencies within the sexual identities. Transgender activism and theory, on the other hand, tend to treat trans as a modality rather than a category. Trans segments the sexual orientations and gender identities in much the same manner as race and class – in other words, a transsexual woman (someone with a transsexual mode of embodiment who lives in the social category woman) can be a lesbian (someone who lives in the social category woman and is sexually oriented toward women), just as a black man could be gay, or a bisexual person could be poor. In doing so, transgender theory and activism call attention to the operations of normativity within and between gender/sexual identity categories, raise questions about the structuration of power along axes other than the homo/hetero and man/woman binaries, and identify productive points of attachment for linking sexual orientation and gender identity activism to other social justice struggles.

A decade before homonormative became a critically chic term elsewhere, I thus suggest, transgender praxis and critique required an articulation of the concept of homonormativity. The border wars that transgender activists fought within queer communities of the 1990s had important consequences for shaping contemporary transgender politics and theorizing, and for charting a future path toward radical activism. Transgender relations to gay and lesbian community formations necessarily became strategic – sometimes oppositional, sometimes aligned, sometimes fighting rearguard actions for inclusion, sometimes

branching out in entirely different and unrelated directions. Central issues for transgender activism – such as gender-appropriate state-issued identification documents that allow trans people to work, cross borders and access social services without exposing themselves to potential discrimination – suggest useful forms of alliance politics, in this instance with migrant workers and diasporic communities, that are not organized around sexual identity. One operation of homonormativity exposed by transgender activism is that homo is not always the most relevant norm against which trans needs to define itself. [...]

1 Lisa Duggan, *The Twilight of Equality? Neoliberalism, Cultural Politics and the Attack on Democracy* (Boston: Beacon, 2003) 50.

2 Judith Halberstam, *Female Masculinity* (Durham, North Carolina: Duke University Press, 1998) 9.

3 I posted an earlier version of these observations on the genealogy of homonormative on qstudy-lL@listserv.buffalo.edu (7 November 2006).

4 Robert Hill, personal communication, 6 October 2005; see also Hill, *A Social History of Heterosexual Transvestism in Cold War America* (PhD diss., University of Michigan at Ann Arbor, 2007).

5 I have made this argument elsewhere; see Stryker, 'The Transgender Issue: An Introduction', *GLQ*, no. 4 (1998) 149–53; 'Transgender Studies: Queer Theory's Evil Twin', *GLQ*, no. 10 (2004) 212–15; and '(De)Subjugated Knowledges: An Introduction to Transgender Studies', in *The Transgender Studies Reader*, ed. Susan Stryker and Stephen Whittle (New York: Routledge, 2006) 4–8. [...]

6 Ann Ogborn, interview by the author, July 5, 1998, Oakland, California.

Susan Stryker, extract from 'Transgender History, Homonormativity and Disciplinarity', *Radical History Review*, no. 100 (Winter 2008) 145–9.

Ron Athey
Split Personality, or So Many Men//1998

Alright, I'm completely out of my mind. Though I didn't inherit my mother's schizophrenia, I suspect I may be a sociopath. I claim to desire consistency and stability, at the same time I can't help but follow my deconstructive nature, abandoning my personal boundaries and comfort zone in the name of fucking with identity. I suppose.

Last month I returned from Italy with a cool but conservative new look. They were having 70 per cent off sales on Dolce & Gabbana, Gucci and Prada, so I stocked up. Since my return, I've been scuffling about in shiny new shoes, button

down shirts, lots of brown and dark blue. Suddenly I'm finding myself shaving every day and spending the weekends lying out in the sun to maintain my Mediterranean tan. Somehow this corresponds with the fact that I've been smoking 2–3 packs of cigarettes a day since the start of that trip – I wasn't smoking when I got on the plane – and have lost 20 pounds, probably as the result of reaching for a cigarette instead of a cookie. I try to justify the smoking by working out at the gym five days a week.

I've had some other behavioural changes as well. Thursday night, in less than a two-hour period, I found myself in two different three-ways where I was getting fucked from behind while sucking dick. Friday for the very first time, I got truly, deeply, thoroughly fist-fucked. (It was amazing.) Wasn't it Jean Genet who said that all writers are bottoms? I don't agree 100 per cent, but this piggy bottom week of mine is taking it to the extreme. But I'm not going to blame writing for my hungry hole, I want to get to the bottom of my current identity crisis.

The whole thing has recently come to a head. For a while now, I've feared that I'm turning into a clone. I've worn nothing but Levis, army boots, tight Tshirts or leather pants and vest for three years. Or if I'm feeling 'costume', I top it off with a cowboy hat, which I really don't have the credentials to be wearing. Writing this now, I'm embarrassed because an image of the Village People just popped into my head. Anyway, after years of each aspect of my appearance being some kind of anti-social or vaguely political statement, I feel desperate to figure how this happened to me. And why I think dressing upwardly mobile is going to fix it.

I start by digging through my photo archive. (I use the term loosely, as there is no rhyme or reason to them, they're sort of shuffled in the top filing drawer of my heavy steel desk.) Must be feeling hypersensitive, because the images freak me out. The bulk of them are from shows, with myself and the cast bleeding. Or after shows (bloodied), laughing over something ridiculous and holding a bouquet of red roses. Sweet. Then I come to the little Ronnie Athey photos, with a Western shirt and feathered hair, turqoise cross around the neck ...

I have to inventory the crisis:

1961–1976. I was raised to be a minister, went to very white trash Pentecostal revivals all over Southern California, and dressed appropriately. Big hair, tight pants, platform shoes, very Elvis in a way. It naturally evolved into a more glam look: jumpsuits, light natural make-up, frosted hair. Somehow when I rejected god, I went the cholo route: slicked back hair, white undershirt and Dickies with a crease. For a few minutes, anyway.

1977–1981. Started going to discos, Ginos II and Robbies, and needed a new look. Pleated Italian pants, gauze shirts, double belts, and bigger blonder hair did the trick. Luckily New Wave/Punk (I didn't know the difference at first) came along quickly, and I developed my own look: choppy, close-cropped hair, dyed

either black, blue, or white, ripped up-shirts, safety pins in the ear, and ridiculously shaped dark sunglasses. Although this is a little hard for me to admit, next up was Goth: big teased black hair, too much eyeliner, red or black lipstick, and whiteface – and of course, all black clothes.

Got a job at the now defunct Melrose Avenue Punk Store, Poseur, and became an Oi! posterboy: coloured liberty spikes, bondage pants, FTW (or the equivalent) T-shirts, and Doc Martens in every style. Met Edward, got a Nazi youth haircut, wore military uniforms, then skinned it off. As a skin, I wore bleach splattered jeans, skinny red suspenders, and tattooed my face some more.

1985–1987. Found a boyfriend with money, grew my hair a medium length, dyed it black, and wore it slicked straight back. Dressed in oversized Yohji Yamamoto shirts and wore diamond rings, acquired bronze skin in the Yucatan. Also got fat for the first time, and the shirts got bigger. Stopped taking drugs and freaked out. Went the regular guy route, was plump with a bob for awhile until I realized I looked like Buster Brown, and shaved it again. Also did a few marine cuts. Started working out, running, trimmed down. Tried suave-lite, but mostly man-on-the-street.

1990s. Club Fuck started in Silverlake, and I became a go-go dancer. At one point I was dancing at three clubs a week. I worked a kinky half-naked look all the time, wearing latex chaps with my ass hanging out to parties, art openings, dinner, sometimes with a matching butt plug. I also started up my performances again after a ten year hiatus, and went for it. Maybe this is where the split happened.

On stage I became a nun, St Sebastian, Christ, a kinky Nazi, a house painter, a factory worker, a nurse, a eunuch and a Butoh dancer painted grey. Also a Victorian Woman, a fertility goddess (too complicated to go into), and sometimes even myself. During the day I wore dirty gym clothes or ill-fitting Levis.

On tour I started wearing second-hand suits, sometimes mixed with my leather gear. A few years have gone by, and I realize how much I've neglected my appearance, having tipped the scales at 205 pounds a few months back! I'm 5'10" with a large frame, but I was fat. Fat with a million excuses: I work too much, I don't have time to work out enough, I love food! I'm stressed, I'm disconnected from my body.

So where am I now? Is it possible to be a butch man who dresses sharp for work and social engagements? And still wear leather/uniforms/latex? Not to mention doing frightening drag characters on stage? To disagree with RuPaul, I don't consider it all drag. At one time all of these trappings have been brought on by, or stood for, something or other. Environment, belonging, rebellion, campy morbidity, sexual identity, desirability and fetishism. A desire to be just another normal guy. Sometimes in a more compromising way, for manipulating my image in PR, or business situations.

I suppose it all goes back to my manifesto: Nothing is pure. I am many things, but my ambiguity, my inability to land, continues. Beyond myself, identity has become tricky in general. Popular culture and fashion has no shame these days. Is that a real gangbanger? Do dreads signify reggae? Are shaved-heads Neo-nazi skinheads? Do those people sporting kinkwear practice SM? Is that butch-looking daddy a top? Not necessarily and probably not. Everything underground has been subverted, or at the very least diluted.

Anyway, I'm in my mid 30s and I don't want to expend my energy following trends. Besides, I find the notion of aging into a salty old dog quite appealing. But now that everything radical means nothing, I'm at a crossroads, the battle is no longer public, it's inside my head. I'm still wearing leather and dirty Levis, and for the meantime, will continue to experiment with Neo-conservative chic. But given my history and the nature of my art, I have to face up to the fact that, no matter what, I am never going be a regular Joe.

Ron Athey, 'Split Personality, or So Many Men', *Honcho* (January 1998) 65–6.

Catherine Opie
In Conversation with Douglas Crimp//2008

Catherine Opie [...] One of the things that always interests me in making art is the relation of the personal to the political. When I was a student at CalArts my professors kept asking me why I didn't make queer work, and I would always respond, 'Why isn't Master Planned Communities queer work?' This conversation has continued throughout my career, and I go back and forth about it in relation to different bodies of work. When I made *Self-Portrait Cutting*, I had started the portrait series, and had also experienced my first real break-up of a domestic relationship. I kept making drawings about this on a pad of paper for a year, and then I knew that I wanted it to be a cutting on my back. Since the early 1980s, and more occasionally now, I have been very much a part of the leather community in San Francisco. Cutting was something I would do in dungeon play or with friends, but I hadn't made images of myself doing it. For a year, I wanted to make a photograph that was about this drawing. The drawing is a child's image of mom and dad, but in this case it's a mom and mom. What is domesticity? How do we seek domesticity? Being queer, am I allowed to have a family? My mom would say, 'You can't have kids because you're a lesbian.' And I'd say, 'Why not? Why

can't I have kids?' And so this was the beginning of the idea of domesticity that I wanted to explore. I had an artist do the cutting, because I wanted it to be done, not by somebody from my S/M community who really knew what they were doing, but to be tentative, not to leave a permanent scar. So Judie Bamber did the cutting. It was the first time she had ever done anything like that.

Douglas Crimp The desire to say, 'Why can't I too have a family?' or to prove, 'I too am interested in family' by making a cutting on your back is wonderfully perverse.

Opie I suppose so. When I was making this work, I never thought about it as perverse. I always thought about it in relationship to my body, about pushing my limits, and also about the incredible control that goes into it. It's a very innocent image, even though it's cut into my back. It's two stick-figure girls with a little bleeding house, a sun coming from behind a cloud, and two birds. What isn't innocent is the attitude in American culture, especially right now, that seeks to deny me permission to have a family. To me, more perverse than the cutting in my back are the limitations placed on people because of homosexuality and so-called perversity.

I tried to bring these two ideas together in the photograph, but it's usually read simply as perverse. I don't think that the other complicated ideas that I was trying to explore while making it get included in the discussion.

Crimp I want to push you a bit here. Houses don't normally bleed in children's drawings. And children's drawings are not normally cut into bodies, so it's hard for me to see this as innocent. It's not that I want a 'normal' image; quite the contrary. The power of this picture is precisely its crossing of what is normal – the stick figures, the family, the house – with what is abnormal, if we can use that term ...

Opie A term I hate.

Crimp You've made an image of 'family values' by resorting to a technique associated with an outré sexual practice. As I said, I find it wonderfully perverse. Let's look at *Pervert*.

Opie *Pervert* was always a harder image for me. Collectors have told me, 'We have *Pervert* in our bedroom', and I think, 'Okay, you're more perverted than me – it's me who actually had "pervert" carved on her chest.' I made it at a time when I was really angry with the direction of gay and lesbian politics in America, and my anger was exactly about questions of normal and abnormal. At the march on Washington for lesbian and gay rights in 1993, we were suddenly all supposed

to appear normal. 'Don't include the leather community because they're abnormal.' It created a huge division in the gay community. *Pervert* was my response. Hans Holbein was an important influence for the early portrait series. *Pervert* is my Henry VIII. It's like I'm a warrior king, and I'm going to carry on the cause of being a pervert, and I'm going to make it very elegant. [...]

Catherine Opie and Douglas Crimp, in conversation (2008), in John Welchman, ed., *The Aesthetics of Risk* (Zurich: JRP/Ringier, 2008) 299–313.

niv Acosta
Thoughts (on *Blues*)//2013

When initially asked to write a response to being in the project *Blues* with Deborah Hay, I was excited finally to put a voice to my experience and be published in the *PJ* [*Performance Journal*]. As time passed, the aftermath of being in this project (panels, internal group discussions, random confrontations with the audience members who had experienced the work live, conversations with loved ones about the emotional stress, etc.) began to leave me feeling overwhelmed and burnt out from being one of very few voices speaking of my experience and feeling like a 'spokesperson', on behalf of the 'black cast'.

Being in *Blues* was disenchanting to say the least. Getting to know the real political views of those established artists who I've admired throughout the years wasn't and hasn't been surprising; it was disappointing. I have hoped that inside of a culture/form of art that uses bodies as a medium, discussions surrounding racialized casting, gender and race hierarchy as well as diverse movement abilities would be less archaic. My experience of disappointment is not exclusive to *Blues*. Often I have felt like a spokesperson for many marginal/subversive identities I am a part of. As a queer transgender person of colour, I feel speaking of my experiences is a crucial part of my creative process and persona in the dance community.

I acknowledge my privilege as someone born in the late 1980s and being able to reap the benefits of racially integrated life, educational and professional opportunities – handed to me with/without consideration to my race – I can be 'gay in america', can choose physically to transition from female to male, and I can vote. Despite all of these socio-political achievements, I know that we still have a long way to go in making space for people like me, people who should be heard and equally considered.

From my point of view, the collective POC (people of colour) experience is not advocated for in politics, art and the everyday. I think this lack of visibility is the element I relate to the most in my experiences as a member of the dance community. I know that 'being seen' is something everyone has to be creative about, but it is evident that the black/POC experience is often invisiblized, marginalized or reduced to tokenism. The effect is often to make people of colour more likely to struggle, be more resilient through failure or from being pigeonholed into a reductive category. My own history of growing up in virtual poverty, a mother dealing with HIV and being raised in and out of foster care informs how I interact with cultural aspects of dance.

The work I create is a part of my activism toward creating more space for people who identify similarly to me. I feel sensitive to the experiences of those who came before me who have experienced similar prejudices. What does it mean that Rudy Perez is the only person of colour that I know who was a member of Judson Dance Theater? And why did I only learn about his involvement in this 'radical' movement a few months ago? Also, why, in my college courses, did we not learn about Ishmael Houston-Jones, Dean Moss, Bebe Miller, Carmen de Lavallade or Katherine Dunham? Within this question lies my interest in exploring those histories. I would like to continue making space for myself and others as people of colour, and more importantly as people contributing equally rich work.

I would like to contribute to an era where asking your director to address their racial naiveté isn't taboo or disrespectful. An era in which working environments remain sites for learning and evolving regardless of positions such as director/collaborator/performer, etc., not environments that undermine the feelings of their participants, that silence those who are socialized to be silent and thereby perpetuate more violence and anger. I want to be a part of a space where the director isn't clueless as to how the people they are entrusting to carry their vision are reacting to the work. I want to be in places where we acknowledge our individual privilege wherever it exists.

It is devastating where the 'dance community' is on the topic of race, among other things – gender, economy, diverse physical ability, etc.

I feel like I'm still seeing the same shit everywhere. All white casts. Or a show fully stocked with white choreographers. Theatricalized heteronormative pairings. Work unaware of its racial subtext.

It sucks that I still feel responsible for educating people on their lack of awareness.

I will implicate myself in being guilty of not educating myself thoroughly enough on many issues. So really this is our problem, all of us.

I don't need anyone to make me feel safe. I don't expect it. I'm used to fending for myself and making space, fighting. I'm just really fucking exhausted, my

blood, histories and lineage are exhausted. It's time we take more accountability.

Identifying for yourself how discrimination feels is more difficult these days, almost indescribable.

niv Acosta, 'Thoughts (on *Blues*)', *Performance Journal*, no. 42 (Movement Research, 2013) 6.

Wu Tsang
In order to fall apart as human beings, we need first to be able to live//2011

tomorrow night is the official live presentation of *full body quotation* at new museum, but tonight we are performing at a private 'friendraiser' for the museum's triennial. it's not an explicit fundraiser, but the purpose of the event is to develop the long term investment of young affluent/influential patrons. i've been worrying about participating in this event for a while ... especially in light of the Abramovic stunt at MOCA Gala last week ... and generally thinking about the role that performance artists often play in these situations, as being complicit 'entertainment' jesters for elite patronage of museums.

i continue to struggle with figuring out a smart way to respond. one way would be to just not perform – but then i miss an opportunity to dialogue with the thing i wanna critique. another obvious impulse would be some FUCK THE 1 per cent gesture, but that so often plays right into the expectations of the audience, that you become this 'transgressive' queer freaky artist. my friend alex (of my barbarian) warned me they love it when you bite their hand that feeds you ...

ironically enough, my performance is about the film *Paris is Burning*. i may have been alluding to that for months now, but the context now demands it be more explicit. because when i look at that photo above (which was taken in the sky room, the event space at the new museum) i see an image equivalent to paris is burning, and a metaphor for the way that film (and things like it) function for mainstream audiences – to like capture and placate their fantasy of queer/poor/poc self-expression. (and i mean the IMAGE not necessarily the content, but how it gets used as certain kind of marketing etc ...) i could go on for days about the nuances, but basically this work is about exploitation. not like in a judgmental way, but like a rubiks-cube way, like these are all the sides to the problem – there is no easy solution. and there are SO MANY ways it can go wrong ... it's a really tight spot.

so the solution i came up with is to make this statement at the beginning of the piece, and also to share the source material.

this is the statement (well maybe it won't be these exact words, but this sentiment):

Dear Audience,
Tonight's performance features all misappropriated material. We are channelling voices of people involved in the making of the film *Paris is Burning* twenty years ago. Originally I wanted to keep this source secret because I didn't want you to take these voices for granted as being 'authentic'. But the site of this performance (i.e. a party at the New Museum, Performa, downtown Manhattan, etc.) is not necessarily a safe space for all the communities referenced in this work. If you wanna witness this; please first recognize that we exist. In order to fall apart as complex beings, we need first to be able to live. [...]

Wu Tsang, retitled extract from untitled blog post (18 November 2011). (www.wildnessmovie.com)

Karol Radziszewski
To push young people in Warsaw to just do it themselves//2014

Homosexuality in Poland is a heated issue. The country is very conservative, with more than ninety percent of Poles declaring they're Catholic. Every Sunday, the priests in the churches teach that gay people are devils, which influences the political situation. In 2005 there was even a proposition preventing gay people from being school teachers. It was then that I decided that I had to do something, so I started *DIK Fagazine*, which is the only artistic magazine from Central and Eastern Europe concentrated on homosexuality and masculinity.

When I founded the magazine, I was already interested in the idea of artists working in public spaces, through interventions and so on, because I'd co-founded a guerrilla artist group called Szu Szu as a student at the Academy of Fine Arts. The idea was that we wanted to take art out of Warsaw's galleries and into the city, so we made a lot of actions and exhibitions in a surprising places. *DIK Fagazine* started small and grew; in the last issue we travelled around Eastern Europe covering different themes relating to gay life before the fall of communism: you have cruising areas described from the Serbian perspective, gay beaches in

Estonia, the first gay zine from Gdansk. The same year that I started the magazine I staged the first openly gay exhibition in a private flat in Warsaw, a manifesto of sorts. I made prints, photographs, wallpapers, murals, videos, the magazine, just so it was done. I could move with more sophisticated issues, not just related to basic topics surrounding what it means to be gay.

However, society has changed in the ten years since I started *DIK Fagazine*, but there's still a lot of homophobia. In the beginning, I couldn't find any gay photographers, so I asked straight photographers to take the pictures. It was funny to watch the straight guys in Poland trying to work out how a gay photo session should look. Sometimes my projects were too provocative for the gay community, even. People thought I was portraying a bad image, so there were times when I was against both the conservatives and the gay community.

Last year, my studio burnt down and everything was destroyed: my paintings, my work and very sadly, my entire *DIK Fagazine* archive. I only have these copies because I went around and got them back from the bookstores. Nobody knows what happened but there are rumours that there was a real estate developer. Some of my friends thought it was because of my work but I didn't think that way; still, it really made me realize what people thought about the situation! I get a lot of emails of course, my last video piece is me reading the letter from a guy praying for me. What's more, Poland is very sex-phobic – we haven't had the sexual revolution here. I still find it hard to get a model to be naked for the photographs. Adding queer issues on top of that? We just had a long discussion in the Polish parliament about the notion of 'gender'. It's crazy, they're manipulating the words so 'gender' issues pop up in relation to, say, paedophilia and the sexualization of children. As for the *Fagazine*, I always saw the word 'queer' connected almost only with university studies, and that's why I use the Polish words. Words like 'Pedal', which is very offensive, like 'faggot'. We're trying to provoke; to put queer politics into practice.

Some people ask me if there's a common experience between those who grew up under communism. I was born in 1980 and I actually think that the beginning of capitalism is a much more significant experience for my generation. The way that people started to believe in capitalism influenced everybody so much that we've lost the ability to think about it critically. It's influenced everything: the fashion, the clubs, the cafés. Young people dress quite fancy in Warsaw but not because they want to express themselves. Rather, there's a pressure that they have to show off. Five years ago, we had Europride gay parade here, and that was a crucial moment for me, because it made me realize there was no queer underground. Europride is a kind of gay pride colonization that's supposed to bring the rainbow flag from Western countries to Poland. Suddenly the parties were just for gay men, and the tickets were super expensive. The

main conference was about pink money – the purchasing power of the exclusive gay community. So we said, 'Fuck off!' A group of us gathered in my flat, queer people from left to right, and we came up with the idea of creating an independent festival called Pomada. We put on one of the first parties, which was totally fifty-fifty girls and boys and more than a thousand people came. In June will be the fifth edition. The central idea is that all of the organizers who work in art, music and culture would put our own money into it so that it would be completely DIY. Ultimately, this is really what we are trying to do: to push young people in Warsaw to just do it themselves.

Karol Radziszewski, statements from interview with Louise Brailey and A.J. Samuels, originally titled 'If you don't know about Karol Radziszewski's DIK Fagazine, you should', *Electronic Beats Magazine* (20 August 2014). (www.electronicbeats.net)

Paul B. Preciado
Videopenetration//2005

I'd rather go blind than to see you walk away.
– Etta James

8.35 p.m. Your spirit comes through the window and darkens the room. I turn on all the lights. Put a blank cassette in the video camera and screw the camera to the tripod. I check the framing. The image is smooth and symmetrical; the black leather couch forms a horizontal line at the bottom of the frame. The white wall easily follows that line, but without creating any feeling of volume or relief. Play. I move to the sofa. Off camera, on the coffee table, I've left electric clippers, a small mirror, a sheet of white paper, a plastic bag, a bottle of hypoallergenic glue for use on the face, a dose of fifty milligrams of testosterone in gel form, a tube of lubricant, anal-dilator gel, a harness with a realistic rubber dildo (9 1/2 x 1 1/2 in.), a realistic black silicone dildo (9 1/2 x 2 1/2 in.), a black ergonomic one (5 1/2 x 3/4 in.), a razor and shaving cream, a plastic basin filled with water, a white towel, and one of your books, the first, the sublime one, the beginning and end of everything. I walk into the frame. Get undressed, but not completely. Keep my black tank top on. As if for surgery, I expose only those organs on which the instruments will be working. I stand the mirror up on the table. I plug in the electric clippers. A sharp, high-pitched sound, the voice of a cyberchild trying to get out of the motor, spitting

in the face of the past. I adjust the blades of the comb to a width of one centimeter. Your spirit sends me a discrete sound of approval. I sit on the couch, and one half of my face – looking expressionless, centreless – appears in the mirror: my short black hair; contact lenses, whose edges create a thin halo around the iris; patchy skin; very white in places and flecked with bright pink in others. I was labelled a woman, but that's imperceptible in the partial image reflected in the mirror. I begin shaving my head, starting at the front and moving backward, then from the middle toward the left, then toward the right. I bend forward so that the locks drop onto the table. I open the plastic bag and slide the hair into it. Turn off the machine and adjust the comb to zero. I place a sheet of white paper on the table, then turn the clippers back on and move them again over my entire head. Short, very thin hairs rain onto the white paper. When my head is completely smooth, I unplug the machine. I fold the sheet of paper in two, so that the hairs collect at the centre, forming a uniform line. A line of black cocaine. I'm doing up a line of hair. It's almost the same high. I open the jar of glue and add a streak of it above my upper lip with the moistened brush, then take a strand of hair between my fingers and set it along the streak of glue until it sticks perfectly to the skin of my face. A fag's moustache. I check myself out in the mirror. My eyes have the same halo around the iris. Same face, skin. Identical yet unrecognizable. I look into the camera, curl back my lip to show my teeth, the way you do it. It's your gesture.

The silver package containing a fifty-milligram dose of testosterone in gel form is the same size as a small packet of sugar. I rip into the aluminum-coated paper; out comes a thin, cold, transparent gel that disappears immediately into the skin of my left shoulder. A cool vapour remains, like a memory of icy breath, the kiss of a snow woman.

I shake the can of shaving cream, deposit a ball of expanding white lather on my palm, then cover the hairs of my pubes, the lips of my vulva and the skin surrounding my anus with it. I dip the blade in water and begin to shave. Hairs and cream float to the surface. A few splashes fall onto the couch or the floor. This time I don't cut myself. When all the skin on my crotch has been shaved, I rinse off and dry. Slip on the harness and buckle the straps at the side of each hip. In front of me, the dildo is super erect, forming a right angle with the line of my vertebral column. The dildo belt is high enough to allow me to see two very distinct orifices when I bend down.

I coat my hands with transparent gel and pick up the two dildos. I rub, lubricate, warm them, one in each hand, then one against the other, like two giant cocks twisting against each other in a gay porn film. I know the camera is filming because I can see the red light blinking. I dangle my silicone cock over the paragraphs tattooed across the pages of *Dans ma chambre*.[1] It's your gesture. The dildo conceals part of the page, creating a barrier that allows certain words to be read and hides

others: 'We laughed. He went with me in the car. I looked at him. His hand signalled me before / night fell. I know that I would have had to / I'll never be in love with him. But how wonderful it was that he loved me. It was good.'[2]

Next I slide the dildos into the openings at the lower part of my body. First, the realistic-looking one, then the ergonomic one, which goes into my anus. It's always easier for me to put something into my anus, which is a multidimensional space without any bony edges. This time, it's the same. On my knees, I turn my back to the camera, the tips of my feet and my head pressing against the floor, and hold my arms behind me so that they can manage the two dildos in my orifices.

You're the only one who could read this book. In front of this camera, 'for the first time I'm tempted to make a self-portrait for you.'[3] Design an image of myself as if I were you. *Do you in drag.* Cross-dress into you. Bring you back to life with this image.

From this moment on, all of you are dead. Amelia, Hervé, Michel, Karen, Jackie, Teo and You. Do I belong more to your world than I do to the world of the living? Isn't my politics yours; my house, my body, yours? Reincarnate yourselves in me, take over my body like extraterrestrials took over Americans and changed them into living sheaths. Reincarnate yourself in me; possess my tongue, arms, sex organs, dildos, blood, molecules; possess my girlfriend, dog; inhabit me, live in me. Come. *Ven.* Please don't leave. *Vuelve a la vida.* Come back to life. Hold on to my sex. Low, down, dirty. Stay with me.

This book has no other reason for being outside the margin of uncertainty existing between me and my sex organs, all imaginary, between three languages that don't belong to me, between the alive you and the dead you, between my desire to carry on your line and the impossibility of restoring your sperm, between your eternal and silent books and the flood of words that are in a hurry to come out of my fingers, between testosterone and my body, between V and my love for V. Looking into the camera again: 'This testosterone is for you, this pleasure is for you.'

I don't watch the mini-DV I just filmed. I don't even number it. I put it into its transparent red case and write on the label:

3 October 2005. DAY OF YOUR DEATH.

1 [footnote 3 in source] In *My Room*, the first novel of French gay writer Guillaume Dustan.

2 [4] Guillaume Dustan, *Nicolas Pages* (Paris: Balland) 155.

3 [5] Hervé Guibert, *L'Image fantôme* (Paris: Editions de Minuit, 1981) 5.

[Paul] B. Preciado, 'Videopenetration' (2005), in *Testo Junkie: Sex, Drugs and Biopolitics in the Pharmacopornographic Era*, trans. Bruce Benderson (New York: The Feminist Press, 2013) 16–20.

Malik Gaines
A Defence of Marriage Act: Notes on the Social Performance of Queer Ambivalence//2013

[...] Ambivalence has been discussed of late as a useful model for managing a matrix of positions, rather than as simply an abdication of positionality. The term helps us think beyond binary structures, and about multiple ways of being that can and must be negotiated and renegotiated provisionally, all the time. In relation to heteronormativity, queerness is already an ambivalent position, and one made of differences. The queer subject cannot be constituted in any ontological sense. Imagine the queer people you know and try to arrange them into a unity and you may find, as I do, that none exists. Queer is everything that's not heteronormative. 'Not this' or 'not that' is no way to define being, particularly in the Western philosophical tradition that brought us the idea of the individual autonomous subject in the first place.

In other writing, drawing on histories of African American cultural production, looking at expressive forms that also derive from a prohibited subject position, I have thought about the experience of subjectivity as a more dynamic opportunity for action than the mode of agency attributed to subjecthood. 'The subject' – of law, of grammar, of human rights, the consumer, the citizen – is a universalized yet restrictive formation that is fulfilled by objects. In the black tradition, objecthood has been a more pervasive experience than subjecthood. On the other hand, everyone has access to subjectivity and some ability to express its terms. Remembering that these histories are different, but considering the ways that civil rights struggles attempt to gain access to agency, and following contours of the public discussion, it's instructive to look at what blackness and queerness share. In both, one can appreciate the ways that daring people have taken terms shaped around exclusion and produced from them multiple positions from which to act. These positions are mobilized not by a universal notion of being, but from the bottom up, built from experience.

Same-sex marriage is experienced and expressed differently depending on one's position: hedge fund guys, working-class moms, weirdos in love, gay middle managers, those in practical need of health insurance, immigration status, and so forth. With all of these different experiences in mind, it becomes necessary to complicate the antagonism between normative/radical, centre/margin, culture/counterculture. In each of those formations, the second term is instigated by the prior term. The prior term is in fact structured around, mobilized by, dependent on its supposed opposite. To be named, heteronormativity must exist in relation to a defined abnormal object, while the subjective experience of

queerness is rather flexible and less easily defined. Queerness can mean being more than one thing at a time, can be ambivalent, and is productively understood as a collection of simultaneous differences. In this sense, valuing the ambivalence of subjectivity is a way to imagine beyond rational binary formations that always use a subject to put an object in its place. All of this is to reiterate that the radical queer critique of same-sex marriage misses some of the point of what's valuable in breaking oppressive dominant terms into little queer pieces. [...]

Malik Gaines, 'A Defence of Marriage Act: Notes on the Social Performance of Queer Ambivalence', *e–flux*, no. 44 (April 2013). (www.e-flux.com)

Danh Vo
In Conversation with Adam Carr//2007

Adam Carr The first time I encountered your work was through 'Not a Drop but the Fall', a solo exhibition held at Galerie Klosterfelde in Berlin in 2005. With this project you seemed to break some rules and push some boundaries that both the art world and this world in general seem to impose. Since I have heard various conflicting stories, rumours and accounts with regard to this show, I would be interested to hear your take on the events. I believe the project involved some stealing on your behalf – both metaphorically and literally. What happened?

Danh Vo Check out my gayromeo profile 'Danhvo', there you will find some explanations for why I am single. But it's really not because I'm unsentimental ... I mean, *McCabe and Mrs Miller* by Robert Altman is one of my favourite love stories. My kind of romance is just like the rest of my way of living, based on what I consider a certain refined complexity and what others might label as fuck-ups.

When Michael Elmgreen and Ingar Dragset had the opening of the closed Prada shop in Marfa, Texas, I really wanted to join them. But I was broke and didn't have the money to travel to the desert of Texas. Therefore I decided to use their names and signatures without them knowing about it, to make a fake application to the Danish Arts Council. I applied for money to have a photographer and a photographer's assistant go to the opening and make visual documentation of this remotely located art project by Michael and Ingar.

The Arts Council approved the application, since they thought it was written by this more 'famous' artist duo, and money was given to the project. A friend of

mine who is a photographer went there, and I went along as her assistant. For the show at Klosterfelde I wanted to present a photo of the shop and another photo of me with Michael, who was my boyfriend at the time, kissing under the dark sky of Marfa. In addition to these snaps I wanted to present the public documents showing my fake application.

I never considered this presentation to be breaking any rules, I mean, I'm a chicken, and I was feeling very safe because Michael was my boyfriend. I was using his signature in order to invent a reality for a bureaucratic system, and then I tried to construct this reality parallel to my private interest. It's a very common strategy of low-class refugees – something that has been part of my education and upbringing. If you live on the edge of society, your moral perspective is of course slightly different from the one you have when you belong to a fully integrated white middle class.

Carr When did Elmgreen & Dragset become aware of this duplication? Was it important that it remained secret up until the opening of the exhibition in Berlin?

Vo Yes it was urgent for me that it wasn't a collaboration. I didn't want to have the role of being a sucker on their status as more established artists. I wanted to be a hacker, a friendly hacker. I didn't want to get them involved in the project before the opening of the show.

To scam the Arts Council or my boyfriend was not arbitrary. I wanted to blow the codes for what was seemingly right and wrong, I wanted to not give a fuck about the conventional views on privacy and authorship and relationship, and I wanted to take the risk of ending up in this beautiful mess, where trust was all that would be left.

Carr The idea of operating within a system only to alter and deconstruct its mechanics that you just mentioned is exemplified in an earlier and ongoing work of yours, *Vo Rocasco Rasmussen* (2003–), which results in a perpetual extension of your surname. Your work seems to be a recurrent questioning of the nation-state, the absurdity of rules and non-rules in a so-called liberal society and, by addressing issues of sovereignty, this piece relates particularly to your own personal history and identity. This issue seems to be the underlying principle of your practice. Could you elaborate on it?

Vo When I pity myself I tend to call myself a refugee, but in reality I'm no longer sure what it means. I was a boat refugee when I was four, but I'm pretty dry now. The thing I'm sure of is that I really understand the innovative ways in which some refugees operate on their own premises, but that might be my own

romantic projection. I can't really appoint myself a spokesman for other refugees. I'm an artist and I'm gay and I might have some perceptions of my 'parasitic' role that are quite off compared to many other refugees.

All my projects tend to deal with issues that are taking place right around me – my private sphere, my love life, my desires, other people's projections on me and my identities. It's all in there. My ideas derive from how I experience various miscommunications between who I am and how the outside world looks at me. The projects are like throwing in various clothing items into a washing machine that doesn't stop working. Sometimes you throw in a pair of red socks and what happens is that these socks dye all the white shirts. For me marriage has always been a hangover from the past. I don't want to be a part of it and I don't want to fight it. I want to reconstruct the meaning of it so it makes sense to me. And my continuously extended last name is making the custom officers very confused, which is a nice side effect in itself.

I started the project when I was still studying at the academy in Copenhagen – a place were there is no reason to produce more traditional art crap – and I wanted to use the marriage institution to marry people that had been important to me, but I wanted to get divorced again immediately because I have another agenda. I only wanted their names. I'm not interested in any given rights because most rights turn out to be repressive after a short while. I'm only interested in amending my name by having their last name as memories. I can take the name with me, a name that has been produced by the very institution that previously wanted to exclude me. It's a kind of revenge, a soft-core revenge. [...]

Danh Vo and Adam Carr, extract from interview, *Afterall online* (9 August 2007) (www.afterall.org)

Ryan Conrad and Braden Scott
Does This Bother You? Well, It Bothers Us ... //2014

This text was originally published under the parodic pseudonyms Jean Marois and Pauline Charest.

While we appreciate the underlying motivations of the Quebec government's anti-homophobia campaign, we can't help but be angry about its many failures. We are unimpressed by the erasure of queer and trans difference through normative claims of being 'just like straight people' – apparently the reason for

which we are worth being treated like humans – in addition to the huge waste of government funding on an advertising campaign that is unconvincing to anyone not already mildly tolerant of us queers.

Really? A whole multi-media ad campaign to make us look just as boring as straight people: raising children, pursuing respectable middle-class careers, performing proper gender roles, and buying overpriced produce? As if. Straights aren't scared of us or hate us because we politely play by their social rules. They're terrified of us because we like to fuck in ways they only wish they could. It's not middle-class, respectable, monogamous, marriage-bound gay couples that terrify even the most liberal, but our ability to enjoy having friends we fuck, fucking in public, fucking in groups, fucking for cash, fucking all genders and sexes, and fucking like we don't give a fuck or fucking with love and compassion.

Millions of dollars wasted on the largest corporate marketing firm in Canada – meanwhile, queer and trans people are under attack, make no mistake. Provincial and federal governments are ramping up criminalization of HIV, sex workers are still fighting for adequate working conditions while provincial police continue to raid our bars, trans people still face some of the most stringent provincial policies in their struggle for gender self-determination on identification papers, high school students get no sex education whatsoever, and queer immigrants and refugees face stricter and more regressive immigration reforms. In the age of never ending austerity, we would rather see this money spent supporting queer and trans organizations doing the work that actually supports our community and educates the straights about how we are wonderfully different and NOT just like you.

Ryan Conrad and Braden Scott, 'Does This Bother You? – Well, It Bothers Us ...', in *Est-ce que ça vous dérange? / Does this bother you* (Montreal: Rats 9 Gallery, 2014) 5.

Vaginal Davis
Twee & Sympathy: A Manifesto//2013

The tyranny of the bed.
It's counterrevolutionary.
The bedroom is the last stronghold of the bourgeoisie.
Sexuality is a force of nature that cannot be contained by a mattress or a sheet.
To all you young men out there:

You're virile! Athletic! Men at the peak of your physical and mental prowess!
You are vigorous, urban gorillas in the mist.
Take sex out of the bedroom and put it in the street where it belongs.
Don't resign yourself to social and sexual *misery*.
Do not deprive youth of the sweet electricity of public sex.
Down with all institutions that have made and sustained capitalism and the capitalist class system that has oppressed and exploited all of the people of our history.
Death to the fascist insect that preys upon the life of the People.
Make revolutionary love not imperialistic war.
Western democracy only presents the illusion of freedom.
Private property can't be stolen – just liberated! So, feel free to shoplift with impunity.
Bourgeois marriage is nothing but licenced prostitution.
I don't want or need a pimp!
Don't question authority.
Eradicate it!
We could concern ourselves with geopolitics and imperialism and the various wars always raging around the world, but that would be addressing the symptom not the cause of the global disease.
Our first priority must be: Liberate the world from its sexual repression.
Personal liberation over political agitation.
And, please, give up your bourgeois fixation on monogamy and fidelity.
Let go of petty, emotional attachments.
Do not become distracted by selfish, ego-driven monogamy.
I've also realized that I am *done* with the conventional penises and from now on I will only dabble with environmentally friendly ones.
They are the future in penile terms.
Also, how useless are dogs?
You can't even do anything with their milk.

Vaginal Davis, 'Twee & Sympathy: A Manifesto' (2013), transcribed statements from video interview with David J. Getsy, *Art and Artists: Vaginal Davis*, School of the Art Institute of Chicago, 1 May 2013 (Video Data Bank). Amended by Vaginal Davis, 4 December 2014.

fierce pussy
Interview//2009

We don't see public space as neutral or abstract. We take queerness out of the 'abstract' and enact a queer conversation out in public. Historically, public space has held a contradiction for queer people; on the one hand we have been invisible and on the other hand we are frequently the target of violence in public. Part of the impulse in making this work has been to let other queer people know that we are here, that queer people are everywhere – simply put, we make ourselves visible.

How do you see your work in relation to the idea of 'queer space' in the city?

From the beginning, fierce pussy cut to the chase. Rather than taking on the critique of mass media, homophobia and the male gaze, we announced ourselves as lesbians and directly addressed other lesbians walking those same streets. Our first poster project, the lists: *I AM A ... AND PROUD* speaks in the first person. Here we not only reclaim this derogatory language, we name ourselves and provide a position for the viewer to do the same.

In *gutter*, we take as raw material lesbian pulp fiction novels from the 1940s through the 70s, which were not necessarily written by lesbians. It is often through the act of reading that young people first find possible reflections of their identity. From the first time one looks up the word 'lesbian' in the dictionary, the pages of books provide a safe and secret space to explore one's fantasies, desire and identity. We turn that private act inside out and invert the experience by taking private 'queer' reading, and turning it public. We redact the text to arrive at a more satisfying narrative. The tropes of lesbian pulp were: the girl could get the girl, but always ended up dead, sad, alone, sick, alcoholic or married to a man. From the position of the reader we become the writer; by crossing-out and underlining we re-edit these stories to more accurately reflect our experience and desire. In our version, women can have hot sex and 'happy endings' – in both senses of the word.

How do you view the role of reappropriation in your work, both in your use of language and in the spaces of intervention?

We use the derogatory names that lesbians have been called and reclaim that language to affirm our identity. We use our own childhood and baby pictures to reconsider the space of family & personal history as queer space. We use found

photographs to question the tyranny of assumed heterosexual identity. We use existing historic texts, newspapers, and most recently lesbian pulp novels. The way history is written often denies our existence. We go back into these texts to reinsert the lesbian experience: our anger, our desire, our impact, our lives.

New York City has changed dramatically from the early days of the collective (1991), and along with it, so have the issues of queer identity and visibility. In what ways has your work adapted/resisted/engaged these changes?

Queers may be more visible, but the city, and our country, have become far more fundamentally conservative. Today, 'gay visibility', which is more about assimilation and gay marriage, has replaced queer visibility and a vision of radical social change. We are committed to the latter and continue to adapt and find new strategies. We remain radical lesbian feminists.

fierce pussy, 'interview', fierce pussy website (2009). (www.fiercepussy.org)

Richard Fung
Beyond Domestication//2013

Sexual liberation was experimental. In the age of neoliberalism sexual marketing eclipses sexual liberation. Experimentation in both content and form is at risk.

Once the only media expression of sexual dissidence, experimental media (and especially the experimental short film and video) is today marginalized. Queer sexual dissidence is itself being replaced by homonormativity, the drive toward respectability. Sex/gender nonconformity once put us all on the outside. Now some of us can fully realize our neoliberal potential – join the military, get married, climb the corporate ladder – while others of us remain victimized by militarism, the legal system and capitalism. The discourse of LGBT rights obscures the disparities within LGBT 'community', yet struggles among queers over corporatization, pinkwashing and other manifestations of homonationalism complicate 'us' and 'them'.

Neoliberalism has made the funding for experimental media and its sibling, the low-budget documentary, increasingly difficult. In gay exhibition contexts, experimental shorts and low-budget documentaries are ever sidelined in favour of the narrative feature film – often one whose value is limited to pretty faces

and good production values – and the odd feature doc narrated by a Hollywood star. Queer experimental film is still being produced; it's just harder to make it and harder to see it.

Beyond a cinema of legitimacy, of homonormativity, of homo/nationalism.

Beyond we are just like you, the 'you' of television. Beyond stable identities. Beyond LGBTQ. Beyond a civil rights agenda. Beyond marriage. Beyond the military. Beyond the neoliberal consensus. Beyond our rights at the expense of theirs. Beyond corporatization. Beyond pinkwashing. Beyond Pride.

Beyond rote formulas. Beyond tokenism. Beyond the people of colour version of ... Beyond the Third World version of ... Beyond waving the flag of difference to defeat difference. Beyond stereotypes. Beyond positive images. Beyond monoculture.

Beyond good taste. Beyond production values. Beyond the theatre. Beyond the gallery.

Beyond the avant-garde. Beyond nostalgia. Beyond dogma.

For a cinema of questioning, not easy answers. Imagination, not formulaic narratives. To be jolted awake, not set to slumber in conformity. For an intersectional cinema. For a critical cinema. Accessibility but not populism.

Richard Fung, 'Beyond Domestication', *GLQ: A Journal of Lesbian and Gay Studies*, vol. 19, no. 4 (2013) 571–2.

niv Acosta is an American dancer, choreographer and performance artist based in New York.

Ron Athey is an American performance artist based in London.

Natalie Clifford Barney (1876–1972) was an American playwright, poet and novelist based in Paris.

Roland Barthes (1915–80) was a French cultural and literary critic and theorist of semiology.

Nayland Blake is an American artist based in Brooklyn.

Zach Blas is an artist and theorist based in London and Lecturer at Goldsmiths, University of London.

Gregg Bordowitz is an American writer, artist and activist, and professor in the Video, New Media, and Animation department, The School of the Art Institute of Chicago.

Leigh Bowery (1961–94) was an Australian performance artist based in London.

AA Bronson is a Canadian artist based in Berlin and was part of the artist collective General Idea.

Kaucyila Brooke is an American artist based in Los Angeles.

A.K. Burns is an American artist based in Brooklyn.

Giuseppe Campuzano (1969–2013) was a Peruvian artist and philosopher best known for his Museo Travesti del Perú.

Jean Cocteau (1889–1963) was a French writer, designer, playwright, filmmaker and artist.

Ryan Conrad is an American activist, artist and scholar based in Maine and Montréal.

Tee Corinne (1943–2006) was an American photographer and author based in Oregon.

Vaginal Davis is an American performance artist based in Berlin.

Barbara DeGenevieve (1947–2014) was an American artist based in Chicago and an influential professor of photography at the School of the Art Institute of Chicago.

Dyke Action Machine! are an American public art project based in New York.

Nicole Eisenman is an American artist based in New York.

Elmgreen & Dragset are a Danish and Norwegian artist duo based in London and Berlin.

Rotimi Fani-Kayode (1955–81) was a Nigerian-born photographer based in London.

fierce pussy are an art collective based in New York.

Simon Fujiwara is a British-born Japanese artist based in Berlin.

Richard Fung is a video artist based in Toronto.

Malik Gaines is a performance artist and writer based in New York, and a member of the artist collective My Barbarian.

Jean Genet (1910–86) was a French novelist, playwright and poet.

Gilbert & George are an Italian and British-born artist duo based in London.

Felix Gonzalez-Torres (1957–96) was a Cuban-born artist based in New York.

Gran Fury was an artist collective based in New York.

Sunil Gupta is an Indian-born Canadian artist and photographer based in London.

Gordon Hall is an American artist based in New York and founder of the Center for Experimental Lectures.

K8 Hardy is an American artist based in New York and member of the artist group LTTR.

Harmony Hammond is an American artist and writer based in New Mexico.

Sharon Hayes is an American artist based in New York.

Hudson (1950–2014) was a performance artist and founder and director of Feature Gallery.

Holly Hughes is an American performance artist based in New York.

Roberto Jacoby is an Argentinian artist and sociologist.

Derek Jarman (1942–94) was an English film director, designer, artist and author.

Isaac Julien is a filmmaker and artist based in London.

Mahmoud Khaled is an Egyptian artist based in Alexandria.

Meena Kumari (1932–72) was an Indian actress and poet who starred in more than ninety films.

Zoe Leonard is an American artist based in New York.

Lesbian Avengers is an American activist group.

Ma Liuming is a Chinese artist based in Beijing.

María Llopis is a Spanish artist and activist.

Catherine Lord is an American artist and Professor Emerita of Art at the University of California at Irvine.

Renate Lorenz is an artist based in Berlin, who works collaboratively with Pauline Boudry.

Charles Ludlam (1943–87) was an American actor, director and playwright based in New York.

Nithin Manayath is an Indian lecturer of Critical Theory at Mount Carmel College in Bangalore.

Allyson Mitchell is a Canadian artist based in Toronto.

Carlos Motta is a Colombian-born multi-disciplinary artist based in New York.

Carrie Moyer is an American painter and writer based in Brooklyn.

Zanele Muholi is a South African photographer based in Cape Town.

Ulrike Müller is an Austrian-born artist based in Brooklyn and member of the artist collective LTTR.

Richard Bruce Nugent (1906-87) was an American writer and painter based in New Jersey.

Ocaña (1947–83) was an Andalusian performance artist and activist whose promenades on Las Ramblas in Barcelona were legendary.

Hélio Oiticica (1937–80) was a Brazilian artist who worked in Rio de Janeiro and New York.

Henrik Olesen is a Danish artist based in Berlin.

Catherine Opie is an American photographer and professor of photography, University of California at Los Angeles.

Hanh Thi Pham is a Vietnam-born artist based in California.

Paul B. Preciado is a Spanish-born philosopher and curator, and professor of Political History of the Body, Gender Theory, and History of Performance at Université Paris VIII.

Queer Technologies is an organization that produces products and situations for queer technological agency, interventions and social formation.

Karol Radziszewski is a Polish artist based in Warsaw and founder of *DIK Fagazine*.

Ridykeulous (Nicole Eisenman & A.L. Steiner) is a curatorial initiative founded by the artists.

Marlon T. Riggs (1957–94) was an African-American filmmaker based in California.

Emily Roysdon is an American artist and writer based in New York and Stockholm, and member of the artist group LTTR.

Prem Sahib is a British artist based in London.

Assotto Saint (1957–94) was a Haitian-born American poet and performance artist based in New York.

Braden Scott is an American musician and visual artist based in Texas.

Alexandro Segade is a performance artist based in New York, and a member of the artist collective My Barbarian.

Tejal Shah is an Indian-born artist based in Goa.

Amy Sillman is an American painter based in New York.

Jack Smith (1932–89) was an American director and performer whose film *Flaming Creatures* (1963) made him a central figure in American underground cinema.

A.L. Steiner is an American multimedia artist based in New York.

Susan Stryker is an American scholar and filmmaker, and director of the Institute for LGBT Studies at the University of Arizona.

Wolfgang Tillmans is a German born photographer based in Berlin and London.

Toxic Titties (2000–10) was a Los Angeles-based feminist artist collective comprising Heather Cassils, Clover Leary and Julia Steinmetz.

Wu Tsang is a filmmaker, artist and performer based in Los Angeles.

Danh Vo is a Vietnamese-born Danish artist based in Berlin.

David Wojnarowicz (1954–92) was an American artist based in New York.

Yan Xing is a Chinese artist based in Beijing and Los Angeles.

Las Yeguas del Apocalypsis (1987–1997) was an artist collective based in Santiago de Chile and comprising Pedro Lemebel (1952–2015) and Francisco Casas Silva.

Akram Zaatari is a Lebanese artist based in Beirut, and co-founder of the Arab Image Foundation.

Sergio Zevallos is a Peruvian artist who, with Helmut Psotta and Raul Avellaneda, formed Grupo Chaclacayo, an artist collective operating outside of Lima from 1982 to 1989 and then in Berlin until 1995.

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Editor's acknowledgements

This book could not have taken its current form without the invaluable advice I received from many artists, scholars, critics, and curators. I experienced real generosity as I reached out to people across the globe who I never met but who were willing to take time to offer suggestions and even assist in the acquisition of texts. I also am indebted to the artists included here for their engagement and openness. I have many new friends among these pages.

My sounding board at every stage of this project has been Frédéric Moffet, whose work has been an inspiration and whose honesty, advice, and friendship have been essential. Omar Kholeif's enthusiasm for the project was instrumental. I am particularly grateful to Ian Farr, who has been a thoughtful interlocutor and editor, and to Francesca Vinter. Also, I would like to thank Ulrike Müller for the use of her work for the cover and for our conversations about it. The research staff at the Flaxman Library of the School of the Art Institute of Chicago consistently gave valuable help in hunting down far-flung texts.

For conversations and correspondence both formal and informal that have contributed to this book or pointed me to new artists, I am grateful to, among others, Denenge Akpem, Elise Archias, Daniel Berger, Elijah Burgher, Zach Blas, Gregg Bordowitz, Julian B. Carter, Delinda Collier, Jennifer Doyle, Jason Edwards, Nicole Eisenman, Rehaan Engineer, Sean Fader, Dena Gilby, Jonah Groeneboer, Gordon Hall, Richard Hawkins, Sharon Hayes, Fang-Tze Hsu, Doug Ischar, Dominic Johnson, Chase Joynt, Eduardo Kac, Lucetta Kam, Kareem Khubchandani, Tirza Latimer, Maud Lavin, Deirdre Logue, Loo Zihan, Slava Mogutin, Matthew Morris, Carlos Motta, Terry Myers, John Neff, Steven Nelson, Lissette Olivares, Joel Parsons, Alpesh Patel, Ernesto Pujol, Jules Rosskam, Daniel Quiles, Colin Self, Kelly Shindler, Amy Sillman, William Simmons, A. L. Steiner, Adele Tan, Nora Taylor, Apichatpong Weerasethakul, Yan Xing, and Zhu Xiaori.

This book is dedicated to the art students.

Publisher's acknowledgements

Whitechapel Gallery is grateful to all those who gave their generous permission to reproduce the listed material. Every effort has been made to secure all permissions and we apologize for any inadvertent errors or omissions. If notified, we will endeavour to correct these at the earliest opportunity. We would like to express our thanks to all who contributed to the making of this volume: niv Acosta, Ron Athey, Nayland Blake, Zach Blas, Gregg Bordowitz, AA Bronson, Kaucyila Brooke, A.K. Burns, Giuseppe Campuzano, Ryan Conrad, Douglas Crimp, Vaginal Davis, Dyke Action Machine!, Elmgreen & Dragset, Nicole Eisenman, Gilla Evans, fierce pussy, Simon Fujiwara, Richard Fung, Malik Gaines, Sunil Gupta, Gordon Hall, Harmony Hammond, K8 Hardy, Sharon Hayes, Hudson, Holly Hughes, Roberto Jacoby, Travis Jeppesen, Isaac Julien, Mahmoud Khaled, Zoe Leonard, Lesbian Avengers, Ma Liuming, María Llopis, Catherine Lord, Renate Lorenz, Charles Ludlam, Nithin Manayath, Allyson Mitchell, Carlos Motta, Carrie Moyer, Zanele Muholi, Ulrike Müller, Henrik Olesen, Catherine Opie, Hanh Thi Pham, Paul B. Preciado, Karol Radziszewski, Emily Roysdon, Prem Sahib, Braden Scott, Alexandro Segade, Tejal Shah, Amy Sillman, A.L. Steiner, Susan Stryker, Wolfgang Tillmans, Toxic Titties, Wu Tsang, Isabel Varea-Riley, Esme Watanabe, Yan Xing, Akram Zaatari, Sergio Zevallos.

We also gratefully acknowledge the cooperation of Afterall, Artforum, Autograph ABP, The Big Indian Picture, Galerie Buchholz, University of Chicago Press, Duke University Press, Frieze, Felix Gonzalez-Torres Foundation, Alexander Gray Associates, Grove Atlantic, Ibraaz, India Today, Institute of Network Cultures, Richard Kasak, Kent Fine Art, LACE (Los Angeles Contemporary Exhibitions), Little Joe Magazine, Matthew Marks, University of Minnesota Press, The MIT Press, The Estate of Richard Bruce Nugent (Peter Hansen), University of Oregon Libraries, Maureen Paley, Profile Books, Regen Projects, Signifyin' Works, Sterling Lord Literistic, Stevenson, Theatre Communications Group, Transcript Verlag, VAGA, White Cube, Whitehot Magazine, Whitewall Magazine, The Estate of David Wojnarowicz.